

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 1 OF SIX

The Bureau of Suspiciously Interesting People

Mystery, investigation and classic adventures

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A letter from the man who has made this a situation

Lillian, I was asked to find a game. A game. The singular was present. I saw it. I chose to believe it was an opening offer.

By the time Shawna found me, I had six departments, a loading dock and a man holding a ribbon across the couch. The man wanted to know when the mayor was coming. I told him the mayor had come as me. Shawna paid him twenty dollars to take the ribbon outside.

“You were supposed to bring something fun,” she said.

“Baby, I brought a civilization.”

“It is leaning on the lamp.”

She was technically correct. The civilization was in six binders. I had bought the largest ones the store carried, then asked if there was a professional line for people whose ideas had a transportation budget. The clerk sent me to shelving. I bought shelving. This is the sort of decisive leadership that eventually gets its own investigation.

Tank arrived carrying the extension cord. He stopped in the doorway, counted the binders, and went back outside.

“Where you going?” I asked.

“Checking if the truck can get close enough.”

“It is a book.”

“Then why does it have a district?”

This is the Panorama. Two hundred and forty real games. Six departments. A selection procedure so elaborate that one of its tables has requested an assistant. You may consult it, argue with it, use it to keep a door open, or turn straight to a title that looks good. The last option upset me until Mercedes pointed out that the book would still be getting attention.

The games are real. The ministries are not. The little scenes are a new comic companion to Ten Toes Down. I have not personally barged into any developer’s studio with a gold stamp. The stamp is here, on this desk, where Rosa has attached a string to it because apparently my leadership is portable.

Under the noise, there is a simple invitation: find a game you want to return to. A mystery can have complicated people and uncomplicated movement. A lovely landscape can still have a camera that is annoying to steer. A game that waits politely can give you fifteen menus. We will say which part looks inviting and which part needs checking. The gold stamp does not get to settle that question.

You do. That is a real rule.

I tried to put my name under it. Shawna drew a line through my signature and wrote “Obviously.” I have chosen to regard this as the first favorable review.

The reader has diplomatic immunity

There is a direct index in every volume. You can pick a title and read its ordinary description without rolling anything. You can also follow the full ceremonial route, invent a ridiculous qualification, appeal to a committee and arrive at the same title with considerably more paperwork. Both are valid ways to use this book.

No rule can require a game you do not want. No fictional point total can overrule uncomfortable controls, a disliked theme, a wish to stop, or the fact that a game is not available on the system you own. “No” is a complete ruling and costs no tokens. Aiden may look wounded. His recovery is extremely well funded.

The collection has a range of demands. Promising entries are plausible starting points. Conditional entries have a meaningful obstacle that needs checking. Detours are here for a narrower activity or a different appetite; they are not quietly being passed off as universally easy. Some turn-based games have enormous menus. Some gentle-looking games have timed sequences. The catches are part of the recommendation.

A card’s first try is an invitation to sample one action, not a prescribed duration or a performance test. Ask before taking over the controls. Sharing a theory, reading dialogue aloud, playing a second character and passing a controller are different kinds of company. Choose the one that feels welcome.

The source desk records what was actually supported by a source. A Steam accessibility declaration is a developer declaration, not a personal guarantee. A blank or unknown control detail remains unknown. No installed-game trial or complete-game accessibility audit is claimed. This book is for leisure, not treatment.

All the research in the world still leaves one useful question unanswered: do you like it? That question has been reserved for the people on the couch. The reservation is permanent. There is no dress code.

The Rules Department Has Acquired a Rules Department

Article 1. Enter through any door you like

Choose a department by what you want to do. Book I investigates suspicious people. Book II lets a turn wait for you. Book III looks around. Book IV moves ideas and objects into place. Book V listens to characters. Book VI brings company. A game belongs to one shelf in this Panorama so the count stays honest; its pleasures can overlap several shelves.

Aiden originally proposed a seventh department to determine whether the first six were departments. Tank asked whether it had a chair. I said it had principles. He said that was why everybody was standing. The seventh department was abolished and its chair returned to the kitchen.

For the practical route, choose two titles from a shelf, read the catch, and try the more appealing opening. For the ceremonial route, continue below. The ceremony does not know better than you do.

Article 2. Name what the evening needs

Write or say up to three actual preferences: no required rush; no separate camera steering; avoid held input; few menus; light reading; little clue tracking; or native co-op. Add any theme you do not want. You can choose fewer than three or add your own.

These are boundaries for the selection, not traits assigned to a person. They can change next time. The record should read “tonight, no camera wrestling,” not an assessment of somebody’s capabilities. One is useful information. The other is a stranger wearing a clipboard.

A source gap is not permission to promise a feature. If we have not established how a game handles a requirement, its card is a question to check or a reason to choose another game. The optional web finder treats strict feature filters conservatively. The printed cards put the concrete catch beside the temptation.

“What if the game gets a very good score?” I asked.

Shawna took the score away.

“What if it gets a gold score?”

She took the gold pen too.

Article 3. Choose a row, because the binder demands coordinates

Each department has forty cases. Pick one of five rows: 1, Quietly Curious; 2, Ready for a Conversation; 3, Willing to Inspect a Thing; 4, Here for the Atmosphere; 5, Open to a Wildcard. These are ceremonial mood names. They do not certify that every game on a row meets that mood; the actual card and preferences decide that.

Choose a row freely. If you want dice, roll one ordinary six-sided die. Results 1-5 select that row. On a 6, visit the Incident Desk once and then choose a row yourself. There is no recursive reroll trap. The Incident Desk has had its authority to extend the evening revoked.

The office briefly tried measuring Quiet Curiosity in centimeters. Rosa came in, saw Tank holding a ruler beside a cup of tea, and asked which of us had paid for training. Nobody answered. We now use row numbers.

Article 4. Select the object whose paperwork you distrust

Choose an emblem, or roll an eight-sided die: 1 Envelope, 2 Key, 3 Plant, 4 Map, 5 Teacup, 6 Spare Chair, 7 Gold Stamp, 8 Clock. Read the corresponding column of the department's five-by-eight route grid.

The grid gives a case number. For example, department 1, row 2, emblem 3 gives local case 11, P011. Department 6 at those same coordinates gives P211. The same coordinates in different departments lead to different games. This is either a filing system or a multiverse, depending on whether you are speaking to Shawna or me.

The forty cases are arranged in catalogue order, not ranked from easy to hard. The object is an amusing way to choose where to look. A plant is not scientific evidence of compatibility. Strange Horticulture is permitted to look smug about this.

Article 5. Optional: give the evening an outrageously specific title

Write one short session trait. Examples: "Two Detectives, One Sandwich"; "The Map Can Come to Me"; "I Want to Know What She Meant by That"; "A House with Excellent Stopping Places"; "The Plant Is Lying"; "My Friend Has the Other Controller." A trait describes a taste or a situation, not a diagnosis.

Whenever it helps explain why a title sounds interesting, point to it. That explanation is already useful. You do not need a numeric bonus to care about a haunted town or a witness with a suspicious alibi.

If you enjoy the extra machinery, begin with three Stamp Tokens. Spend one token to add two to the optional paperwork total, or reroll the four paperwork dice once. Spend at most one token per selection. Refusing a game is always free. Tokens never buy exceptions to preferences. They exist because I ordered a bowl that said TOKENS before deciding what tokens did.

Article 6. Optional: four dice acquire office jobs

Roll four ordinary six-sided dice. Each 1 or 2 means minus one, each 3 or 4 means zero, and each 5 or 6 means plus one. Add the four values. Your paperwork total is between minus four and plus four. This optional layer draws on Fate's familiar signed-dice idea; the surrounding selection rules are original Panorama rules.

A negative result is not failure. It moves you backward in a circular shelf. A positive result moves you forward. A zero result means four dice have attended a meeting and declined to change anything. Aiden considers this a promotion opportunity.

If you spend a Stamp Token, either add two or reroll all four dice once and use the new total. You cannot buy a second modification on this selection. Reset to three tokens whenever you begin a new browsing session; no ledger needs to survive dinner.

“What is the maximum possible result?” Tank asked.

“Distinction.”

“A number, Aiden.”

“Plus six if you rolled plus four and spent a token for plus two.”

“See? We can say things.”

Article 7. Optional: the snack amendment

Record a separate snack adjustment: one if somebody has already brought the drink they wanted, plus one if wanted snacks are within reach and no one is expected to fetch them. The maximum snack adjustment is two. Keep it separate from the dice-and-stamp paperwork total; Article 8 adds it exactly once. If these conditions are irrelevant, use zero. This arithmetic is a joke about hospitality; nobody needs to eat or drink anything to participate.

I attempted to claim an additional bonus because the plate was expensive. Mercedes turned it over and found the price sticker. Tank said the sticker had more authority than the plate. We removed the proposed Wealth of Crockery modifier and carried on.

Do not delay choosing a game to qualify for this amendment. Do not make a snack score into a task for somebody else. The best possible snack state is people having what they actually want.

Article 8. The entirely unnecessary formula

First find the local case from the grid: eight times (row minus one), plus emblem. Add the paperwork total and the snack adjustment, if you used them. If the result exceeds forty, subtract forty until it is 1-40. If it is below one, add forty until it is 1-40. Otherwise keep it. The final local case number is always between 1 and 40.

Then add forty times (department minus one) to get the complete P-number. Department 3, row 1, emblem 2 starts at local case 2. A paperwork total of minus three and a snack adjustment of one gives zero. Wrap zero to forty. In department 3, local case forty is P120.

This is a shelf address. It is not a probability of enjoyment, a cognitive score, a ranking, or an instruction to buy something. It chooses a page to consider. Read that page’s ordinary fields before treating it as a candidate.

I wrote the formula on a whiteboard. Tank copied it onto a napkin. Shawna chose a game from the index while we were still discussing which version looked more official. All three methods reached a page. Only one required cleaning a whiteboard.

Article 9. Read the ruling, then check the real game

Every case has two voices doing different jobs. Aiden’s scene and ceremonial ruling provide the comedy. The ordinary pleasure, actual catch and first action provide the useful selection information. A funny reason is not a source for a game feature.

Check the exact edition and platform. A remake can change movement, menus and saves. A touch port can differ from a desktop pointer. A Steam store date may be the port’s date rather than the

original release. Local co-op, online co-op and two people discussing a single-player game are not interchangeable.

If the card conflicts with a real preference, reject the candidate. If it is promising but has an unresolved operation, check that specific operation before investing in it. “Can we select this inventory object comfortably?” is more useful than “Is this an easy game?”

The stamp says PROVISIONALLY INTERESTING. I wanted DESTINY CONFIRMED. Rosa explained that destiny could come over and set up the controller if it felt that strongly.

Article 10. The appeals court

You may make one ceremonial appeal or skip the ceremony entirely. To appeal, choose a neighbor: the previous local case, the next local case, or the same local case in another department. Wrap case 1 backward to 40 and case 40 forward to 1. Check the new card as usual.

After that one appeal, stop calculating. Choose either candidate, browse the direct index or close the book. Every route ends with a human decision; there is no compulsory loop, escalating fee or penalty for declining both.

Aiden’s right of appeal is limited to thirty seconds of dramatic silence. The book does not actually time that silence. Tank usually fills it by asking who wants the last biscuit.

If the perfect result is “we would rather talk,” the system has located an activity. It will not print a certificate unless you ask. I have already designed the certificate.

Article 11. A genuinely useful first session

Load the chosen edition before introducing its controls. Show one meaningful action. Keep a reminder if wanted. Find pause, save or exit so leaving feels ordinary. Do not turn a trial into a lesson with a hidden passing grade.

For a mystery, that might mean one conversation or one clue. For an exploration game, a nearby path and a place to stop. For a turn-based game, one decision with the menus already explained. For co-op, agree who wants which role and whether the roles have equal kinds of action.

Stop, change games or take a break whenever wanted. A day off makes room for leisure; it does not require a whole day of screen time. The useful note afterward is a sentence about what was enjoyable and where to resume.

“How will we know it worked?” I asked.

Mercedes glanced at the enormous binder.

“If they forget about this for a while.”

I accepted the compliment after modifying its tone internally.

Article 12. What these departments are allowed to claim

This is a researched, source-linked candidate catalogue with original comic writing. Game descriptions were checked against publisher, developer, platform or identified supporting sources. Control classifications and first-trial suggestions are editorial judgments unless tied to an explicit declaration. No card claims a complete-path playtest.

The catalogue deliberately contains different levels of complexity. Turn-based strategy and elaborate deduction belong here only for readers who want those specific demands. The direct index and catches let you pass them by. “There are two hundred and forty games” does not mean “all two hundred and forty will suit the same evening.”

The offline finder uses the same case IDs as the books. It makes no network requests and does not inspect your library. Marking a title interesting does not install or buy it. Its strict feature filters require stated evidence; an unknown is not silently accepted.

The final authority remains the person playing. The opening scene, the next conversation, the wish to continue: those are results the printed research cannot manufacture. I can commission a gold seal. I cannot make somebody like a fishing minigame. Several fisheries have been unnecessarily involved in establishing this distinction.

Twelve optional declarations of personality

1. Two Detectives, One Sandwich. Mysteries to discuss together; a single-player game can support shared theorizing without claiming native co-op.
2. The Map Can Come to Me. Prefer a desk, static scenes or fixed framing; inspect the actual navigation demands.
3. I Keep Receipts for Ghosts. Supernatural investigations; check horror and emotional tone as well as controls.
4. A Small World with Large Opinions. A compact place can still offer interesting people; size and depth are separate.
5. Let Me Finish My Turn. Look at turn-based candidates, then check menu and planning demands.
6. Two Chairs, Two Useful Jobs. Seek actual co-op and examine whether both roles offer the kinds of agency you want.
7. The Plant Is Lying. Observation, classification and occult mysteries; watch for cross-referencing burden.
8. I Would Like to Build a Thing. Toys, creative modes and construction; check whether a quiet mode is actually available.
9. People Before Equipment. Character stories over gear optimization; reading and choice pressure still matter.
10. I Want a Place to Remember. Exploration with a strong setting; navigation and camera controls need their own check.
11. The Puzzle Can Wait for Me. Look for stated untimed behavior; genre labels alone do not establish this.
12. No Committee Can Tell Me My Taste. Choose a title directly. This trait defeats every arbitrary rule in this book without a roll.

The incident desk

1. The printer requests representation. It has printed “PC LOAD LETTER” on a page already containing a letter. Give it no further work; choose your row.
2. Tank finds the purchase order. The gold stamp cost more than the table. This changes no game controls. Choose your row while Aiden explains shipping.
3. The plant has filed an appeal. Its complaint is that every mystery assumes the plant knows something. You may hear it or choose your row.
4. Shawna removes a paragraph. Nobody can find a practical consequence. The book is shorter. Choose your row in celebration.
5. The spare chair becomes a department. It already offers more support than the committee. Sit if you want; then choose your row.
6. Mercedes selects a game directly. The ceremony has been outperformed by a preference. Follow her example or choose your row.
7. The stapler goes missing. Rosa is using it to hold two useful pages together. The suspected coup is stationery doing its job.
8. Aiden wins an award he commissioned. Tank asks who finished second. The certificate refuses to answer. Continue without a speech.
9. The map is upside down. Turn the paper, not the room. Camera comfort remains a separate issue.
10. The snacks are promoted. A biscuit is now Deputy Minister of Being Here. Its term ends when somebody actually wants it.
11. A mysterious envelope arrives. Inside is the same menu with bigger writing. This may be the only productive committee decision so far.
12. The clock is asked to leave. No timer has been added to the book. The clock can remain if everybody likes knowing what time dinner is.

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 1. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P001	P002	P003	P004	P005	P006	P007	P008
2. Ready for conversation	P009	P010	P011	P012	P013	P014	P015	P016
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P017	P018	P019	P020	P021	P022	P023	P024
4. Here for the atmosphere	P025	P026	P027	P028	P029	P030	P031	P032
5. Open to a wildcard	P033	P034	P035	P036	P037	P038	P039	P040

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

A Small Question Requires a Building

The trouble began when somebody asked what would be fun to play. An ordinary man might have named a game. I ordered a table. Not just any table: twelve feet of dark wood, brass corners, and enough gravitas to make a sandwich explain where it had been. By the time it arrived, I had founded the Bureau of Suspiciously Interesting People, appointed myself director, and requisitioned a gold stamp. The stamp said APPROVED BY AIDEN. I believed this covered the important questions.

Shawna read the delivery sheet. 'You ordered a conference table for a question.' 'A serious question.' 'You put next-day air.' 'Curiosity shouldn't sit in a warehouse.' Tank stood in the doorway holding the small red stapler that had come free with the stationery order. He clicked it once. 'This little bastard works. Which end of the table answers questions?' I told him logistics was not permitted to interrupt strategy. He clicked the stapler again. The sound had already acquired an opinion.

We placed forty game files on the table. They were mysteries, investigations, strange journeys, and adventures full of people who clearly needed either help or better locks. The plan was straightforward. Lillian could find something interesting, try the actual controls, and keep going only if she wanted. Unfortunately I had also commissioned a seal, a visitor register, and a ceremonial pencil too thick for the sharpener. Mercedes picked up the pencil. 'Did the question ask to borrow a fence post?' 'That is executive equipment.' 'It's a branch with ambition.'

Rosa arrived with coffee and asked where the visitors were supposed to sit. I pointed to the far end of the table, beneath a framed chart titled THE CORRECT SEQUENCE OF ENJOYMENT. She moved the chart onto my chair. 'They sit wherever they like.' 'The chart provides structure.' 'So does a roof. You don't make people read the roof before lunch.' This was a strong argument, delivered by a woman carrying the lunch. I revised the seating policy immediately.

There was one sensible rule, and Shawna wrote it on the first page before I could improve it: interest comes first, actual comfort gets the final say. A game could contain an excellent murder and still require an awkward drag. A conversation could sound urgent while allowing unlimited thought. A beautiful story could arrive inside menus that made the evening feel like unpaid office work. We would keep those distinctions visible. No stamp would turn an unknown control into a verified feature. I asked whether we could stamp that rule. She took the stamp.

Tank had brought a magnifying glass. He began investigating the pastry box. 'Half these have disappeared.' 'You ate them.' 'Allegedly.' He inspected a crumb on his sleeve. 'Somebody planted this.' I admired the professionalism. Here was a man who could turn breakfast into a procedural drama without even standing up. He asked whether any of the games involved doing that. I slid the first folder across. The folder knocked over my gold nameplate. This was our first useful result.

These forty possibilities are not an order to finish forty games. Nobody owes the Bureau a complete case, a perfect answer, or another chance after something has stopped being enjoyable. Pick the title, the atmosphere, or the particular bit of nonsense that catches your attention. Read the plain account beneath my testimony. That account is where the real controls, burdens, and uncertainties live. My testimony is where an expensive man finds increasingly elaborate ways to be corrected by his friends.

I opened the binder. Its rings sprang apart with a noise like a small gate losing a legal dispute. Papers slid toward Rosa's coffee. Tank caught the coffee. Mercedes caught the source notes. Shawna caught my hand before I could bring the stamp down on a napkin. 'We can begin,' she said. I looked over the assembled department, the evidence, the remaining pastries, and the table that had cost more than several perfectly respectable vehicles. 'Good,' I said. 'I have made this effortless.' Tank stapled the receipt to my sleeve.

P001 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Blackwell Legacy

The Ghost Who Refused a Visitor Badge

Edition considered: PC original game; current publisher patch must be recorded

I introduced Joey Mallone to the Bureau's visitor policy. In my imagined demonstration he walked through the turnstile, which was unfair because I had paid extra for the turnstile. Tank asked whether a dead man counted toward the fire limit. Shawna said we were discussing The Blackwell Legacy, not opening a haunted convention center. I had already ordered lanyards.

What interested me was Rosa: somebody handed a peculiar responsibility while still dealing with an ordinary, difficult life. I offered to become her supernatural consultant. Mercedes asked what qualified me. 'Presence.' She looked at the empty chair I had reserved for Joey. 'He's got you there.' The chair received better reviews than my presentation.

We left the chair empty and opened the first file. Nobody needed to prove anything to the ghost, the notebook, or me. Rosa could discover one lead while I discovered that a visitor badge cannot improve every relationship.

The actual attraction

A compact New York supernatural mystery joins a reluctant medium to a sardonic spirit guide. Conversations and notebook connections make discovery feel personal; the developing partnership offers more reason to continue than simply clearing another puzzle.

The catch worth knowing

Notebook combinations, returning to locations, and remembering names remain real work. Suicide and bereavement are central. Reviews report no timed or dexterity challenges, but this is not a complete-path playtest. Current desktop patches offer manual speech advance through a Ctrl+P toggle; verify it waits.

An opening invitation

Set manual speech advance if you want it, with help if useful. Try one conversation and one notebook lead, then decide whether these two people are company worth keeping.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because a ghost with opinions may be entertaining, and the Bureau badly needs someone who can ignore its turnstile.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher premise and developer Ctrl+P patch notice; timing description is a secondary review, not current complete-path testing. PC original only.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80330/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/80330/allnews/>

Source 3: <https://www.keengamer.com/articles/reviews/the-blackwell-legacy-review/>

P002 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Darkside Detective

A Department Smaller Than My Expense Account

Edition considered: PC first game; current accessibility build must be recorded

I had sympathy for Detective McQueen's underfunded paranormal department. A man should not have to investigate a tentacle while worrying about toner. I proposed donating our surplus equipment. 'What surplus?' Shawna asked. I indicated the ceremonial pencil. 'They investigate crimes,' she said. 'They don't need another weapon.'

Tank volunteered to inventory the Bureau's supernatural incidents. He listed the printer's ability to demand cyan while printing black text, my recurring claim that the table was an investment, and a sandwich that vanished during questioning. The final suspect looked remarkably like him. He crossed that entry out on procedural grounds.

The Darkside Detective's small cases suited this department better than my grand inquiry. A few rooms, a strange problem, two people with something funny to say: enough room for an evening without requiring an empire. I lowered our proposed donation to a stapler. Tank quietly put his hand over it.

The actual attraction

Comic paranormal investigations offer a recurring detective partnership and short case boundaries. Static scenes let attention settle on objects, dialogue, and absurd situations rather than keeping an avatar and camera moving together.

The catch worth knowing

Current Steam metadata declares play without timed input. That does not mean hold-free: PC reviews describe dragging inventory items onto objects or other items. Pipe and tile puzzles also appear. Text reading and small hotspots deserve an actual check before treating this as comfortable.

An opening invitation

Begin the first case, inspect one object, and test one inventory drag. Check that text advance and the save/exit route feel understandable before continuing.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for anyone who suspects the printer is possessed and would enjoy watching professionals make equally questionable deductions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary Steam accessibility declarations inspected. Inventory dragging is documented by a PC review; no hold-free alternative was verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/api/appdetails?appids=368390&l=english>

Source 2: <https://www.bigbossbattle.com/review-the-darkside-detective/>

P003 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Phoenix Wright: Ace Attorney Trilogy

Objection to the Sandwich Witness

Edition considered: 2019 PC compilation; post-November 2025 update scope

I called Tank to testify about the missing sandwich. He said he had last seen it in a position consistent with lunch. I presented the plate. He objected to the plate's character. Mercedes asked whether either of us had read the file. I had underlined my own name seven times, which I considered preparation.

Phoenix Wright made my courtroom ambitions look inexpensive and poorly rehearsed. Here the pleasure was finding the statement that failed to match the evidence, not delivering an impressive noise at a man holding mayonnaise. Shawna arranged three actual facts in front of me. My argument collapsed between facts two and three.

I attempted to invoke Story Mode on the hearing. 'That's a game feature,' she said. 'You still have to explain the receipt.' I admired a system that could move a story past a roadblock. My own proceedings remained tragically manual, with no option to skip the cross-examination of the catering budget.

The actual attraction

The original trilogy supplies memorable witnesses, recurring friendships, and theatrical courtroom mysteries. Comparing testimony with a piece of evidence can deliver a satisfying click of understanding; the story has room for comedy and emotional stakes.

The catch worth knowing

Reading and Court Record menus are central, and wrong evidence can incur penalties. Dramatic music may feel urgent even when the interface waits. The November 2025 update adds Story Mode and Auto-play; automatic text progression may itself feel rushed. Later evidence interactions still need checking.

An opening invitation

Use the updated 2019 compilation. Start The First Turnabout with manual text advance, compare one statement, and use Story Mode whenever enjoying the next scene matters more than solving it.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Selected because an objection should sometimes be supported by evidence, a principle the Bureau is introducing on a trial basis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current Steam declares play without timed input; Capcom November 2025 notice confirms Story Mode for this 2019 trilogy. No hands-on audit of all cases or holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/787480/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/787480/announcements/>

P004 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Strange Horticulture

The Fern Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC current release

I opened a botanical branch of the Bureau with one fern and an intimidating brass label. Tank asked its name. 'Executive Verdance.' Rosa turned the pot around. The nursery label said Dave. 'Dave has seniority,' she told me. The fern immediately looked more difficult to dismiss.

Strange Horticulture offered a much better reason to keep plants on a desk: their identities and effects mattered to an unfolding occult mystery. I attempted to identify Dave from his expression. Shawna supplied the relevant correction: plants do not become poisonous because they disapprove of management. Mercedes said this was fortunate for everyone in the room.

The actual attraction was the little act of matching an observed detail to a book, then seeing where that knowledge led. I reached for another label. Rosa stopped me. 'Find out what it is first.' We wrote that on the Bureau's purchasing forms. Several departments ceased to exist overnight.

The actual attraction

A rain-soaked plant shop provides a recurring home base, curious customers, and an occult story. Identifying specimens connects looking closely with useful decisions, while letters and map clues gradually widen the world beyond the counter.

The catch worth knowing

Books, plants, labels, letters, and a map can create substantial cross-referencing. Desk objects use dragging; a developer patch added a double-click sticky-drag alternative, whose own double-click demand needs testing. Wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can lead to a recovery puzzle. Calm presentation is not simplicity.

An opening invitation

Identify one customer's plant with the reference book. Compare ordinary dragging with the documented sticky option before adding map exploration or several simultaneous questions to the desk.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed under interesting plants, with a separate order forbidding me from granting a fern executive authority before checking its species.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected; developer patch mirrored on SteamDB supports sticky dragging. No-customer-deadline observation is secondary, not full-path verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1574580/>

Source 2: <https://steamdb.info/patchnotes/8300183/>

Source 3: <https://www.gamesradar.com/have-you-tried-strange-horticulture/>

P005 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Case of the Golden Idol

A Statue With No Respect for the Seating Chart

Edition considered: PC 2022 game with current Redux edition; not The Rise of the Golden Idol

The Golden Idol file arrived beside my gold stamp, and for a moment I enjoyed the resemblance. Then Shawna read the part about strange deaths. I moved the stamp farther away. Tank moved his chair farther away from both. Nobody appreciated my explanation that mine was merely expensive, not cursed.

I staged a practice scene using three paper figures and a fallen biscuit. Mercedes was asked to determine the motive. 'You wanted everyone looking at your statue.' 'The biscuit could have been politically significant.' She assigned it to the snack column. The clarity of her reasoning was becoming a professional problem.

A frozen scene was an inviting proposition: look again, compare the objects, reconsider who did what. It did not promise that the deduction would be easy. Shawna made that distinction before I could declare myself a genius for identifying the biscuit. Then Tank ate the murder weapon and our reconstruction acquired a second suspect.

The actual attraction

Static scenes of suspicious deaths become a larger conspiracy as names, objects, and motives connect. The reward is constructing an explanation that fits the evidence, with visual detail and social relationships doing much of the storytelling.

The catch worth knowing

Later cases add many names, roles, and possible words. Murder imagery is deliberate, and the grotesque art may not be welcoming. This card concerns the original game with its current Redux edition, not Rise. Check exact word-placement, text size, and hint controls rather than assuming every release behaves identically.

An opening invitation

Study the first scene and identify the people before attempting its full explanation. Try moving one word into a deduction slot, then inspect the hint interface if curiosity has turned into bookkeeping.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Suitable for an evening of suspicious objects, provided my gold stamp is kept outside the evidence room and preferably outside the building.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes freely investigated freeze-frame scenes; current-edition announcements establish Redux. Drag/hold behavior and full completion were not playtested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1677770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1677770/allnews/>

P006 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Syberia

The Business Trip That Refused to End at Lunch

Edition considered: 2002 PC original; not Syberia Remastered

Kate Walker travels to arrange a factory sale. I understood immediately: arrive, sign something, discover a machine with a personality, and accidentally become responsible for an entire journey. Tank said I had managed the same result buying a table. I told him my transaction had international significance. He held up the assembly instructions in six languages.

Syberia's automata appealed to my standards of office equipment. A machine should have dignity. It should also perform a recognizable task, a requirement our printer had been evading with artistic confidence. Shawna pointed out that Kate's journey mattered because her priorities changed, not because she bought a more impressive machine.

I prepared an itinerary titled QUICK STOP. Mercedes asked why it contained a train, an inventor, and half a continent. 'Flexibility.' She crossed out quick. We kept the journey and lost the sales pitch. That seemed closer to the game's promise, and considerably kinder to anyone reading my travel arrangements.

The actual attraction

The original Syberia follows a lawyer into an unusual European world of mechanical wonders and unfinished lives. Kate's changing sense of what matters gives the travel emotional momentum beyond collecting the next useful object.

The catch worth knowing

This is the 2002 PC original, not the remaster. Click movement removes a separate look control, but fixed camera cuts, small hotspots, dialogue topics, inventory, and repeated travel can still frustrate. The publisher walkthrough's late sections use ordinary interactions; that is not an exhaustive no-timer guarantee.

An opening invitation

Explore the opening hotel, speak with one person, and test the inventory and save route. Let one useful object establish whether the older interface is inviting before committing to a long journey.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommended when a peculiar train sounds more appealing than a realistic business meeting, which is a demanding but reasonable standard for an evening.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected original-game publisher description and seven-page official walkthrough, including late sequences. Original PC control scope only; no full playtest.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46500/>

Source 2: <https://support.microids.com/fr/support/solutions/articles/23000009217-solutions-syberia-1-et-2>

P007 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Unavowed

My Companions Demand a Better Selection Screen

Edition considered: PC release

Unavowed offers companions with different talents. I announced that the Bureau already possessed the ideal team. Shawna could distinguish a fact from my enthusiasm, Rosa could feed people without founding an empire, Mercedes could end a foolish speech with one eyebrow, and Tank could carry the empire to the recycling bin. My own talent was leadership. Nobody wrote that down.

I tried selecting the day's party by arranging their photographs on the desk. Mercedes picked hers up. 'Ask.' 'This is a strategic interface.' 'Ask strategically.' So I asked who wanted to investigate a hidden supernatural New York. The conversation improved once the photographs stopped pretending to make decisions.

What caught me was the possibility of learning about people through the problems they solve together. Then Shawna read the content warning and the companion-ability demands. We placed both beside the promise. A rich ensemble could be worth the work, but even my department could not turn darkness into a light snack by changing the folder color.

The actual attraction

An urban-fantasy investigation puts companions, their histories, and their abilities at the center of puzzle solving. Origins and branching situations give the ensemble room to react differently, making the people a reason to explore the next case.

The catch worth knowing

Inventory plus companion abilities creates more to remember than a simple conversation game. Violence, possession, death, and strong language are substantial. Ordinary PC interaction is pointer-based, but urgent scenes and every branch's timing or holding demands have not been fully audited.

An opening invitation

Choose an origin because it sounds interesting, meet the opening companions, and try one interaction. Verify text waiting and pause on the actual edition before relying on the adventure's slower ordinary rhythm.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted an ensemble permit because four interesting companions can justify a longer story; they cannot justify my attempt to assign friendship through office photographs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher premise and companion features inspected. PC interaction and content detail supported by review; zero timed inputs across branches remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336140/>

Source 2: <https://gamecritics.com/gc-staff/unavowed-review/>

P008 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Her Story

The Search Term Was Not My Name

Edition considered: PC release

Her Story places an interview archive in front of the player. I entered my own name into our practice database, expecting relevance to recognize me. It returned a receipt for seventeen brass drawer handles. Tank leaned over. 'Strong opening. Motive established.' I suggested a more glamorous search term. Shawna suggested reading the result.

The game's unusual invitation was to notice a word, search it, and let another fragment change the question. Mercedes liked that the story did not need me to march a little man through a hallway before listening to a woman speak. I objected to the little man characterization. She clarified that she meant me.

I began creating a wall of theories. Rosa removed three arrows that all pointed to my photograph. We kept one question on a card instead. A story assembled from fragments could be compelling; it could also become a pile of names. The Bureau had produced enough piles to respect the distinction.

The actual attraction

A live-action police interview mystery lets a noticed word become the next direction of exploration. Performance, contradiction, and interpretation supply the interest; there is no avatar or separate look camera between the player and the testimony.

The catch worth knowing

Typing, names, nonlinear clips, and remembering what a phrase referred to can be demanding. Convenient video pausing is unverified: player reports describe holding the slider to freeze a clip. Do not assume search-at-your-own-pace means hands-free pause during playback. Crime and relationship material is mature.

An opening invitation

On desktop, watch one returned clip, test how it stops or replays, and follow one promising word. Keep a short question nearby only if it helps preserve the thread.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted because the next useful clue may be a word rather than a key, and because the archive is under no obligation to admire my drawer handles.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher describes search/watch loop. Pause limitation is dated secondary user evidence, not verified current behavior; Telling Lies controls must not be substituted.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/368370/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/368370/discussions/0/530645446312998268/>

P009 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow

A Very Poor Location for the Staff Picnic

Edition considered: PC release

I saw an atmospheric Yorkshire village and proposed a Bureau retreat. Rosa asked what the trip involved. 'History. Countryside. A burial mound.' She stopped packing the picnic basket. Tank asked whether the mound had parking. Mercedes asked whether it had a reason to stay buried. Shawna read the words folk horror aloud until my brochure began to look dishonest.

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow interested me precisely because its landscape and people withheld an easy answer. Thomasina arrives to investigate, and the invitation does not become less peculiar when she reaches it. I respected a story with the confidence to make a village feel like an unresolved question.

I changed the excursion form from relaxing getaway to dark story for those who want one. Rosa put the basket away. 'Better.' Tank kept one sandwich for emergency research. We could appreciate atmosphere without pretending dread was a hospitality feature. My proposed lantern budget remained excellent, but irrelevant.

The actual attraction

Victorian folk horror gives its investigation a strong sense of place: moors, suspicious villagers, an antiquarian, and a burial mound. For someone who enjoys unease, the slow accumulation of wrongness may be as engaging as solving the inventory puzzles.

The catch worth knowing

Bleak horror, violence, and abrupt audiovisual moments can create pressure without a reflex timer. PC descriptions include inventory dragging. A Switch accessibility assessment reports low pressure and optional holds, but that does not prove hold-free PC play. Later puzzle chains still require remembering information.

An opening invitation

Try the opening village and one conversation. Test an inventory action and text advance on the exact edition; leave if the atmosphere itself is unpleasant, even if the controls behave perfectly.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Issued a lantern rather than a cozy stamp: suitable only when suspicious soil sounds like an invitation instead of a reason to choose another room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher horror premise inspected. Switch low-pressure panel and PC drag description are secondary and edition-specific; no blanket control guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182310/>

Source 2: <https://www.nintendolife.com/reviews/switch-eshop/the-excavation-of-hobs-barrow>

Source 3: https://as.com/meristation/2022/09/28/analysis/1664375021_208084.html

P010 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Pentiment

The Meeting That Consumed Tuesday

Edition considered: PC release

Pentiment made me nostalgic for a time when an important man could spend an afternoon discussing art and call it work. Shawna said I had done that yesterday while choosing the border on my nameplate. 'Historical continuity,' I explained. She opened the receipt and found the extra charge for historical continuity.

The game's community changes through relationships and decisions, and investigating one lead can mean leaving another behind. I attempted to solve this by scheduling every conversation simultaneously. Tank attended a meeting with three empty chairs and a bowl of nuts. He reported unanimous agreement that the bowl should be larger.

There was no need to race a button press to find this sort of choice weighty. Mercedes crossed out my phrase perfectly relaxing. She replaced it with interesting if consequential decisions appeal. I protested that this was less marketable. 'Good,' she said. 'Now it tells somebody something.' The nameplate border survived, but the sales pitch did not.

The actual attraction

A richly drawn historical community makes art, class, faith, and personal loyalties part of the investigation. People and consequences unfold over years, offering conversation and interpretation rather than a constant demand for quick physical reactions.

The catch worth knowing

Developer accessibility notes state there are no timed inputs or QTEs. Investigation time still advances through chosen activities, which creates decision pressure. Reading is extensive, movement may require holding, and names and relationships accumulate. Narration support differs by platform; do not assume every line is spoken.

An opening invitation

Try walking and one early conversation with readable text settings. Notice whether choosing a lead feels intriguing or burdensome before promising yourself an entire investigation or an optimal outcome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Registered for readers who enjoy a community with arguments worth hearing, subject to the finding that my calendar cannot make two afternoons out of one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected developer accessibility notes and first-hand interview on activity-based investigation time. Turn pacing differs from decision pressure; actual movement setup untested.

Source 1: <https://pentiment.obsidian.net/>

Source 2: <https://www.mmorpg.com/interviews/the-rpg-files-building-obsidians-pentiment-interview-with-game-director-josh-sawyer-2000126821>

The Evidence Has Been Eating the Evidence

By midday, the Bureau had solved three minor administrative mysteries and created a fourth. The missing pencils were behind my ear, the missing coffee was in Tank, and the printer's complaint about paper size was apparently a complaint about paper size. I had assumed a deeper motive. The fourth mystery concerned a packet labeled URGENT. Inside were six perfectly ordinary crackers and a note from Rosa: not everything in a red envelope is an emergency.

I convened a hearing. 'The department has been misled.' 'By color?' Mercedes asked. 'By presentation.' Shawna turned the packet over. 'It also says crackers.' 'Fine print.' 'It's larger than urgent.' Tank ate one while the evidence was being discussed. I asked him to preserve the chain of custody. He held out the remaining packet. 'Chain starts here. Ends here.' He pointed to his mouth. I entered his explanation into the record under deeply unhelpful and completely accurate.

We had reached the portion of the work where a phrase like point-and-click began trying to do too many jobs. It told us something about a game's ordinary interaction. It did not tell us whether an item had to be dragged, whether dialogue waited, whether a late confrontation demanded a quick response, or whether the inventory contained three things or half a hardware store. Shawna put separate tabs on those questions. I had bought tabs in twelve colors. For the first time all day, a purchase of mine became useful without modification.

The printer produced an extra copy of the same page. I held it up. 'Independent corroboration.' 'Same printer,' said Mercedes. 'Same page,' said Rosa. 'Same expensive idiot,' said Tank, very quietly, because he still wanted access to the snack cabinet. We did not count duplicated claims as fresh evidence. We also did not turn an absent warning into a promise. Some cards had a clear statement from the publisher; some had a specific review; some still needed a check on the actual edition. A blank space stayed a blank space.

Then the gold stamp disappeared. For nine minutes I pursued a theory involving international rivals, a forged signature, and the service elevator. Shawna found it beside the kettle, holding down a curling recipe card. 'I needed something heavy.' 'That seal represents my judgment.' 'Then it's found appropriate work.' She left it there. I was permitted to keep the handle, provided I did not call it an official accessibility certification. Tank wrote KETTLE DIVISION on a fresh label and applied it to my nameplate.

We returned to the cases with less stationery and better questions. Which world looked worth entering? What would your hands actually do? What might pile up in memory? Did a game let the player wait, or did we merely hope it did? There was no humiliation in deciding against a promising story because its interface was unpleasant. The Bureau's job was to offer possibilities. The visitor's job, if any, was to enjoy the evening. Mine was apparently to stop standing in front of the tea bags.

P011 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Old Skies

Yesterday Is Outside the Refund Window

Edition considered: PC release

I wanted a time-travel department for one specific purpose: canceling the table order before Shawna saw it. Tank said we could also retrieve the pastry he dropped that morning. Mercedes proposed returning to the exact second before I founded the department. I began to suspect our historical priorities were incompatible.

Old Skies assigns Fia Quinn the job of supervising paying travelers through the past. This sounded alarmingly like customer service with consequences larger than a bad review. I composed a waiver. Shawna read the first line, which excused me from responsibility for the nineteenth century, and put it in the shredder.

The attraction was not simply visiting different dates. It was encountering people with reasons to go back, then dealing with what those reasons meant. I had been thinking about furniture; the game had unfinished lives in mind. Tank quietly removed his pastry request, although he asked whether crumbs counted as a historical record.

The actual attraction

A time agent's work provides seven historical settings and travelers with different motives. Temporal puzzles and a voiced ensemble connect the speculative premise to questions about regret, curiosity, and the consequences of changing what already happened.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly says the player can die and try again. That is a meaningful failure-state warning, not proof of harmless pacing. Temporal cause and effect can increase memory demands, and later timing, dragging, and dialogue advance need an edition-specific check. Some historical settings carry serious emotional weight.

An opening invitation

Meet Fia and inspect the first assignment before promising a complete excursion. Test ordinary object interaction and the pause/save route; treat any stressful sequence as a reason to reconsider, not an examination to pass.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorized for curiosity about yesterday, with a strict prohibition on using the past to conceal my perfectly traceable furniture expenditure.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description: time-agent premise, historical eras, temporal puzzles, and retryable death. No declared absence of timed sequences established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346360/>

P012 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Primordia

The Printer Discovers Religion

Edition considered: PC release

Primordia concerns robots living among the remains of humanity. I explained this premise to our printer, hoping it would develop perspective. It requested magenta. Tank said perhaps that was its sacred text. I opened the maintenance panel and found enough paper dust to establish a small archaeological site.

Horatio and Crispin's search for a stolen power core struck me as a sensible beginning for a much larger question. Who made this world? What did its makers leave behind? Why does every office possess a cable that fits nothing? Shawna told me the last question was ours, not the game's, and handed me another useless cable.

I liked the contrast between a solitary, principled machine and a companion willing to answer back. Mercedes said we already had that dynamic, except I was neither solitary nor a machine and my principles came with accessories. The printer hummed. For the first time I thought it might be laughing at the correct person.

The actual attraction

A robot partnership explores a post-human landscape and a city whose history changes the meaning of the initial theft. Mechanical decay, belief, independence, and companion banter make its world distinctive rather than merely another collection of locked doors.

The catch worth knowing

Environmental and inventory puzzles still ask for connections and returning to details. Optional puzzles exist, but optional extras do not make the main path effortless. The inspected storefront does not certify zero timers, no holds, or a particular text-wait setting; those remain checks, not benefits to assume.

An opening invitation

Spend an opening scene with Horatio and Crispin. Try examining one object and following one concrete problem, then decide whether the world's mood and puzzle language invite another visit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Entered because a philosophical robot may provide better company than an actual office printer, despite both having strong opinions about power supplies.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description for robots, stolen core, Metropol and optional puzzles. Control and complete-path timing guarantees were not found in that record.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/227000/>

P013 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Strangeland

The Carnival Fails Its Hospitality Inspection

Edition considered: PC release

I suggested a carnival theme for the Bureau's open evening. Rosa asked what attractions I had in mind. I showed her Strangeland: a nightmare park, unsettling inhabitants, and a mystery connected to a woman's repeated death. She returned my proposed welcome banner face down. 'You need to say horror before you say outing.'

The game interested Mercedes because its strange images had something to mean, not simply something to startle. I attempted a profound interpretation of our broken copier. She unplugged it. 'Some metaphors are just broken equipment.' Tank had already named the snack cabinet the Furnace of Endless Want. We allowed that one to stand.

There could be pleasure in deciphering this disturbing world, provided disturbing was what somebody actually wanted. We replaced the carnival invitation with a clear description. No smiley sticker made it gentler. I kept one balloon for myself. It deflated during my explanation of symbolism, which seemed unnecessarily editorial.

The actual attraction

A surreal carnival turns identity, grief, and interpretation into an adventure's setting and puzzles. The publisher describes different solutions and meanings, a voiced cast, and an optional in-character hint system, giving the strange inhabitants more purpose than decoration.

The catch worth knowing

Suicide imagery, repeated death, grotesque bodies, and horror are central. Alternative puzzle solutions do not establish a fully reaction-free path; the publisher itself contrasts a shooting approach with another solution. Inventory reasoning and symbolic interpretation can also be substantial. Verify actual interaction before relying on a particular route.

An opening invitation

Read the premise and look at the opening atmosphere before beginning an investigation. If that is appealing, try one conversation and locate the optional hint system; no need to demonstrate tolerance for distressing imagery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A permit for the deliberately uncanny, withdrawn immediately if the desired carnival contains ordinary popcorn and no existential furnace.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description explicitly covers nightmare imagery, multiple solutions and hints. No universal timing or hold exemption inferred from those alternatives.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1369520/>

P014 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Shardlight

The Stamp Cannot Distribute Hope

Edition considered: PC release

Shardlight's city is ruled by people controlling scarce resources. I immediately hid the Bureau's snack ledger. Rosa found it anyway. 'This says executive biscuits.' 'A quality distinction.' 'It says everyone else may apply.' Tank had filled out three applications under different names, all with the same mustard fingerprint.

Amy Wellard's search for a cure was a different scale of story entirely: a person trying to act inside an unjust system rather than waiting for it to become kind. I took the gold stamp off the table. Some premises do not need management jokes at the center of their explanation. The joke could stay where it belonged, on my ridiculous ledger.

Mercedes opened the cupboard and redistributed the biscuits without commissioning a reform paper. Shawna wrote down the game's bleakness beside its appeal. A determined heroine and a troubled world might be engrossing, but nobody had asked us to disguise disease and deprivation as a pleasant afternoon in a village.

The actual attraction

Amy's investigation gives an oppressive post-apocalyptic world a personal point of entry. The premise puts inequality, loyalty, and the search for a cure into the story, offering a protagonist with a concrete reason to keep asking difficult questions.

The catch worth knowing

Disease, hunger, death, and coercive government are explicit parts of the setting. They can make the experience emotionally heavy even during quiet interaction. Adventure puzzles bring inventory and clue demands. The source inspected here does not establish all-path timing, holding, or dialogue-wait behavior; those require a specific check.

An opening invitation

Try the opening conversation and one stated task only if the setting appeals. Test an inventory interaction and find save/quit before taking on the wider investigation or its darker consequences.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Chosen for a heroine willing to challenge the people controlling the cupboard; the Bureau's executive biscuit classification has consequently been abolished.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact publisher premise inspected, including deprivation and vaccine lottery. Pointer-adventure classification is editorial; no complete-path control verification claimed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336130/>

P015 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Technobabylon

Central Has Denied My Password Request

Edition considered: PC release

Technobabylon's future includes an omnipresent city AI. I offered our printer the position on a temporary basis. It went offline. Mercedes said this was the clearest policy decision the Bureau had received all morning. Tank asked whether the AI could locate his headphones. They were around his neck; he requested that this remain classified.

The game's three perspectives interested me more than the impressive machinery. People inside the same system could have sharply different loyalties, vulnerabilities, and reasons for breaking its rules. Shawna liked that distinction. I tried adding it to the department charter. The charter immediately exceeded the stapler's capacity.

We put the cyberpunk file beside the words mature themes, not under the category shiny future. I had once assumed a good interface could solve any institutional problem. Then I remembered the lunch-order spreadsheet I built with seventeen required fields. Rosa brought me a sandwich and refused to call it a workflow improvement.

The actual attraction

Interwoven perspectives bring a cyberpunk city's systems down to individual choices and loyalties. A police conspiracy, virtual experience, and complicated personal stakes can supply a rich story for someone who enjoys gradually discovering how a speculative society works.

The catch worth knowing

Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, inventory solutions, and layered motives increase the amount to track. The publisher warns of mature themes and violence. Point-and-click presentation does not establish that every later confrontation waits indefinitely, nor that every interaction avoids holds; the inspected source leaves those questions open.

An opening invitation

Follow one opening character and one immediate objective. Check text advance, ordinary interaction, and saving before deciding whether learning this future feels interesting rather than like another system to administer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed for readers who want to question a powerful computer without spending the entire evening explaining to my printer that it is already connected.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher account of three protagonists, Central, Trance, conspiracy and mature content. Exact late-game input demands remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/307580/>

P016 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Unbound

The Department Purchases a Saxophone Alibi

Edition considered: PC release

Blackwell Unbound begins its invitation with 1973 New York and an ethereal saxophone. I decided the Bureau required a more atmospheric entrance. Tank found a recording on his phone. Unfortunately an advertisement for patio furniture interrupted the haunting. The room became melancholy about discounted cushions.

Lauren Blackwell and Joey investigate connections ordinary people have missed. I liked a mystery built from a sound in one place and suspicious trouble elsewhere. Shawna asked whether our new saxophone budget connected to my recent interest in wearing a long coat indoors. I said the evidence was circumstantial. Mercedes said the coat still had the tag on it.

We distinguished this earlier-set story from Rosa's first adventure instead of pretending a sequel number explained everything. Familiarity could help, but it was not an admission requirement set by me. Rosa switched off the advert. The quiet that followed was excellent, and unlike the coat, it had cost us nothing.

The actual attraction

An earlier Blackwell investigation changes the central human partner while retaining Joey's sardonic presence. Period New York, a ghostly musician, and apparently separate incidents provide a contained supernatural mystery with a different emotional texture from Legacy.

The catch worth knowing

Clues, names, dialogue topics, and switching attention between the living and the dead can still require tracking. This title's publisher record does not certify the same manual-speech patch behavior as another Blackwell game. Do not transfer Legacy's review-based timing assurance or Ctrl+P setup without checking this edition.

An opening invitation

Meet Lauren and Joey, listen to the first lead, and inspect the actual text and interaction settings. Continue because their relationship interests you, not because a series order has become another obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Issued a period-appropriate file for anyone tempted by a supernatural saxophone, with the Bureau's patio-furniture advertisement removed from the atmosphere.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description establishes Lauren, Joey, 1973 and connected incidents. Input settings and no-timer claims are not inherited from other series entries.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80340/>

P017 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Convergence

The Empty Office Has a Better Lease Than We Do

Edition considered: PC release

Blackwell Convergence offers an empty uptown office, a troubled film, an artist, and an investor. I liked the empty office best until Shawna reminded me that it was evidence, not available workspace. I had already measured where the table might go. Tank asked whether a haunting reduced the deposit.

A story drawing separate city lives together suited the Bureau's finest habit: suspecting that everything was connected. Mercedes pointed out that our missing labels and our jammed printer were connected because I had fed the labels into the wrong tray. Not every conspiracy required a corkboard. Some required reading the arrow on a box.

Still, there was pleasure in seeing a familiar partnership follow a new set of threads. We placed the game beside its predecessors without claiming that returning characters eliminated every burden. I crossed out my property inquiry. Shawna kept the measuring tape, correctly anticipating that I would mistake another mysterious room for a branch office.

The actual attraction

Rosa and Joey return to a city mystery whose apparently separate people and locations conceal a larger connection. Familiar characters can make another investigation attractive after an earlier entry, while the art, film, and finance setting gives it a specific flavor.

The catch worth knowing

This is a later series entry, so character history and supernatural rules add context to the clues. Inventory and conversational deductions remain work. The inspected publisher description establishes the premise, not a guarantee about timed scenes, held inputs, or current dialogue controls on every version.

An opening invitation

If the partnership already appeals, investigate one opening location and one lead. Check text waiting and item use on this installation rather than relying on remembered settings from a different Blackwell title.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted for the pleasure of discovering why strangers share a secret, with an explicit ban on converting an unoccupied crime scene into my executive suite.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected for connected film, office, artist and investor story. Later-series burden is editorial judgment; control guarantees remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80350/>

P018 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Deception

The Fortune Teller Predicts a Rejected Expense Claim

Edition considered: PC release

I set up a neon sign promising wealth, happiness, and a correctly sorted game shelf. Mercedes asked which promise I could substantiate. I demonstrated the sign's excellent electrical workmanship. She unplugged it. The future became darker but more accurate.

Blackwell Deception concerns people exploiting hope, and the spirits left behind when their victims die. That made the distinction between an entertaining mystery and an actual promise particularly useful. Shawna took my APPROVED stamp away from the recommendation column. 'Nobody gets guaranteed happiness from stationery.' Tank asked whether the guarantee included the neon sign's return policy.

Rosa and Joey's investigation could still be inviting: clubs, apartments, a yacht, and secrets with personal consequences. I pictured myself arriving discreetly at the yacht. Everyone pictured the opposite. We left the game to its detectives and the sign to its box. On the box, Tank wrote FUTURE PENDING REFUND in very clear letters.

The actual attraction

A mystery about fraudulent psychics lets an established supernatural partnership investigate both exploitation and personal secrets. Contrasting city settings and Joey's buried history may reward someone already curious about these characters rather than only the next puzzle solution.

The catch worth knowing

Death and manipulation of vulnerable hopes are central themes. Existing series relationships, dialogue, and clue connections can accumulate. The publisher premise does not establish an all-path absence of timed inputs or holds. Current text advance and inventory behavior should be checked independently of earlier Blackwell editions.

An opening invitation

Try one conversation and one lead if Rosa and Joey are welcome company. Notice the tone as well as the controls; interest in supernatural mysteries does not require enjoying every kind of darker subject.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted investigation rights because a story can question false promises while offering good company; my neon happiness guarantee has been removed from service.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description of psychic fraud and Joey's secrets. No unsupported transfer of input or timing features from another Blackwell game.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80360/>

P019 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Epiphany

The Blizzard Is Not a Seasonal Decoration

Edition considered: PC release

I requested snow for the Bureau's winter mystery display. The supplier asked how much. 'Enough to suggest depth.' Tank read Blackwell Epiphany's premise and said we should start by suggesting a coat. Shawna pointed to the threat against the dead themselves. I quietly removed the phrase festive chills from the welcome card.

A series reaching a grave question about its own supernatural world could be powerful precisely because the characters had become familiar. Mercedes said that was different from requiring everyone to begin with the finale. I had been about to announce a shortcut through four games. Apparently emotional context could not be expedited by courier.

We placed the file near the earlier investigations, with room for someone to choose the beginning instead. Tank put the artificial snow back in its carton. One handful remained on my chair. When I sat down, a glittering cloud rose around the director, providing all the seasonal foolishness the room actually needed.

The actual attraction

The final Blackwell story raises the stakes around Rosa, Joey, and the nature of the spirits they help. For someone already attached to the partnership, the larger mystery offers emotional continuity and the possibility of a meaningful series conclusion.

The catch worth knowing

Destruction of souls, death, and a bleak winter atmosphere make this a darker choice. It is a later entry with accumulated character history, not necessarily the best introduction. The publisher's story description does not verify every timed, held-input, or text-advance behavior; inspect this edition directly.

An opening invitation

Consider whether earlier Blackwell stories sound more inviting before opening the finale. If continuing an enjoyed series, try the opening investigation and verify dialogue waiting and saving without committing to finishing its darker arc.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Reserved for an existing attachment to these two investigators, not for my theory that putting snow on a folder makes tragedy suitable for a holiday party.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description of the central threat. Series-position recommendation is editorial; no complete-path control or emotional-fit guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/236930/>

P020 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Shivah: Kosher Edition

The Donation Arrives With a Question Mark

Edition considered: PC Kosher Edition

An unexpected payment arrived at the Bureau, and I immediately planned a second nameplate. Shawna checked the envelope. It was a refund for a canceled nameplate. Tank said the department had finally discovered a renewable source of disappointment.

The Shivah begins with a financially troubled rabbi receiving money from a dead former congregant and being unable to simply take the windfall at face value. The interesting part was conscience making an apparently convenient answer insufficient. I understood that in principle. In practice, I had already selected the second nameplate's lettering.

Mercedes asked what I would do if the money carried a difficult history. 'Investigate.' 'Before buying the sign?' I took a moment to demonstrate thoughtfulness. Rosa set a plain handwritten label on my desk. It said AIDEN, in ordinary ink, and performed the entire job. We gave the fictional rabbi his moral question and left my stationery problem at an appropriately smaller scale.

The actual attraction

A short-form mystery places conscience, faith, and doubt inside a specific New York community. Russell Stone's reason to investigate is personal and ethical, giving the conversations an appeal beyond collecting evidence for an abstract case.

The catch worth knowing

This card specifies the Kosher Edition, whose publisher lists revised presentation, voiced dialogue, multiple endings, and a distinctive conversation/combat system. That last feature requires checking rather than assuming all point-and-click interaction is relaxed. Death, cynicism, and moral decisions also give it a serious tone.

An opening invitation

Meet Rabbi Stone and hear the premise. Preview how a conversation choice works and how to save or leave; do not use the early calm as proof that the later confrontation has no timing demands.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted when an inconvenient moral question sounds more interesting than an uncomplicated windfall; the Bureau will investigate its refund before ordering anything engraved.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher's explicitly titled Kosher Edition page, including conversation/combat and endings. Timing and holds not verified; unrelated or unresolved store matches excluded.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/the-shivah/>

P021 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Resonance

Four Witnesses, One Deeply Suspicious Whiteboard

Edition considered: PC release

I announced that our investigation now required four simultaneous versions of me. Shawna asked whether one reliable version might be a cheaper pilot. I explained that Resonance followed four people whose lives converged around dangerous scientific work. Clearly, a man with my range should cover at least three of them. Tank put four mugs on the desk and watched me lose track of which one contained tea.

The whiteboard was divided into LONG-TERM MEMORY, SHORT-TERM MEMORY, and THINGS AIDEN SAID WITH CONFIDENCE. Mercedes drew a thick border around the last section. 'Separate evidentiary standard.' I connected the tea mugs with red string, which made the drinking arrangements considerably worse without advancing particle physics.

When Rosa asked what the actual appeal was, I said secrets, intersecting lives, and the pleasure of noticing connections. 'Good,' she said. 'Leave that on the board.' The rest came down, including the string attached to my watch.

The actual attraction

Four playable characters approach a science-fiction conspiracy from different lives and loyalties. The unusual memory system lets remembered subjects become conversation material, giving investigation more texture than simply collecting objects and exhausting a fixed list of questions.

The catch worth knowing

Character switching, separate knowledge, inventory and two kinds of stored memory create substantial bookkeeping. The developer's dramatic race-against-the-clock wording does not establish which passages use actual timers. Required late action and held-input demands remain unverified; this is a conditional mystery, not a no-rush certification.

An opening invitation

Explore one character's first available conversation and inspect how a remembered subject becomes a question. Keep a short note with that character's name and immediate objective before considering a second viewpoint.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when connecting four suspicious lives sounds enjoyable; decline if the Bureau's four-mug incident already resembles an unpaid administrative position.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports four playable characters and the long-/short-term memory system. It does not verify a wholly untimed path. This is Wadjet Eye's adventure, not another product with Resonance in its name.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/resonance/>

P022 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Gemini Rue

The Raincoat Does Not Remove the Gunfight

Edition considered: PC release

I wore a raincoat into the Bureau to establish noir credibility. The ceiling was dry. Tank supplied a small watering can and asked whether authenticity should include the paperwork. Gemini Rue looked exactly like the sort of rain-soaked, compromised future in which I could deliver an excellent monologue beside a broken neon sign.

Mercedes read the file. 'There's combat.' I continued gazing mournfully through the window. 'A troubled man confronts his past.' 'And combat.' I adjusted the collar. 'Two lives, fractured identity, institutional secrets.' She placed the word COMBAT directly over the portrait I had clipped to the dossier.

Shawna explained that atmosphere and input were separate questions. That was inconveniently correct. I surrendered the raincoat and kept the recommendation in the detour drawer, where an interesting story could remain interesting without pretending its gunfights were merely enthusiastic conversations. Tank watered the office plant instead. It immediately looked more qualified for detective work.

The actual attraction

Azriel's search on a bleak colony world intertwines with an amnesiac captive's story. The attraction is adult science-fiction noir: damaged identities, oppressive institutions, rain, and uncertainty about how two apparently separate lives connect.

The catch worth knowing

This adventure includes required combat, so ordinary point-and-click investigation does not describe the complete experience. The PC interface also uses contextual actions. A publisher announcement discusses redesigned combat for a mobile port; that port's accommodations must not be assumed present on PC. A no-rush route is not established.

An opening invitation

If the atmosphere appeals, inspect an early investigation scene while someone checks the PC combat requirements separately. Do not treat a comfortable conversation as evidence that the later action will suit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Keep for a deliberate noir detour or shared viewing, with the gunfight warning attached more firmly than my decorative detective badge ever was.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC store supports the dual-character premise; the developer's mobile announcement explicitly confirms a combat system. Mobile redesign claims are not transferred to the PC edition. Complete PC control/timing accommodations are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80310/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/2013/04/11/gemini-rue-now-on-the-app-store/>

P023 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Emerald City Confidential

The Emerald City Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC release

The moment I heard Oz had a private investigator, I prepared my testimony. Mercedes asked what crime I was confessing to. 'None. I am a valuable witness to my own importance.' She opened a fresh notebook under the heading MOTIVE. Emerald City Confidential offered familiar storybook figures wearing the moral weather of a detective film, which struck me as an overdue improvement to civic tourism.

Tank arrived with a green desk lamp and a receipt charging it to Magical Infrastructure. I approved the expense until Shawna pointed out that this meant our missing stapler now qualified as a metropolitan corruption case. The lamp cast a sinister glow over its perfectly ordinary position beside my elbow.

Rosa suggested we let Petra, the actual detective, conduct her own inquiry. I agreed, provided the city recognized my consulting status. Mercedes wrote CONSULTING STATUS: UNRECOGNIZED. For a supposedly enchanted place, Oz had acquired excellent standards.

The actual attraction

Petra investigates an Oz recast as a noir city, meeting altered versions of recognizable figures. The pleasure lies in the friction between childhood storybook associations and a mystery full of suspects, witnesses and complicated motives.

The catch worth knowing

Recognizable characters do not make the investigation childish or mechanically effortless. Expect dialogue, clues and puzzle connections across locations. The inspected publisher material establishes the mystery structure but does not settle every timed sequence, drag gesture or later input requirement. Treat those as checks, not absent features.

An opening invitation

Meet Petra and follow one early conversation far enough to decide whether the reimagined Oz feels intriguing. Inspect one clue deliberately before opening a larger chain of objectives or consulting a walkthrough.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve if a fairy-tale city hiring a tired detective is your kind of absurdity; the green lamp confers atmosphere, no professional qualifications and absolutely no jurisdiction over snacks.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher descriptions support Petra, the Oz reinterpretation, voiced characters and investigation across five chapters. No blanket no-timer or hold-free claim is established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/37260/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/emerald-city-confidential/>

P024 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Mermaid Mask

Submarine Reservations for a Man Who Cannot Pack Light

Edition considered: PC release; current release status verify

I booked the Bureau an imaginary submarine excursion because a murder aboard a peculiar vessel deserved maritime expertise. Tank looked at the six trunks I had assembled. 'Which one contains the expertise?' I pointed to the smallest. It contained cufflinks, a compass-shaped biscuit and a photograph of me beside a boat that had never left its restaurant.

Grimoire and Sally were investigating the Mortuga. I proposed joining as Chief Surface Consultant. Shawna explained that a locked-room mystery did not improve when an extra man arrived carrying a portable lectern. Mercedes added that the submarine was already suspicious enough without my luggage manifest.

We inspected the game instead. Strange crew, detailed objects, an impossible death: at last, a vessel with something better to offer than my nautical speech. Rosa unpacked the biscuit. My compass was eaten before it could lead anybody astray, which counts as an unusually successful voyage.

The actual attraction

Grimoire and Sally investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine. Voiced suspects, an elaborate locked-room setup and objects to examine offer a richly theatrical detective outing, with the investigators' partnership anchoring the weirdness.

The catch worth knowing

The current PC listing declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Those are developer declarations, not a personal control trial. Inspectable three-dimensional clues may still involve gestures worth testing; dialogue, case-file relationships and deductions retain a meaningful memory load.

An opening invitation

Enter an early conversation, inspect a clue, then test how its view changes and how the case file records it. Judge those operations before committing to solving the whole submarine's personnel problems.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Strongly consider for a strange, characterful mystery whose official pacing declaration is encouraging. Bring curiosity; leave the six-trunk consulting practice on the dock where it belongs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact current Steam game and SFB site confirm release, premise and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Released July 16, 2026. Object-manipulation comfort is not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1696770/>

Source 2: <https://www.sfbgames.com/>

P025 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

The Tourist Who Filed a Conspiracy Expense Claim

Edition considered: PC Reforged edition

Paris seemed an excellent place to expand the Bureau. I imagined a tasteful office above a cafe, my name on the glass, and an expense account capable of understanding pastries. George Stobbart's holiday apparently took a different direction. Shawna described the Templar mystery. I crossed out LEISURE and wrote RESEARCH in the same expensive pen.

Mercedes asked why every item on my itinerary was edible. 'Local intelligence.' Tank held up a croissant. 'Then this source is flaky.' I considered dismissing him until Rosa pointed out that his report was both accurate and already paid for.

Broken Sword's attraction was the journey: George and Nico, places with history, questions that grow beyond one incident. I tried to appoint myself Third Lead. Mercedes assigned me the more practical role of Person Who Remembers Where We Put the Mouse. It was demanding work, but for once the appointment addressed an actual vacancy.

The actual attraction

George Stobbart and journalist Nico Collard follow a Templar conspiracy through a classic travel adventure. Reforged presents the first Broken Sword in a modern visual edition, retaining the appeal of conversation, places, objects and a mystery expanding beyond an ordinary trip.

The catch worth knowing

Classic inventory logic and returning to locations can require notes or outside hints. The inspected Reforged page does not establish an entirely untimed, hold-free completion path. Verify troublesome set pieces in this exact edition before recommending it for a strict no-rush requirement; older versions are not interchangeable evidence.

An opening invitation

Try an early safe conversation and inspect a nearby object, watching whether the interface makes available actions clear. Stop after that small investigation and decide whether the travel-mystery tone earns further checking.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit provisionally for people who enjoy a holiday acquiring historical complications. My pastry receipts remain excluded from the evidence because somebody has eaten the exhibits and the margins.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution's page identifies the 2024 Reforged edition and supports premise and adventure structure. Full-path timing and held-input details remain unverified; no older-edition accommodation is assumed.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-1/

P026 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

An Obsidian Artifact Versus My Gift-Shop Magnet

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

An obsidian artifact can apparently begin a vast international mystery. I put our souvenir fridge magnet into an evidence bag and waited for the same professional momentum. Mercedes read its inscription: I WENT TO THE BEACH. 'The conspiracy is concealing very little.' I told her that obviousness was often the first layer.

Broken Sword's second case reunited George and Nico around a dangerous discovery. I reunited Tank and Rosa around the problem of my evidence bag being the last clean sandwich bag. Rosa resolved that conflict in favor of lunch. The magnet resumed its civilian employment holding up a shopping list.

Shawna reminded me that this was the Remastered second game, not a fresh copy of the first one's guarantees. I said the Bureau loved precision. She turned my dossier around. I had written BROKEN SPOON. In my defense, the kitchen had recently suffered an unrelated incident and deserved its own investigation.

The actual attraction

George and Nico return in a second globe-spanning mystery involving an artifact, criminal entanglements and a larger historical threat. The attraction is their continuing partnership and the traditional pleasure of turning an apparently isolated discovery into a much stranger story.

The catch worth knowing

The Remastered edition must be assessed on its own. Inventory puzzles, revisiting places and remembering what each person knows can become demanding. Its adventure label does not prove that every hazardous scene waits indefinitely; the inspected developer page leaves complete timing and hold requirements unresolved.

An opening invitation

Inspect the actual controls and one early interaction before investing in a long session. If the opening danger itself feels unwelcome, switch games rather than treating endurance as the price of seeing the later mystery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

File beside the first adventure for readers who want more of this particular partnership, with its own control questions attached. Do not substitute the beach magnet for a second source.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies the second game's Remastered edition and artifact-led story. No edition-specific complete no-timer/no-hold route was verified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-2/

P027 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword 5 - the Serpent's Curse

The Gallery Has Rejected My Self-Portrait

Edition considered: PC complete release

A stolen painting brought George and Nico back to work. I understood immediately. My own portrait had vanished from the Bureau reception area that morning. I assembled the staff, dimmed the lights and demanded to know who benefited from my disappearance. 'The reception area,' Mercedes said. Even Shawna looked away to hide a smile.

Tank produced the painting from behind a chair. He had moved it because its frame blocked the thermostat. I explained that art often challenged comfort. Rosa explained that visitors should not have to roast beneath my painted expression of modest achievement.

The Serpent's Curse offered a more substantial gallery crime than our heating dispute: murder, a missing work and a conspiracy. I restored the room to normal and wrote one excellent question at the top of the file. Why that painting? Mercedes nodded. 'See? You can investigate something without making it a referendum on your cheekbones.'

The actual attraction

The fifth Broken Sword begins with a Paris gallery robbery and murder, then follows George and Nico into a conspiracy. Fully voiced characters and classic point-and-click investigation make it an invitation to follow people, motives and a troublesome work of art.

The catch worth knowing

Expect inventory reasoning and an expanding cast. Revolution lists extra interface features under a separate Definitive Edition heading; this card does not assume that those features exist in the selected PC release. Required timing, holds and speech-advance behavior need checking in the installed edition.

An opening invitation

Follow the first available witness exchange and inspect a piece of gallery evidence. Notice whether dialogue pace and object selection feel comfortable before adding a second location or a page of speculative connections.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommend conditionally when a cultured theft turning into an uncultured conspiracy sounds appealing. Portraits of Bureau personnel are not acceptable substitutes for checking which edition is actually installed.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports gallery theft/murder and classic point-and-click structure. Its Definitive Edition feature list is explicitly not transferred to the unspecified complete PC edition; full timing remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-5/

P028 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Beneath a Steel Sky

The City Computer Wants My Expense Password

Edition considered: 1994 PC original

A city governed by a sinister artificial intelligence seemed an appropriate place to submit my expense account. Surely a machine would appreciate the mathematical inevitability of a gold-plated stamp. Shawna said that an oppressive computer and a competent accountant were different problems, and mine could be solved by either one saying no.

Robert Foster arrived in Union City with a robot friend's circuit board and a much more serious reason to distrust authority. I arrived with a printer cartridge and a petty grievance. Tank suggested that, should we be abducted into a dystopia, my first priority ought to be escape rather than requesting a corner office.

Mercedes placed our office rules beside the game file. There were forty-seven. Rosa removed forty-six, leaving ASK BEFORE BORROWING SOMEONE'S CHAIR. I considered this a dangerous weakening of institutional power. Everyone sat down more happily, which made my position surprisingly difficult to defend.

The actual attraction

This is the original 1994 adventure: Robert Foster is taken into a city under authoritarian machine control, accompanied by the circuit board of his robot friend. Its appeal is a bleak science-fiction setting with room for satirical personality and practical investigation.

The catch worth knowing

This older adventure's interface, object logic and navigation deserve a direct trial. Abduction, violence and oppressive institutions shape the story. The developer page does not establish a death-free or untimed complete path, and its mobile release details must not be transferred to the original PC game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first accessible environment and identify the immediate objective without trying to cover the whole city. Check how examining and using an object differ, then decide whether that interaction makes sense in practice.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for a taste of dystopian mystery when old adventure conventions sound interesting. Deny any city computer permission to interpret my stationery budget as a model for civilization.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies original release 1994, Foster, Union City and the AI premise. The card targets original PC, not the later mobile edition or Beyond a Steel Sky. Complete timing/death/hold behavior remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/beneath-a-steel-sky/

P029 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Kathy Rain: Director's Cut

Journalism Has Asked to See My Sources

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Kathy Rain had a motorcycle, a notebook and a family mystery. I had a swivel chair, a monogrammed pen and a theory about who kept lowering my chair. The similarities were obvious until Mercedes asked whether I had interviewed anybody other than myself. I said that narrowing the source pool reduced inconsistency.

Shawna raised the chair. 'There. Investigative breakthrough.' I lowered my voice and explained that the chair might be a symptom of a much larger pattern. Rosa handed me Kathy's file, where a grandfather's death and the past of a small town actually justified serious questions.

The notebook appealed to me. Evidence should have somewhere to live besides the back of a shopping receipt. Tank supplied a clean one, then confiscated my proposed cover: TRUTHS TOO LARGE FOR ORDINARY PEOPLE. He wrote NOTES. I protested that the title lacked atmosphere. 'It leaves space for facts,' he said.

The actual attraction

Kathy's investigation connects her grandfather's death, family history and the secrets of a small town. The Director's Cut expands the original mystery and advertises a single-click mouse interface, making the combination of investigative conversation and a clear protagonist worth examining.

The catch worth knowing

A simpler click interface does not remove puzzle memory or emotional intensity. Family trauma and disturbing material matter here. The source does not settle every late chase, timer or held-input requirement. This is specifically Director's Cut, not an assumption that the 2016 original behaves identically.

An opening invitation

Read the initial context and try one conversation with Kathy's notebook close at hand. Assess both the single-click interaction and whether this family mystery feels compelling today; neither decision requires completing a case.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a sharp, adult protagonist and a troubled hometown sound like good company. The Bureau authorizes an ordinary notebook and withdraws my twelve-word title from circulation immediately.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Director's Cut listing supports single-click interface, expanded story and family investigation. It is not a full-path accessibility audit; late required timing and holds remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1395030/>

P030 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Whispers of a Machine

My Personality Upgrade Requires a Reboot

Edition considered: PC release

Vera's abilities responded to her approach to people, which I considered an excellent argument for equipping me with advanced investigative technology. Mercedes asked which upgrade corresponded to making a speech while someone else fixed the problem. 'Strategic presence,' I said. She searched the imaginary menu and found nothing.

Whispers of a Machine offered a cybernetic investigator whose choices could change how she solved things. I announced my three available approaches: Magnificent, Extremely Magnificent, and Waiting for Applause. Shawna added a fourth: LISTEN. This generated more applause than I had budgeted for.

Tank brought me a headset made from two paper cups. 'Prototype empathy augmentation.' I put it on and heard Rosa asking whether anybody wanted tea. For once I answered the actual question before developing a theory about it. The technology was crude, but the results suggested a promising future for the entire institution.

The actual attraction

Vera investigates murders in a Nordic science-fiction world where forbidden technology and personal history intersect. Her responses influence the augmentations available for solving problems, connecting the detective's character to the practical shape of the investigation.

The catch worth knowing

Different abilities, dialogue approaches and possible solutions create more to remember than a single straightforward clue chain. The premise includes violence and grief. The inspected listing does not establish every required timer or held gesture, so character depth should not be mistaken for a simple interface promise.

An opening invitation

Follow an early conversation and choose the response that feels natural, then inspect how the game explains Vera's available abilities. Write down one ability in plain language instead of trying to optimize an entire personality.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit if the idea of a detective's temperament influencing her methods sounds intriguing. Paper-cup empathy upgrades remain available in the lobby, provided I stop talking long enough for them to work.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports Vera, cybernetic abilities shaped by responses, voiced dialogue and multiple puzzle solutions. Memory rating is editorial; full-path timing and input requirements are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/631570/>

P031 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Kathy Rain 2: Soothsayer

The Detective Budget Has Finally Found a Plot

Edition considered: PC release

Kathy Rain's next investigation began with a financial problem, which made her immediately relatable to the Bureau's treasurer. I explained that our deficit was an investment in future authority. Shawna pointed at the invoice for embossed folders. 'Your future authority has ordered the wrong size.' I called that a bold rejection of conventional filing.

The Soothsayer case promised Kathy a way out of money trouble and into something considerably worse. Mercedes asked whether I could distinguish a compelling fictional predicament from a sensible household budgeting strategy. I could, although the distinction did damage to my proposed detective-reward revenue forecast.

Rosa slid a plain envelope across the desk. It contained enough for ordinary paper and a note saying NO MORE GOLD EDGES. I found the restraint moving. Tank found the arithmetic easier. We gave Kathy the dangerous case and gave me the equally appropriate challenge of operating within one envelope.

The actual attraction

The sequel follows Kathy in 1998 as a private investigator drawn into the Soothsayer serial-killer case. Its appeal is an established adult lead facing a larger city, new people and a case that ties professional ambition to immediate financial stakes.

The catch worth knowing

A larger investigation means more names, locations and clues, even with a notebook to organize them. Serial murder brings dark material. The inspected store page establishes the story and notebook, not a guarantee about all late timing or input sequences. Director's Cut findings do not automatically apply to this sequel.

An opening invitation

Read Kathy's opening situation and investigate one available lead. Use the notebook to summarize what the lead means, then judge whether the sequel's mood and interface invite another conversation rather than another obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when you want to follow Kathy into a bigger case, not because a larger budget promises simpler play. My envelope system remains available at a much smaller dramatic scale.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 sequel listing supports 1998 setting, financial premise, Soothsayer investigation and notebook. All-path timing and held inputs remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1466390/>

P032 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Tangle Tower

The Painting Would Like a Lawyer

Edition considered: PC release

A murder mystery in which a painted figure appeared to be implicated seemed designed to rehabilitate my reception portrait. 'At last,' I told Mercedes, 'proof that artwork can possess agency.' She said the only agency my portrait possessed was making people choose a different chair. I filed that as a hostile witness statement.

Tangle Tower supplied a strange mansion, a peculiar family and a very inconvenient crime scene. I supplied a tiny paper lawyer to stand beside my frame. Shawna asked why the lawyer looked like me. I explained that legal representation required trust. 'Then your painting needs a second opinion.'

Tank turned the portrait toward the wall while Rosa opened the actual mystery. The painted suspects had better expressions, the investigators had better questions, and the mansion had better lighting. I withdrew my objection. A detective game should be permitted to outshine the office decor without triggering a constitutional crisis.

The actual attraction

Grimoire and Sally investigate Freya Fellow's death in a mansion where a painting appears entangled in the crime. A fully voiced, animated cast and richly drawn rooms make conversation and character observation a large part of the appeal.

The catch worth knowing

The current PC listing declares mouse-only play, play without timed input and saving at any time. Those declarations are useful but do not establish comfortable dragging or manipulation of every puzzle object. Remembering family relationships and comparing testimony still require attention; an untimed mystery can be a substantial mystery.

An opening invitation

Speak with one suspect and inspect one object closely enough to test selection and any manipulation. Decide whether the voices, expressions and room details make you want to ask a second question.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising first stop for an eccentric, theatrical investigation with encouraging declared pacing. The painting may retain counsel; my self-portrait must continue representing itself on a strictly unpaid basis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports premise, voices and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Gesture comfort and complete-path suitability have not been independently tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/359510/>

P033 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Detective Grimoire

The Swamp Monster Has Better Visitor Facilities

Edition considered: 2014 PC commercial game; not Flash original

I proposed that the Bureau open a swamp attraction. Tank asked whether the swamp existed. I pointed to the damp patch beneath my abandoned noir raincoat. 'We start small.' Mercedes said that charging admission to an office maintenance problem was an unusually pure expression of my business instincts.

Detective Grimoire's case concerned a real attraction within its fictional swamp, a dead owner and a creature everybody seemed ready to suspect. I admired the efficiency of a community arriving with its own suspect. Shawna admired nothing about that sentence and made me read the word EVIDENCE aloud.

Rosa shut our attraction before opening day by hanging up the raincoat. I protested that a unique cultural opportunity had been lost. Tank placed a paper sign beside the dry floor: MONSTER NOT CONFIRMED. It was the most honest advertising the Bureau had produced all week, and therefore completely unsuitable for my original campaign.

The actual attraction

The commercial 2014 Detective Grimoire builds a compact murder investigation around an odd swamp attraction and its inhabitants. Interviews and assembled conclusions give the detective's reasoning a visible role, while the creature rumors invite questions about what people assume and why.

The catch worth knowing

This is the paid standalone game, not the earlier browser title. Its mouse/touch-oriented design still involves connecting ideas and handling puzzle interfaces. The inspected listing does not explicitly verify that every sequence is untimed or that no drag-and-hold gesture is required; check the actual build before treating it as a sure fit.

An opening invitation

Meet an early witness and try forming one small conclusion from the available ideas. Observe whether selecting and joining those ideas feels natural, without imposing a deadline for reaching the correct answer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when an eccentric little suspect community sounds appealing. Any swamp attraction founded by me requires independent plumbing inspection before the Bureau will permit the word tourism on its paperwork.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The 2014 commercial game's Steam listing supports the swamp case, voiced cast, conclusion system and mouse/touch design. Complete timing and held-gesture requirements are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/272600/>

P034 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Roottrees are Dead

A Family Tree with a Very Ambitious Root

Edition considered: 2025 Steam remake; not free browser original

I began our genealogy session by placing my own photograph at the top of the family tree. Shawna asked whether I was claiming to be everyone's ancestor. 'Symbolically.' Mercedes moved the photograph to a separate sheet titled UNRELATED FUNDING APPLICANT. This was hostile, but the diagram became easier to read.

The Roottrees investigation involved inheritance, blood relationships and an early internet full of clues. I offered to improve the family's public image for a modest fictional retainer. Rosa pointed out that identifying a person and liking a person were different tasks. Tank pointed out that my retainer consisted of the last chocolate biscuit.

We started with one confirmed relationship instead of my forty-seven speculative branches. Suddenly the tree looked like evidence rather than a climbing frame for my ego. I reclaimed the biscuit under a newly discovered legal principle: if nobody hires the consultant, he may still eat his own lunch.

The actual attraction

The 2025 remake turns a wealthy family's genealogy into an investigation through a simulated 1998 internet. Photographs, articles and other fragments gradually identify people and their relationships, making the central reward the moment scattered information clicks into a coherent family tree.

The catch worth knowing

Names, generations, visual identification and search terms create a heavy memory and reading load. Typing and navigating the information interface matter more than reflexes in the described core activity, but that does not certify every input as effortless. This remake differs from the free 2023 browser original.

An opening invitation

Identify one person using one clearly connected source, then place or record that single relationship. A separate scratch note can hold a name while you test the search and family-tree interface without filling the whole chart.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for someone who enjoys following documentary threads and can tolerate a busy evidence web. Reject my attempt to inherit merely by occupying the diagram's largest available rectangle with confidence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 Steam remake listing supports early-internet research, family-tree deduction and rebuilt interface. The memory assessment is editorial; no universal timing/hold guarantee is inferred from the genre.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2754380/>

P035 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Rise of the Golden Idol

The Seventies Have Requested a Wider Collar

Edition considered: PC base game

I wore a large-collared shirt to receive The Rise of the Golden Idol. Mercedes said the collar entered the room several seconds before I did. I told her historical immersion required commitment. Tank asked whether the shirt needed its own chair. It did, but I refused to dignify the question with a seating chart.

The game's strange chain of crimes and coincidences belonged to the 1970s, two centuries beyond its predecessor. I proposed that my shirt was therefore valid primary evidence. Shawna said clothing could establish a mood without establishing a fact, a distinction that ruined at least half my public appearances.

Rosa put one case before us. One scene, some people, something that did not add up. My collar stopped being the most interesting object in the room. This was a severe institutional setback and an excellent sign for the game, which had achieved it without appointing a single wardrobe committee.

The actual attraction

A new era gives the Golden Idol deduction format fresh social scenery: investigators piece together strange events involving crime, belief and institutional ambition. The game invites close reading of scenes and reconstructing what happened rather than steering an action hero through them.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly describes exploring scenes at your own pace. That supports unhurried observation, not low complexity: names, collected words, connections across cases and chapter-level deductions can become dense. Input comfort and any required dragging still need a local check; dark crime scenes are central.

An opening invitation

Open the first case, inspect a small cluster of connected clues, and try stating aloud what seems to have happened before filling every answer. Leave the broader conspiracy for another sitting if the first scene is enough.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising choice for patient deduction when a puzzle-rich mystery sounds pleasurable. The Bureau accepts no claim that a wider shirt collar provides a wider evidentiary perspective or additional deduction slots.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description supports 1970s setting, twenty cases and exploration at the player's pace. The waits label refers to scene investigation, not a tested blanket guarantee about every input or comfort need.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2716400/>

P036 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Gabriel Knight: Sins of the Fathers 20th Anniversary Edition

The Bookshop Owner Declines My Autobiography

Edition considered: PC 20th Anniversary Edition

A novelist running a bookshop while investigating sinister murders struck me as a man with the correct number of simultaneous occupations. I offered Gabriel Knight my autobiography for his shelves. Mercedes asked whether it had an ending. 'History is ongoing.' She said this was also a problem with my staff meetings.

New Orleans supplied a setting full of atmosphere, while the mystery drew Gabriel toward his family's past. I supplied a stack of imaginary signed copies. Tank used them to level the wobbly table. For the first time my collected wisdom had produced an immediate, measurable improvement to somebody's day.

Shawna insisted we identify the exact game: the twentieth-anniversary remake, not the old release with assumptions taped over it. Rosa added that a dark story could be compelling without becoming tonight's obligation. I agreed and shortened my book signing to no books, no queue and one grateful table.

The actual attraction

Gabriel's investigation of ritual murders draws a writer and bookshop owner into a family mystery in New Orleans. The twentieth-anniversary edition retells the first game with rebuilt presentation and additional material, offering a strong dose of place, conversation and supernatural noir.

The catch worth knowing

The story includes murder, horror and fictionalized religious material. Adventure puzzles can demand inventory reasoning and remembered conversations. This remake's complete path has not been checked for every dangerous or timed passage; do not assume its modern presentation removes the original design's possible pressure points.

An opening invitation

Try one early conversation or bookshop interaction and see whether Gabriel's personality and the setting appeal. Check the interface at the same time, keeping the first objective small rather than committing to the entire supernatural history.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit conditionally for an atmospheric adult mystery with literary ambitions. My autobiography may remain beneath the table until it proves a more useful clue than a furniture repair technique ever should.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact twentieth-anniversary Steam edition supports Gabriel, New Orleans, murders and added remake material. Complete timing and held-input requirements remain unverified; fictional portrayals are not presented as cultural research.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/262000/>

P037 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Still Life

Two Investigators and One Unqualified Art Critic

Edition considered: 2005 PC original

I thought Still Life might qualify as a pleasant afternoon discussing fruit bowls. Mercedes opened the dossier. 'Serial murder.' I turned my proposed wine-and-cheese reception into a much quieter tea service. A title, it appeared, could not be trusted to perform the entire work of content screening for me.

The investigation crossed between Victoria in Chicago and an earlier case involving her grandfather in Prague. I constructed a family timeline with two photographs and an extremely expensive piece of string. Shawna asked why the string was expensive. I explained that it had been sold as exhibition cord. She explained that it remained string.

Rosa read the later control warning and kept it attached to the front. The grim crime story and the timing-dependent robot puzzle belonged in the same recommendation. I wanted a tidier verdict. Tank said a tidy verdict purchased by hiding the awkward part was just my usual filing system with better stationery.

The actual attraction

Two related investigations in different places and eras create the appeal: a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work gradually echo one another. This is a dark serial-crime adventure for someone specifically interested in disturbing mysteries and historical connections.

The catch worth knowing

A contemporary review describes a required robot-and-laser puzzle that depends on timing even though it is not a simple countdown. That materially conflicts with a strict no-rush preference. Graphic crime material and layered puzzle logic add further demands; this is a clearly marked detour, not an easy recommendation.

An opening invitation

Start by considering the subject matter and the documented later timing obstacle. If both are acceptable with a chosen helper or shared-viewing arrangement, inspect an early investigation scene without interpreting it as the whole game's control profile.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retain for deliberate dark-mystery browsing only, with the laser warning visible. The Bureau's fruit-bowl reception is cancelled, and its title-screen assumptions have been placed under professional supervision for the afternoon.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing establishes the original game's dual-era crime premise. GameBoomers' contemporary review specifically reports timing-dependent robot/laser movement. No claim that this obstacle has an accessible skip is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46480/>

Source 2: <https://www.gameboomers.com/reviews/Ss/Stilllifebynickie.htm>

P038 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Grim Fandango Remastered

The Department of Death Has a Better Travel Desk

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Manny Calavera sold travel arrangements for the dead, which suggested a clientele less likely to complain about my opening speeches. Rosa asked whether I had learned anything at all from hospitality. I clarified that I admired the dramatic premise, not the business opportunity.

Mercedes wrote that clarification down in case I needed it again.

Grim Fandango's afterlife bureaucracy had stylish suits and a corruption problem. Our Bureau had an ill-fitting blazer and a laminator. I proposed a merger on the grounds of shared institutional themes. Shawna said the game already contained enough compromised administrators without importing one whose main scandal involved commemorative coasters.

Tank played an imaginary trumpet flourish as I put the merger file away. The music, the noir atmosphere, the strange journey: these were actual reasons to look at Manny's world. I allowed them to speak for themselves, a management innovation so radical that Rosa checked whether I had a sore throat.

The actual attraction

Manny's journey through a noir-inflected land of the dead combines memorable characters, an unusual visual world and a rich musical identity. The remaster refreshes presentation while preserving the adventure's central pleasure: a compromised little job opening into a much larger story.

The catch worth knowing

Traditional inventory puzzles and indirect solution logic can require considerable memory and hints. The developer confirms additional control schemes, but that alone does not establish comfortable movement or every timing requirement. Check the PC controls in practice; do not import PlayStation button instructions or assume remaster means simplified puzzles.

An opening invitation

Explore Manny's first available workplace interactions, compare the installed control choices, and test movement between two nearby points. Let the voice and atmosphere win your interest before agreeing to carry a long inventory of unsolved errands.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a stylish, characterful adventure when unusual puzzle logic sounds welcome. Deny the Bureau's merger proposal: the afterlife has enough paperwork without my commemorative stationery subsidiary seeking permanent office space.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC listing supports premise and remastered presentation; Double Fine confirms additional control schemes. Full control comfort and all-path timing are unverified. No native co-op is inferred from Remote Play Together metadata.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316790/>

Source 2: <https://www.doublefine.com/news/grim-fandango-remastered-pre-orders-now-available>

P039 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Thimbleweed Park

The Town Where Everybody Deserves a Separate Folder

Edition considered: PC release

Thimbleweed Park offered five playable people in a town with more secrets than ordinary municipal planning would recommend. I issued five folders. Mercedes opened hers and found my photograph in all of them. 'A filing error,' I said. Shawna said it was a consistent filing policy and therefore worse.

A strange town, a dead body, a haunted hotel and an abandoned circus gave the investigation plenty to work with. I suggested adding a Bureau visitor center. Tank asked whether it would contain a bathroom or simply a sixth suspicious man. I promised an informative brochure, which answered neither question.

Rosa selected the idea of a smaller first task and made me put the other folders aside. One character could inspect one place before we tried to understand an entire town. This struck me as offensively sensible. I preserved the five-folder set for later, after removing the portrait inserts and the unnecessary ribbon.

The actual attraction

An eccentric 1987 town ties together five playable characters and an increasingly strange mystery. The attraction is ensemble comedy, peculiar locations and the satisfaction of uncovering connections while a traditional adventure keeps revealing another layer of oddness.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher offers Casual and Hard modes and describes exploration at your own pace. Casual is the more relevant first trial, but it does not make five characters, inventories and ongoing objectives trivial. Interface gestures and any exceptional sequence still need checking; selecting a difficulty is not a universal no-hold guarantee.

An opening invitation

Choose Casual and follow one character's immediate objective. Try one conversation and one object interaction, noting whether the action interface is clear before switching people or collecting a large list of unfinished tasks.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a strange ensemble mystery with a useful lower-puzzle-load starting choice. The Bureau may issue multiple folders only after proving that each one contains somebody other than me this time.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports five playable characters, Casual/Hard modes and exploring at one's pace. Casual is an editorial first-trial choice, not proof that every interaction or entire path meets all preferences.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/569860/>

P040 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Full Throttle Remastered

The Motorcycle Cannot Be Driven by Reputation

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

I borrowed a leather jacket to introduce Full Throttle. Tank asked whether I could ride a motorcycle. I said I possessed the bearing. He placed a kitchen stool in front of me and requested a safe demonstration of mounting it. The jacket caught on the armrest. My bearing required assistance.

Ben and the Polecats inhabited a tale of motorcycles, corporate trouble and murder. I inhabited a tale of one sleeve refusing to release me. Mercedes watched Shawna untangle it and said this was an unusually faithful preview of why style and mechanical demands needed separate paragraphs.

The game had action sequences, including its road material, alongside adventure puzzles. Rosa kept that fact beside the glorious engine noise. I finally stood up, returned the jacket and approved a detour label. A person could admire a biker story without being recruited into its driving requirements, particularly after the stool had won the opening encounter decisively.

The actual attraction

Ben's trouble with powerful interests unfolds through a compact biker adventure full of distinctive characters, visual attitude and rock music. The remaster restores the original game's presentation and adds archival material, preserving a very particular kind of animated road-movie energy.

The catch worth knowing

This is not solely unhurried conversation and inventory work. Its remastered road sequences retain active gameplay, and the adventure includes action demands. A complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here. Treat it as a deliberate detour if required timing is unwelcome.

An opening invitation

Watch or try an early quiet conversation to judge the tone, while keeping the later action warning visible. Decide separately whether someone wants to handle those sequences; shared help is an arrangement, not native cooperative play.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Keep when the cast and biker atmosphere justify a consciously chosen detour. A leather jacket, however persuasive, cannot satisfy the control check or overturn the kitchen stool's recorded victory in single combat.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Double Fine supports the remastered game's premise; the platform interview with Tim Schafer confirms the playable Mine Road sequence's preservation. No unverified skip/no-action route is claimed.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/full-throttle-remastered>

Source 2: <https://blog.playstation.com/archive/2017/01/13/how-double-fine-is-tuning-up-full-throttle-remastered-for-ps4/>

The Case of the Guest Who Simply Picked Something

I had prepared a closing ceremony. There would be a ribbon, a brief speech, and a photograph in which I appeared to have personally invented leisure. Tank had practiced releasing a handful of paper stars from behind the filing cabinet. He had practiced too enthusiastically. We were finding stars in the sandwich tray, the printer, and one of the mystery files. 'Atmosphere,' he said. Rosa removed a silver star from a tomato. 'Paper.' He considered this distinction without conceding it. Shawna reviewed the ceremony. 'Where does someone actually choose a game?' I showed her the final box on the flowchart. 'After the remarks.' 'How long are the remarks?' 'Depends how the audience responds.' Mercedes took the chart and drew a new arrow from the entrance directly to a chair. 'There.' 'That bypasses the whole department.' 'I know. Beautiful work.' The arrow was not gold. It had no embossed border. It performed its function with humiliating economy.

What mattered had become embarrassingly clear. One person might want a ghost who talks too much; another might prefer a courtroom contradiction, a strange plant, or a lawyer whose business trip goes spectacularly off schedule. Even the right premise could meet the wrong evening. A short first encounter was enough to learn something. A control check could reveal a catch before the story became a commitment. A decision to stop did not require a report, a reason, or an apology to the folder.

I put the flowchart away. Not because Mercedes had won. Because, after careful leadership, I had decided that her idea should be allowed to resemble my policy. Tank asked whether the closing speech was canceled. I said postponed. 'Until what?' 'Until an appropriate occasion.' 'Printer jam?' 'Possibly.' He nodded. He had learned the diplomatic art of leaving a man one harmless illusion while unplugging the microphone.

The room grew quieter. Somebody opened a game. A line appeared, somebody laughed, and the table stopped being the most interesting thing in it. I watched for a moment without interrupting. Shawna rested her hand on my shoulder. 'You found some good possibilities.' That pleased me more than the photograph would have. I nearly said so. Then the printer made a grinding noise and delivered the first page of my canceled speech across the floor.

Tank picked it up. 'Distinguished delegates of pleasure - ' 'Private draft.' ' - through my tireless leadership - ' 'Give me that.' Rosa took the page, turned it over, and wrote the next useful question on the blank side: what sounded fun? She set it where everyone could reach it. No timer, no required sequence, no demand to justify an answer. A question small enough to belong on one piece of paper. I had built a department around it. My friends, with considerable difficulty, had let the question survive.

An index with no authority over you

The case number works in every format. The last column is this volume's printed page. Click a title in the PDF to jump to it.

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 2 OF SIX

The Committee for Taking One's Turn

Turn-based strategy, cards and role-playing

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 2. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P041	P042	P043	P044	P045	P046	P047	P048
2. Ready for conversation	P049	P050	P051	P052	P053	P054	P055	P056
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P057	P058	P059	P060	P061	P062	P063	P064
4. Here for the atmosphere	P065	P066	P067	P068	P069	P070	P071	P072
5. Open to a wildcard	P073	P074	P075	P076	P077	P078	P079	P080

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Inauguration of the Turn

The second great reform of the Bureau began when I discovered that people had been taking turns without an official object to indicate whose turn it was. Centuries of informal practice. Civilizations rising and falling on the strength of somebody saying, 'After you.' It was a scandal, and I was exactly the man to commission a solution with unnecessarily expensive lettering. By nine the next morning, a polished wooden rolling pin stood on my desk beneath a card reading THE SOVEREIGN INSTRUMENT OF DELIBERATION. The baker who sold it had called it a rolling pin, but he lacked the institutional imagination to appreciate its future.

Shawna picked it up. 'What does it do?' I explained that whoever held the instrument would have the floor. 'Then I'm going to put it down,' she said, 'because I'm using the floor to stand on.' Mercedes arrived during this constitutional disagreement and immediately requested asylum from the institution conducting it. Tank wanted to know whether the instrument had been charged to refreshments. Rosa wanted to know why a perfectly good kitchen object was wearing a velvet ribbon. I had anticipated resistance to reform, but I had expected it to require a less accurate set of questions.

The plan was elegant. Nobody would be hurried. A person could consider a move, read a card, compare a possibility, or simply look at the room. Then, when ready, that person would act. Unfortunately, I had illustrated this elegant plan with a nineteen-step chart. Step eleven referred people back to step four if their readiness had not been countersigned. Mercedes traced the arrow with one finger. 'You've invented waiting for permission to wait.' I informed her that this was an unfair description of the Optional Preliminary Readiness Reconfirmation. Shawna removed the chart from the wall with the calm of a woman preventing a minor traffic disaster.

Rosa put the rolling pin on the table and asked what we were actually trying to learn. There were games in this volume where the decision itself waited: maps, cards, party commands, battles divided into turns. That could be valuable. There were also dozens of menus, complicated rosters, equipment systems and long stories asking to be remembered. Taking the clock away from a decision did not automatically make the decision pleasant. I looked at the nineteen-step chart in Shawna's hand. Evidence, when allowed to move freely through a room, can become extremely disloyal to the man who ordered the stationery.

Tank laid out three ordinary cards. On the first he wrote TIME TO THINK. On the second, THINGS TO KEEP TRACK OF. On the third, WHAT YOUR HANDS ACTUALLY DO. I suggested laminating them. 'Later,' he said, with the confidence of a man who had learned to intercept me before a useful idea developed a purchasing department. A battle could wait and still contain ten abilities whose differences mattered. A game could have straightforward turns and movement elsewhere that felt awkward. A small-looking card might carry a paragraph of rules. None of these facts insulted the game. They simply belonged in its description.

Mercedes added a fourth card: DO I WANT THIS? I told her the wording lacked bureaucratic distinction. She said that was its principal qualification. Someone might enjoy comparing armor or planning a city's districts; someone else might prefer one conversation and a strange house. Tonight's answer could differ from next week's. The Bureau had no authority to convert interest into homework. I objected that authority was the main reason I had bought the rolling pin. Rosa took the ribbon off it. Without the ribbon it remained an excellent object, which was more than I could say for my nineteen-step chart.

We opened the files. I kept the wooden instrument close enough to suggest leadership but far enough from the ink pad to avoid another incident. The plan was now almost embarrassingly workable: name what was appealing, name what could get in the way, choose a small first trial, and let the person playing decide. A failed trial was information, not a personal defeat. A successful trial did not require a campaign completed before dinner. I would have preferred to announce these principles from a balcony. We did not own a balcony. Tank offered the serving trolley, and Rosa said absolutely not.

P041 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Sid Meier's Civilization VI

The Empire That Could Not Afford Its Own Welcome Sign

Edition considered: PC base game, no expansion requirement

I founded Aidenia on the conference table and declared its first golden age before lunch. Our territory consisted of a coaster, two paperclips and a district reserved for a monumental likeness of the founder. Shawna asked where the food would come from. I pointed at the portrait district. 'Tourism.' She moved the biscuit plate beyond our border.

Civilization VI gave cities room to spread across the map. I gave mine room to spread across everyone else's paperwork. Mercedes recognized this as imperial expansion and requested immediate negotiations. I offered a mutual admiration pact. She proposed that I return her notebook.

Tank arrived with the treasury report: no treasury, no report. Rosa offered a practical founding principle. Build something useful before commissioning a wonder about how useful you are. I returned the notebook, restored access to the biscuits and renamed the golden age the Promising Administrative Morning.

The actual attraction

Build a civilization across a large sweep of history, choosing how cities grow, what people research and how to deal with neighboring powers. The appeal is seeing many small decisions create a society with a recognizable direction rather than following one prescribed storyline.

The catch worth knowing

District placement, research, policies, diplomacy and multiple units produce heavy menu and planning demands. Single-player turns permit deliberation, but this is emphatically not cognitively simple because it is turn-based. Avoid assuming online turn settings match solo play; held map gestures and interface readability still need a trial.

An opening invitation

Use the guided opening or a modest single-player start to found one city and make one production choice. Judge whether the explanations make that decision interesting before opening an empire's worth of additional responsibilities.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when building and planning are the pleasure themselves. Aidenia's unpaid ministerial vacancies should not be mistaken for a relaxing evening with a low-menu game or a functioning national economy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base-game PC listing supports districts, research, policies and diplomacy. Waits refers to single-player turn decisions; complete input comfort and multiplayer timer/co-op configurations are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/289070/>

P042 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: yes

Old World

The Dynasty Has Denied My Hereditary Desk Claim

Edition considered: PC base game

Old World encouraged thinking in generations, so I bequeathed the Bureau's largest chair to my future descendants. Mercedes informed me that the chair belonged to Rosa. I revised the will to bequeath my continuing interest in sitting there. Shawna said this was not how inheritance worked, even for a dynasty with unusually aggressive upholstery ambitions.

The game mixed statecraft with families, personalities and succession. I convened a royal household by giving Tank a paper crown. He immediately demanded a better lunch allowance. Rosa supported his claim. Within thirty seconds, my carefully constructed monarchy had developed a powerful opposition united around sandwiches.

I tried diplomacy, offering to name a future library after the sandwich. Mercedes explained that noble families might care about resources rather than compliments. We reached a settlement: ordinary chairs, shared food, no hereditary claims on anyone else's furniture. History would remember my restraint, assuming I wrote the history myself.

The actual attraction

Old World combines historical strategy with a living dynasty: rulers age, families compete, children grow and personal events affect the state. People and relationships can give empire management a more intimate story than a map of anonymous production totals.

The catch worth knowing

The developer declares play without timed input, a mouse-only option and saving at any time. That is encouraging for pacing, while court relationships, cities, resources and character roles still make this a dense strategy game. Declared co-op exists, but its setup and shared responsibilities require a separate check.

An opening invitation

Follow the introductory guidance until one ruler faces one clear decision. Read the affected person's name and consequence, then decide whether that personal layer makes the surrounding management enjoyable or merely adds another spreadsheet to remember.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider if you want your strategy to include difficult relatives as well as difficult borders. The Bureau's monarchy has been suspended until I return the chair to its actual owner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact listing supports dynasties/families and declares no timed input, Mouse Only Option, Save Anytime and co-op. Those declarations do not establish low menu load or a personally comfortable multiplayer arrangement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/597180/>

P043 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

HUMANKIND

One Civilization, Six Wardrobe Changes

Edition considered: PC base game

I interpreted HUMANKIND's changing cultures as permission to reinvent the Bureau every time a policy became embarrassing. By breakfast we were a maritime republic. At eleven, a scholarly federation. By lunch, Mercedes called us an unpaid restaurant review club and asked who had authorized my ceremonial sash.

The game's civilization could develop through different historical cultures, accumulating a distinctive path. Mine developed through different excuses for keeping the largest chair. Shawna put the actual file in front of me and asked whether I could explain a meaningful choice without dressing it in a flag.

I said that choosing the next culture changed what a civilization could do and what sort of history it might build. 'Good,' Rosa said. 'That sounds interesting.' Tank removed the sash while I was distracted by this rare moment of educational success. He folded it into a perfectly serviceable napkin, establishing our most useful cultural advance of the day.

The actual attraction

Shape a civilization by combining cultures across eras rather than staying with a single identity throughout history. City growth, fame and tactical conflicts turn the map into an account of accumulated decisions, including choices about what kind of achievements matter.

The catch worth knowing

Empire management and battlefield decisions sit on top of one another. Culture transitions add systems to learn, while resources, diplomacy and competing goals make the memory load high. Turn-based battles do not establish a universally simple control scheme or relaxed multiplayer timer settings; begin with solo play and inspect menus.

An opening invitation

Follow the early guidance through one development choice and read what it changes. Stop to decide whether comparing those possibilities feels engaging before treating the next historical era as an obligation to keep playing.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when the fantasy is shaping a long history and changing direction along the way. Reject my attempt to explain a missing snack budget as an inevitable transition between political cultures.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports combining cultures, fame and turn-based tactical battles. Pacing label applies to solo strategic decisions; complete holds, map controls and multiplayer configurations remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1124300/>

P044 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Into the Breach

The Monster Has Submitted Its Intended Damage in Writing

Edition considered: PC Advanced Edition update

Into the Breach's enemies announced what they were about to attack. I considered this an admirable professional courtesy and issued the Bureau a form titled NOTICE OF IMPENDING NONSENSE. Mercedes filled it in before I finished speaking. Under Expected Impact she wrote EVERYWHERE, THEN filed it in my pocket.

The small battlefield appealed to my taste for manageable grandeur. A few mechs, visible threats, buildings worth protecting. I demonstrated with salt shakers and crackers. Tank objected when I sacrificed his lunch to illustrate collateral damage. I explained that strategy required difficult choices. He chose to take the crackers away.

Shawna moved one salt shaker and showed how changing a position could alter the whole problem. It was elegant, which offended me because she had used no speeches. Rosa restored the crackers to civilian status. I amended my form to require consultation before any tactical deployment of someone else's cheese.

The actual attraction

Small mech battles become visible tactical puzzles because enemy attacks are telegraphed before the next turn. The pleasure is finding an unexpected move that changes several threats at once, often by shifting positions rather than simply choosing the strongest attack.

The catch worth knowing

A compact board can still ask for demanding spatial reasoning. Protecting buildings, understanding attack direction and managing limited actions are central, and failure changes a run. The turn structure supports thought before acting; it does not prove every menu or selection gesture suits the player. Advanced Edition adds more systems.

An opening invitation

Try the opening guidance and inspect one announced enemy attack before choosing a move. Say which square is threatened and what one action changes; there is no need to solve the entire campaign to test that central pleasure.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising tactical experiment for someone who enjoys a bounded puzzle more than a sprawling inventory. Civilian crackers remain protected under the Bureau's first treaty that anybody actually intends to obey.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes minimalistic turn-based combat with telegraphed attacks; current PC includes Advanced Edition content. Waits reflects tactical decision structure, not a complete no-hold/comfort certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/590380/>

P045 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: yes

Wargroove

The Commander Has Mistaken the Dog for a Deputy

Edition considered: PC base game

I wanted a commander whose authority required no explanation. Tank suggested the office dog, should we ever acquire one, because at least a dog would bring something back when asked. Wargroove's colorful commanders made the proposal dangerously plausible. I ordered a smaller hat for myself before this became a succession crisis.

The map offered towns to capture and units with different uses. I offered Mercedes a squadron of paperclips to secure the biscuit tin. She captured my pen while I was describing the operation. Shawna said this demonstrated the value of knowing what everyone could do before committing to an elaborate plan.

Rosa made a better plan: learn one unit, then another, and leave the map editor alone until somebody actually wanted to build a map. I withdrew my seventy-page campaign about the liberation of my parking space. The paperclips returned to civilian service, where their tactical effectiveness was frankly much higher.

The actual attraction

Wargroove gives turn-based army battles a bright fantasy cast and a campaign about a displaced queen seeking allies. Commanders have distinctive special abilities, while different units and terrain make each map a problem about positioning and resource choices.

The catch worth knowing

Managing an army, its funds and its unit matchups is more involved than moving one character. The editor and multiplayer add separate layers rather than simplifying the campaign. Co-op is listed, but exact campaign coverage and setup should be checked; no untimed or hold-free claim applies automatically to every configuration.

An opening invitation

Start with the campaign's opening instruction and command one unit through one explained action. Test the map selection interface and the clarity of the unit information before recruiting a large army or opening the editor.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a colorful tactical campaign sounds fun in its own right. My parking-space epic is withheld until the author demonstrates competence with one paperclip and a clearly stated objective.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports turn-based campaign, commander Grooves and native co-op categories. Co-op mode scope is not assumed to cover the whole main campaign; complete input demands are unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/607050/>

P046 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: yes

Wargroove 2

The Scholarly Expedition Has Brought Siege Equipment

Edition considered: PC base game

Wargroove 2's scholarly mouse-folk arrived with technology and ambitious research interests. I understood them completely. My own scholarly expedition had brought a folding podium, a portable printer and no useful questions. Mercedes said that discovering questions after shipping the equipment was how our budget got this way.

Three intertwined campaigns sounded like enough material to justify an expanded headquarters. Shawna pointed out that this was content to play, not a lease application. I tried to demonstrate a supercharged commander ability by ringing the reception bell twice. Tank answered both times with the same message: lunch was still not ready.

Rosa proposed that an expedition might begin by looking at the land in front of it. I reluctantly studied one battle rather than announcing a research empire. The bell stayed silent. Without it, everybody could hear the actual explanation, an unexpected technological breakthrough we agreed to investigate further immediately.

The actual attraction

The sequel builds a new conflict around forbidden technology and several connected campaigns, with new commanders and a revised Groove system. Its attraction is returning to colorful map tactics with fresh factions, tactical possibilities and a continuing fantasy world.

The catch worth knowing

New commander abilities and linked campaigns add knowledge to the familiar army-management demands. The separate Conquest mode and editing tools are optional avenues, not recommended first steps here. Native co-op is listed, but campaign coverage, timing settings and comfortable selection controls need their own verification.

An opening invitation

Take the initial campaign instruction one action at a time and read one commander's ability carefully. Compare that single mechanic with ordinary movement before exploring extra modes or designing an ambitious custom scenario for everyone else.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit if the first Wargroove's kind of planning appeals and more of that planning sounds welcome. Deny any claim that ringing the bell twice counts as a funded scientific expedition or an upgraded command system.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current publisher listing supports three campaigns, revised Grooves, Conquest and native co-op. Waits refers to turn-based tactics, not an all-modes or hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346020/>

P047 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp

The Toy-Sized Army Has Requested Full-Sized Instructions

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch compilation

I spread a bright map across the table and declared that its cheerful appearance made me a natural commander. Shawna asked how the naval unit would cross the land. I said morale could overcome many obstacles. Tank moved the little boat back to the water before morale damaged the furniture.

Advance Wars looked approachable in the way a well-arranged board can look approachable: the pieces are visible, the landscape readable, the problem waiting to be understood. Mercedes warned me that recognizable pieces still had different rules. I agreed, then attempted to promote a supply truck on grounds of excellent posture.

Rosa removed my ceremonial baton and handed me the ordinary controller. Learn what one unit does, she said. Then learn why the terrain matters. My appointment as Supreme Commander lasted just long enough to become Trainee Who Can Find the Confirm Button, a post with smaller privileges and far clearer public benefit.

The actual attraction

This Switch collection rebuilds the first two Advance Wars campaigns around colorful land, sea and air battles. Commanding officers bring personalities and special powers, while terrain, capture decisions and different unit roles provide a board-game-like tactical focus.

The catch worth knowing

Bright presentation does not remove the need to compare ranges, terrain, funds and matchups. It is turn-based, but particular mission conditions can still create strategic urgency. Nintendo's listed multiplayer includes versus play; do not assume a shared campaign. Hold behavior and readability require a check on the actual display.

An opening invitation

Follow the early training and move one unit using its displayed information. Check whether the explanation makes its purpose clear before progressing to a larger force with several different roles to remember at once.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a clear, colorful battlefield when learning unit rules sounds enjoyable. The Bureau's navy must remain in water until I produce better evidence than a motivational speech and a very optimistic arrow.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo identifies the Switch remake collection and turn-based land/sea/air tactics, terrain and CO powers. Versus multiplayer is confirmed; native campaign co-op is not established. No complete no-hold guarantee.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/advance-wars-1-plus-2-re-boot-camp-switch/>

P048 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Fire Emblem: Three Houses

The Professor Has Been Assigned Remedial Listening

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

I appointed myself professor before checking whether the Bureau had students. Mercedes said that receiving one unsolicited lecture a day already qualified everyone present. Fire Emblem: Three Houses combined teaching, relationships and battlefield decisions, which I mistook for confirmation that my proposed Aiden Academy had educational value.

Shawna examined my syllabus. Monday: entrances. Tuesday: advanced entrances. Wednesday: respectful appreciation of the instructor. She replaced the schedule with a single question: what does each student actually need? I said the question lacked dramatic ambition. Rosa said it sounded like the beginning of teaching.

Tank supplied three house banners made from dish towels. My attempt to choose a house by which towel best complemented my jacket was denied. We considered the characters instead. A story full of loyalties and friendships deserved more attention than my branding scheme, though I retained one towel for a genuinely useful job at the sink.

The actual attraction

A teacher's relationship with students develops alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis. Choosing a house gives the long story a particular group to know, making friendships, loyalties and changing circumstances a substantial part of the experience.

The catch worth knowing

Normal difficulty with Casual mode revives fallen allies after battles, but it does not remove lessons, schedules, equipment or tactical menus. Monastery exploration adds three-dimensional movement and camera considerations. This is a rich character game with heavy management demands, not a simple visual novel because conversations are prominent.

An opening invitation

Choose Normal and Casual for the first trial, then assess one introductory battle explanation and one conversation. Test monastery movement separately when available; comfort with selecting a battle square does not answer the camera question.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when getting to know a large cast justifies managing their daily and military lives. The Bureau's teaching credential remains provisional until its founder learns to distinguish a lesson plan from an applause schedule.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based battles, academy exploration/calendar and Normal/Casual options. Casual removes permanent allied losses in battle, not other complexity. Whole-path hold/camera comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Three-Houses-1175482.html>

P049 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Fire Emblem Engage

The Legendary Ring Has Rejected My Finger

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

I put on a large ring and announced that a legendary hero would soon answer my call. Tank said the ring was a curtain fitting. I told him ancient artifacts often passed through ordinary hands. Mercedes asked whether the legendary hero would at least help put the curtains back up.

Fire Emblem Engage let fighters borrow strength from heroic Emblems. My plan was to borrow strength from everybody else while retaining full credit for the result. Shawna identified the flaw immediately: the game gave the partnership actual abilities, whereas my proposal gave her more work.

Rosa held the ladder while I restored the fitting. From that elevation I delivered a brief speech about teamwork. 'Use both hands for the curtain,' she said. I did. The room became less drafty, the speech ended early, and our first successful combination attack was recorded against an entirely civilian window covering.

The actual attraction

Engage emphasizes colorful tactical battles and the abilities gained by pairing characters with legendary Emblems. The appeal is experimenting with a cast's different strengths and seeing how a chosen pairing changes the possibilities on a grid-based battlefield.

The catch worth knowing

Weapon relationships, rings, skills and party development create many interlocking rules. Nintendo confirms Normal difficulty, Casual mode and Auto-Battle, plus a limited rewind system. Those aids change punishment or decision support; they do not prove low menu load or comfortable movement around the hub.

An opening invitation

Use Normal and Casual, read one unit's weapon matchup, and try its basic action before exploring every ring combination. Examine Auto-Battle as an optional tool only after seeing what it controls, keeping the choice to participate or delegate yours.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when tactical combinations themselves are attractive. Any ring found in Bureau property must pass the curtain test before being classified as a source of legendary power or a legitimate personal accessory.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo supports grid tactics, Emblem pairings, Normal/Casual, Auto-Battle and limited rewind. No full-path hold/camera assurance or shared campaign is inferred; multiplayer scope remains unverified here.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Engage-2267157.html>

P050 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

The Rabbids Have Applied for Senior Management

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

I watched the Rabbids' approach to organized activity and recognized several of my leadership principles. Mercedes said that explained a great deal. Kingdom Battle combined their chaos with Mario's world, giving me hope that an institution could survive somebody taking a selfie while everyone else solved the problem.

I proposed a tactical photograph of myself beside the printer. Shawna asked what tactical advantage it produced. 'Morale.' Tank asked whose. While I prepared an answer, Rosa organized the actual comparison: turn-based battles, character abilities, exploration and separate cooperative challenges. Four useful facts, achieved without a portrait session.

I tried to recruit Rabbid Peach as deputy communications director in absentia. Mercedes pointed out that fictional hiring did not reduce the real inbox. We left the Rabbids in their game, where their nonsense had been properly designed, and reduced mine to one permitted photograph with absolutely no commemorative banner behind it.

The actual attraction

Mario characters and Rabbids join forces in colorful tactical battles, with each hero contributing a different role. The mismatch between earnest adventure and Rabbid behavior offers a comic frame for learning positioning, cover and coordinated attacks.

The catch worth knowing

Combat takes turns, but exploration, equipment and abilities still require learning and navigation. Nintendo describes local co-op as additional challenges, not the entire story campaign. Do not infer the sequel's hold toggles or other accommodations for this first game; exact gesture and camera comfort need checking.

An opening invitation

Follow an early solo battle explanation and compare one movement option with one attack. If playing together is the main attraction, inspect the separate co-op challenges and their requirements rather than promising shared control of the whole campaign.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when bright tactical comedy appeals, with the mode boundary clearly marked. The Rabbids may consult on office morale after I demonstrate that the printer can function without being included in a publicity shoot.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based combat and separate local co-op challenges. Co-op flag is restricted to those challenges; no whole-campaign co-op or Sparks of Hope control options are transferred.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/mario-plus-rabbids-kingdom-battle-switch/>

Source 2: <https://play.nintendo.com/news-tips/game-releases/mario-rabbids-kingdom-battle-release-date/>

The Coup of the Biscuit Tin

By the midpoint of our proceedings, I had decided the real problem with the rolling pin was portability. A leader could not circulate with a substantial constitutional object in one hand and a cup in the other without sacrificing the possibility of a dramatic gesture. I solved this by placing the instrument on the serving trolley, thereby creating the world's first mobile ministry of turn-taking. Tank watched me wheel it across the room. 'You've put waiting on wheels.' I said that sounded like an excellent slogan. Mercedes said it sounded like something a witness would tell an insurance investigator.

The trolley immediately developed a territorial dispute with the biscuit tin. I needed its top shelf for official documents. Rosa needed the top shelf for the food it had been designed to carry. I proposed a mixed-use arrangement in which visitors could access refreshments after acknowledging the agenda. Rosa moved the papers onto my desk and served everybody. The transfer of power was bloodless, decisive and accompanied by shortbread. I retained the title of Founder, but the department controlling the useful object had fallen to someone with a clearer understanding of why people had come into the room.

To rebuild my position, I arranged a demonstration of strategic urgency. I gave Tank three counters and asked him to deliver a biscuit from one end of the table to the other in three moves. He thought, moved, thought again, and finished. Then I produced a timer and asked him to do it before the bell. 'Those are different,' Shawna said. 'Exactly,' I announced, relieved that my demonstration had accidentally reached its intended point. A limit on moves can let someone consider each move carefully. A limit on seconds creates a different physical demand. Both can still feel pressuring, and nobody owed either one an apology for declining.

Mercedes took the timer before I could add a dramatic sound effect. 'You know what else creates pressure? Four people watching somebody learn and saying things like obviously.' I denied having said obviously that morning. She opened her notebook. I withdrew the denial on narrow procedural grounds. We agreed that a shared game could involve quiet company, invited advice, or somebody handling an awkward operation if asked. It did not require an audience grading every decision. The person with the controls could also ask everyone else to shut up for a moment. This motion passed so quickly that I suspected prior organization.

Shawna brought out the co-op files. Some games let people control their own characters through a campaign. Some offered separate challenges. Some merely allowed two people to compete. Passing a controller around was a possible household arrangement, but it did not create a feature inside the software. I suggested that the Bureau's spirit of togetherness could bridge these distinctions. 'Your spirit can carry the mugs,' Rosa said. I carried them. From the kitchen I could hear the much more useful discussion continuing without me, which was both a logistical success and a deeply unsettling observation about the efficiency of our governance model.

When I returned, Tank had found a card game in which placement mattered and asked how moving a card actually worked. Was it a click? A held drag? Something else on a controller? I started to answer from the picture. Shawna tapped the words ACTUALLY WORKED on his note. The picture was attractive. The source described the premise. Neither told us everything a hand would need to do. We left the question visible instead of filling it with confidence. This made the file slightly less triumphant and much more trustworthy. I was learning to endure that trade, although I preferred it served with a biscuit.

The rolling pin rolled off its velvet cushion and settled against the binder, preventing the massive thing from sliding into someone's lap. Tank observed that the instrument had finally found a legitimate office. I considered arguing, then noticed how well it performed this office without a single speech. We appointed it Keeper of the Binder. The job required no crown, no agenda and no user training. Mercedes wrote the appointment on a sticky note. I permitted this modest ceremony because the trolley had been liberated, the biscuits were available, and the room had somehow become a place where choosing something could be enjoyable again.

P051 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope

The Cosmic Adventure Has a Surprisingly Useful Options Menu

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

I built a cardboard spaceship for the Bureau's trip through Sparks of Hope. Tank climbed halfway in and discovered that I had allocated the entire interior to the captain's chair. 'Where does the crew sit?' I indicated a motivational poster. Mercedes asked whether its inspirational value included structural support.

The game had real options worth discussing: hold actions could become toggles, repeated presses could become a single press, and difficulty could be adjusted. Shawna read these aloud while I tried to solve the spacecraft's seating crisis by promoting everyone to standing officers. Rosa rejected the promotion and fetched ordinary chairs.

For once the technical menu was doing the generous thing my grand design had failed to do: offering choices. We still needed to check movement and camera comfort. I reduced the spaceship to a decorative dashboard and let everybody sit where they wanted. Our mission immediately became less heroic and considerably more habitable.

The actual attraction

Mario and the Rabbids travel between imaginative planets, meeting odd characters and combining heroes with helpful Sparks. Tactical battles sit inside a larger exploratory adventure, with the cast's antics providing a light comic reason to see what the next place contains.

The catch worth knowing

Ubisoft documents specific hold toggles, single-press alternatives, camera adjustments, automatic skill management and invulnerability. These are real options, not proof of a wholly no-rush path: direct movement, camera handling and airborne or traversal actions need checking. The first game's co-op challenges do not establish co-op here.

An opening invitation

Inspect those control options before play, then test ordinary movement and a first battle at the preferred difficulty. Check how a team jump or other moving action feels when introduced; stop there if the practical demands outweigh the appeal.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider conditionally because useful accommodations deserve a fair trial, with remaining movement questions visible. The Bureau's spaceship is certified only for sitting indoors and making engine noises voluntarily at a sensible volume.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer UX interview documents listed options and time to think during turns; publisher article confirms direct real-time movement. These do not verify every traversal sequence. Single-player sequel assessed separately from Kingdom Battle.

Source 1:

<https://news.ubisoft.com/en-gb/article/3geL8IbYETmgHk6W017HpS/mario-rabbids-sparks-of-hope-accessibility-spotlight>

Source 2: <https://news.ubisoft.com/en-us/article/65J7B5ga4HkMpXtYWQ7QX5>

P052 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

XCOM: Enemy Unknown

Humanity Has Placed Me on Probation

Edition considered: PC base game; not Enemy Within expansion

When aliens threatened Earth, I offered to command its defense from the Bureau. Shawna asked what relevant experience I possessed. I gestured toward a stapler I had successfully unjammed last Thursday. Mercedes said humanity might wish to review other applicants before the invasion became irreversible.

XCOM combined squad tactics with research and base management. I combined a flashlight with a colander to produce a command helmet. Tank saluted the helmet and asked whether its ventilation represented an exposed weakness. I explained that advanced leadership required airflow.

Rosa read the actual duties: people, equipment, missions, money. This was substantial management beneath the exciting alien story. I removed the helmet and admitted that a player might love those responsibilities or reasonably prefer fewer of them. Mercedes recorded the admission as Earth's first successful contact with an unfamiliar form of intelligent life inside the Bureau, then returned the colander to the kitchen.

The actual attraction

Lead a defense organization against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers while choosing research, equipment and battlefield tactics. The appeal is the connection between a strategic headquarters and the small, consequential decisions made by a squad on the ground.

The catch worth knowing

Turn-based ground combat still involves cover, ranges, hit chances and multiple soldiers. Research, budgets and base decisions add another layer, while casualties and global threats create pressure. This card is Enemy Unknown without assuming Enemy Within additions; complete interception, timing and held-input behavior has not been audited.

An opening invitation

Use the opening tutorial and focus on one soldier's move into cover and one explained action. Assess whether the battlefield information feels interesting before treating the larger base-management system as part of an evening's commitment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider only when commanding a complicated defense effort is the desired fantasy. The colander offers no reduction in menu demands and has been removed from the Bureau's official procurement recommendations for planetary emergencies.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base-game listing supports turn-based squad combat, base/research management and interceptions. Pacing is mixed because the full strategic/interception loop is not certified wholly untimed. No expansion feature is assumed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/200510/>

P053 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

XCOM 2

The Resistance Has Refused My Opening Parade

Edition considered: PC base game; not War of the Chosen expansion

A resistance movement operating from a mobile headquarters sounded exactly like the Bureau after our landlord discovered the cardboard spaceship. I proposed a liberation parade. Shawna reminded me that concealment was useful. I reduced the parade to a single banner. Mercedes reduced it to no banner, a plan whose tactical elegance I found personally inconvenient.

XCOM 2 asked a squad to act within limited resources and sometimes limited turns. I held up a kitchen timer to demonstrate urgency. Tank removed the batteries. 'Turns. We are explaining turns.' I put the timer down and drew several boxes instead, feeling the loss of dramatic ticking quite deeply.

Rosa made the important distinction: you can have time to think about a move and still dislike a mission demanding efficient moves. Both reactions count. I accepted this, then submitted my parade for a different game. The resistance maintained concealment by declining to tell me which drawer it used.

The actual attraction

The sequel turns Earth's defenders into an insurgent force, building a mobile organization and conducting tactical missions under alien occupation. Ambushes, soldier development and the changing campaign give each squad's successes and losses a continuing personal history.

The catch worth knowing

Turn limits create strategic urgency without requiring a fast mouse click. The manual also describes many action controls, camera operations and a held Control-key gesture for waypoint paths. Base management, skill trees and permanent casualties add weight. This is the base game; expansion options for changing timers are not assumed.

An opening invitation

Leave the tutorial enabled and inspect one soldier's movement boundary and cover information. Read a turn-limited objective literally when it appears, then decide whether pressure measured in decisions is acceptable even when the decision itself can be considered.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional choice for deliberate tactical tension, not a relaxed default. All resistance parades remain postponed until I can explain the difference between a countdown clock and a row of turn boxes without props.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports base-game premise; official port manual documents turn-based actions, turn timers, casualties and held Control for waypoint movement. Waits concerns tactical decisions, not absence of turn pressure. No War of the Chosen options transferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/268500/>

Source 2: <https://www.feralinteractive.com/en/manuals/xcom2/latest/steam/>

P054 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Invisible, Inc.

The Alarm Rises Every Time I Finish Talking

Edition considered: PC base game

I volunteered to infiltrate a hostile corporation wearing a visitor badge the size of a dinner plate. Mercedes said the word INVISIBLE had apparently failed to reach the costume department. I turned the badge sideways, achieving a narrower profile and no improvement whatsoever in subtlety.

Invisible, Inc. raised its alarm as turns passed. I attempted to improve our odds by describing every move at length. Shawna explained that thought itself did not spend a turn, but eventually we would have to make choices. Tank suggested we begin by leaving my badge at home, freeing enough space for an actual operative.

Rosa liked the distinction between tension and speed. You could consider a move carefully while the situation still tightened with each committed action. I called this elegant design. Mercedes called it a warning that my one-hour speech could be physically unhurried and spiritually exhausting at precisely the same time. The badge was retired.

The actual attraction

Corporate espionage becomes a tactical puzzle about agents, security systems and getting out with something valuable. Different operatives and equipment combinations let a plan feel clever when a small, well-chosen action opens an unexpected route through trouble.

The catch worth knowing

The designer describes an alarm that rises at the end of each turn. Thinking time is available, but escalating consequences can still feel urgent. Agent abilities, hacking resources, sight lines and extraction plans create heavy demands. Custom modes exist, yet a specific no-pressure configuration has not been established here.

An opening invitation

Try the introductory mission and inspect a guard's attention and one available agent action. Watch what changes when the turn ends, then judge the alarm's emotional effect rather than deciding solely from the absence of a seconds countdown.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for someone who wants careful stealth under mounting strategic pressure. The Bureau will not issue its dinner-plate visitor badge to any operative expected to remain undetected in a reasonably well-lit building.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports stealth systems/custom modes; first-person designer article explains alarm advancement per turn. No particular alarm-removal setting or full input accommodation is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/243970/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/game-design-deep-dive-alarm-systems-in-klei-s-i-invisible-inc-i->

P055 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Shadowrun Returns

The Wizard Has Joined the Corporate Complaint Department

Edition considered: PC original release

Shadowrun offered a world where magic and ruthless corporations coexisted. I immediately drafted a complaint asking whether a dragon could process our printer warranty. Shawna said dragons were not necessarily customer-service specialists. I said neither was the last customer-service specialist, but at least a dragon might get the department's attention.

Seattle's investigation mixed a killer, mercenary work and people living in the shadows of enormous institutions. I suggested a Bureau character combining every available specialty. Mercedes called this the same management error as appointing me head of both finance and publicity, only now with fireballs.

Tank recommended learning one role before adding another. Rosa recommended reading the conversations because the people were the reason to be there. I created a modest plan: one character, one useful ability, one current lead. The dragon complaint remained unsent, pending evidence that it would not void the warranty or incinerate its attached proof of purchase.

The actual attraction

A murder investigation moves through a Seattle where cybernetics, magic and corporate power collide. The story offers an adult genre mixture, while turn-based team combat lets different kinds of characters contribute practical abilities to the same job.

The catch worth knowing

Character creation, attributes, equipment, spells and tactical positioning are substantial systems. The game also relies on considerable reading, so a mystery-led premise does not make it a simple detective interface. Turn-based fights allow consideration, but the complete mission path and every held gesture have not been independently tested.

An opening invitation

Pick one clear starting archetype and follow the first conversation before studying every possible build. In the first instructed battle, learn one basic action and one support option rather than trying to master magic, drones and hacking together.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider if cyberpunk people and mysteries make a tactical role-playing system worth learning. Printer complaints should remain in ordinary language until the Bureau verifies which supernatural departments actually accept consumer correspondence by email.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes Seattle murder investigation, classless development and single-player turn-based tactical RPG. Waits refers to combat decisions; no complete no-hold or low-complexity certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/234650/>

P056 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut

The Dragon's File Is Larger Than the Office

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

I requested a dragon-sized filing cabinet for the Dragonfall case. Tank asked whether the file was large or whether I simply enjoyed saying dragon-sized. I told him both could be true. Mercedes examined the proposed delivery route and found that the cabinet would permanently seal the entrance, turning our Bureau into a very small secret society.

Berlin's shadowrunning crew offered personalities, loyalties and a job that grew more dangerous than expected. Shawna suggested we pay attention to the crew instead of measuring the door. I assigned myself Team Visionary. Everyone else assigned me Person Who Cancels the Cabinet Order.

Rosa made coffee while I completed that unexpectedly difficult mission. Then we considered what actually distinguished this edition: a standalone campaign, revised systems and expanded character material. The office remained accessible to visitors, and the dragon stayed in the story, where its relationship to the available square footage was somebody else's thoroughly interesting problem.

The actual attraction

Dragonfall brings Shadowrun's magic-and-technology world to Berlin and centers a crew with distinct personalities and histories. The Director's Cut expands the campaign and team material, making relationships and difficult loyalties a substantial reward for learning its tactical systems.

The catch worth knowing

This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG with character builds, equipment and team abilities. Its redesigned interface is not evidence that menus are few or self-explanatory. The standalone Director's Cut differs from the earlier expansion; complete timing, held gestures and late mission demands have not been verified here.

An opening invitation

Meet the initial team and try a small portion of its first job, focusing on one character's role. Decide whether the conversations make you want to know these people before planning an optimized build or committing to every side mission.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a complicated crew is the attraction and learning a tactical system feels worthwhile. Deny dragon-sized storage unless the applicant can demonstrate both a real need and a remaining way out of the room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact Director's Cut page confirms standalone identity, Berlin, expanded missions/team material and revised combat/interface. No all-path timing/hold guarantee; mature themes include explicit violence and difficult backstories.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/300550/>

P057 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

The Hacker Has Asked Me to Stop Guessing the Password

Edition considered: PC Extended Edition

I claimed I could hack any corporate system by projecting confidence into the keyboard. Mercedes offered the office Wi-Fi as a preliminary examination. I entered MAGNIFICENCE. It failed. I entered MAGNIFICENCE with an exclamation mark. Shawna said the problem was not punctuation.

Hong Kong's Shadowrun story promised a dangerous city and a crew with its own troubles, but its Matrix systems required separate attention. I wanted to wave them through because the conversations sounded excellent. Rosa asked whether a good conversation could turn a timed minigame into an untimed one. I had to concede that even mine had never demonstrated that power.

Tank supplied the Wi-Fi password, printed on the router where it had always been. I called his method unsporting. Mercedes called it reading. We kept the game as a marked detour, with its attractive story and awkward mechanical questions on the same page. The network survived my intervention without filing a formal complaint.

The actual attraction

The third standalone Shadowrun adventure offers a dense urban fantasy setting, a developed crew and corporate intrigue in Hong Kong. Its Extended Edition includes the later bonus campaign, giving players who enjoy the characters more story beyond the original ending.

The catch worth knowing

Do not treat the whole game as unhurried because combat takes turns. Its Matrix has stealth and timed code/symbol-matching elements reported in gameplay documentation. A comfortable way through all required instances has not been verified. Text, character builds and inventory management are also heavy; this is a deliberate story-focused detour.

An opening invitation

Assess an early crew conversation and the character interface, then investigate the Matrix requirements before committing to the campaign. If someone offers help, agree which operations they would handle instead of quietly assuming every later obstacle will disappear.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Keep only with the Matrix caveat firmly visible and a consciously chosen plan. The Bureau cannot authenticate a no-rush claim by typing MAGNIFICENCE more loudly or increasing the number of exclamation marks.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Extended Edition publisher page confirms revised Matrix and bonus campaign. Community gameplay documentation describes timed Matrix minigames; full-path alternatives are unverified, so no untimed completion is promised.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/346940/>

Source 2: <https://shadowrun-series.fandom.com/wiki/Matrix>

P058 / PROMISING / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: yes

Wildermyth

My Legendary Origin Was Apparently Washing Dishes

Edition considered: PC base game

Wildermyth could turn ordinary people into legends, so I submitted my life for immediate adaptation. Rosa asked which ordinary beginning I wanted recorded. I suggested a prophetic storm. She suggested the afternoon I learned where the clean tea towels lived. Mercedes said the second version had a stronger character arc.

The game's heroes could age, change, disagree and develop relationships over adventures. I proposed that my fictional self remain permanently magnificent and never suffer an embarrassing consequence. Shawna observed that I was requesting a brochure, not a life. Tank added a small stain to the proposed portrait for narrative credibility.

We made room for the possibility that an interesting character might be changed by the story. This was easy to endorse in principle and harder when Mercedes named my heroic chapter THE MAN WHO FINALLY RINSED HIS CUP. Still, everybody wanted to hear what happened next, which was more than my prophetic-storm pitch had accomplished.

The actual attraction

A band of initially ordinary heroes develops through tactical adventures, personal events and relationships. Characters can transform and carry their histories forward, giving the player a story that feels partly discovered through consequences rather than entirely delivered by a fixed cast.

The catch worth knowing

Tactical positioning, abilities, event choices and evolving characters all require attention. Injury, sacrifice and aging are part of the story. Native cooperative play can divide hero control, but setup and shared decisions still need agreement; it is not automatic simplification. Every input and late sequence has not been audited.

An opening invitation

Begin an introductory campaign and meet the first heroes before judging their long-term builds. Try one event choice and one battle action. If sharing play, agree who controls which hero and whether advice is invited.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising character-led possibility when making a group's story sounds better than merely optimizing damage. The Bureau accepts humble origins, including dishwashing, provided I stop requesting a commemorative statue before the cup is dry.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports evolving heroes, tactical battles, difficulty choices and cooperative campaign play with separately controlled heroes. Memory rating is editorial; co-op does not guarantee reduced burden or complete input comfort.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/763890/>

P059 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Wartales

The Mercenaries Have Discovered Payroll

Edition considered: PC base game

I founded a mercenary company with three vacancies and a magnificent crest. Tank asked what we paid. I said opportunity. He crossed his name off the application. Rosa asked what the company ate. I pointed at the crest's decorative wheat. She crossed my name off the catering plan.

Wartales made a band of hired fighters responsible for its own survival, equipment and camp. Mercedes explained that this was almost exactly the organization I had been pretending the Bureau did not require. My first expedition reached the kitchen, where it stalled over unpaid biscuits and an inadequate understanding of inventory.

Shawna checked the professions as well as the battles. Timing-based activities could lurk outside the turn-based combat label. I tried to solve this with a grand speech about fellowship. Tank said fellowship could begin with an honest warning and a sandwich. We supplied both, an unusually sound foundation for my revised mercenary business model.

The actual attraction

Lead a band through a harsh medieval world, choosing contracts and gradually shaping its camp, skills and equipment. The appeal is the practical, emergent story of a company surviving together rather than fulfilling a single hero's destiny; native co-op can share that company.

The catch worth knowing

Food, money, gear, professions and tactical battles create extensive management. Some profession activities use timing-based minigames, so turn-based combat does not mean a completely untimed game. A whole-route way around those activities is unverified. Exploration and party maintenance add further demands; this is a marked detour.

An opening invitation

Inspect an opening party and camp menu before pursuing contracts. Check the specific profession interactions a chosen plan would need, and only then consider a short shared outing with clear agreement about who handles each operation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retain for someone deliberately attracted to mercenary logistics, with the timing caveat up front. A crest featuring wheat is not food, and a recruitment speech is not payroll, however richly embossed either one becomes.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher confirms open-world company management, turn-based combat and up-to-four-player co-op. Gamepressure's profession guide describes timing minigames. Their complete avoidability has not been established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1527950/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamepressure.com/newsroom/professions-in-wartales-explained-list-and-description/zd543a>

P060 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Battle Brothers

The Contract Contains an Unhelpful Amount of Consequences

Edition considered: PC base game

I accepted a mercenary contract before reading it because the seal looked expensive. Mercedes asked what we had agreed to do. I said the details were surely conventional. Shawna turned the paper over. 'Deliver the meeting chairs downstairs.' I announced that our company specialized in strategic transport, then immediately delegated command to Tank.

Battle Brothers offered contracts whose risk could exceed a commander's optimism. I thought about my chairs. Equipment, wages, injury and uncertain opponents gave the fantasy teeth. Rosa asked whether the reader wanted those teeth tonight, an excellent question that my glossy recruitment poster had somehow omitted.

We carried the chairs together after negotiating a fee of shared lunch. I learned that a clear, modest contract could be more satisfying than a glorious one with hidden costs. Mercedes amended our company motto from FORTUNE FAVORS AIDEN to READ THE DAMN PAPER. The lettering was smaller, but the advice traveled considerably better.

The actual attraction

A mercenary company develops its own history through recruits, contracts, equipment and battles in a changing world. The appeal is a tough, unscripted campaign where decisions leave marks and a modest success can feel earned because failure remains possible.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly separates real-time world travel from turn-based battles. Roster management, wages, equipment, injuries and risk assessment are substantial. Harsh consequences can produce pressure even when battle decisions wait. Pause behavior during travel and every held-input requirement need checking; this is not a low-management fantasy adventure.

An opening invitation

Inspect a starting company's people and equipment, then read one contract's terms before accepting anything. Test travel controls and pausing deliberately. If the administrative burden already dominates the fun, another entry deserves the evening instead.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider conditionally when difficult company management is the point of the outing. The Bureau recommends reading contracts before admiring their seals, especially if the chairs turn out heavier than the commander's promotional promises suggested.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes real-time travel, turn-based combat and mercenary contract/equipment management. Travel pause/hold details are not established here; strategic pressure is an editorial warning, not a seconds-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/365360/>

P061 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

BATTLETECH

The Giant Robot Has Failed Its Annual Service

Edition considered: PC base game

I acquired an imaginary BattleMech and announced that the Bureau's parking problem was solved. Tank asked how. 'No one parks beside a giant robot.' Shawna asked about maintenance. I said the machine would be sustained by prestige. Mercedes opened a repair estimate long enough to reach the floor and suggested we test that theory with the printer first.

BATTLETECH's mercenary outfit had to keep its machines and people functioning between tactical battles. I considered this a cruel intrusion of invoices into an otherwise excellent giant-robot fantasy. Rosa said caring for the crew was part of the fantasy, unless I planned to travel alone in a monument to my own exhaust emissions.

We replaced the proposed mech purchase with one small desk model. It required no fuel, endangered no parking spaces and let Tank demonstrate how positioning mattered. My empire of steel had become educational and affordable, a double blow from which I expected to recover after tea.

The actual attraction

Command enormous combat machines while managing the mercenary company behind them. The attraction is the connection between personalities, damaged equipment and tactical decisions: a battle's outcome follows the crew back to a traveling base rather than vanishing at a results screen.

The catch worth knowing

Weapon loadouts, heat, armor, positioning, repairs and contracts create substantial technical and menu demands. Battles take turns, yet long engagements and economic consequences can still feel taxing. The publisher lists competitive multiplayer and solo skirmishes; do not infer cooperative campaign play from sharing a screen or discussing tactics.

An opening invitation

Try the opening instruction or a solo skirmish and inspect one machine's movement and weapon choices. Before accepting a company-wide campaign, decide whether reading its equipment information is an enjoyable part of the experience or simply too much administration.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when giant robots plus maintenance logistics sounds more appealing than giant robots alone. The Bureau's prestige-powered engine remains theoretical, and no vehicle may be purchased on the strength of its nonexistent fuel economy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports turn-based mech combat, contracts, repairs, company management and solo skirmish/PvP modes. Complete held/camera interactions are not tested; no native co-op inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/637090/>

P062 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

TRIANGLE STRATEGY

The Vote Did Not Go the Way My Speech Expected

Edition considered: PC release

I introduced the Scales of Bureau Conviction: one tray for my proposals, another for objections. Tank placed my proposal to buy a throne on the first tray. Mercedes placed the actual price on the second. The scales hit the table with enough force to settle the debate without further constitutional guidance.

Triangle Strategy made important decisions a matter of persuading allies and accepting a vote. I admired the idea until Shawna said the allies might disagree. 'Even after the speech?' 'Possibly because of it.' I revised my speech into three sentences and experienced a distressing increase in its persuasive power.

Rosa asked everyone what they actually wanted from the evening. The answers differed, yet somehow nobody needed to be conquered. I recorded this as a successful trial of democratic procedure and attempted to name it after myself. The motion failed four to one, with the one vote carefully documented in gold ink.

The actual attraction

Political conflict, scarce resources and competing principles shape a story in which allies can vote on major choices. Tactical battles and conversations both matter, making the central attraction the tension between personal conviction, persuasion and the needs of a group.

The catch worth knowing

The PC listing declares play without timed input, adjustable difficulty and saving at any time. Those features help pacing but do not shrink the dialogue, political names, unit abilities or positional tactics. Expect a heavy reading and menu load; the story's moral weight may itself feel demanding.

An opening invitation

Choose a comfortable difficulty and follow an early conversation before testing one explained battle action. Pay attention to whether the political questions interest you enough to learn the surrounding systems; no vote of the Bureau can supply that interest.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when persuading an ensemble through difficult choices is part of the desired drama. My throne proposal may return only after the price decreases or the laws of basic arithmetic are legitimately amended.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports conviction/voting and tactical systems; current PC metadata declares no timed input, adjustable difficulty and Save Anytime. These are declarations, not independent full-path control validation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1850510/>

P063 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Tactics Ogre: Reborn

The Civil War Has More Factions Than My Label Maker

Edition considered: PC Reborn edition

I bought colored labels to keep a political epic organized. By the time I finished labeling the labels, Mercedes had founded a rival administration dedicated to getting something done. Tactics Ogre's divided kingdom looked suddenly familiar, although its disputes had rather more at stake than ownership of the large marker.

I offered to mediate with a speech titled EVERYONE HAS A POINT, ESPECIALLY ME. Shawna replaced it with a list of people, allegiances and the immediate decision. The list was much less impressive from across the room and much more useful from the chair where somebody was actually trying to understand events.

Rosa suggested that a game could be rich precisely because its choices were complicated, while still being a poor choice for a night when nobody wanted another complicated thing. I removed the admission oath from the door. Tank used the colored labels to mark tea tins, securing the first uncontested territorial settlement of the afternoon.

The actual attraction

Denam's decisions unfold amid factional conflict in a kingdom shaped by past rule and renewed war. Branching story choices and tactical battles make the appeal a sustained political fantasy in which personal loyalties and public consequences rarely stay neatly separate.

The catch worth knowing

The current Reborn PC listing declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and saving at any time. Even so, a large roster, equipment, classes, battle rules and political names demand substantial learning. Reborn's revised systems differ from earlier releases; comfortable selection and camera use still need testing.

An opening invitation

Read the opening situation and try one unit's basic turn without planning an entire army. Keep a small character note if useful, then decide whether the political intrigue makes the menus feel worthwhile rather than automatically accepting them as a toll.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for deliberate, layered tactical drama. The Bureau's label maker may assist with names but cannot resolve a civil war, determine which faction deserves trust or explain why I ordered the metallic refill pack.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Reborn listing supports branching story, revised tactical systems and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only/Keyboard Only/Save Anytime. Complexity assessment is editorial, not a clinical rating.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1451090/>

P064 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS - The Ivalice Chronicles

The Squire Has Been Given a Better Job Description

Edition considered: PC Enhanced version proposed for later assessment

I arrived in Ivalice wearing a sash that said TACTICIAN, which I had printed before understanding the difficulty choices. Shawna turned it over and wrote START BY READING. I objected that this title lacked martial authority. Mercedes said martial authority had become considerably less important after I deployed the stapler facing my own sleeve.

The Ivalice Chronicles offered an Enhanced version with a Squire difficulty, making this a more specific proposal than vaguely recommending an old tactical classic. I accepted the distinction and requested a ceremonial squire's stool. Tank supplied the ordinary chair I had been avoiding because it lacked a crest.

Ramza and Delita's story had enough class, loyalty and political trouble without my adding a furniture hierarchy. Rosa said the reader could choose the gentler setting and still take the story seriously. I sat down. The chair supported this argument with excellent practical evidence and no need for a commemorative plaque.

The actual attraction

Ramza and Delita are drawn through a struggle over power, class and competing loyalties in Ivalice. This edition's Enhanced version adds fully voiced dialogue and refinements, offering a specific modern route into a substantial tactical story rather than an unspecified nostalgic recommendation.

The catch worth knowing

Use Enhanced with Squire difficulty for the proposed trial. That lowers a barrier but does not remove job systems, equipment, positioning or a large cast of names. The Classic version has different features. Complete held-input and camera comfort remain unverified, and a gentler setting does not make every battle simple.

An opening invitation

Select Enhanced and Squire, then follow the opening explanation through one character's movement and action. Read only the abilities immediately available before considering future job combinations; the first question is whether this turn feels understandable and interesting.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a serious political story can justify learning tactical menus, with the named version kept attached. My TACTICIAN sash is unavailable until its owner can operate the office stapler without friendly fire incidents.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Square Enix's current official page confirms exact title, Enhanced/Classic distinction, voiced Enhanced dialogue and Squire difficulty. Job/ability complexity is documented; complete no-hold/camera comfort is not.

Source 1: <https://final-fantasy-tactics-the-ivalice-chronicles.square-enix-games.com/en-us>

P065 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Disgaea 5 Complete

The Dark Assembly Has Approved My Worst Idea

Edition considered: PC Complete edition

Disgaea let a person visit a Dark Assembly and argue about the rules. I felt professionally recognized. At last, a game understood that an unreasonable plan could improve if it acquired enough official procedure. Mercedes said this explained the enthusiasm but not the wisdom of giving me access to a fictional legislature.

I submitted a motion declaring every snack an item of legendary power. Tank supported the motion until he discovered it required a quest before opening the biscuits. Shawna defeated the proposal by asking what practical benefit it produced. I cited dramatic scale, a metric she refused to include in the budget.

The game's absurd quantities and systems were part of its deliberate comedy. Mine were mostly a procurement problem. Rosa separated those facts kindly but firmly. We could enjoy a wildly excessive strategy game without importing its entire scale into the kitchen, particularly when the kitchen had no upgrade path beyond finding the clean plates.

The actual attraction

Disgaea 5 turns tactical role-playing into an extravagant comic machine of demons, rebellion, huge numbers and unusual combinations. Its appeal is enjoying systems that become increasingly ridiculous, with a cast and world equally happy to push beyond ordinary fantasy restraint.

The catch worth knowing

The Complete edition contains extensive added material and many deep systems: jobs, items, special battle mechanics and customization. That is a major menu and memory burden, not a promise of more effortless entertainment. Turn-based decisions help pacing, but the publisher's abundance is exactly the catch for someone wanting few systems.

An opening invitation

Try only the opening explanation and a basic battle action. Leave bonus scenarios and long-term optimization alone until the fundamental move-and-act loop feels enjoyable; there is no requirement to consume everything included in the word Complete.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when magnificent mechanical excess is itself funny and attractive. The Dark Assembly's jurisdiction ends at the kitchen door, where biscuits may be eaten without first achieving legendary rank or completing a procedural hearing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Complete listing documents included scenarios, jobs, customization and multiple strategic systems. Waits is tactical decision pacing; no full-path no-hold or low-menu claim is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/803600/>

P066 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Disgaea 7: Vows of the Virtueless

The Fine Print Has Achieved Jumbification

Edition considered: PC base game

Fuji's arrangement with Pirilika convinced me that every ambitious partnership needed a contract. I printed ours in letters large enough to be read from the parking lot. Mercedes unfolded it across three chairs and said the fine print had apparently undergone the game's Jumbification process before the rest of the office.

Disgaea 7 promised another outrageous collection of systems. I promised that this time our absurdity would be managed efficiently. Shawna asked why clause one gave me sole rights to all applause. I said intellectual property deserved protection. Rosa crossed it out and added a provision for everyone to leave the meeting whenever they wished.

Tank read the actual auto-battle condition: stages had to be completed before the feature unlocked for them. I had been ready to wave the phrase around like a universal escape hatch. We corrected the file. My enormous contract became wrapping paper for a much smaller and more useful set of straightforward instructions.

The actual attraction

A reluctant fighter and an enthusiastic client anchor a demonic tactical adventure with exaggerated powers and comic excess. New systems such as oversized combat transformations fit a series whose appeal includes seeing a seemingly sensible strategy become gloriously unreasonable.

The catch worth knowing

The PC publisher specifically supports keyboard/mouse menu and target selection, but the many classes, items and mechanics remain dense. Auto-battle unlocks after successfully completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass. Turn-based structure does not settle every held-input requirement or make the management light.

An opening invitation

Learn the first battle's ordinary movement and attack before opening every customization possibility. Test whether the PC menu and target controls feel clear, and judge the cast's humor separately from the attraction of increasingly elaborate numerical combinations.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit if you want the comedy of excessive systems and are happy learning those systems. No employee must sign my oversized contract merely because the text has become large enough to count as office furniture.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base PC listing supports Fuji/Pirilika, Jumbification, keyboard/mouse menu controls and auto-battle unlocked by completed stages. No complete-edition extras, unconditional autoplay or hold-free guarantee is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2250600/>

P067 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Chained Echoes

The Airship Has Developed a Second Maintenance Department

Edition considered: PC release

Chained Echoes offered swords, dragons and piloted machines in the same adventure. I declared this the proper level of generosity for a fantasy world. Mercedes asked whether I could maintain a sword before requesting a mech. I pointed out that maintenance was Tank's department. Tank created a department of Refusing That Arrangement.

I drew an airship shaped like my initials. Shawna said the shape made the boarding ramp inaccessible and the wings politically embarrassing. Rosa suggested choosing companions for their personalities rather than for how well they fit into my proposed cabin assignments. This improved both the conversation and the imaginary emergency exits.

The attraction was a big journey with an ensemble and places worth discovering. The catch was that a rich journey also carried combat systems and equipment. I put both facts in the brochure. For once the brochure described the actual trip instead of a monument that happened to possess several passenger seats.

The actual attraction

An ensemble crosses a war-torn continent in a fantasy world that mixes dragons and machines with a deliberate older-RPG visual style. The appeal is a long journey through varied places, with character stories and political trouble giving the travels a continuing purpose.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly describes a complex skill and equipment system. Turn-based battles permit choosing actions, while exploration still requires directional movement and may involve sustained inputs. Visible enemies replace random encounters, but that does not eliminate combat, navigation demands or every potential timing question across the whole story.

An opening invitation

Follow the opening until you can test one movement segment and one explained battle choice. Read the currently useful skill information, then decide whether the cast and world make further systems learning attractive rather than assuming retro-looking graphics mean retro-sized complexity.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for an expansive ensemble adventure when learning equipment and combat is acceptable. The Bureau's airship will not be built in the shape of my initials until somebody demonstrates where the passengers could safely get off.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports story-driven ensemble journey, visible enemies, turn-based battles and complex equipment/skills. Held movement and complete path comfort are unverified; no all-game no-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229240/>

P068 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Sea of Stars

The Solstice Committee Cannot Vote the Sun into Waiting

Edition considered: PC base game

I appointed myself Minister of Celestial Scheduling for Sea of Stars. Shawna asked what powers the office possessed. I said the sun would rise at a dignified hour after my briefing. Mercedes opened the blinds before I finished, delivering a devastating natural-world rebuttal through the entire east-facing window.

The adventure's beautiful fantasy world was tempting, and a later update had added cooperative play. I nearly stamped the file on that basis alone. Tank stopped my hand. Timed hits were still part of the combat description. Rosa added that a friend joining the journey did not magically erase the journey's operations.

I revised the recommendation into an honest detour: attractive characters and places, but actual movement and timing questions to settle first. The sun continued without consulting me. I considered filing a complaint, then accepted its useful contribution to the room's lighting and reassigned my ministry to the much smaller problem of closing one curtain.

The actual attraction

A colorful, classically inspired role-playing journey follows Solstice Warriors through a world of sun-and-moon magic. The combination of scenery, companions and adventure is the attraction; the Dawn of Equinox update also makes the story available in local cooperative play.

The catch worth knowing

Timed hits are a real combat mechanic, including in co-op. The developer documents difficulty presets and relic adjustments, but this research does not establish a complete path avoiding every timed or held action. Movement and traversal require separate checks. Treat it as a deliberate detour rather than assuming turn-based means entirely unrushed.

An opening invitation

Inspect the installed version's difficulty and relic explanations, then test movement and one early battle with no expectation of perfect timing. If the required operations already conflict with preferences, enjoy the premise and choose another route without a mastery assignment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retain for a consciously chosen shared or assisted adventure after checking the mechanics. The Bureau's celestial office cannot authorize the sun to pause, and it has even less authority over an undocumented accessibility promise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer describes original story with Dawn of Equinox's up-to-three-player local co-op, timed hits and difficulty presets. This assesses that updated base adventure, not the OST or unverified Sunset Edition changes. Complete no-timed/hold path unknown.

Source 1: <https://sabotagestudio.com/press-release/sabotage-studio-announces-free-sea-of-stars-update-dawn-of-equinox-bringing-top-fan-requested-additions-to-pc-and-consoles-gains-november-release-date/>

P069 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II

Eight Travelers Have Declined My Group Itinerary

Edition considered: PC release

Eight travelers sounded like exactly enough people for my deluxe guided tour. I prepared a schedule beginning with forty minutes of admiring the guide. Mercedes asked whether any traveler had requested this. I said leadership anticipated needs. Shawna said the travelers appeared to have their own reasons for leaving home, none of which involved my commemorative lanyard.

Octopath Traveler II gave each person a different beginning and useful talents. I tried to choose a lead by whose outfit best matched the Bureau's stationery. Rosa redirected me toward whose story sounded interesting. A modest correction, yet somehow the whole expedition improved before it moved an inch.

Tank divided my itinerary into eight neat strips and used them as bookmarks. I protested until he explained that this allowed each person's story to remain identifiable. The brochure had finally developed a practical function. I kept one lanyard as a reminder that organizing an ensemble and making everyone follow me were very different ambitions.

The actual attraction

Eight protagonists bring separate motivations and talents to a shared world, with stories that can be approached through different beginnings. The attraction is choosing a person who catches your interest, then discovering how an expanding cast and their journeys relate.

The catch worth knowing

The PC listing declares play without timed input, but battles still use several interacting systems and the wider journey includes movement, jobs, equipment and distinct character abilities. Remembering eight stories can become substantial. Directional hold comfort remains a separate question even when battle selections wait.

An opening invitation

Choose one traveler because the premise appeals, read that opening, and learn one ordinary battle action. Keep the next step attached to that character before treating the whole ensemble as a single large list of unfinished obligations.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a long character-led journey when turn-based systems and reading feel welcome. The Bureau's lanyard is optional, and no traveler must attend my introductory lecture to prove a legitimate interest in the wider world.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports eight travelers, Path Actions, jobs and Break/Boost; developer declares no timed input. Mixed label reflects active exploration alongside waiting battle decisions, not a contradicted timer claim. Hold comfort unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1971650/>

P070 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

The Luminary Has Requested a Less Complicated Name Badge

Edition considered: PC Definitive Edition

The Dragon Quest title required so much space that my first name badge unfolded like a road map. Mercedes asked whether the hero needed a second companion just to carry the subtitle. I explained that grandeur sometimes required hyphenation. Shawna pointed out that our purpose was to identify the edition, not to build a suspension bridge from typography.

The story gave a young hero a disputed identity and a growing group of companions. I sympathized with being misunderstood by authority until Rosa reminded me that I was usually the authority causing the misunderstanding. Tank folded the badge into something that fit a pocket.

This Definitive Edition offered a two-dimensional presentation as well as the three-dimensional one. That was a concrete choice worth discussing instead of simply announcing that all colorful fantasy was easy. I left room for the player to test it. My own badge now said AIDEN, a bold reduction in both paperwork and wind resistance.

The actual attraction

A young hero accused of being a threat gathers companions and searches for the truth of his identity. The appeal is a substantial, colorful adventure with personal backstories and a traditional turn-based battle structure; this edition also includes a two-dimensional presentation option.

The catch worth knowing

Party equipment, abilities, navigation and a long story create a meaningful memory load. The 3D presentation brings camera demands; trying 2D may change that burden but is not a universal solution or instant switch at every moment. Directional holds and optional minigame timing remain separate checks.

An opening invitation

Inspect the Definitive Edition's presentation choices and begin without extra Draconian challenge settings. Try ordinary movement and one early turn-based battle, judging both the immediate controls and whether the companions' tone makes a long adventure sound inviting.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider conditionally for a traditional, characterful fantasy journey with a useful presentation choice. No applicant is required to memorize the complete subtitle, which the Bureau has finally agreed to print on ordinary paper at a reasonable size.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact XI S Definitive page confirms 2D/3D modes, companions, turn-based combat and optional Draconian challenges. Mode-switch limits and full input/timing comfort are not fully verified; no original-XI assumptions.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295510/>

P071 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Persona 5 Royal

The Phantom Thief Has Stolen His Own Appointment Book

Edition considered: PC Royal edition

I announced my secret identity as a Phantom Administrator while wearing a mask over my ordinary name badge. Mercedes said secrecy had suffered a paperwork breach. Persona 5 Royal offered a double life full of friendships and supernatural rebellion. I offered a double-booked afternoon and an unusually dramatic explanation for missing the budget meeting.

Shawna found the later timing caveat before I could stamp the file. A turn-based game could still contain an actual countdown in a required encounter. I wanted the excellent-looking cast to overrule this inconvenient fact. Rosa said the cast was welcome to be excellent while the fact remained inconvenient.

Tank returned my appointment book, which I had hidden under the mask to symbolize freedom from schedules. Every appointment was still there. I accepted that a game about managing a double life might be a rich story and a substantial demand at once. My secret identity was downgraded to Man Who Can Be Found Beside the Printer.

The actual attraction

A stylish ensemble of students balances daily relationships with a supernatural campaign against abusive power. Royal offers an extensive character story with striking music and presentation, making the desire to spend time with its cast entirely understandable even when its systems are demanding.

The catch worth knowing

This is a detour for a strict no-rush preference. Royal walkthroughs document a required later boss with a thirty-minute countdown, alongside timed traversal elsewhere. Ordinary turn-based combat does not erase those exceptions. Calendar choices, relationship planning, combat menus, dungeon movement and camera handling create additional complexity.

An opening invitation

Judge the opening conversations and presentation, but keep the late countdown warning in the decision from the start. Establish a deliberate shared-viewing or help arrangement before investing in a long campaign if those required operations are unacceptable alone.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retain for the cast and story only with an honest plan for the documented conflicts. A stylish mask cannot conceal a countdown, and the Bureau is forbidden to rename one as an unusually enthusiastic calendar notification.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Royal PC listing supports premise. Royal-specific walkthroughs corroborate required Okumura time limits; no PC option removing them was verified. Story interest is separated from full-route suitability.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1687950/>

Source 2: <https://gamefaqs.gamespot.com/ps4/260936-persona-5-royal/faqs/78256/week-24-october-1st-october-9th-okumuras-palace>

Source 3: https://www.neoseeker.com/persona-5-royal/Okumura%27s_Space_Station

P072 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

BRAVELY DEFAULT II

I Have Borrowed Four Turns Against Next Tuesday

Edition considered: PC release

BRAVELY DEFAULT II allowed characters to store actions or spend several together. I attempted the same system with the Bureau's meetings, announcing that I would deliver four closing speeches now and owe silence next Tuesday. Mercedes accepted the silence and rejected the speeches, creating an unfavorable exchange rate for my initiative.

The game's Brave and Default choices were a real tactical system; my scheme was merely an overdraft against everybody's patience. Shawna demonstrated the distinction with a handful of counters. Save an opportunity, spend it thoughtfully, understand the consequences. I tried to purchase applause with two counters. Tank said applause was not an eligible action.

Rosa liked that the game explained a distinctive rule around a traditional party adventure. Whether managing that rule would be fun was the actual question. I returned the counters and honored a small portion of my silence debt immediately. The room's response suggested that my creditors might finally receive a satisfactory settlement.

The actual attraction

Four heroes undertake a crystal-centered fantasy journey with jobs and abilities that can be combined in different ways. The signature battle idea is deciding when to store action capacity and when to spend it, creating a recognizable rhythm of preparation and commitment.

The catch worth knowing

The PC publisher declares play without timed input and adjustable difficulty. That helps pace, while Brave Points, primary and secondary jobs, equipment and enemy behavior still create a heavy tactical load. Exploration requires directional control; a no-timed-input declaration does not establish that movement is comfortable without holds.

An opening invitation

Choose a comfortable difficulty and learn one ordinary attack and one Default action in the early guidance. Observe what changes on the next turn before planning elaborate job combinations or trying to bank an entire party's future at once.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider if a clear central battle rule sounds enjoyable inside a long fantasy story. The Bureau will not accept speculative future silence as payment for four unwanted speeches delivered immediately with ceremonial enthusiasm.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing explains Brave/Default, jobs and four heroes; developer declares no timed input and adjustable difficulty. Mixed pace distinguishes exploration from waiting decisions, not a claim of required timers. Holds untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1446650/>

P073 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Slay the Spire

The Tower Has Refused My Membership Card

Edition considered: PC original game

I approached the Spire with a deck containing my business card, a loyalty card for coffee and a photograph of the Bureau's ribbon-cutting. Mercedes asked which one blocked damage. I said my reputation had discouraged critics for years. Shawna said the enemy intended to bite rather than publish a review, making our defensive position somewhat less secure.

Slay the Spire asked for cards that worked together. I asked whether merely expensive-looking cards counted. Tank put an ordinary defend card beside an ordinary attack card and explained the immediate choice. It lacked the glamour of my opening hand and possessed the advantage of actually doing something.

Rosa suggested trying one fight before planning the perfect deck. The tower did not need to be conquered tonight for that fight to be worthwhile. I retired the ribbon photograph from active service. The coffee card remained useful, but only in the separate and less lethal campaign conducted around the kitchen counter.

The actual attraction

Build a deck while climbing a changing sequence of encounters, choosing cards and relics that make the next fight play differently. The appeal is recognizing a useful combination and gradually shaping a plan from imperfect, limited choices rather than executing a fixed routine.

The catch worth knowing

The developer declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Card text, energy, status effects and deck interactions still demand reading and planning. Test card selection and targeting for drag or hold comfort; losing a run is part of the structure, not evidence that the trial was wasted.

An opening invitation

Begin with the first available character and examine one attack card and one defensive card before playing either. Try one encounter and judge whether the tradeoff is satisfying without aiming to finish the entire climb on the first visit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising card-game trial when visible choices and patient planning appeal. The Bureau's business card offers no block value, regardless of paper thickness, embossed lettering or how prominently my qualifications appear on the reverse.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original PC game listing supports deckbuilding/roguelike structure and declares Mouse Only, no timed input and Save Anytime. Card manipulation comfort and full-path suitability are not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/646570/>

P074 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Monster Train

The Train to Hell Has Three Seating Classes and One Fire

Edition considered: PC original game

I accepted responsibility for a train carrying the last infernal flame and immediately installed a first-class carriage. Tank asked whether the flame could afford the supplement. I said premium service should be available to every sufficiently important combustion event. Mercedes began drafting the complaint on its behalf.

Monster Train placed the tactical problem on several levels, which I admired as an efficient use of vertical real estate. Shawna pointed out that units needed useful positions, not seats assigned by social prestige. Rosa refused to serve tea until I stopped calling the lower floor economy damnation.

Then we found the mode distinction: ordinary solo deckbuilding and a separate Hell Rush competition with a ticking clock. I removed Hell Rush from the proposed route before my marketing instincts could call it invigorating. The flame received an ordinary seat, the passengers kept their own pace, and my premium-service empire collapsed before its first scheduled departure.

The actual attraction

Defend a train across stacked battle spaces by combining units, spells and upgrades into a developing deck. The vertical layout changes the familiar card-battle question: where a creature stands can matter as much as which card is played next.

The catch worth knowing

Use an ordinary solo run for this proposal. The publisher explicitly describes Hell Rush multiplayer as a real-time, clock-driven competition, so exclude it from a no-rush trial. Multiple floors, unit placement, card upgrades and interacting effects still create a substantial mental load; dragging and held-input behavior require checking.

An opening invitation

Open a solo run and inspect one unit's placement and one spell before advancing the fight. Keep attention on the immediate floor arrangement; there is no need to plan a perfect deck or enter any competitive challenge to understand the attraction.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for layered card tactics with the solo-mode boundary attached. The Bureau's first-class surcharge has been abolished, and the infernal flame may travel without listening to my five-part presentation on premium opportunities for controlled combustion.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original-game publisher page supports three vertical fields/deckbuilding and explicitly identifies Hell Rush as timed real-time multiplayer. Waits applies to the proposed ordinary solo mode, not all modes; holds remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1102190/>

P075 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Griftlands

My Argument Deck Contains Too Many Compliments About Me

Edition considered: PC release

Griftlands used cards for negotiation as well as combat. I laid out my best arguments: VISIONARY, WELL-DRESSED and YOU WILL THANK ME LATER. Mercedes countered with WHERE IS THE RECEIPT. The encounter ended faster than expected, although technically I still possessed considerable unused confidence.

A separate negotiation deck sounded like a fine way to expose the machinery of a conversation. Shawna asked whether I understood that other people had interests independent of my preferred outcome. I said I was prepared to consider this as an advanced rule. Rosa informed me it was part of the tutorial.

Tank offered me a straightforward deal: carry the mugs and receive a biscuit. I accepted without invoking my prestige modifier. The transaction succeeded, nobody developed a lasting grudge, and the kitchen remained unbroken. Mercedes suggested I keep that card. For once, an improvement to my build was both cheap and visible from the doorway.

The actual attraction

Three separate protagonists navigate a rough science-fiction world through fights, negotiations and relationships. Maintaining different decks for talking and combat makes social encounters mechanically substantial, while choices about allies and enemies can follow the character into later situations.

The catch worth knowing

Two decks, relationship effects, faction loyalties and run-based consequences make this more demanding than a small casual card game. Considerable text explains abilities and social stakes. Turn-based card decisions support deliberation, but no full-path guarantee about every gesture or timing exception has been independently established.

An opening invitation

Start the opening character's story and read one negotiation card in context before building a grand strategy. Try one exchange, observing both what the card does and why the other person cares, then decide whether managing conversation this way is enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when arguments treated as playable tactics sound intriguing. The Bureau's deck may include confidence, but at least one card must answer the question actually asked by the person standing across the table from its founder.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports three campaigns, separate negotiation/combat decks and persistent social consequences. Waits describes core card decisions; held gestures and complete-path exceptions have not been tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/601840/>

P076 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Dicey Dungeons

The Dice Have Become Staff and Immediately Requested Benefits

Edition considered: PC release

I welcomed six walking dice to the Bureau and assigned each a department. Tank asked why every favorable number had been placed in Public Relations. I said the allocation reflected organizational strengths. Mercedes rolled the personnel chart onto the floor and demonstrated that chance had declined to recognize my reporting structure.

Dicey Dungeons made random rolls into decisions about equipment. I tried to negotiate a better result by complimenting the die. Shawna said the point was to use the roll received. Rosa said this was also useful advice about an afternoon that had already included two imaginary empires and a failed infernal railway upgrade.

I placed a small number where it could still help instead of complaining that it was not a large number. The committee observed this unfamiliar behavior with interest. Tank offered a biscuit for continued progress. I accepted without rolling for prestige, narrowly avoiding another dispute about whether snacks should require performance-related numerical evidence.

The actual attraction

Walking dice face a peculiar dungeon game show, turning rolled numbers into attacks and other equipment effects. Different characters change the rules enough to make a familiar-looking die produce very different little tactical problems, with lively art and music supporting the absurdity.

The catch worth knowing

Equipment conditions, arithmetic and random outcomes require thought; later characters change the rules substantially. Turn-based play is the core, but placing dice may involve dragging or other gestures worth testing. Begin with the initial character rather than treating every class or bonus episode as equally simple.

An opening invitation

Use the first available character and try assigning one die to one piece of equipment. Read the requirement, observe the result, and judge the placement gesture before considering a whole dungeon or a different character with an entirely new rule system.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising short tactical experiment when adapting a small handful of numbers sounds fun. The Bureau cannot promise favorable rolls, but it can stop asking the dice to attend departmental meetings in matching ties.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer store supports characters/equipment; official project wiki describes turn-based dice allocation. Drag/hold alternatives and every episode are not verified; recommendation targets the initial character's basic loop.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/861540/>

Source 2: https://wiki.diceydungeons.com/doku.php?id=dicey_dungeons

P077 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Balatro

The Joker Has Taken Over Accounts

Edition considered: PC base game

I appointed a Joker to improve the Bureau's finances because its expression suggested a healthy disregard for conventional accounting. Shawna asked what it actually did. I said the number would become larger. Mercedes said that explanation sounded uncomfortably similar to our last budget meeting and would require more specific supporting arithmetic.

Balatro rewarded combinations between familiar-looking hands and unusual modifiers. I placed two ordinary cards beside a glittering business card and claimed a pair of opportunities. Tank ruled the hand invalid. Rosa said the interesting part was learning the game's real interactions, not proving I could rename anything until it sounded profitable.

We examined one hand and one Joker. The result was understandable without convening a financial summit. I was relieved and mildly offended. My proposed summit had included excellent place cards. Mercedes put those cards away, leaving the actual game enough room to explain why a small choice could change the entire shape of a run.

The actual attraction

Poker-like hands become ingredients in a single-player score-building puzzle, transformed by Jokers and other modifiers. The attraction is watching a modest combination become unexpectedly powerful and deciding how each new card changes the plan for the next target.

The catch worth knowing

The developer declares play without timed input and mouse-only play. Hand recognition, scoring modifiers, changing boss rules and reading several effects at once still take attention. Card rearrangement and selection need a gesture check; a familiar deck does not mean all the surrounding rules are familiar or memory-light.

An opening invitation

Try the opening explanation and build one clearly recognized hand. Read one Joker's effect in plain language before buying or arranging a complicated combination, then decide whether discovering the score interaction feels satisfying rather than like unwanted arithmetic homework.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising possibility when combinations and growing numbers are the entertainment. The Bureau forbids its founder from calling an invalid hand an opportunity merely because the phrase looks more optimistic on a quarterly presentation slide.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base listing supports poker-inspired deckbuilding, Jokers and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only. No real-money gambling claim or guaranteed hold-free card manipulation is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2379780/>

P078 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Cobalt Core

The Spaceship Only Moves Sideways, Unlike My Excuses

Edition considered: PC release

A spaceship duel arranged along one axis seemed ideal for the Bureau. At last, a navigation system could accommodate my tendency to move sideways whenever the budget question arose. Mercedes said this was not a piloting qualification. Tank asked whether my ship would dodge the invoice or simply present a different part of itself for impact.

Cobalt Core gave cards practical orders: protect the ship, shift position, exploit a weakness. I gave my crew cards reading ADMIRE CAPTAIN and ADMIRE CAPTAIN AGAIN. Shawna replaced them with MOVE and THINK. The vessel's prospects improved immediately, though my personal satisfaction took a temporary hit.

Rosa liked the crew's individual stories and the mystery behind repeated loops. I liked that the fiction could support an actual relationship with the mechanics. We tried one imagined sideways move. The invoice followed. Some threats, it appeared, belonged to a more sophisticated combat system than the Bureau was currently prepared to evade.

The actual attraction

A small crew's personalities and a time-loop mystery sit inside spaceship card battles. Moving along a single line makes positioning part of the card choice: avoiding a shot or lining up a weapon can matter as much as adding more damage.

The catch worth knowing

Crew decks, ship layout, incoming fire and upgrades create interacting information to track. The publisher invites play at one's own pace, but gesture comfort and the complete sequence of encounters are not independently tested. This is a card-driven tactical game, not a reflex flying game, yet it still requires attentive planning.

An opening invitation

Inspect one incoming attack and one movement card during the opening guidance. See what shifting the ship changes before building a multi-card sequence, then decide whether the crew's banter gives you a reason to explore another encounter.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a modest spatial puzzle and a characterful crew sound appealing together. The Bureau acknowledges that moving sideways is a legitimate spaceship tactic and an ineffective response to an ordinary request for the missing receipt.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports card-driven single-axis combat, crew stories and playing at one's pace. No continuous-action flight claim; complete hold/gesture comfort remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2179850/>

P079 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Wildfrost

The Snowman Is Waiting Three Turns to Ruin My Presentation

Edition considered: PC release

I planned a winter conference with a snowman as keynote speaker. Mercedes asked what expertise it possessed. I said it had excellent seasonal relevance. Tank asked whether the room's heating would shorten the address. I called this a natural safeguard against overlong speeches and received several meaningful looks from the staff.

Wildfrost's cards had counters showing when they would act. I misunderstood and began speaking faster. Shawna stopped me. The counters tracked turns, not seconds. Rosa let the distinction sit on the table until I quit trying to improve it with a stopwatch and a decorative scarf.

Once I understood the order of actions, the little battlefield became more interesting. A delay could be useful; a companion's position could matter. I cancelled the keynote and used the scarf to keep my own neck warm. The snowman retained the more appropriate role of hypothetical opponent, where its professional credentials were much less important than its next displayed move.

The actual attraction

Build a traveling group of companion cards in a frozen world, arranging their effects and attacks to work together. The distinctive pleasure is planning around visible action counters, so that a carefully chosen move changes what happens several turns later.

The catch worth knowing

The counters measure turns until actions, not a requirement to click within seconds. Even so, attack order, positioning, status effects and companion survival can be demanding, and a cute appearance does not predict an easy run. Card placement gestures and all-path input comfort remain checks rather than verified assurances.

An opening invitation

Read one friendly counter and one enemy counter, then use the opening guidance to observe what advances them. Try predicting only the next action before attempting a long chain of effects or comparing every possible leader and deck.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when planning a visible sequence sounds satisfying and setbacks are acceptable. The Bureau's snowman has no obligation to speak before melting, and I have no authority to turn a move counter into a personal deadline.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher explicitly explains turn-based battles and counters measured in turns. This distinguishes counters from real-time deadlines; no low-difficulty or hold-free promise is inferred from visual style.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1811990/>

P080 / PROMISING / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics

Fifty-One Games and One Chairman Who Must Stop Choosing All of Them

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch; individual games must be assessed separately

I received a collection of fifty-one games and declared a fifty-one-event Bureau championship. Rosa asked whether anybody had requested a championship. I said the trophy had already been drawn. Mercedes said a pencil sketch created no binding athletic obligation and, judging by its shape, might actually be a gravy boat.

Clubhouse Games offered enough variety to make a smaller decision possible: one board, one set of rules, one pleasant conversation while taking turns. I attempted to replace this with a seeded tournament bracket. Shawna folded the bracket into a stand for the controller, improving the plan without changing any actual game rules.

Tank chose a quiet board-game option to inspect. No one entered Toy Boxing by accident, and no one had to treat every item in the collection as equally suitable. I placed the gravy-boat trophy in storage. For the first time, the evening had a respectable chance of ending with a game played rather than a championship permanently under construction.

The actual attraction

The collection offers many small, distinct games with in-game explanations, from familiar boards to cards and more active diversions. Its useful promise is variety within one package: it may be possible to find one pleasing little ritual without adopting a long campaign.

The catch worth knowing

Assess individual games, not the collection as one control profile. Nintendo explicitly distinguishes strategic choices such as Four-in-a-row from reflex games such as Slot Cars and Toy Boxing. Multiplayer, motion, touch and undo availability vary by game. Shared competitive play is not automatically cooperative play.

An opening invitation

Open Four-in-a-row and read its own instructions, then test selecting and placing a piece in a local or solo arrangement without an added household timer. Check that game's controls and player setup before trying a second title.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising route when the desired outcome is one modest game and room to talk. The Bureau's fifty-one-event championship is cancelled by unanimous agreement, including a reluctant but legally valid vote from the man who designed its gravy boat.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms collection/tutorials and explicitly separates strategic/reflex games; proposed trial is Four-in-a-row only. Collection-level mixed pace/input must not certify every included game. Native co-op scope and game-specific holds are unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/clubhouse-games-51-worldwide-classics-switch/>

One More Turn, If You Want One

At the end of the forty files, I prepared an official ranking. It began with the title that best supported my theory of leadership and continued through a complex formula involving chairs, dramatic potential and the likelihood that a protagonist would appreciate a gold stamp. Mercedes looked at it for several seconds. Then she asked where the reader's preferences appeared. I pointed to an appendix. Shawna closed the binder very gently, the way somebody might close a cupboard after finding a raccoon inside it. We had already settled this. My entertainment could accompany the choice; it could not commandeer it by hiding the important question behind an equation.

Rosa set three empty saucers on the table. One was for things that sounded interesting. One was for things needing a practical check. One was for things we could leave alone. I immediately asked whether the saucers needed labels. 'Only if they help,' she said. This was a maddening standard because it required looking at the effect of an idea rather than admiring its appearance in my head. A title could move between saucers. A game with an awkward camera could remain a lovely story to watch together. A game with excellent pacing could still be uninteresting. None of the saucers was a verdict on anybody's worth.

Tank chose one small, ordinary action to illustrate a first trial. Inspect a card. Read what it says. Select it once. Notice what happens. The experiment did not demand winning the run, mastering the class system or promising a hundred hours to a glowing review. If a tutorial explained itself well, that was useful information. If the first menu already felt like a wall of obligations, that was useful too. I offered to record the result in the official ledger. Mercedes handed me a scrap of paper. 'One sentence will do.' The ledger was disappointed, but the scrap handled the assignment admirably.

We also left room for a more ambitious answer. Maybe someone would love a huge tactical drama, learn its menus gradually, and spend weeks discussing the characters. Depth was welcome. Nobody had to choose a smaller game merely because the Bureau had learned the word burden. The distinction was between a demand willingly enjoyed and one endured because somebody else insisted a good story justified everything. Shawna said this was obvious. Mercedes raised an eyebrow at the word. Shawna laughed and corrected herself: it was easy to forget when enthusiasm got loud. I looked around the room. Apparently this lesson had more than one authorized recipient.

The printer woke up and produced my ranking anyway. I had queued it earlier under the filename `FINAL_FINAL_ACTUALLY_FINAL_WITH_PERSONAL_AUTHORITY`. Tank read the name from the screen, slowly, with the devastating restraint of a man who knows the document has already written the joke for him. I said the filename reflected robust version control. Mercedes said it reflected a hostage negotiation with a spreadsheet. Rosa turned the pages over and gave them to us for notes. The ranking's blank sides became useful at once. I considered this a successful reuse of public resources and wisely declined to give it an award.

Someone chose a game. The room did not erupt in a victory ceremony. There was a little reading, a question about a control, an answer from the instructions, and enough quiet to try it. I remained beside the table with the gold stamp in my hand, waiting for a role large enough to justify my posture. Rosa asked me to move a cup out of the way. I did. This was not the heroic conclusion I had rehearsed, but it improved the view of the screen. For a man who had spent two volumes obstructing straightforward decisions with magnificence, it represented a respectable practical advance.

The wooden instrument held the binder steady. The trolley carried snacks. The printer was silent because Tank had turned it off at my request, a detail I insisted be preserved in the official history. I settled into an ordinary chair and let the next turn belong to whoever wanted it. Another move, a different game, a conversation, or stopping altogether: all valid. Mercedes caught me reaching for the stamp and slid a coaster under my hand. I stamped the coaster. APPROVED BY AIDEN. Nobody needed the approval, but the ink stayed off the table, and for that small mercy the household was prepared to recognize my administration.

An index with no authority over you

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 3 OF SIX

The Ministry of Looking Around Before Doing Anything

Forty places, small worlds and scenic arguments about what counts as progress.

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 3. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P081	P082	P083	P084	P085	P086	P087	P088
2. Ready for conversation	P089	P090	P091	P092	P093	P094	P095	P096
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P097	P098	P099	P100	P101	P102	P103	P104
4. Here for the atmosphere	P105	P106	P107	P108	P109	P110	P111	P112
5. Open to a wildcard	P113	P114	P115	P116	P117	P118	P119	P120

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Exterior Affairs Office Is Still Indoors

I established the Ministry of Looking Around on a Tuesday, using a folding table that had previously supported snacks with considerably less administrative overhead. The sign was magnificent. The table was not. Whenever somebody touched the binder, one leg made a sound like a minor official reconsidering his pension.

Tank stood in the doorway with a roll of tape. 'Where's the outside?' he asked. I gestured toward the screen. 'We are offering a curated range of environments.' He looked at the window, which displayed a perfectly serviceable actual tree. 'That one's included.' I told him not to undermine the launch with competitive pricing.

The problem was simple. We had found interesting worlds, and I had responded by inventing a department to issue permission to enter them. Shawna read the first form and asked why walking toward a beach required an approved statement of purpose. I said the statement could be informal. She crossed out the whole form and wrote, 'Does the beach look good?'

Rosa put a chair beside the table. It was for the guest, she explained, and it would remain available without a purchase, a performance or an account of how the previous game had gone. I agreed so enthusiastically that she checked the chair for hidden paperwork. There was none. I had put it under the cushion instead. She found it immediately.

Mercedes arrived carrying nothing. I considered this a failure to appreciate the scale of the operation. She considered the operation a failure to appreciate that someone might simply want to choose something. Both positions had merit, although only mine had a printed seal. 'You can keep the jokes,' she said. 'You cannot make the joke the only way through the door.'

So we built two doors. One was a normal index: a game, an appealing idea, the controls it might demand, the things still uncertain. The other was my magnificent route through several offices whose authority had not been recognized by any government with working lights. Anyone could use either door. Nobody needed to finish the route, justify a veto or admire the sign.

That last provision hurt more than I expected. I had commissioned the sign in my head at considerable imaginary expense. Tank fixed it to the table anyway, slightly crooked. When I asked him to straighten it, he said the ministry specialized in looking around and should benefit from the practice.

The first rule concerned scenery. A beautiful landscape could still require steering, holding a direction, turning a camera and making quick decisions. Calling the landscape peaceful did not make the controls peaceful. Shawna drew two columns on a blank page: what the place offers, and what the player actually does. This was so useful that I briefly considered claiming authorship.

The second rule concerned scale. A room, an island, a village, an ocean and a solar system were all places, but they were not the same promise. Some offered a small repeated activity. Others asked the player to learn a complicated geography. A person could love the idea of space and prefer to spend the evening arranging a kitchen. The ministry was forbidden to diagnose that as insufficient ambition.

The third rule was Rosa's. 'If somebody says the view is lovely and the controls feel bad, believe both halves.' She placed a biscuit on the page as if ratifying a treaty. I reached for the gold stamp. Mercedes moved the biscuit. Tank moved the ink pad. Between them, they prevented the first snack-related international incident of the volume.

We were ready. The chair was clear, the plain index worked and the elaborate route existed mainly to keep me occupied. Outside the window, the actual tree continued offering its services without a brochure. I respected the competition. Then I opened the first box on the screen and asked where the socks should go.

P081 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Unpacking

The Minister of Socks Has Misplaced His Jurisdiction

Edition considered: PC current release

I appointed myself Secretary of Domestic Arrival before the first box was open. It was an executive appointment. Nobody had voted, which saved everyone the embarrassment of choosing incorrectly. I placed the gold stamp beside a pair of imaginary shoes and announced that every object would receive a destination, a serial number and a brief statement of loyalty.

Shawna picked up the red stapler. 'Where does this go?' 'Headquarters.' 'Where is headquarters?' I indicated the desk. She indicated the floor beneath it, where three abandoned binders had formed a government without me. Tank said the socks already had a stronger claim to territory. Rosa handed me a box and asked whether I wanted a home or a filing system. I opened my mouth with enough confidence to answer both. Then I saw a small object that clearly mattered to someone, and the speech lost its place.

The actual attraction

Unpacking tells a life through belongings and the rooms they enter. The pleasure is partly arranging a space and partly noticing what survives each move. A familiar object can carry more character information than a long conversation. This is a worthwhile route for curiosity about people expressed through ordinary things.

The catch worth knowing

The developer documents no time limits, mouse-only PC play and alternatives to dragging or holding. Those specific provisions make it a stronger starting candidate. Visual searching, small objects and deciding where things belong can still take effort. Check the Allow Items Anywhere option if placement rules interfere with the pleasure.

An opening invitation

Open one box in the first room and place an object. Test the click-based interaction and whether the objects are comfortably visible before organizing everything.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for anyone who believes a toothbrush can deliver testimony without hiring a courtroom.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports belongings-as-story and no timers. Official developer accessibility page previously inspected supports mouse-only PC, no required holds/drag/simultaneous buttons and Allow Items Anywhere. Actual comfort remains individual.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1135690/>

Source 2: <https://www.unpackinggame.com/>

P082 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Townscaper

A City Council With No Citizens to Annoy

Edition considered: PC release

I built one little house and immediately called a press conference. A city had been founded. It possessed waterfront access, excellent prospects and, at that moment, no toilets that anyone could prove were missing. Tank asked who lived there. 'Visionaries,' I said. He zoomed in. 'I see a roof.' 'Visionaries value privacy.'

My second click made the building taller. The third created a balcony, which I named after myself before Shawna could stop me. She asked for the transit plan. I made another house. Rosa asked where people could sit together. I added a courtyard and felt, briefly, like a competent public servant. Then Mercedes said the town looked better without the twenty-foot statue I had described. The statue did not exist, but I defended its artistic importance anyway. Tank opened the snack bag and declared the city solvent.

The actual attraction

Townscaper is a construction toy in which clicks generate buildings and pleasing architectural connections. You can follow a small visual idea, such as a street over water or a cluster of towers, without first learning a production economy. Its interest is shape, color and the surprise of what the building system produces.

The catch worth knowing

The small tool set does not remove every physical task. Moving the view, zooming and placing a precise block may involve a different input pattern from selecting a menu. Preview those actions on the chosen device. This is a place-making activity with little authored character story, so the appeal must come from making rather than following a plot.

An opening invitation

Make a three-house waterfront, change one color and turn the view once. Keep building only if those ordinary actions feel satisfying.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The zoning commission authorizes a balcony for every thought that did not need an entire skyscraper.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1291340/>

P083 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Dorfromantik

The Train Has Been Sent to the Department of Pleasant Bends

Edition considered: PC release; Creative mode is a separate assessment target

The first landscape tile contained a railway, so I declared the nation connected. 'Connected to what?' Tank asked. I laid down another tile with a forest. 'Nature.' He waited while I rotated the piece three times. 'The train appears to terminate in a tree.' I explained that this was a premium woodland arrival experience.

Shawna wanted to know whether we were building for a score or building because the little countryside looked good. I said those were inseparable elements of my development philosophy. She opened the mode menu and separated them in five seconds. Rosa put a biscuit beside the keyboard and requested a river with a place to imagine sitting. That was an achievable public demand. I stopped trying to make the railway impress a committee and began making the water bend around a village. Nobody thanked my previous railway policy, which was probably fair.

The actual attraction

Dorfromantik assembles a landscape from hexagonal tiles. Fields, settlements, forests and waterways make the next placement visually meaningful. The attraction is a small repeated action that grows into a countryside you can inspect and enjoy. It can suit someone who likes arranging a world more than managing its inhabitants.

The catch worth knowing

Choose the mode deliberately. Standard play involves tile supply, objectives and scoring; Creative mode is a separate assessment target, not a label for every session. Rotation, camera movement, small connection details and interpreting the interface still need checking. The sources support the game's building premise, not a universal promise that every control is hold-free.

An opening invitation

Open Creative mode with setup help if needed. Place one village tile, one field and one stretch of water, then examine the connections without chasing a score.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The railway may end in a forest, provided nobody calls it a national emergency.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1455840/>

P084 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Hidden Folks

A Witness Has Been Misfiled Under Everybody

Edition considered: PC release

I took one look at the crowded drawing and announced that I had located the suspect. 'Which suspect?' Shawna asked. 'The one behaving suspiciously.' Tank leaned closer. 'That's a bush.' I adjusted my glasses, which were not prescription and therefore had no professional obligation to help. 'An unusually informed bush.'

The scene contained little people, little objects and enough tiny activity to make my official theory feel underfunded. Every click produced another reaction. Rosa found the person we were actually seeking while I was drafting a request to question the vegetation. I said her discovery was the natural result of my perimeter work. Mercedes asked why my report contained the phrase 'possible criminal shrub.' I turned the page over. On the back was a sketch of the shrub wearing a hat. Tank said that did improve the resemblance.

The actual attraction

Hidden Folks turns searching into a lively illustrated scene. The hand-drawn crowds and interactive details reward looking closely, while target clues give a concrete reason to investigate. A companion can help spot possibilities without taking over a character or handling an inventory. The pleasure is noticing, testing and finally recognizing the right little detail.

The catch worth knowing

A static-looking scene can still demand visual scanning. Small targets, dense drawings, zooming and panning may be the main obstacles. Check whether navigation requires an uncomfortable drag on the selected device. The absence of an avatar does not itself establish every accessibility property, and this card does not certify the complete game as hold-free.

An opening invitation

Choose one target from an early scene. Read its clue, enlarge the view if useful and search together for that one person before opening a longer list.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The bush is released without charge, although its lawyer has requested a larger font.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435400/>

P085 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

A Short Hike

The Summit Has Declined Our Scheduling Invitation

Edition considered: PC release

I issued an itinerary for the mountain. It included a departure ceremony, three scenic pauses and a photograph in which everyone would appear spontaneously delighted by my leadership. Tank read the title. 'It says short hike.' 'That describes the mountain's contribution. Mine is comprehensive.'

A little path curved toward the shoreline, and Rosa followed it with her eyes instead of consulting my document. There was someone to talk to down there. I reminded her of the summit reception. Shawna asked who had confirmed attendance. I said the summit had an excellent reputation for remaining in place. Mercedes folded the itinerary into a shape that looked uncomfortably like a paper airplane. For a moment I considered confiscating it. Then the game offered a lovely view and an ordinary conversation, and I realized the mountain had not actually employed me. I sat down and let the path be a path.

The actual attraction

A Short Hike offers a compact island, a climb toward a destination and small encounters along the way. Its warmth comes from the people you meet and the freedom to let one nearby curiosity become the next activity. It is a smaller, more legible exploration proposition than a vast map filled with competing objectives.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes an unhurried journey, but the controls still ask for movement. Climbing and gliding use held input; gliding also requires steering. Those demands matter even when the mood is gentle. Side activities need their own check, and there is no native simultaneous local co-op in the assessed version.

An opening invitation

Walk along an early shoreline or marked trail and speak to one character. Introduce climbing and gliding only after ordinary movement has become comfortable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Summit attendance is optional; the shoreline has already accepted your reservation for absolutely nothing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer Steam description supports unhurried summit exploration; named hands-on review supports held climb/glide and steering. No blanket statement about every optional activity.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1055540/>

Source 2: <https://saveorquit.com/2021/01/16/review-a-short-hike/>

P086 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Yonder: The Cloud Catcher Chronicles

I Have Acquired Eight Biomes and No Sensible Shoes

Edition considered: PC release

I saw the island and immediately requested an empire-sized suitcase. 'We're going for a walk,' Shawna said. 'Across eight environments,' I replied. 'That is at least eight kinds of authority.' Tank asked whether authority was waterproof. I told him to pack a second pair of socks and respect the itinerary.

The world offered things to gather, places to visit and people who might want help. I tried to accept all of it at once. Within a minute my fictional administration had a forestry department, a tailoring unit and a committee studying whether every rock needed a name. Rosa removed seven folders from the desk. 'Pick one thing you actually want to do.' That sounded alarmingly efficient. Mercedes suggested that freedom could include leaving an activity alone. I wrote that down under emergency constitutional amendments. Then I chose a path because I liked the trees at its end.

The actual attraction

Yonder provides an open island with several environments and a broad set of activities, including gathering, farming, crafting and helping residents. Its appeal is the possibility of choosing a direction and making a small life within a landscape. The central restoration premise gives exploration a purpose without making every interest identical.

The catch worth knowing

This is a conditional open-world candidate. Third-person navigation brings movement and camera control, while professions, inventory, trading and quests can accumulate into a substantial interface. The developer's own-pace language does not erase the changing day, seasons or the work of remembering goals. It is single-player, even when a friend helps.

An opening invitation

Have a helper find an uncomplicated nearby route. Walk to one visible destination and try one gathering action before enrolling in every available profession.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The Ministry permits one unnamed rock; subsequent rocks may also decline registration without penalty.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/580200/>

P087 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Eastshade

The Minister of Art Has Painted the Wrong Mountain

Edition considered: PC release

I announced that I would capture the landscape's essential dignity. Tank asked whether that meant painting it. 'Among other executive functions.' I positioned the imaginary easel with the seriousness of a man opening an embassy. Unfortunately, the view I had selected was largely a wall.

Shawna suggested turning around. I explained that the wall represented the limits society places on vision. She turned the view. There was an entire island behind us, which made my interpretation harder to defend. Rosa noticed someone nearby who looked worth talking to. Mercedes said I could meet a person before making them stand beside my masterpiece. I wanted to object on artistic grounds, but the person had a story and the story was more interesting than my explanation of beige. The wall remained available for future exhibitions. Tank named it 'Public Money, Private Fence' and refused to withdraw the title.

The actual attraction

Eastshade makes a traveling painter the center of an island adventure. Meeting residents, discovering places and making paintings give curiosity a tangible role in the world. The atmosphere and local stories may appeal to someone seeking a grown-up journey that does not revolve around fighting.

The catch worth knowing

The no-combat design is not the same as simple physical input. First-person walking and looking typically use separate controls, and crafting, canvases and quests add interface work. The developer's design essay is older than release; the final storefront supports the painting and exploration premise, not a guarantee about every environmental rule or input.

An opening invitation

Try a short village walk and one conversation. Test turning the view while standing still before deciding whether to learn the painting and crafting systems.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Your easel receives diplomatic immunity, but the committee cannot make a difficult camera disappear by calling it culture.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports painter, relationships and exploration. Developer no-combat essay is pre-release (2015); it does not establish all final environmental or input rules.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/715560/>

Source 2: <https://eastshade.com/without-combat/>

P088 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Alba: A Wildlife Adventure

The Bird Has Refused to Sign Its Release

Edition considered: PC release

I founded a wildlife publicity office with a budget of two sandwiches and a camera. My first subject was a bird that had never heard of me and showed no desire to correct the omission. I asked it to turn slightly toward the light. It continued being a bird. Tank called this a strong negotiating position.

Shawna suggested we learn what we were looking at before designing the campaign. I had already named the operation Feathers of Destiny, so there was considerable paperwork to lose. Rosa pointed toward the island and the people living there. 'Maybe the place matters more than your poster.' Mercedes took the gold stamp away before I could certify a tree as an honorary sponsor. I looked again. The small animal was doing something interesting without any help from my office. For once, that seemed like an excellent use of the budget.

The actual attraction

Alba places wildlife discovery and care for an island at the center of a bright adventure. Looking for animals and recording what you find supplies a recognizable activity within a place that also has residents and a conservation story. It offers a possible bridge from noticing details to moving around a small world.

The catch worth knowing

The gentle premise should not be mistaken for a verified control profile. Check movement, camera adjustment, aiming the camera, target recognition and the way objectives accumulate. Any required timing or unusual interaction remains an open question until the exact version is inspected. The child protagonist does not by itself determine whether the subject will interest an adult.

An opening invitation

In an early accessible area, find one animal and try one photograph. Assess the ordinary move-look-photograph sequence before making a collecting plan.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for field research in which the bird keeps creative control and the publicity director learns to shut up.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1337010/>

P089 / PROMISING / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

TOEM

A Photograph Has Been Submitted in Place of a Mission Statement

Edition considered: PC release

I arrived with a lens-cleaning cloth, a ceremonial lanyard and a speech about the burden of seeing what others overlook. Tank asked whether I had removed the lens cap. I told him the darkness was an artistic opening statement. Shawna removed it and improved the exhibition immediately. The little world was full of people with things to show us. Instead of issuing an agenda, Rosa suggested listening to one request. I liked this less formal system, particularly because it meant nobody could discover that my official agenda was an old restaurant menu. Mercedes looked at a photograph I had taken and said, 'That one has a point.' I assumed she meant the image's emotional center. She meant I had finally aimed at the thing someone had asked us to find. Either way, it was encouraging. I retired the lanyard to a drawer marked Developing Expertise.

The actual attraction

TOEM uses photography to turn exploration into observation. Its illustrated world and small requests give a reason to look at a place carefully, then try a picture that connects what you saw with what someone needs. The changing camera view can make an ordinary corner feel like a little discovery.

The catch worth knowing

Movement and photography are distinct tasks, so check both rather than assuming a small-looking world has one-button play. Camera aiming, view changes, object size and remembering several requests may matter. The store's photographic-adventure premise does not establish that every task is untimed or that every input avoids holding.

An opening invitation

Take one request, locate its subject and make one photograph. Keep the current request visible or write a short reminder if that makes the next action clearer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The committee accepts photographic evidence and politely returns the twelve-page statement about your lanyard.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam app 1307580, TOEM: A Photo Adventure (2021). The automated TOEM 2 match was rejected. Source supports photography, conversations and puzzles, not universal no-timing or no-hold claims.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1307580/>

P090 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Lil Gator Game

My Cardboard Sword Has Been Reclassified as Office Equipment

Edition considered: PC release

I expected an adventure to require a procurement meeting. The little alligator appeared prepared to proceed with imagination and whatever was lying around. This threatened an entire division of my organization. I held up a cardboard sword and asked who had authorized its edges. Tank said the recycling bin.

Shawna pointed out that playing together did not require a royal charter. I said I knew that, then quietly slid my proposed charter under the snack bowl. Rosa liked the idea of making a game out of a place and inviting people into it. Mercedes said the most interesting part was persuading someone to join without turning fun into an obligation. That landed close enough to my desk to leave a mark. I shortened my recruitment speech from four pages to one sentence. Tank tested the sword against a cushion and declared the equipment budget a triumph.

The actual attraction

Lil Gator Game builds an island adventure around play, make-believe and meeting people who can become part of it. Exploration and small activities offer a lighthearted sense of progress. The emotional question of sharing an enthusiasm may resonate even when the visual style is deliberately playful.

The catch worth knowing

This remains a movement-based adventure. Check camera control, climbing, gliding, jumping and the frequency of held or combined inputs in the chosen version. A playful tone does not make those demands disappear. Someone who wants a darker mystery or dense adult dialogue may simply prefer another shelf, which is a matter of taste.

An opening invitation

Explore one nearby patch of the opening area and talk to a character. Try the basic movement and camera separately before committing to traversal challenges.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The cardboard sword is approved for imaginary heroism; the charter is reassigned to protecting the table from biscuit crumbs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1586800/>

The Camera Comfort Summit

I convened the summit after discovering that I had used the word relaxing three times without mentioning how anyone would move. Shawna arrived with the offending pages. Tank arrived with a mug. Rosa arrived with the ordinary expectation that a meeting should eventually improve something.

'Imagine a lovely village,' I began. 'I can,' Mercedes said. 'Now tell me what my hands are doing.' I described the village again, using better adjectives. She waited. It was the sort of silence that turns an expensive sentence into a small unpaid debt.

Shawna put a controller on the table and separated the actions. Moving was one thing. Turning the view was another. Aiming at an object could be a third. Sometimes the game combined them; sometimes stopping before turning helped; sometimes the whole arrangement remained unwelcome. The summit had been called to record that distinction, not to argue a person out of noticing it.

I proposed a badge reading APPROVED BY THE COUNCIL OF BEAUTIFUL HORIZONS. Rosa suggested CAMERA CHECK FIRST. Mine had grandeur. Hers had information. We used hers.

Tank asked whether the same principle applied to holding buttons. It did. A peaceful forest could ask for a long climb. A friendly photograph game could ask for awkward panning. No amount of soft music could click the mouse for you. We wrote the actual action beside the actual attraction.

By the end, the summit had produced a short checklist and no compulsory exercise. Mercedes called it a success. I called it the first session of a continuing international initiative. Shawna crossed out continuing. Tank ate the remaining biscuit before I could appoint it ambassador.

P091 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Smushi Come Home

A Mushroom Has Greater Travel Expenses Than the Minister

Edition considered: PC release

I was prepared to help a lost traveler. I was less prepared to discover that the traveler was a mushroom and therefore could not carry the suitcase I had ordered. Tank said my suitcase was larger than the protagonist. 'That is why we planned ahead.' Shawna asked whether the mushroom had requested luggage. I admitted the consultation stage had been brief.

The forest made every small distance look like an expedition. A ledge became a decision. A creature became someone worth asking. Rosa liked that the journey had a simple emotional direction: getting home. I tried to add a diplomatic reception along the way and was outvoted by everybody, including the mushroom, whose expression did not change. Mercedes suggested I put the suitcase down and pay attention to the tools actually available. It was excellent advice, although accepting it meant leaving a perfectly respectable imaginary luggage tag unused.

The actual attraction

Smushi Come Home follows a tiny mushroom trying to return home through a forest. New tools, helpful creatures and light puzzles give the trip a clear purpose. The small scale can make familiar natural objects feel surprising, and the mycology journal supplies another kind of curiosity beyond simply reaching the next place.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description explicitly includes running, gliding, climbing, swimming and light platforming. Those are real control demands despite the cozy presentation. Assess held movement, steering and transitions between abilities. An own-pace exploration claim does not demonstrate that every jump or required action will be comfortable.

An opening invitation

Try a small stretch of walking and one conversation. Then inspect the earliest necessary traversal action before deciding whether the homeward journey feels inviting.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The mushroom's travel allowance is approved; the minister's suitcase has been returned to the Department of Making Things Bigger.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1740300/>

P092 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Haven Park

The Campsite Has Requested Fewer Speeches and One Chair

Edition considered: PC release

I surveyed the campground and saw tremendous potential for a ribbon-cutting ceremony. Rosa saw a place where someone might want to sit. These were not mutually exclusive visions until I tried to reserve the only chair for the ribbon. 'The ribbon doesn't get tired,' she said. I argued that it carried symbolic weight. Tank offered to cut it before the argument developed a budget.

A little park is a dangerous thing to show a man who likes departments. I had already imagined a Directorate of Pleasant Afternoons. Shawna asked what the campers actually wanted. That question reduced my organization from nine divisions to a handful of useful tasks. Mercedes suggested we listen to the place's history instead of naming every bench after me. I gave one bench a discreet working title, which she crossed out. Then we found something to improve that somebody other than me could enjoy.

The actual attraction

Haven Park combines a small explorable park with campsite improvements and conversations. Taking care of a place gives wandering a practical rhythm: find something, learn what a visitor needs and make the park more welcoming. Its family connection and local stories provide a modest narrative thread around that activity.

The catch worth knowing

The developer presents a peaceful open world, but building and gathering still introduce resources, quests and navigation. Check camera behavior, interaction distance, held movement and how many unfinished tasks the interface expects you to track. The advertised mood should not stand in for an edition-specific input assessment.

An opening invitation

Explore one nearby campsite and identify a single useful improvement. Complete that little loop before accepting a broad program of park redevelopment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Permission is granted to improve the park without producing a commemorative plaque for the person who moved the chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1549550/>

P093 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Mail Time

The Postal Service Has Hired a Hat

Edition considered: PC release

My first postal reform concerned headwear. The mushroom hat was memorable, approachable and visible from a respectable distance. I announced that the entire department would adopt it. Tank asked whether the hat could sort envelopes. 'It establishes trust.' 'So does delivering the envelope.'

The forest contained recipients with their own business, which was inconvenient for a man hoping every letter would congratulate him. Shawna read the address while I practiced my arrival. Rosa reminded me that the best delivery usually ends when the intended person receives the thing. I had prepared a substantially longer version involving a small trumpet. Mercedes confiscated the trumpet on behalf of everybody's afternoon. Once that was settled, the simple task became appealing: travel somewhere, meet someone, give them what they were waiting for. I kept the hat policy. Even a reformed institution deserves one good piece of nonsense.

The actual attraction

Mail Time turns deliveries into a forest adventure with distinct characters and places. Letters provide a clear reason to visit someone, while the world makes the route part of the attraction. It is a potential option for enjoying small social encounters without needing a dense mystery or a complicated economic simulation.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly states no time limits or fall damage, which supports the pace side of this candidate. It also explicitly includes running, jumping and gliding. These physical demands must be assessed separately. Check camera movement, held glide input and remembering delivery destinations; do not assume the listed accessibility options solve every concern.

An opening invitation

Follow one early delivery from address to recipient. Test the first necessary jump or glide at a comfortable moment before planning a full mail route.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The hat is approved as ceremonial equipment; the trumpet has been permanently reassigned to a different forest.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1607240/>

P094 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Lake

My Executive Vehicle Contains Other People's Mail

Edition considered: PC base game

I was delighted to receive a vehicle until Shawna explained that its contents had destinations unrelated to me. 'You're delivering the mail.' 'Then the town will associate my arrival with good news.' Tank held up an imaginary bill. 'And this.' I decided public service was more complicated than the campaign photographs suggested.

The lake looked calm. The road offered time to notice a place. People had histories and opinions that could not be resolved with my gold stamp, although I briefly considered trying. Rosa asked whom I wanted to visit after work. It was a much better question than how many houses I could process. Mercedes suggested I choose a conversation without treating it like a networking event. I took that personally for half a second, then recognized the accuracy. The truck remained useful. It was my speech about the truck that needed unloading.

The actual attraction

Lake follows Meredith during a return to her hometown and a temporary job delivering mail. Adult relationships, ordinary decisions and the question of what kind of life to choose are the main attractions. The setting offers a slower social story rather than a grand fantasy quest.

The catch worth knowing

Driving and walking are real activities, not just scenery between dialogue screens. The developer mentions an autopilot option for the mail truck, which is worth checking, but it does not establish that all navigation becomes automatic. Verify camera control, interaction and the extent of that feature in the exact release before relying on it.

An opening invitation

Try one nearby delivery and conversation. Examine the driving assistance option, then decide whether the route itself adds pleasure or merely gets between the conversations.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The department authorizes a life decision larger than a postage stamp and forbids the minister from branding the entire lake.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1118240/>

P095 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

SEASON: A letter to the future

The Archive Has Requested One Less Picture of Me

Edition considered: PC release

I understood the assignment immediately: preserve what matters before the world changes. Naturally, I began with a portrait of myself near a meaningful-looking wall. Shawna asked what the wall meant. I said history would decide. Tank suggested history might prefer a picture of the actual village.

The journal had room for sounds, images and encounters. That made it less like an official inventory and more like a person's attention made visible. Rosa recorded something small that I would have walked past. Mercedes asked a question of someone we met and allowed the answer to take its own shape. I found this reckless absence of branding strangely moving. My portrait remained available, but it no longer seemed like the obvious cover. I put it near the back, under a caption admitting that the photographer had been present and was trying, with mixed success, to notice.

The actual attraction

SEASON centers a bicycle journey, a customizable journal and the effort to preserve memories of a changing world. Photography, recordings and conversations make observation the substance of the story. It offers a more reflective reason to explore: choosing what deserves attention and how to remember it.

The catch worth knowing

A reflective premise does not establish an easy physical route. Cycling, walking, camera use and arranging journal material are different interactions to check. The story's impending change may also feel emotionally urgent even without a verified real-time deadline. Record the exact controls and pause behavior rather than inferring them from the mood.

An opening invitation

In the first available quiet area, collect one image or sound and place it in the journal. Decide whether the recording and arranging process itself is enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Your archive may contain a leaf, a conversation and no photograph whatsoever of the person who invented the archive.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/695330/>

P096 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Sable

The Ministry Has Lost Its Map and Found a Better Question

Edition considered: PC release

I saw the desert and ordered a signpost. Tank asked where it should point. 'Toward significance.' He looked across the dunes. 'That's going to need a second sign.' I was prepared to commission a whole system until Shawna asked whether discovering the route was part of the point.

Sable's journey had masks, ruins and people carrying their own ways of belonging. I tried to choose an identity before leaving the desk. Mercedes said that was a bold shortcut through the entire experience. Rosa wanted to visit one place because it looked interesting, without promising to become the kind of person associated with it. This sounded suspiciously like freedom. I put away the sign specifications. Then I noticed the hoverbike and immediately began drafting a vehicle title. Tank gently turned the paper over and wrote, 'Try riding it first.' It was the best policy document we produced all morning.

The actual attraction

Sable offers a rite of passage across a striking desert landscape. Exploring ruins, meeting nomads and collecting possibilities for an identity give its open world a personal theme. Its appeal lies in choosing a path and considering where the traveler belongs, rather than following a crowded list of victories.

The catch worth knowing

The developer's description includes a hoverbike, climbing, jumping and gliding. Navigation and held movement therefore deserve a practical trial. The distinctive art may be beautiful without automatically making landmarks or depth easy to read. Menus, route-finding and puzzle difficulty should be checked before presenting it as a simple wandering game.

An opening invitation

Explore one nearby stretch on foot, then test the first vehicle or climbing interaction separately. Follow one visible curiosity instead of committing to a complete map.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The identity committee adjourns until you have had the discourtesy to form an opinion of your own.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/757310/>

P097 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

ABZU

The Ocean Has Rejected My Request for a Reception Desk

Edition considered: PC release

I entered the water with the confidence of a man who had never attempted to run an office underwater. Within seconds, my imaginary papers had become an expensive soup. Tank asked whether the fish needed to complete a visitor form. I said we were modernizing toward verbal admission. The fish did not answer.

There were colors everywhere, movements within movements, and no obvious place to hang a portrait of the director. Rosa followed a school of fish with genuine interest. Shawna tested the controls instead of accepting my claim that floating was basically sitting with ambition. Mercedes said the view was enough to justify being quiet for a moment. I managed nearly the whole moment. Then a much larger shape passed nearby, and all my prepared remarks became irrelevant. The ocean, I discovered, had been operating successfully without a reception desk for an embarrassingly long time.

The actual attraction

ABZU makes underwater movement and marine life the center of a largely visual journey. Swimming among schools of creatures and discovering changing seascapes can be absorbing without a dialogue-heavy plot. Its attraction is the feeling of entering a place that moves around you.

The catch worth knowing

Swimming in three dimensions can require substantial steering and camera coordination. The official description also warns of dangers in the depths, so a peaceful visual style is not proof of uniformly pressure-free play. Check whether turning, ascending, descending and stopping are comfortable before committing to the wider journey.

An opening invitation

Use the first suitable open-water area to practice a short forward swim and a gentle turn. Let a companion observe the controls rather than immediately taking over.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The fish have unanimously approved your presence and unanimously declined to become a committee.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/384190/>

P098 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Journey

The Stranger Has Arrived Without a Business Card

Edition considered: PC release

A traveler appeared, and I prepared to ask which department had sent them. They supplied no credentials. No résumé. Not even a tasteful embossed card. Tank said perhaps we could simply travel in the same direction. I found this dangerously unstructured, although it did eliminate the need for a printer.

The ruins stretched ahead. Movement and music did more explaining than my orientation packet ever had. Rosa liked the possibility of company that did not arrive with an obligation to perform. Mercedes pointed out that I was giving an unusually long speech about an unusually quiet experience. Shawna lowered my imaginary microphone. For once I followed someone without turning it into a leadership exercise. We crossed a little distance together, and I did not need to know their job title. Later I wrote 'colleague' in the visitor book, then crossed it out and wrote 'person.'

The actual attraction

Journey builds meaning through landscape, movement, music and the possibility of encountering another traveler. Its sparse presentation leaves room for the player to interpret the trip. This may appeal when the desired story is a feeling of passage or companionship rather than detailed dialogue and inventory puzzles.

The catch worth knowing

The experience still involves steering, gliding and moving through a three-dimensional environment. The possibility of another traveler is online companionship, not a promise of local couch co-op or a reliably present helper. Check camera comfort and later pressure before treating its quiet opening as representative of every scene.

An opening invitation

Cross one early area and notice whether movement and the visual direction feel natural. Decide whether the atmosphere is engaging before worrying about reaching the destination.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The stranger may accompany you without submitting a biography, a loyalty statement or a photograph suitable for the newsletter.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/638230/>

P099 / DETOUR / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: no

The Pathless

The Eagle Has Been Promoted Above Me

Edition considered: PC release

I arrived intending to direct an expedition and immediately discovered that the eagle was better equipped for the job. It could see farther, travel faster and had never once ordered a binder that blocked a doorway. Tank asked whether I would accept an advisory position. 'Senior advisory,' I said, because dignity should not be abandoned casually.

The hunter moved with a confidence my office could not manufacture. Shawna watched the archery and asked the only useful question: would those actions be enjoyable to perform? I began describing the landscape. She waited. Rosa said admiring a game and wanting to operate it were two separate pleasures. Mercedes offered to put that sentence on the wall, replacing my certificate of exceptional relevance. I agreed, reluctantly. The eagle circled overhead with the expression of someone who had already approved the motion. Some leadership transitions happen without a meeting.

The actual attraction

The Pathless combines a hunter, an eagle companion and a large mythic landscape. Movement and archery are part of its identity, alongside exploration of ruins and the story of a curse. It belongs here as a visually appealing action detour for someone specifically curious about that kind of movement.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description explicitly includes high-speed archery, acrobatics and boss battles. This is not an ordinary no-rush recommendation. The developer's forgiving treatment of permanent damage or death does not remove required reactions. Camera, aiming and combined inputs are central checks, and a strict no-reaction preference should send the reader elsewhere.

An opening invitation

Watch a short official gameplay sequence together, then test basic traversal only if that motion looks appealing. There is no obligation to turn admiration into play.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The eagle is appointed acting director; you retain full authority to choose a game with fewer moving targets.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1492680/>

P100 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Feather

I Have Become a Bird and Still Requested a Window Seat

Edition considered: PC release

I took flight and immediately asked where the passenger lounge was. Tank reminded me that I was the aircraft. 'Then the service should improve.' Shawna suggested learning to turn before filing a complaint about the sky. It was a reasonable suggestion delivered with the confidence of someone who had seen me attempt parallel parking.

The island had places to circle and sounds to discover. Rosa liked the absence of enemies. Mercedes liked that no one appeared to be asking for a quarterly result. I tried to name a cloud after myself, but it moved away before the paperwork could be completed. That felt healthy for the constitution. After a few turns, I stopped treating the air as a route between meetings and began noticing the movement itself. Tank said I looked peaceful. I ruined it by requesting a commemorative feather, but only after a respectable interval.

The actual attraction

Feather offers bird flight around an island, with music and changing scenery as the reward. The developer explicitly describes a world without enemies, combat or threats and supports flying alone or with online players. Its appeal is movement for its own sake, rather than collecting equipment or following a character drama.

The catch worth knowing

The absence of threats does not make flight effortless. Continuous steering, orientation, camera motion and any held controls need a practical check. Online multiplayer is different from native local co-op. Someone who wants a substantial mystery or a clear sequence of tasks may find the open-ended flight less satisfying than the premise suggests.

An opening invitation

Try one broad circle above an open area. Check turning and camera comfort before exploring narrow passages or inviting another online flyer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Your window seat has been upgraded to the entire sky; catering remains a matter between you and the nearest tree.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam app 545040, Feather; rejected Feather Land match. Developer explicitly describes no enemies/combat/threats and online multiplayer. Flight comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/545040/>

The Minister Attempts to Monetize a View

The ocean page gave me an idea. We could issue scenic appreciation certificates. A bronze certificate for noticing a tree, silver for noticing a mountain and gold for making a thoughtful sound near water. Tank asked whether 'huh' qualified. I said it depended on the water.

Rosa stared at me long enough for the idea to begin retreating on its own. 'Why does enjoying something need proof?' I explained that the certificates were fictional. 'So is the fee,' she said, 'but you still made the reader think about paying it.' This was a fair criticism of a scheme that had existed for less than a minute.

We replaced the certificates with a return note: one place, one person, one unanswered question. The note was optional. It could help someone return later without reconstructing a whole evening. It could also remain blank. Mercedes insisted that blank was a legitimate state for a piece of paper, which threatened several of my departments.

Shawna added a line about stopping. A game could be left at a pleasant moment, before mastery, before completion, even before my dramatic explanation reached its conclusion. I felt that last example was unnecessarily personal.

Tank tested the system by closing the binder in the middle of my sentence. Nothing bad happened. The room remained intact. The snacks were still present. When he opened it again, the page had remembered where it was without requiring an apology.

I withdrew the certificate program. The printer expressed no opinion, but I like to think its silence contained relief.

P101 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

AER Memories of Old

The Pilgrimage Requires a Bird, Not a Boarding Pass

Edition considered: PC release

I had prepared a speech for the departure gate when the traveler turned into a bird. This was excellent for efficiency and terrible for my proposed luggage fee. Tank asked whether I intended to charge myself for carrying the binder. I said institutional materials traveled under a special exemption. Shawna called that a promising first reform target.

The islands hung in the sky with no apparent concern for the zoning code. Rosa wanted to know their stories. I wanted to know who had approved the support structures. Mercedes suggested that wonder could survive without an engineering complaint. We watched the traveler move between flight and walking, and my entire transport department suddenly looked like an elaborate way to postpone leaving. I closed the gate, which had only ever been two chairs anyway. Tank put one back at the table. Our first successful infrastructure project was having somewhere to sit.

The actual attraction

AER combines bird transformation, floating islands and the investigation of an old, broken world. Flying between places and entering temples gives its mystery a distinctive rhythm. The visual simplicity may make the landscape inviting, while the pilgrimage provides more direction than an entirely open-ended flight toy.

The catch worth knowing

Changing between flight and on-foot exploration means learning more than one movement pattern. Check steering, landing, camera behavior and the controls used inside temples. Puzzles and route-finding add another layer. The official atmospheric description does not establish an absence of all timing demands or a hold-free route through the complete game.

An opening invitation

Try one short flight and a controlled landing, then explore a small nearby space. Decide whether the transformation feels pleasurable before following the wider pilgrimage.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The boarding pass is unnecessary; the landing deserves considerably more attention than the minister's departure speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/331870/>

P102 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Proteus

The Island Will Not Tell Me What the Meeting Is About

Edition considered: PC release

I waited for the island to assign a task. It continued being an island. I approached a tree with the air of a man expecting a briefing. The tree contributed a sound. Tank said that was more concise than my usual briefings. I decided not to enter his comment into the minutes.

There was no obvious list to conquer, which left my stamp unemployed. Rosa walked toward something because it looked interesting. Mercedes listened. Shawna asked whether I could allow an experience to be worthwhile without collecting a certificate at the end. I said certainly, then checked whether there was a certificate. The colors shifted; the surroundings made music out of our presence. Gradually I stopped waiting for the place to explain my importance. It was a peculiar relief. Tank later asked what I had accomplished. I told him I had been somewhere. He nodded like that was a complete answer.

The actual attraction

Proteus is an exploratory island experience in which the surroundings respond musically to where you go. It has little conventional instruction, text or plot. The pleasure comes from observation and the changing relationship between sound, color and place, rather than solving a case or completing a set of chores.

The catch worth knowing

Its minimal goals can be either freeing or frustrating. First-person movement and camera control remain necessary even when there are few menus. The lack of hints is a documented design choice, so someone who wants a clear next action should treat that as a meaningful catch. There is no basis here for promising that an unstructured world will feel easy.

An opening invitation

Walk toward one visible landmark and listen to what changes. If the absence of a stated objective feels empty rather than inviting, choose a more directed game.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

No productivity report is required; the island has already filed its response in the form of a noise near a tree.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/219680/>

P103 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Dear Esther: Landmark Edition

The Letter Has Declined to Become a Checklist

Edition considered: PC Landmark Edition

I tried to summarize the island in five actionable bullet points. The first concerned wind. The second concerned a voice reading something that did not sound as though it wanted a committee response. By the third, Rosa quietly took the pen away. 'Maybe listen before assigning outcomes.' Tank looked at the empty landscape and asked where we were supposed to check in. I said the experience might be operating on an honor system. Shawna tested the walking controls and then let the narration continue. Mercedes said some stories arrive in fragments because that is how their subject feels, not because the writer has lost a page. I had been preparing a lost-page form, so I put it beneath my chair. We moved farther into the place. I did not suddenly understand everything. I did, however, begin to suspect that understanding and listening were not identical departments.

The actual attraction

Dear Esther: Landmark Edition presents a remote island through walking, spoken fragments and music. Its story turns around loss, memory and interpretation. This is a route for someone interested in literary atmosphere and adult emotional material, with relatively little conventional inventory or puzzle activity described by the developer.

The catch worth knowing

The physical task is still first-person navigation. Check turning, walking holds, audio clarity, subtitles and how narration behaves when you stop or revisit a place. The fragmented telling may demand attention even without complex controls. Its bleak tone is central, and the Landmark Edition should not inherit unverified technical details from another release.

An opening invitation

Walk to the first narration trigger and listen to one passage. Consider both the movement and the form of storytelling before treating the island as a longer commitment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The letter may remain a letter; no one is authorized to convert grief into a progress bar for the minister's convenience.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/520720/>

P104 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Everybody's Gone to the Rapture

The Village Meeting Has Achieved Perfect Attendance by Being Empty

Edition considered: PC release

I arrived in the village prepared to address its residents. The village had other plans. Nobody came out to greet the binder, which I initially interpreted as a failure of publicity. Tank pointed out the larger mystery. 'Everybody's gone.' 'Then our attendance percentage is technically difficult to calculate.'

Shawna ignored the arithmetic and followed a trace of conversation. Rosa noticed the abandoned ordinary things: the places where a life had been happening before it stopped. Mercedes said the absence mattered because the people had mattered. I had no useful joke ready for that, so I let the place speak. Later, when a memory suggested a disagreement, I resisted the urge to appoint a mediator. We were there to understand, not to rescue my meeting agenda. The gold stamp stayed in the bag, where for once it could do no damage to the evidence.

The actual attraction

Everybody's Gone to the Rapture explores the vanished community of an English village through traces of conversations and events. Its mystery is inseparable from relationships, resentments and ordinary lives. The attraction is piecing together what happened to people rather than mastering combat or a large equipment system.

The catch worth knowing

The open environment requires first-person movement, orientation and finding the next useful trace. Spoken scenes and nonlinear order may create memory demands. Check interaction with the light phenomena, text support and walking controls in the PC version. A contemplative story still can be emotionally unsettling, and the source does not certify every interaction as untimed.

An opening invitation

Explore one small village area and follow one conversation fragment. Note a single person or question worth returning to, rather than attempting to map the entire community.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The committee is dissolved until the village's actual inhabitants have had a chance to tell their side.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417880/>

P105 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

What Remains of Edith Finch

The Family Tree Has Filed an Architectural Complaint

Edition considered: PC release

I looked at the house and recognized a familiar problem: somebody had continued adding things after the sensible stopping point. Tank looked at my binder. Neither of us said anything for a moment. Then I announced that I respected ambitious structures, provided they did not expect me to carry them.

Each room suggested a person rather than merely another section of the floor plan. Rosa asked me to stop calling the house an asset. Shawna warned that the way we interacted might change as the stories changed. Mercedes said a family cannot be understood by arranging its members into a tidy chart. I had already drawn the chart, naturally, but its lines began to look inadequate. We stepped toward another story. I put the ruler away. The house did not become less strange, but its strangeness started to feel like somebody's attempt to keep a person from disappearing.

The actual attraction

What Remains of Edith Finch uses a remarkable family home to connect a series of short, varied stories. The attraction is the inventive relationship between each person's life and the way their story is presented. It offers rich emotional material without requiring the player to manage a conventional role-playing character sheet.

The catch worth knowing

Variation is also the principal control catch. The developer explicitly says the gameplay changes between family stories, so learning the opening does not establish a stable interaction pattern for the whole game. First-person navigation and later combinations need checking. Death is central throughout; this is a content preference to consider, not a surprise to conceal behind the attractive house.

An opening invitation

Explore an early room and assess the first change of interaction. Continue because that style of storytelling interests you, not because the opening seemed mechanically simple.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The architect is excused from making the family sensible; the player is excused from finishing a story whose emotional weather is unwelcome.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/501300/>

P106 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Gone Home

The Drawer Contains Evidence and None of My Approved Labels

Edition considered: PC release

I entered the house ready to investigate and immediately began opening things with the confidence of a man who had never had his own desk searched. Shawna asked how I would feel if someone found my emergency speech folder. 'They would recognize preparedness.' Tank said the folder labeled Spontaneous Remarks was particularly convincing.

The belongings made the house feel occupied even in the absence of its family. Rosa noticed how one ordinary object changed the meaning of another. Mercedes read a note without turning it into a courtroom accusation. I tried the same approach. It was slower than declaring everyone suspicious and substantially more useful. The place began to reveal a life rather than merely a puzzle. I put down the stamp marked EXHIBIT A. It had been hovering over a personal letter, and even I could see that this was a moment for less machinery.

The actual attraction

Gone Home invites the player to understand a family by exploring its house and examining the things left behind. The personal story grows through rooms, possessions and written material. The developer explicitly describes no combat and no conventional puzzles, making investigation itself the central activity.

The catch worth knowing

First-person camera control, walking and inspecting objects still require comfort with navigation. Reading and keeping track of rooms may be more demanding than the mechanical premise suggests. The stormy, empty-house atmosphere can feel suspenseful even though the developer rules out attacks. Check text size and object manipulation instead of assuming the story's pace settles every concern.

An opening invitation

Investigate one room and choose one object or note that changes your understanding of the family. Test returning it and moving to the next doorway.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The drawer may be opened; the minister's urge to subpoena everybody's feelings remains outside his jurisdiction.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/232430/>

P107 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Firewatch

My Only Colleague Is on the Radio and Has Heard Enough

Edition considered: PC release

I liked the lookout tower immediately. It offered height, visibility and the possibility of giving instructions to distant people who could not easily interrupt me. Then the radio spoke back. Tank said this was a promising corrective to my management style. I lowered the volume on my imaginary inauguration speech.

The wilderness looked inviting, but the conversation carried another kind of landscape. What someone said, what they avoided and why a person might choose isolation all seemed more important than my proposed smoke-reporting stationery. Rosa listened to the exchange. Shawna watched how the response options worked. Mercedes asked whether I could answer as a person instead of as chairman of the entire horizon. I selected a reply without adding a slogan. It was a small victory for human communication, although I later tried to have it recognized with a certificate.

The actual attraction

Firewatch combines an adult relationship over a handheld radio with exploration of the Wyoming wilderness. Its appeal is the interplay between place, conversation and a developing mystery. The characters have histories and imperfect motives, so the emotional complexity comes from people rather than elaborate combat systems.

The catch worth knowing

First-person movement, map use and terrain navigation are substantial checks. Dialogue response behavior also needs direct inspection: a conversation-driven game should not receive an unlimited-waiting claim without testing it. The developer describes suspense and adult themes. This is a conditional story candidate, especially if any feeling of urgency is unwelcome.

An opening invitation

Try the earliest ordinary radio exchange and a short walk. Check whether response choices allow the desired pace before investing in the relationship or mystery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The radio may disagree with you; no executive order can convert a complicated conversation into a weather report.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/383870/>

P108 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Stanley Parable: Ultra Deluxe

A Narrator Has Applied for My Job

Edition considered: PC Ultra Deluxe

The voice began telling me what I was doing, which I considered an unacceptable overlap with my own department. I looked for the narrator's appointment letter. There was none. Tank said perhaps authority could occasionally arrive without a gold stamp. I asked him not to encourage the ceiling.

A choice of doors became a negotiation over who got to describe the choice. Shawna found this deeply relevant to our catalogue. Rosa asked whether the voice would allow us to ignore it. Mercedes said we could test that proposition without holding a symposium. I went the other way and discovered that the game had anticipated the sort of person I was. This was flattering for approximately three seconds. After that it was simply funny. I tried to reclaim dignity by announcing a formal review of the narrator. The narrator continued speaking, which was the most realistic institutional response so far.

The actual attraction

The Stanley Parable: Ultra Deluxe is a comic exploration of choices, narration and the rules games pretend to enforce. An office becomes the starting point for branches, contradictions and jokes that respond to what the player does. Its appeal is especially strong if arguing with an overconfident narrator sounds like entertainment.

The catch worth knowing

It uses first-person movement and contains many different branches. A simple corridor is not evidence that every ending has the same input or emotional demands. The developer lists added accessibility features, including content warnings, but their presence does not certify a no-hold or no-timing route. Check camera comfort and preview the relevant settings.

An opening invitation

Reach the first meaningful choice and follow the route you actually find amusing. Test pausing and leaving without treating every possible ending as an assignment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Two narrators may occupy the building, but neither is allowed to overrule the person holding the controls.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1703340/>

P109 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Beginner's Guide

The Curator Has Mistaken an Interpretation for a Deed

Edition considered: PC release

I offered to explain the collection before anyone had seen it. This is a recurring weakness in men who own presentation folders. Shawna asked whether the objects might speak for themselves first. I said interpretation was a public service. Mercedes asked whether I had obtained permission to speak for the person who made them.

That question stayed in the room. Tank, who usually punctured an argument with a snack-related observation, became unusually quiet. Rosa suggested that helping someone understand a work and deciding what its creator must mean were different acts. I wrote the distinction down and resisted adding my name beneath it. We entered the next small space. I still had opinions, naturally. The difference was that I could now hear the moment when an opinion began dressing itself as somebody else's truth. Even my binder seemed less certain of its authority.

The actual attraction

The Beginner's Guide uses a sequence of game spaces and a narrator to tell a story about interpretation, creativity and a relationship to another person's work. It is a compact narrative experiment rather than a conventional quest or collection of systems. Its adult interest lies in the questions it raises about understanding and ownership.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description offers very little detailed control information. Do not turn its lack of traditional goals into a guarantee that every scene uses one simple input. First-person movement and changes between spaces should be checked directly. The story may also be emotionally uncomfortable rather than merely clever or relaxing.

An opening invitation

Experience the first short space and narration, then assess whether the combination feels compelling. Check movement and stopping behavior before following the entire sequence.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The curator may offer a reading, but the Department of Other People's Inner Lives has no vacancies for self-appointed directors.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/303210/>

P110 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Vanishing of Ethan Carter Redux

The Valley Has Rejected My Innocent Little Tourism Brochure

Edition considered: PC Redux edition

The scenery looked so good that I began composing a tourism slogan before learning why we were there. Rosa read the premise and quietly removed the phrase 'a cheerful escape for everyone.' Tank suggested I investigate first and advertise never. It was an efficient correction, although hard on the brochure budget.

The valley held traces of events that did not belong on a souvenir mug. Shawna reminded me to distinguish an atmospheric mystery from a mechanically gentle one. Mercedes said the beauty could be part of the unease rather than evidence against it. I looked again. A place can be lovely and still carry something terrible. My brochure had no box for that, so I folded it shut. We were following a disappearance now, not inspecting a holiday property. For once, the appropriate contribution from the Ministry of First Impressions was silence.

The actual attraction

The Vanishing of Ethan Carter follows an occult-minded investigator through a detailed valley and a dark family mystery. Observation and reconstructing events give the landscape narrative purpose. It may appeal to someone who wants grown-up detective atmosphere with supernatural unease rather than a large combat system.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes no combat, but that does not erase horror, violence or first-person navigation. Check scene-specific interaction, camera use and any unsettling sequences before promising a relaxed route. This card targets Redux; the inspected store treats it as content associated with the original product, so edition and installation details must be kept straight.

An opening invitation

Explore an early outdoor area and inspect one trace. Decide whether the visual atmosphere feels intriguing rather than oppressive before advancing into the darker investigation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The tourism board withdraws its slogan; the detective may proceed only if the valley's particular kind of unease is welcome.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Redux store entry and linked base-game store. Redux is described as associated content; base page supports the remaster relationship, mystery and no combat. Exact Redux input behavior remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/400430/>

Source 2: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/258520/>

The Day the Map Became a Tablecloth

I printed a map of the ministry's proposed travel routes and discovered that it was larger than the table. This was not a printing error, I explained. It represented the generosity of our scope. Tank said scope was hanging over the side and touching his shoe.

Shawna asked what decision the map helped someone make. I pointed to a branching route through clouds, machines, islands and philosophical robots. She asked what happened if someone only wanted a small place to explore. I traced three lines, lost the third beneath the snack bowl and admitted that the map had developed ambitions unrelated to its job.

Rosa turned it over. The blank side made a surprisingly good tablecloth. Mercedes wrote three options in the center: a room, a short walk, a larger world. Under each, Shawna added the control check that mattered. The result was less majestic and dramatically more usable.

I objected that forty games could not possibly fit into three options. Mercedes said they did not have to. The options were ways into the catalogue, not cages around it. A person could choose a page directly, change interests halfway through or decide the best destination was the kitchen.

Tank put the snack bowl back. This time it obscured no essential information. I considered naming the tablecloth after myself, then noticed that the ministry had finally achieved a rare kind of elegance: the complicated thing had become furniture for the simple thing.

We kept the reverse side available for anyone who wanted to admire the absurd map. It was funny. It was also optional. Those two facts improved each other.

P111 / DETOUR / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

INFRA

My Infrastructure Tour Has Become an Infrastructure Problem

Edition considered: PC complete game

I had expected a clipboard game. I own a clipboard, understand its authority and can point it toward a crack in a wall with considerable conviction. Tank said this was the first job description in the catalogue that genuinely matched my equipment. Then the environment began looking less like a routine inspection and more like a reason to leave.

Shawna read the actual description aloud, emphasizing the part about survival. Rosa asked why I had filed the game under Peaceful Men Looking at Concrete. I said the folder title had been provisional. Mercedes replaced it with Look Carefully Before Entering. The camera was still useful, but now the question was not merely what we noticed; it was whether the place would let us continue noticing. I lowered the clipboard. There are moments when an impressive form is less valuable than understanding which floor you are standing on.

The actual attraction

INFRA makes structural inspection into a detailed environmental puzzle adventure. Photographing damage, tracing routes and uncovering how a city's systems failed can appeal to someone fascinated by real places and hidden institutional stories. The mystery grows from infrastructure rather than fantasy combat equipment.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly describes hazards and a fight for survival despite the absence of guns. This is therefore an investigative detour, not an automatic calm-walking recommendation. First-person navigation, environmental puzzles, resource handling and dangerous situations need direct checks. A camera as the main tool does not mean the game behaves like a leisurely photo album.

An opening invitation

Inspect a short, ordinary early area and try documenting one defect. Assess movement and the first hazard warning before deciding whether this kind of investigation is enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The clipboard is approved; the building is not certified safe merely because the minister has written his name on it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251110/>

P112 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Obduction

The Relocation Office Has Sent My Neighborhood Into Space

Edition considered: PC release

I expected an alien world to arrive with at least a welcome packet. Instead, there were familiar pieces of Earth in an arrangement that suggested the moving company had experienced a philosophical crisis. Tank asked whether the address change applied to the whole planet. I said we would need a larger envelope.

Shawna wanted to inspect the place rather than guess the paperwork. Rosa noticed how an ordinary object became strange when everything around it changed. Mercedes asked whether we were trying to get home or simply understand where we had landed. Both sounded worthwhile. I began a map, then stopped when it became clear I was decorating my confusion instead of resolving it. We chose one machine and one question. The world remained enormous, but the next act became manageable. I have since tried applying this method to my desk with less spectacular results.

The actual attraction

Obduction places fragments of familiar life inside an alien setting and asks the player to investigate how its worlds work. Environmental puzzles and the desire to understand the place provide the story's momentum. Its appeal is the patient discovery of connections that initially seem unrelated.

The catch worth knowing

The game is visually and spatially elaborate. Walking, looking, operating devices and remembering how places connect can be substantial demands. This card proposes the ordinary screen version, not VR. The primary description establishes an exploration puzzle adventure with consequential choices, not a blanket absence of timing, holds or difficult navigation.

An opening invitation

Inspect one nearby structure and test a single interaction. Keep a brief note or image of the immediate question before exploring several routes at once.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The relocation office acknowledges your complaint and recommends learning what one lever does before suing the universe.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/306760/>

P113 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Myst

The Island Has Hidden Its User Manual Inside Another Island

Edition considered: 2021 PC remake; not the 1993 original

I have great respect for a book that can take you somewhere. I have less patience when it takes you somewhere without explaining which drawer contains the instructions. Tank said this was rich coming from the man who numbered his appendix before writing page one. I suggested we focus on the island's shortcomings.

The place was full of mechanisms that looked meaningful. I wanted to pull everything and announce a result. Shawna proposed observing first. Rosa found a detail that connected to something elsewhere. Mercedes asked us to keep the question smaller than the entire mystery. We made one note, then another, and the machinery gradually stopped looking like decorative hostility. I still wanted an orientation desk. But I could feel the particular satisfaction of understanding something the world had not simply told me. I stamped my notebook with a modest 'Possibly Relevant' and considered that progress.

The actual attraction

Myst combines a mysterious island, linked worlds and a story of family betrayal with environmental puzzles. The attraction is learning how a place works through observation and inference. This entry targets the 2021 remake, whose presentation and controls differ from the original screen-by-screen game.

The catch worth knowing

Do not assume the old game's navigation applies to the remake. Free movement, camera control, device manipulation and remembering clues all require checking. The developer documents an in-game photo feature that may help preserve clues, but VR comfort features should not be misrepresented as ordinary-screen settings. Puzzle difficulty can remain considerable regardless of input comfort.

An opening invitation

Explore one small area, photograph one useful-looking clue and test one mechanism. Use that concrete question to decide whether the island's style of reasoning is appealing.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The library may contain entire worlds; your first assignment is permitted to contain only one switch.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1255560/>

P114 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Riven

The Golden Dome Has More Authority Than My Golden Stamp

Edition considered: 2024 PC remake; not the 1997 original

I saw the enormous dome and felt professionally challenged. My stamp was gold-colored and portable, but it had never altered a skyline. Tank asked whether I was jealous of architecture. I said I was evaluating institutional symbolism. Shawna asked what the dome actually did. This was an irritatingly useful distinction.

The world seemed built around meanings we had not yet learned. Animals, numbers, machinery and the lives of its people might all matter. Rosa refused to treat the residents as background decoration for our puzzle-solving. Mercedes pointed out that a ruler's claim to authority was part of what we were examining, which made my opening remarks look worse. I put the stamp in my pocket. We watched, compared and tried to understand one small system. The dome remained impressive. It no longer seemed like something I needed to compete with.

The actual attraction

Riven asks the player to understand a richly connected world and the power shaping it. Observation of the environment supplies information that later becomes meaningful, making discovery feel like learning a place rather than completing disconnected puzzles. The 2024 remake expands and reimagines the original game's world.

The catch worth knowing

The remake explicitly uses free movement in a three-dimensional environment. That matters for camera comfort and must not be confused with the 1997 original's screen navigation. Its interlocking clues also make memory and note-taking significant. This is a deliberate reasoning stretch, not an easy label earned by the absence of a weapon.

An opening invitation

Observe one small area and record a single pattern or symbol without demanding an immediate solution. Test movement and view control before building a large notebook.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The dome may remain unexplained for a while; the reader is under no obligation to solve an entire civilization before tea.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1712350/>

P115 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Firmament

The Adjunct Has Been Promoted From Tool to Entire Department

Edition considered: PC non-VR mode proposed for assessment

I liked the idea of one device that could operate many machines. It suggested that my office might finally reduce its collection of cables, keys and objects whose purpose Tank described as 'you bought it because it looked official.' I asked whether the device could also sort correspondence. Shawna recommended learning its actual function first.

The great mechanisms around us looked as though somebody had once known exactly why they existed. Rosa wanted that story. Mercedes wanted to know whether the voice accompanying us could be trusted. I wanted to know whether the device came with a warranty, which put me third in the order of interesting questions. We tried one interaction and watched what changed. There was satisfaction in that small cause and effect. For a moment my entire administration had a sensible structure: observe, act, notice. Then I tried to give those three steps individual offices.

The actual attraction

Firmament offers a puzzle adventure through large mechanical environments, using a device called the Adjunct to interact with their systems. The mystery concerns the purpose of the realms and the companion who speaks to you. It may appeal to someone who enjoys machinery as part of a world's history.

The catch worth knowing

The imposing spaces require navigation and camera control, while device puzzles add interpretation and sequencing. Assess the ordinary-screen version separately from VR; the developer's VR comfort list does not automatically describe a desktop control solution. A recurring tool can simplify the vocabulary without making all its uses physically or mentally simple.

An opening invitation

Try the first device interaction and identify exactly what changed. Check moving, looking and targeting the mechanism before deciding whether the broader machine world is inviting.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

One useful tool is authorized; creating three new departments to hold it is pending an investigation by the cupboard.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/754890/>

P116 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Witness

The Panel Has Answered My Speech With a Line

Edition considered: PC release

I approached the first puzzle with a prepared theory about the island's philosophical purpose. Tank suggested trying the line. I explained that a serious investigator establishes context. Shawna drew the line and opened the way. This was a devastatingly brief rebuttal.

The island kept changing what the panels asked us to notice. A shape that meant one thing nearby might require a different kind of attention elsewhere. Rosa looked beyond the panel at the surroundings. Mercedes said learning a rule could be enjoyable without making it a measure of personal worth. I agreed, especially because my first theory had just failed. We tried another idea. The world did not need me to be impressive; it needed me to be curious enough to revise. I found that considerably more pleasant than defending a speech nobody had requested. Tank filed the speech under Unused Building Material.

The actual attraction

The Witness develops a large collection of line puzzles across an explorable island. Its particular pleasure is discovering what a visual rule means through examples, then recognizing a new twist. The environment becomes part of the thinking, so looking carefully can matter as much as manipulating the panel.

The catch worth knowing

First-person walking and camera control separate one puzzle from another. Drawing lines may involve precision or held input, and the reasoning becomes demanding. The presence of many apparently static panels does not prove the entire game has no timed or pressure-based content. Check the chosen route and ordinary panel interaction rather than offering a universal calm-game guarantee.

An opening invitation

Try a few introductory panels and stop when a new rule becomes interesting. Assess the drawing action itself and avoid treating the full island as a completion obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The panel accepts a workable line; it has no opinion about your speech, your title or your ability to sound profound.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/210970/>

P117 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

The Talos Principle

The Robot Has Questions That Do Not Fit the Form

Edition considered: PC original release; not Reawakened

I was prepared to answer a machine's question until it asked what made a person a person. My form offered three boxes: employee, visitor and other. Tank said this might be the moment to update the form. I suggested a subcommittee. Mercedes said the question deserved a conversation, which was cheaper and more alarming.

Among the ruins, machines and old traces of thought, the practical puzzles kept interrupting my attempt to issue a final definition. Shawna moved one device and changed what was possible. Rosa read something that complicated the story. I began to appreciate a world that let a question survive longer than my answer. The stamp marked RESOLVED stayed untouched. We solved one physical arrangement and left the philosophical matter open. It was a productive afternoon by every measure except the one I had invented to flatter myself.

The actual attraction

The Talos Principle combines environmental puzzles with questions about personhood, authority and the remains of human civilization. Devices, beams and other mechanisms create practical problems, while texts and choices add an adult philosophical story. It offers both a place to think and something specific to manipulate.

The catch worth knowing

This entry targets the original PC game, not Reawakened. Movement, camera control, object handling and spatial planning all require assessment. The developer explicitly includes drones and time-related puzzle mechanics, so a turn-like appearance in some rooms should not become a claim of universal waiting. Reading and remembering relationships can also be substantial.

An opening invitation

Attempt one introductory device puzzle and read one optional piece of story material. Decide whether both halves are enjoyable before pursuing a larger sequence of rooms.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The robot may retain its question; the minister is denied permission to stamp consciousness with a three-box form.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/257510/>

P118 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Talos Principle 2

Civilization Has Asked Whether We Really Need Another Committee

Edition considered: PC base game

A city of robots raised an uncomfortable possibility: intelligence might survive humanity and still have to attend meetings. I offered to consult on parliamentary procedure. Tank said that sounded like the worst inheritance we could leave. Shawna asked whether the city actually wanted more procedure. I had not reached that part of the consultation.

The larger questions concerned growth, responsibility and what a civilization should become. Rosa wanted to hear different people before choosing a position. Mercedes pointed out that uncertainty was a reason to listen, not an excuse for me to seize the chair. Meanwhile, the puzzles gave our hands something concrete to do. I liked that combination more than I expected. One could move a useful object, understand a mechanism and still admit that the future was complicated. My proposed Ministry of Correct Answers was quietly renamed the Room Where We Talk.

The actual attraction

The Talos Principle 2 develops its puzzle world into a more populated, character-driven discussion of civilization and its future. New devices and abilities accompany conversations and choices. It may appeal when philosophical ideas become more engaging through people who disagree about them.

The catch worth knowing

The large environments retain movement and camera demands, and new mechanics increase the amount to learn. The developer says the game can be finished without solving every puzzle, which may help set expectations, but that does not establish a low-input route. Check device manipulation, navigation and the difficulty of ordinary required puzzles.

An opening invitation

Try an introductory puzzle and one conversation. Use those two activities to judge the balance of physical interaction, reasoning and story, rather than aiming to master every optional challenge.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The city authorizes disagreement and declines to replace its future with the minister's favorite answer printed in gold.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/835960/>

P119 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Looker

The Island's Profound Meaning Appears to Be Laughing at Me

Edition considered: PC release

I recognized the air of significance immediately. An island, some puzzles, the possibility that a line might symbolize the human condition: excellent territory for a man who owns a ceremonial pen. I began speaking slowly so everyone could hear the importance. Tank asked whether that made the speech deeper or just longer.

Then the joke arrived. It did not merely interrupt my interpretation; it stole the chair from beneath it. Shawna laughed first. Rosa laughed because I tried to pretend I had anticipated the joke. Mercedes laughed when I described my failure as a successful demonstration of intellectual flexibility. I considered appointing an inquiry into the island's disrespectful behavior, but the next puzzle was interesting enough to distract me. This was probably the game winning. It was also, annoyingly, a pleasant way to lose an argument with my own self-importance.

The actual attraction

The Looker uses an island of puzzles to make jokes about a familiar style of serious puzzle adventure. The attraction is the combination of solving something and recognizing the absurdity around it. A little familiarity with the genre may make the satire richer, but curiosity about the joke can be enough to begin.

The catch worth knowing

Its compact comic premise does not certify easy controls or uniformly untimed play. First-person movement, drawing interactions and changing puzzle expectations should be checked directly. Humor also depends on taste; someone who wants an absorbing character story may prefer a different route. This is an editorial puzzle-comedy candidate, not a guarantee based on its brevity.

An opening invitation

Try the first small cluster of puzzles and see whether the jokes make the thinking more enjoyable. Stop freely if the parody feels like commentary on a party you did not attend.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The Department of Profound Explanations is temporarily closed while its director learns to recognize a punchline.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1985690/>

P120 / DETOUR / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: no

Outer Wilds

The Solar System Has Imposed a Deadline I Did Not Approve

Edition considered: PC base game; expansion assessed separately

I accepted the space-program appointment because the campfire looked welcoming and the equipment appeared to have been assembled by people with confidence comparable to mine. Tank asked whether that was reassuring. I chose not to interpret the question. Shawna read further and pointed to the time loop.

I attempted to negotiate. Surely a universe could accommodate a late start, a longer explanation and an unscheduled snack. The universe did not send a representative. Rosa said the mystery sounded wonderful, but its way of unfolding might be exactly the wrong kind of pressure for some evenings. Mercedes added that a beautiful game could remain beautiful on the shelf. That was a useful thought. I had been treating curiosity as an obligation to operate every interesting machine. We stayed by the imagined fire a moment longer, and I stopped trying to issue a calendar extension to the sun.

The actual attraction

Outer Wilds builds a remarkable mystery around a small, changing solar system. Exploration and accumulated understanding reveal how its worlds connect. It belongs in the panorama because curiosity, discovery and a sense of place are central to its appeal, even though its demands differ sharply from the opening route.

The catch worth knowing

The official description explicitly identifies a time loop, environments that change with time, hazards and oxygen management. Flight and first-person navigation add major control demands. A strict no-rush preference makes this a detour, not a match. Do not imply that a companion, pause setting or familiarity removes those systems without evidence.

An opening invitation

Look at the premise or share a brief, spoiler-light official gameplay preview. Consider direct play only if timed exploration and flight are appealing rather than merely tolerable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The committee cannot postpone a solar event, but it can authorize a different game without diminishing your curiosity by one inch.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/753640/>

A Window That Does Not Require an Appointment

By closing time, the ministry had sent nobody anywhere against their wishes. I regard this as an administrative triumph, although Rosa said it was merely the minimum standard for hosting someone in a room.

The cards had offered boxes, villages, forests, birds, machinery, houses, deserts and a solar system with a thoroughly uncooperative schedule. Some were promising because their documented interactions matched the desired pace. Others were conditional because the beauty came with a camera, a held movement or a puzzle structure worth checking. A few were detours, present because admiration and curiosity are broader than immediate suitability.

Shawna stacked the pages without ranking the people who might choose them. There was no ladder from respectable games to lesser ones. There were different pleasures and different demands. A small toy could hold an evening. A grand narrative could be exactly wrong. A game could be interesting today and unwelcome tomorrow without anybody needing to defend the change.

Mercedes opened the plain index and selected a page without consulting my route. I experienced a brief constitutional crisis. Then I remembered that this was precisely what the route had been built to permit. The institution was working best when it made itself unnecessary.

Tank took the crooked sign down and leaned it beside the window. The actual tree was still there. I asked whether we should include it in the next edition. Rosa said only if I could describe it without inventing a user account.

We left a clear chair, an ordinary note and three possible starting points. The binder remained large, but it no longer blocked the doorway. That was progress worth noticing.

I reached for the gold stamp one last time. Shawna looked up. I stamped a scrap of paper instead of a requirement: YOU MAY JUST LOOK. Tank said the tree had already communicated that more efficiently. I agreed, which startled everybody enough to end the meeting.

An index with no authority over you

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 4 OF SIX

The Department of Things That Fit Into Other Things

Puzzles, mechanisms, creative toys and retro desktop diversions

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 4. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P121	P122	P123	P124	P125	P126	P127	P128
2. Ready for conversation	P129	P130	P131	P132	P133	P134	P135	P136
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P137	P138	P139	P140	P141	P142	P143	P144
4. Here for the atmosphere	P145	P146	P147	P148	P149	P150	P151	P152
5. Open to a wildcard	P153	P154	P155	P156	P157	P158	P159	P160

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Cabinet Refuses the Binder

I bought the cabinet because its label said STORAGE SOLUTION. I considered this a binding professional promise. The cabinet arrived flat, which was the first sign that it expected me to participate in the solution. Tank carried the pieces inside and laid them next to the table. Shawna found the instructions. I found the decorative nameplate I had ordered separately and placed it where the finished cabinet would eventually have a chest.

'You bought a nameplate before checking the measurements,' Mercedes said. 'A institution needs an identity,' I replied. 'It also needs to fit through the doorway.' Rosa brought tea, examined the wall and quietly moved a vase beyond the area in which my confidence was most likely to cause damage. Tank held two boards together. The pieces looked deceptively simple. There were only a few shapes, a small bag of fittings, and an unlimited number of ways for me to explain that the problem was somebody else's.

The binder was supposed to go in the top compartment. It did not. I turned it sideways. The cabinet declined. I removed a page, which reduced the thickness by an amount Tank described as emotionally significant. Shawna asked why I had started assembling a storage system around an object without measuring the object. I told her the binder represented a living vision. She handed me a tape measure. 'Then let's see how long it lives.'

This was the moment the Department of Things That Fit Into Other Things discovered its subject. A puzzle can use a few familiar actions and still ask a wonderfully difficult question. A quiet board can offer deep reasoning. A richly rendered cabinet can conceal a control that needs a held drag. An attractive cartoon can contain a severe logic problem, while a serious-looking mechanism can become perfectly readable once somebody shows you what moves. Appearance and physical demand had been filing reports in the same folder. Shawna separated them.

I proposed three labels: BRILLIANT, EXTREMELY BRILLIANT, and AWAITING MY ARRIVAL. Mercedes crossed them out. Rosa wrote two actual questions on an index card: Do I want to know what happens? Does doing it feel good? Tank added a third: Is Aiden standing on the instructions? I stepped aside. Under my shoe, a diagram showed the shelf fitted the other way around. The cabinet had not been refusing the binder. It had been refusing my interpretation of a rectangle.

We agreed that the book could contain difficult reasoning without pretending every difficulty was the same. A game could wait patiently while a person considered a complicated relationship. Another could demand a quick movement despite its thoughtful story. A puzzle about changing rules might be exciting; a menu full of tiny icons might merely be tedious. The job was to say which activity was actually on offer, identify the catch, and leave the decision with the person who would play.

I tried to turn this agreement into a certification scheme. Shawna said a useful description would do. I tried to add a compulsory introductory lecture. Rosa said the tea would get cold. Mercedes selected a page directly, bypassing my entire route system, and the floor remained under us. Tank fitted the shelf correctly. The binder still protruded a little, but the cabinet now served a purpose. I attached the nameplate on the inside, where its authority would interfere with fewer people.

P121 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Baba Is You

The Law Has Been Pushed One Square to the Left

Edition considered: PC release

I wrote AIDEN IS IN CHARGE on a card and placed it at the head of the table. Shawna removed IN CHARGE and replaced it with FURNITURE. Tank immediately asked whether I was available to support the snack bowl. I objected that words could not simply alter the governing order. Then we opened Baba Is You, which made that argument difficult to sustain.

The little blocks did more than describe the world. Moving them changed what the world allowed. Rosa experimented with a sentence instead of defending the first arrangement. Mercedes asked whether my title was useful if it prevented us from reaching the interesting part. I considered this a suspiciously specific philosophical attack. Then a rule changed, the puzzle opened in a new direction and I forgot to be offended. The card at the head of the table now read AIDEN IS THINKING. For once, nobody challenged its accuracy.

The actual attraction

Baba Is You turns the rules of a puzzle into objects you can move. A short arrangement of words can transform what a wall, flag or character does. The appeal is the surprise of realizing that the rule you assumed was fixed is actually the thing to manipulate.

The catch worth knowing

The small number of movement actions should not be confused with easy reasoning. The developer describes a large collection of increasingly inventive rule interactions. Reading the words, predicting consequences and revising a plan can become demanding. Check the exact movement, undo and restart controls rather than assuming they are comfortable because the board is compact.

An opening invitation

Try an introductory level and deliberately move one rule word. Observe what changes before attempting a long solution or consulting an entire set of hints.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The legislature authorizes rewriting the wall, but nobody is required to solve grammar's revenge before enjoying a biscuit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/736260/>

P122 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Patrick's Parabox

The Storage Box Contains the Storage Department

Edition considered: PC release

I bought a box to hold the smaller boxes. This was a sensible beginning. Then I discovered a box that contained itself, and my inventory system suffered a spiritual injury. Tank asked whether we could put the binder inside it and recover the table. I said the implications required study. He said the table required space.

Shawna pushed one box and demonstrated that the strange rule could be understood through an ordinary action. Rosa followed the relationship between the outside and the inside. Mercedes suggested that I stop trying to name every layer before moving anything. I did, and the puzzle became less like an insult from mathematics and more like a toy with an unfamiliar but learnable grammar. The storage department remained confused about its office address. That was acceptable. We had reached a point where confusion was producing curiosity instead of another requisition form.

The actual attraction

Patrick's Parabox explores boxes that contain other boxes, including recursive arrangements. The repeated act of pushing gains new meaning as the space folds into itself. Its interest is in discovering how a small set of relationships can support surprisingly rich puzzles.

The catch worth knowing

The current Steam listing declares play without timed input and keyboard-only support. Spatial nesting can still require holding several relationships in mind even when the controls are limited. Verify key repeat, undo and any zoom behavior in the actual version. There is little conventional character story to carry the experience if the recursive logic itself does not appeal.

An opening invitation

Play the earliest introduction to entering and leaving a box. Explain one relationship aloud if useful, then try a move that tests that explanation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The Department of Storage may now fit inside its own cabinet, but its annual report must remain shorter than the cabinet.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1260520/>

P123 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Stephen's Sausage Roll

The Catering Subcommittee Has Become a Logic Problem

Edition considered: PC release

I assumed the sausage would be the easiest item on the agenda. This was before the fork, the narrow space and my rapidly declining confidence became involved. Tank watched me consider the arrangement. 'You could admit you need to think.' 'I am allowing the ingredients to reveal their strategy.'

Rosa asked whether the sausage had consented to becoming a strategic actor. Shawna suggested making one move and seeing what it taught us. Mercedes declined my proposal to call the situation a catering emergency. There was no emergency. There was a small, exact problem that did not care how confidently I described it. I found that annoying and then, unexpectedly, satisfying. A better idea arrived only after I stopped trying to make my first idea look correct. Tank said this was the most educational lunch we had never eaten. I asked him not to put that on the menu.

The actual attraction

Stephen's Sausage Roll is a compact three-dimensional puzzle game built around unusually exact spatial problems. Its appeal is the satisfaction of understanding a small arrangement deeply enough to make it work. It belongs on the reasoning shelf for someone who enjoys a stubborn little mechanism more than an expansive story.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected primary storefront supplies very little detailed control information, so this card does not certify timing, holds or the full interaction set. The title's cheerful food premise should not imply easy puzzles. Treat both input comfort and the amount of planning as questions for an early trial, with no expectation of quick completion.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first small puzzle and test a single movement. If the rules interest you, try one hypothesis; if they merely irritate, leave the plate unfinished.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The sausage is excused from being dinner and appointed a temporary consultant on the limits of executive confidence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-game Steam description is very brief ('A simple 3d puzzle game'); source supports identity and basic genre, not detailed control or difficulty certification. Scene is original fiction. Specific input and full-game timing remain to be checked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/353540/>

P124 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Snakebird

The Bird Has Exceeded the Approved Length for Birds

Edition considered: PC original game

I requested a bird of standard dimensions. The bird ate fruit and became longer, which I considered an unauthorized amendment to the seating plan. Tank suggested reserving two chairs. Then it grew again. My hospitality model was losing ground to produce.

Shawna asked what the extra length made possible. I had been so busy declaring it inconvenient that I had not considered usefulness. Rosa watched the shape cross a gap in a way a shorter creature could not. Mercedes said a constraint sometimes becomes a tool if you stop insisting it should be something else. I wrote that down, then discovered I had used the entire width of the page. Tank offered a longer sheet and waited for the irony to reach me. Eventually it did. We returned to the puzzle with a better question: not how to make the bird ordinary, but how to use the bird we had.

The actual attraction

Snakebird makes the length and shape of its fruit-eating creatures central to spatial puzzles. What looks like a small comic animal becomes a tool for crossing, supporting and arranging a route. The attraction is the way a simple change in body length changes the whole problem.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly calls the game deceptively challenging. A friendly drawing and a small board should not be sold as easy reasoning. Check directional input, switching between creatures and recovery from mistakes. The card does not establish universal no-timing behavior from genre alone; its strongest case is for a player who enjoys concentrated spatial experimentation.

An opening invitation

Try the earliest fruit-and-exit arrangement. Notice what the new length permits before attempting to plan several moves ahead.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The bird may exceed the furniture specification; the reader may decline the puzzle without submitting a shorter bird.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/357300/>

P125 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Snakebird Primer

The Orientation Bird Has Brought a Smaller Problem

Edition considered: PC separate prequel game

After our first encounter with an extremely long bird, I commissioned an orientation program. It contained a twenty-page introduction to the concept of fruit. Shawna removed nineteen pages. Tank ate the visual aid on the remaining one. We were forced to begin with the actual game.

The new island introduced its ideas with less apparent hostility to our afternoon. Rosa appreciated having room to learn a pattern before the pattern acquired relatives. Mercedes said a gentler introduction did not make the activity lesser; it made the invitation clearer. I agreed, then tried to call myself the architect of this educational philosophy. Shawna pointed to the developer's name. I withdrew the claim and concentrated on the creature in front of us. One small success led naturally to another question. This was a much better orientation than my speech about the historic significance of the banana.

The actual attraction

Snakebird Primer is a separate set of puzzles designed as a more approachable introduction to Snakebird's spatial ideas. The developer explicitly contrasts its easier island with the original game's serious challenges. It can be a useful place to discover whether moving and shaping these creatures is pleasurable before choosing the harder title.

The catch worth knowing

Easier is a comparison, not a personal guarantee. Directional movement, visual planning and keeping track of a changing shape still matter. Check undo, restart and control repetition in the exact release. The appeal remains puzzle logic rather than rich character dialogue, and a player need not graduate to the original game to justify enjoying this one.

An opening invitation

Complete or explore one introductory arrangement, focusing on how fruit changes the creature. Let curiosity about the next idea decide whether to continue.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The orientation certificate is optional, the banana is gone and nobody has been enrolled in mandatory advanced bird studies.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1014140/>

P126 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build

The Snowman Has Asked Me to Stop Calling Him a Deliverable

Edition considered: PC release

I set a target of three snowmen before lunch. Rosa asked why. 'A department requires outputs.' She looked at the small monster on the screen, then at me. 'Maybe the monster wants to make one nice snowman.' Tank supported this position, partly because lunch was already approaching without any help from my target.

Shawna studied how the snowballs occupied the space. Mercedes wondered what would happen if I stopped measuring the afternoon by completed figures. I tried making one deliberate move. The little arrangement became interesting in itself: size, position and the order in which things could happen. My production chart began to look ridiculous beside it. I turned the chart over and drew a face on the back. Tank said it was my most useful contribution so far. I gave the face a senior title anyway, because reform is a gradual process.

The actual attraction

A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build makes a small, affectionate premise into a spatial puzzle: a monster creating snowmen. The compact scenes invite attention to a few objects and how their positions relate. It can offer a satisfying repeated activity without needing a sprawling world or a dense inventory story.

The catch worth knowing

The current developer listing declares play without timed input and keyboard-only support. Check movement, undo and snowball manipulation on the chosen device; those declarations do not establish that every action avoids holding. The puzzles still require planning and trial, so the gentle presentation should not become a promise of effortless solutions. Narrative is limited to the charm of the activity.

An opening invitation

Try making one snowman and notice where your first plan changes. Learn the recovery control before treating a mistaken move as a reason to restart everything.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The snowman is recognized as a pleasant use of an afternoon and exempted from quarterly productivity reporting.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316610/>

P127 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Cosmic Express

The Railway Can Carry One Passenger and All of My Mistakes

Edition considered: PC release

I promised the aliens a world-class transit system. Then I discovered the passenger car could carry only one of them at a time. Tank asked whether my promise had included capacity planning. I said the service emphasized intimacy. Shawna began drawing a route that actually reached the houses.

Every turn in the track mattered. Rosa considered the passengers as destinations rather than decorative obstacles. Mercedes asked me to stop calling a loop around nowhere a scenic service. I erased the loop. Another route almost worked, which was somehow more interesting than my first confident answer. We watched the small consequences accumulate until the problem became clear. The station did not need a grand announcement. It needed a track that delivered somebody home. I canceled the ribbon ceremony and spent the saved time looking at the final corner. This improved transport more than any of my slogans.

The actual attraction

Cosmic Express asks you to lay railway routes through small space stations and deliver their residents. The one-passenger constraint makes the order of visits important. Its appeal is the clean relationship between a visible route and the consequences that follow from it.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes the puzzles as difficult and separately declares play without timed input, with keyboard-only and mouse-only options. Drawing tracks may still involve sustained pointer actions, so test the intended input method. Cute passengers do not reduce the planning burden: a compact station can hold a demanding puzzle. The declared input options do not certify hold-free interaction.

An opening invitation

Draw a route in an early station and watch one passenger's trip. Test editing or resetting the route before trying to optimize a complicated arrangement.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The railway is authorized to be small, provided it goes somewhere more useful than the minister's opening speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option plus Mouse Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/583270/>

P128 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

A Monster's Expedition

The Museum Has Mistaken My Stapler for a Ceremonial Animal

Edition considered: PC release

I have always believed ordinary office equipment deserves more respect. Then the monsters began interpreting human objects, and I discovered that respect can take a very strange shape when nobody knows what anything was for. Tank said the red stapler did look like a small creature with a bad attitude.

Rosa read the exhibit with delight. Shawna examined the little island and the tree that might become a path. Mercedes asked whether our own explanations of unfamiliar things were always more reliable. I began to answer confidently, then remembered several recent incidents involving birds, boxes and an allegedly criminal shrub. We tried moving the tree instead. It produced a concrete result, unlike my lecture. The next island held another object and another chance to be amused by certainty. I quietly changed my proposed museum plaque from 'Authoritative History' to 'A Person Had a Guess.'

The actual attraction

A Monster's Expedition combines tree-pushing spatial puzzles with comic museum observations about humanity. Small islands form a larger exploratory structure, so solving a route can lead to both a new place and a new joke. It offers a particular mix of thoughtful manipulation and dry amusement.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes simple mechanics with substantial depth. That depth can mean difficult planning even when the action vocabulary is small. Check movement, undo, reset and the readability of the islands and exhibits. Its open structure should not be treated as proof that every puzzle is optional or that every route remains easy.

An opening invitation

Solve or experiment with one early crossing, then read the nearby exhibit. Judge whether the combination of puzzle and joke makes you want another island.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The stapler may remain a ceremonial animal until someone produces evidence that its bite served a different social purpose.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1052990/>

P129 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Bonfire Peaks

The Archive Has Been Asked to Consider Letting Something Go

Edition considered: PC release

I objected to the premise on professional grounds. An archive exists to keep things. The game appeared interested in leaving them behind. Tank looked at the three binders beneath my chair and said the game might have a point. I said those binders contained important historical context. Shawna opened one. It contained old versions of the same seating chart.

Rosa suggested that choosing what to release could be as meaningful as collecting. Mercedes added that a difficult object did not become valuable merely because I had carried it a long way. This was a troubling conversation to have beside a puzzle about movement and cargo. I tried arranging the next few steps without defending the entire archive. The small physical problem gave the larger idea room to breathe. I did not immediately throw away a binder. I did, however, admit that one of them could become a doorstep without betraying civilization.

The actual attraction

Bonfire Peaks presents a spatial puzzle journey organized around closure and moving onward. Its compact, sculptural environments make objects and their placement visually central. It may appeal when the satisfaction of an exact arrangement is strengthened by a quiet theme about what people carry.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description promises rewarding challenges and evolving mechanics, not low difficulty. Manipulating objects in three-dimensional puzzle spaces may require careful orientation and planning. Check the actual movement and object controls before assuming the fixed-looking presentation eliminates physical demands. The emotional theme is suggestive rather than a richly voiced character drama.

An opening invitation

Inspect an early puzzle, learn one object interaction and test how to recover from a mistake. Continue only if the precise arrangement feels absorbing rather than burdensome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

One obsolete binder may be released from service; the minister is permitted to survive the loss without commissioning a memorial.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1147890/>

P130 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Can of Wormholes

The Hint Department Has Built a Smaller Puzzle Instead of a Lecture

Edition considered: PC release

I opened the can expecting a manageable administrative issue. Worms were involved, then space behaved strangely, and before long I was considering whether a can could file a complaint against its own contents. Tank said the title had provided adequate warning. I argued that warning and preparation were different budgets.

Shawna noticed the hint system. Instead of simply handing over an answer, it offered a smaller playable idea. Rosa liked that: a nudge that still left discovery in the player's hands. Mercedes asked whether my own explanations could become shorter and more useful in the same way. I said yes, then took four sentences to prove that I had not yet achieved it. We tried the small hint puzzle. Something clicked. The larger problem changed from a wall into a question we could work with. I appointed the tiny puzzle head of training and accepted a probationary role.

The actual attraction

Can of Wormholes develops many interactions from a small collection of puzzle objects. Its distinctive strength for this catalogue is a documented playable hint system: a smaller related stage can suggest the insight needed for the larger one. Experimentation and discovery are the main rewards.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly states that no time-critical inputs or simultaneous key presses are required, and documents unlimited undo and restart. Those are unusually useful concrete claims. Keyboard or gamepad play is supported, with a Mac gamepad limitation noted by the developer. Spatial reasoning and learning new interactions can still be demanding; hold behavior should be checked separately.

An opening invitation

Try an introductory stage, use undo once and inspect a playable hint if curiosity stalls. Learn how the support works before a difficult puzzle makes it feel urgent.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The training department is approved because it offers a useful smaller idea instead of requiring attendance at my worm-related keynote.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer Steam description explicitly says no time-critical input or simultaneous key presses, unlimited undo/restart and playable hints; gamepad on Mac is not currently supported in that description. This supports the stated narrow timing claims, not universal hold-free operation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295320/>

The Undo Budget

I established an Undo Budget after noticing how often a puzzle could become interesting precisely when an earlier idea turned out to be wrong. The proposal included a request form, a committee and a modest administrative charge payable in public acknowledgment of my foresight. Tank asked whether we could undo the proposal. I said that would require the form. Shawna tore the form in half. Apparently the department had discovered a direct-action interface.

Rosa put two of the cabinet's spare fittings on the table. She moved one, considered the result, then put it back. 'That's all,' she said. 'Sometimes trying an idea is how you find out what the problem is.' Mercedes added that a mistake should not automatically become a performance review. I had been preparing a report on the fitting's lack of ambition, so this intervention saved everyone several pages.

Undo and restart still needed to be checked in the actual game. We could not award them by wishing, and we could not assume that a feature in one installment existed in another. But when a useful reversal was present, it changed the feeling of experimentation. A move could be a question. An unsuccessful arrangement could leave behind a better understanding. Nobody had to preserve the first idea simply because I had stamped it.

I attempted to undo my purchase of the oversized binder. Tank said that feature belonged to the shop's returns policy, not the puzzle. We found a practical alternative: divide the contents into smaller volumes and keep the route card visible. It was not a spectacular solution, which made it unusually easy to explain. I claimed the improvement as a triumph of iterative leadership. Mercedes asked whether she could undo that sentence. We let her.

P131 / DETOUR / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: no

Braid, Anniversary Edition

I Would Like to Rewind the Part Where I Announced Expertise

Edition considered: PC Anniversary Edition

The ability to reverse time struck me as the most promising administrative reform in history. I could retract an entire speech without issuing a correction. Tank asked whether I would use it before or after we had heard the speech. I said the implementation details were still being negotiated.

Then the game made time part of a puzzle rather than a service for preserving my reputation. Shawna watched how the rules changed between places. Rosa noticed the memories and regrets woven into the journey. Mercedes pointed out that undoing an action and understanding it were not the same thing. I had been hoping they were. We tried a movement again, this time with a different idea. It was satisfying, but it still required the movement. The rewind did not transform my hands into a committee. I recorded that distinction before my enthusiasm could accidentally turn it into a promise.

The actual attraction

Braid, Anniversary Edition combines platform movement with puzzles built around unusual behavior of time. Its story and images concern memory, desire and regret. The new edition also includes extensive creator commentary, offering another route into the design for someone interested in how a game thinks.

The catch worth knowing

Rewinding does not remove jumping, hazards or required movement timing. The developer explicitly describes platforming and changing time mechanics. This is a conditional action-puzzle detour, not a standard no-rush fit. Check movement, jump combinations and rewind holds separately; a forgiving recovery system can reduce failure cost without reducing the action itself.

An opening invitation

Try one introductory movement puzzle and the rewind control. If the physical action is unwelcome, consider the design commentary as an interest to investigate rather than forcing play.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The minister may revise a mistaken move, but the laws of time decline to erase every embarrassing claim of competence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/499180/>

P132 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

World of Goo

The Bridge Is Held Together by Optimism and a Concerning Amount of Goo

Edition considered: PC original game

I approved the bridge design because it looked ambitious. Tank asked whether ambition could bear weight. I said history was full of structures people had doubted. Shawna suggested this was not a substitute for examining the lower connection. The lower connection chose that moment to prove her point.

The little living pieces made construction feel less like drawing a line and more like persuading a crowd to hold hands in a dangerous shape. Rosa wanted them to arrive somewhere useful. Mercedes wanted me to stop naming unfinished bridges after myself. I tried a shorter structure. It held a little longer. Another adjustment changed the balance. Soon we were watching cause and effect rather than defending a glorious silhouette. The company in the game appeared to have its own questionable priorities. I felt personally attacked by several of them and therefore suspected the satire was functioning correctly.

The actual attraction

World of Goo turns drag-and-drop construction into a physics puzzle with a comic corporate world around it. Structures bend, balance and fail in visible ways, so a small design change can be satisfying to test. Its personality comes from the creatures, signs and increasingly strange purposes of the construction work.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description explicitly says drag and drop. Holding and positioning the pointer may therefore be a central barrier. Physics unfolds while structures are running, and hazards vary by level, so do not assume an unlimited-waiting solution from the word puzzle. Check the ordinary building loop before becoming invested in the larger campaign.

An opening invitation

Build the smallest useful connection in an early level and watch it behave. Test selecting, dragging and releasing one piece before attempting an elaborate tower.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The bridge may carry traffic after it carries itself; the commemorative nameplate can wait indefinitely.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/22000/>

P133 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

World of Goo 2

The Company Has Rebranded the Leak as a Sustainability Initiative

Edition considered: PC sequel

The company said everything was greener now. I respected the confidence of a rebrand that arrived before the mess had been cleaned up. Tank pointed to the liquid moving across the scene. 'Is that meant to be there?' I said the press release described it as dynamic. Shawna asked what we needed to do about it.

Rosa was less interested in the logo than in where the little creatures ended up. Mercedes had questions about the company's motives, which the company's imaginary spokesperson answered by changing the subject to the logo again. I recognized a professional at work. Meanwhile, the puzzle demanded a real arrangement of materials and flow. We tried something, watched the result and changed it. No amount of positive messaging altered the liquid's behavior. It was refreshing to encounter a system that could not be talked into pretending my first design had succeeded.

The actual attraction

World of Goo 2 expands the construction idea with flowing liquid, new material behaviors and another satirical corporate story. The attraction is watching a designed structure interact with a physical process, then discovering a better arrangement. It is a distinct sequel with new puzzles rather than an alternative edition of the first game.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes a dangerous world and varied material mechanics. Pointer precision, holding or dragging, moving liquid and level-specific hazards need assessment. Do not assume that familiarity with one type of goo makes the complete game mechanically simple. This is most plausible when hands-on construction is itself enjoyable, not merely a route to the jokes.

An opening invitation

Try one early construction problem and observe how one material behaves. Check whether editing the structure feels comfortable before attempting to manage several interactions at once.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The sustainability report may use green ink, but the bridge still has to work in the color gravity prefers.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/3385670/>

P134 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: real time / native co-op: no

HUMANITY

The Crowd Has Voted to Follow the Dog

Edition considered: PC non-VR mode proposed for assessment

I assembled the people and prepared a motivational address. They followed a small dog instead. Tank said the dog's instructions were clearer. I asked whether the dog had ever managed a budget. Shawna noted that it had already moved the crowd farther than my entire opening ceremony.

There was something wonderful about seeing a simple direction produce a large pattern. Rosa watched the people as a flow rather than a set of names on my attendance sheet. Mercedes asked whether I wanted to solve the route or regain the microphone. I chose the route, publicly and with enough emphasis to make the microphone question obvious. The arrangement changed, the crowd turned and a little part of the problem made sense. Then the description mentioned action sections and bosses. Shawna underlined them before I could file the dog under Universally Gentle. Even an excellent supervisor can have demanding working conditions.

The actual attraction

HUMANITY turns crowd direction into a striking puzzle-action spectacle. A dog places commands that shape the movement of many people, making routes and group behavior visible at a large scale. Its visual ideas may appeal to someone who enjoys watching a small instruction transform a complex scene.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly includes action-focused stages, platform-like elements and boss battles. This prevents an unqualified no-rush recommendation. Navigation, command placement and the behavior of moving crowds need checking, and the ordinary-screen version should be assessed separately from VR. A clever planning premise does not remove required reactions elsewhere.

An opening invitation

Inspect an introductory routing stage and test one command. Treat later action sections as a real selection barrier, not a detail to discover after making a commitment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The dog is promoted on demonstrated performance; the minister is reassigned to checking whether the job description includes boss fights.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1581480/>

P135 / DETOUR / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

COCOON

The World Has Been Put in a Ball and Assigned to Lost Property

Edition considered: PC release

I found the idea of carrying a whole world extremely efficient. It could reduce the ministry's travel costs to one shelf and a strong bag. Tank asked what happened if we put down the wrong world. I said a labeling policy would prevent that. Shawna watched the game and suggested understanding the relationships before printing labels.

The strange little environments connected in ways that changed what an object could mean. Rosa followed the visual logic without demanding a lecture from every doorway. Mercedes said the mystery benefited from being experienced, not explained into exhaustion by me. I accepted this with the grace of a man temporarily deprived of a podium. Then we read about the guardians. They were not merely decorative custodians of my imaginary lost-property office. The game expected battles. I moved the card to the conditional shelf and admitted that a beautiful system could still ask for actions somebody did not want.

The actual attraction

COCOON builds an alien puzzle adventure around worlds contained within portable orbs. Carrying a world into another world changes what can be done, creating a strong visual form of discovery. The appeal is the elegant connection between an object, a place and a new possibility.

The catch worth knowing

The official description explicitly includes guardian battles with new mechanics. A small-looking action vocabulary therefore does not prove a no-reaction experience. Check movement, aiming or triggering abilities, required timing and the effect of failure. This is a narrow puzzle-adventure detour for someone interested in those interactions, not a default quiet-game recommendation.

An opening invitation

Try the first world-and-orb interaction to see whether its logic feels satisfying. Preview a representative guardian encounter before assuming that the opening describes the full game.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Lost Property will accept an entire world, but it must disclose any guardian currently living inside the claim ticket.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1497440/>

P136 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Gorogoa

The Picture Has Opened a Door Into the Other Picture

Edition considered: PC release

I arranged four images and announced an exhibition. Mercedes moved one panel, and the exhibition became a mechanism. I said that had been my intention. Tank asked why I had just called the empty space between them 'the artist's silence.' I explained that silence is flexible under pressure.

The images invited a different kind of attention. A shape could be a clue; a frame could become an opening; something small might connect to something far larger. Rosa noticed a relationship I had missed while composing the wall text. Shawna tried the movement and watched what it changed. I found myself looking rather than naming. It was pleasant, and mildly threatening to the catalogue's longest sentences. By the time a new connection appeared, I no longer wanted to preserve my first arrangement. I wanted to see what the next one could reveal. The wall text remained mercifully short.

The actual attraction

Gorogoa tells its story through illustrated panels that the player arranges and combines. Its puzzles depend on visual relationships, scale and the possibility that one image can become part of another. The result can feel like discovering how a picture thinks rather than manipulating a conventional inventory.

The catch worth knowing

Panel movement and visual precision are the main checks. The store supports arranging and combining images, but not a complete hold-free control claim. Inspect whether dragging, zooming or small targets are comfortable on the chosen device. The story is largely visual and interpretive, which may be appealing or may feel less concrete than dialogue-led mysteries.

An opening invitation

Move or inspect one panel in the opening arrangement and watch for a new relationship. Focus on that single change before trying to explain the whole story.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The gallery permits the pictures to disagree with their captions and the reader to enjoy a connection before finding words for it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/557600/>

P137 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Monument Valley: Panoramic Edition

The Staircase Has Exploited a Loophole in the Building Code

Edition considered: PC Panoramic Edition

I examined the staircase and declared it noncompliant. Then the view changed and the staircase connected perfectly. Tank asked whether the building code had considered perspective. I said the code was undergoing an urgent review. Shawna suggested that the review begin with turning the actual mechanism.

The little architecture made impossibility look inviting. Rosa followed the figure through a path that my first glance had dismissed. Mercedes said that sometimes a puzzle asks you to stop enforcing the rules you brought from outside it. I resisted on behalf of the building inspector, who was also me. Then I moved a piece and watched a new route appear. There was no need to conquer a continent. One elegant change had made somewhere reachable. I crossed out the violation notice and replaced it with a drawing of the staircase. Tank said the drawing also looked impossible. I decided that was progress.

The actual attraction

Monument Valley guides Ida through compact architectural illusions. Manipulating parts of the monuments changes which paths connect, giving visual discovery a clear purpose. The Panoramic PC presentation can suit someone drawn to beautiful, contained spaces rather than a freely steered open world.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes pushing, pulling, clicking, raising and lowering parts of the scenery. Those operations need a hold-and-drag check; the game's approachable marketing is not a control guarantee. The current Steam header uses Monument Valley, while its description explicitly identifies the Panoramic edition. Keep that edition scope when checking settings and input.

An opening invitation

Complete one early architectural transformation and send Ida along the new path. Test the manipulation itself before deciding that the quiet presentation matches the desired physical comfort.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The staircase receives a temporary exemption from ordinary geometry, while the player's actual comfort remains stubbornly non-negotiable.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected correct Steam app 1927720. Current header shortens the name, but detailed description explicitly identifies Panoramic Edition and manipulation actions. Wrong or unresolved automatic cache excluded. Holds/timing not certified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1927720/>

P138 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Monument Valley 2: Panoramic Edition

The Building Has Made Room for Someone to Grow

Edition considered: PC Panoramic Edition

I designed two identical routes and called the arrangement equitable. Rosa asked whether the two travelers needed the same thing at the same moment. I said consistency was an administrative virtue. Mercedes said care sometimes required noticing a difference. Tank quietly removed the second copy of my route.

The mother and child moved through a world that changed around them. Shawna watched how the architecture expressed separation and connection without needing a speech from me. This was excellent news for everybody except my speech. I tried to understand the next shape as a relationship rather than merely a clever staircase. The puzzle still needed solving, but the reason to solve it felt warmer. I put the duplicate route in the recycling. It was not a dramatic gesture, though I attempted to give it a title. Rosa said I could let one useful act remain small.

The actual attraction

Monument Valley 2 connects architectural illusion with a story of Ro and her child. The changing paths give its themes of care and independence a visual form. The developer describes it as a standalone adventure, so interest in this relationship does not require finishing the first game.

The catch worth knowing

The PC description explicitly calls for clicking and dragging to reshape the world. That is a concrete conditional barrier, even though the presentation is calm. Check how long manipulations must be held, target size and recovery from an unintended movement. The current storefront's shorter title still identifies the Panoramic edition in its detailed description.

An opening invitation

Try one early interaction involving the two travelers and the structure around them. Assess the drag action before assuming that a gentle story means physically effortless play.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The architecture may grow with its travelers; the committee is forbidden to demand that everyone use the same staircase at the same time.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected correct Steam app 1927740. Detailed text identifies Panoramic Edition and explicitly describes clicking and dragging. Wrong or unresolved automatic cache excluded. Calm presentation is not a hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1927740/>

P139 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Room

The Box Contains a Smaller Reason to Distrust the Box

Edition considered: PC original game

The object looked expensive, secretive and difficult to open. Naturally, I assumed it belonged in my office. Tank asked what it did. 'It establishes atmosphere.' Shawna turned it and found something that might actually be useful. I advised caution with a tone suggesting I had noticed it first.

Every surface seemed capable of concealing a latch, a clue or another arrangement of parts. Rosa enjoyed the invitation to look closely. Mercedes asked whether I could resist declaring the first discovery a final victory. I said yes and immediately tried to announce a breakthrough. The next layer opened, proving that the breakthrough had merely acquired a hallway. We laughed and kept looking. The pleasure was not in owning the box or displaying it beside my nameplate. It was in finding the small thing that changed what the box could become. I considered that an improvement in my relationship with office equipment.

The actual attraction

The Room offers close inspection of elaborate mechanical objects within an atmospheric mystery. Cryptic letters and unusual devices give each discovered mechanism a little narrative weight. Its concentrated setting may appeal more than walking through a large world, especially when the desired activity is examining something with a purpose.

The catch worth knowing

Close-up object puzzles can demand rotation, zooming, sliding and held pointer movement. The primary PC description calls the experience tactile but does not certify click-only controls. Check a representative latch or dial and the readability of details. The eerie tone may also matter even if the player is not controlling a combat character.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first object, identify one movable part and test the exact interaction. Learn how to leave a close-up before proceeding through several layers.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The box may keep its secrets until asked properly; the minister may not replace observation with an expensive-looking nameplate.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/288160/>

P140 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Room Two

The Second Room Has Requested a Larger Suspicion Budget

Edition considered: PC release

I returned prepared for a box. The sequel appeared prepared to offer more than one thing worth examining. Tank watched my face as the scope expanded. 'You brought the small binder.' 'I was demonstrating restraint.' Shawna said restraint could also mean investigating one object before drafting an entire catalogue of everything suspicious.

The cryptic trail gave us a reason to keep noticing. Rosa chose a detail and followed it. Mercedes reminded me that a room was not a demand to solve every visible surface simultaneously. I found this useful because my first instinct had been to point at all of them. One mechanism suggested another. A letter gave the arrangement a different tone. The investigation developed through attention rather than volume. I left the large binder in the cupboard. Later, Tank found me considering a medium binder and gently closed the cupboard door.

The actual attraction

The Room Two continues the series' mechanical mystery while expanding the spaces and objects to investigate. Following an enigmatic scientist's letters gives the tactile puzzle work a thread to pursue. It may suit someone who liked the first game's close observation and wants a broader version of that activity.

The catch worth knowing

An expanded environment can add object and location memory to the familiar manipulation demands. Check turning, zooming, dragging and moving between viewpoints in the PC release rather than carrying over assumptions from a mobile version. The primary source establishes a rebuilt PC edition, not universal comfort or a completely untimed completion path.

An opening invitation

Investigate one object in the opening area and complete a single interaction chain. Notice whether finding the next relevant object feels inviting or starts to become visual clutter.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

The suspicion budget may increase, but it must be spent one useful detail at a time instead of on a bigger binder.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/425580/>

A Quiet Board Can Contain a Loud Problem

At the next meeting I displayed two pictures. One was a cheerful creature. The other was an ornate machine surrounded by impressive shadows. I asked the committee which was easier. Shawna asked, 'Easier to move, easier to understand, easier to read, or easier to stop thinking about?' This was an unreasonable number of useful questions for a presentation that had originally contained only two slides.

Tank said the creature could require a difficult sequence of moves. Mercedes said the machine might be lovely to inspect even if she needed a clue. Rosa said neither picture told us whether somebody had to hold a button while doing something else. I looked at my labels, which read FRIENDLY and IMPORTANT. They did not survive the discussion.

We replaced the labels with descriptions of actions. Moving one square. Turning an object. Holding and dragging a piece. Reading a clue. Remembering which room contained a symbol. Waiting for a safe moment to pass a guard. These were not interchangeable demands, and none of them could be inferred reliably from the amount of gold trim on the screen. The book's quieter page design suddenly seemed more useful than my attempted hierarchy of seriousness.

I wanted to preserve one grand distinction: a grown-up evening could include simple play without needing to apologize for it. Mercedes agreed, provided we also acknowledged the opposite. A person who wanted complicated characters should not be handed a coloring toy merely because its controls were small. Taste was part of the decision. We returned both pictures to the table with better descriptions. The creature kept its dignity. The machine lost its automatic promotion. I lost a slide deck, which everyone described as an improvement.

P141 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Room Three

The Invitation Has a Secret Compartment and No Return Address

Edition considered: PC release

The Craftsman sounded like someone who would understand my desk. Then I imagined arriving on a remote island with a cabinet whose drawers demanded qualifications before opening. Tank inspected the invitation. 'It doesn't say refreshments.' I said a mysterious patron would surely provide. Rosa brought a bag anyway, which is why her expedition had better survival prospects than mine.

I appointed myself Director of Small Brass Revelations. Shawna asked whether the title helped locate a hinge. It did not, although I maintained that the phrase had excellent acoustics. The attraction was the workmanship: an object seemed to hold a question in its joints. I could imagine wanting to know what the next mechanism concealed. Mercedes said that curiosity was a perfectly good reason to continue and did not need my office attached. I agreed, then tried to find somewhere on the island to hang the sign.

The actual attraction

The Room Three expands mechanical puzzle investigation into a mysterious island and the trials of an elusive Craftsman. Its rebuilt PC presentation offers richly detailed objects and spaces. This is a candidate for someone who enjoys handling intricate mysteries and wants a broader setting around the mechanisms.

The catch worth knowing

Broader spaces can increase navigation and remembered-location demands. Close manipulation still needs an exact-device check for turning, dragging and zooming; a mouse interface does not establish that everything is click-only. The inspected description does not certify every later interaction as untimed. Eerie isolation is part of the appeal, so choose it for that mood rather than assuming the title means a quiet decorating game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first available mechanism and follow one clue to its consequence. Check manipulation comfort before treating the island's larger mysteries as a commitment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit the Craftsman if the machinery invites curiosity. Reject my application to manage his drawers until I can open one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/456750/>

P142 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Room 4: Old Sins

The Dollhouse Has More Affairs Than the Full-Size Office

Edition considered: PC release

The dollhouse looked like an administrative efficiency miracle. An entire estate could fit on a desk; surely I could reduce the department's rent. Tank pointed out that the tiny rooms appeared to contain a troubling amount of history. I said history was usually cheaper at that scale. Shawna asked me to stop valuing secrets by square footage.

A miniature interior made me lean into observation. A small object could imply something larger about the people missing from the real house. Rosa said that was the interesting part: the house was a story container, not simply an ornate cupboard. Mercedes declined my proposal to furnish the smallest room with a miniature gold stamp. 'Somebody already disappeared,' she said. 'Let's not add you to the paperwork.' I put the stamp away and considered what the house was actually telling us. Even a small door deserved a better question than whether my name would fit above it.

The actual attraction

Old Sins frames its mechanical puzzles around an unusual dollhouse and a disappearance at Waldegrave Manor. An engineer, his wife and a sought-after artifact give the investigation a darker domestic story. The PC edition rebuilds the visual presentation around detailed rooms and their interconnections.

The catch worth knowing

The dollhouse is a mysterious adult setting, not evidence of simple mechanics. Moving among rooms and tracking object uses can add memory demands; rotating and manipulating mechanisms may involve sustained pointer actions. Check the PC controls directly. The reviewed source establishes the premise and tactile puzzles, but leaves full-game timing and hold requirements unresolved.

An opening invitation

Explore one dollhouse area and identify what changed after a single mechanism. Continue if the relationship between the small room and the larger mystery feels satisfying.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A small house may contain a large story. It does not automatically qualify for my small-business grant or miniature executive parking.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1361320/>

P143 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The House of Da Vinci

My Apprenticeship Has Begun with an Unflattering Comparison

Edition considered: PC release

I arrived for an imaginary Renaissance apprenticeship carrying a notebook entitled *Inventions I Would Have Thought of Eventually*. Leonardo's workshop made the cover feel ambitious. Tank suggested starting with a working paperclip. I said I was more interested in visionary infrastructure. 'You mean a shelf,' he said. 'A shelf that stays up this time.'

The workshop offered a better form of ambition: look at what the mechanism does, then figure out why it will not yet do it. Shawna inspected the parts without announcing a historic breakthrough every time she noticed a wheel. I tried that and found it surprisingly productive. Mercedes said the missing master's story might keep her interested between mechanisms. Rosa put the notebook away before I added Leonardo as a collaborator without asking. By the end of the imagined visit I had invented almost nothing, but I had paid attention. The application office considered this a promising change in professional direction.

The actual attraction

As Leonardo's apprentice, investigate his disappearance through mechanical puzzles and hidden objects in a Renaissance setting. Special devices add unusual ways to inspect the environment. The appeal is fictional intrigue joined to elaborate machinery, with an atmosphere inspired by historical inventions rather than a plain sequence of abstract boards.

The catch worth knowing

Inspecting objects can involve viewpoint changes and tactile manipulation; do not assume that a point-and-click label eliminates dragging or holds. Puzzles may require noticing small details and remembering where a device belongs. The source describes a fictional adventure, not a history lesson or a verified fully untimed control path. Test the intended PC input arrangement.

An opening invitation

Examine one early device and identify its moving parts before trying to solve everything nearby. Check whether manipulating it feels pleasant enough to support a longer mystery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve the apprenticeship for curiosity about mechanisms. My patent for a shelf remains under review by the person who owns the wall.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/522470/>

P144 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The House of Da Vinci 2

The Past Has Been Asked to Correct This Morning's Filing

Edition considered: PC release

The possibility of changing the past arrived at exactly the right moment for a man who had spilled coffee on his own final report. I proposed a minor historical intervention. Shawna said an extraordinary time device probably had better work to do. Tank disagreed: that report had already consumed enough resources to qualify as a regional disaster.

We imagined following the apprentice into another tangle of mechanisms and secrets. A change in one period could matter in another; cause and effect now had architectural consequences. I immediately wanted a chart. Mercedes allowed one page and confiscated my roll of string. Rosa was interested in hearing the story unfold, which made the advertised narration useful to investigate. Nobody agreed to let me rewind a conversation merely because I had lost an argument. Apparently the technology could be miraculous while the household rules remained disappointingly stable. I ordered a fresh cup of coffee and placed it considerably farther from history.

The actual attraction

The second House of Da Vinci combines Renaissance mystery, mechanical puzzles and a device that connects past actions with present conditions. The developer describes a fully narrated story and redesigned controls. Those are useful distinctions to check when choosing this installment, particularly if hearing the narrative is part of its appeal.

The catch worth knowing

Redesigned controls are not proof of low physical demand. Test the actual manipulation, viewpoint changes and dragging on the PC version. Time travel can increase the number of relationships to remember, and narration does not guarantee that every clue is spoken. The reviewed source does not settle all later timed interactions or the option to avoid sustained input.

An opening invitation

Try one narrated scene and one mechanical interaction. Notice separately whether the voices help the story and whether the device controls feel comfortable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorize travel through history for an interesting mystery. Coffee damage must still be handled with an ordinary cloth and a more sensible desk layout.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1259840/>

P145 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The House of Da Vinci 3

The Final Report Has Revealed Two Earlier Reports

Edition considered: PC release

I liked the words trilogy finale because they implied an institution might eventually finish something. Tank asked whether I planned to begin with the final chapter and infer the paperwork backward. I said this was an advanced leadership technique. Mercedes called it arriving late and requesting a summary.

Giacomo's continuing adventure offered conspiracies, machines and a reason to follow the people involved. I pictured a cabinet opening onto a larger scheme while my own cabinet opened onto fourteen copies of the same lunch order. Shawna said the difference might be intentional design. Rosa wanted to know whether the characters would mean more after the earlier games. That seemed a better selection question than whether three was a more prestigious number than one. I withdrew my proposal for immediate admission based on seniority. The trilogy could be approached in a sensible order, unless somebody already knew its world. This concession was entered in a very small report so it would not accidentally start another trilogy.

The actual attraction

The third game concludes Giacomo's adventure with Leonardo, combining mechanical puzzles, time-related mysteries and conspiracies across Italian settings. The developer advertises voiced historical figures within the fictional story. It is most appealing as a continuation for someone already enjoying the series' machinery and atmosphere.

The catch worth knowing

A finale can carry more narrative context than a first encounter needs. Its polished presentation and claims of intuitive interaction do not verify click-only play or absence of required holds. Check the PC manipulation and camera behavior, and establish whether prior story knowledge matters to the intended experience. Full-route timing remains unverified in this source pass.

An opening invitation

Watch or inspect the opening premise without racing onward. If the characters and controls are already familiar, try one mechanism; otherwise consider starting with the first installment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Grant continuation rights to an enjoyed mystery. A higher sequel number does not entitle my filing cabinet to describe itself as experienced.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1603640/>

P146 / PROMISING / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Carto

The Map Has Moved the Destination Closer to the Biscuits

Edition considered: PC release

I proposed solving the office's long walk to the kitchen by moving the kitchen on the map. Tank said that was not how the building worked. Then Carto presented a world where rearranging map pieces really could change the route. I asked everyone to acknowledge the visionary basis of my earlier proposal. Nobody did, although Rosa seemed interested in the practical biscuit implications.

The lovely part was the relationship between the paper world and the place you walked through. A map could be a thing to think with rather than a chore to memorize. Shawna turned our attention to the reason for the journey: a girl trying to find her way back to her grandmother and meeting people along the way. Mercedes preferred that to my plan for a cartographic convenience empire. I agreed to rearrange geography in service of reunion, with only a modest unofficial hope that one of the new paths might pass a bakery.

The actual attraction

Carto combines a journey to reunite with Granny with puzzles that rearrange the map itself. Changing the arrangement creates new paths and possibilities in the world. Friendly encounters and varied communities give the spatial puzzle a human thread, offering more story context than an isolated logic board.

The catch worth knowing

There are two activities to learn: moving the character and manipulating map pieces. Check rotation, placement, any dragging and the amount of direction holding needed for walking. The peaceful presentation is encouraging, but it does not establish every interaction as untimed or effortless. Later map relationships may demand more spatial reasoning than the first examples suggest.

An opening invitation

Complete one map change, then walk the resulting route and notice what it changed. Judge whether switching between map thinking and character movement feels natural.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve if changing a map feels like making a useful discovery. Requests to move the actual kitchen must still include a plumbing estimate.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1172450/>

P147 / DETOUR / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Chants of Sennaar

The Sign May Say Welcome or Departmental Merger

Edition considered: PC release

I saw unfamiliar symbols and immediately considered issuing my own official translation. Shawna asked what evidence supported it. 'The font has authority,' I said. This was apparently not enough. Tank suggested that a man who had once misread PUSH should proceed carefully with an entire language.

Watching people and comparing uses of a symbol felt more satisfying than memorizing a dictionary somebody had handed over. A word could become plausible, then become doubtful, then suddenly connect a conversation to something else. Mercedes liked the possibility of understanding people who had been kept apart. Rosa preferred that goal to my plan for licensing all future nouns. I agreed to keep guesses provisional. The notebook became a place for evidence instead of a place where my first opinion acquired a decorative border. That was a substantial institutional reform. I tried to announce it in the new language, but Shawna suggested waiting until I knew whether my sentence requested a meeting or a bucket.

The actual attraction

Chants of Sennaar builds a tower journey around interpreting several interconnected languages. Observation, conversations and a notebook of symbols support the process of finding meaning. Its distinctive appeal is the moment when a scene becomes understandable, with communication across separated peoples supplying a larger purpose.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly confirms stealth sections that require choosing a path and timing movement around guard patterns. This conflicts with a strict no-rush route. The Steam listing's mouse-only and camera-comfort declarations do not remove that demand, and the developer says the gamepad cover/free toggle does not apply to mouse-and-keyboard play. Language deduction also adds substantial memory work.

An opening invitation

Explore the early language puzzle only if that bounded visit is wanted. Preview the stealth requirements before committing; do not promise that enjoying the opening makes the full game suitable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for the pleasure of understanding a stranger. My first translation remains provisional, especially if it appears to appoint me king of the tower.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam premise and declared input categories; developer Rundisc replies of December 4, 2023 and March 23, 2024 explicitly confirm stealth timing and distinguish gamepad from mouse/keyboard. No whole-game no-rush claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1931770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1931770/discussions/0/4040354734349221032/>

P148 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Heaven's Vault

The Ancient Inscription Has Declined to Endorse My Theory

Edition considered: PC release

An archaeologist and a robot travelling among ruins sounded like the kind of partnership I could supervise from an extremely comfortable chair. Tank asked which one would tolerate me. I said the robot might appreciate clear instructions. Shawna looked at the binder and said that would make two of us looking for them.

The writing on a discovered object invited a theory about the people who made it. Another discovery might strengthen the theory or knock a leg out from under it. Mercedes liked a story in which understanding could change without everyone pretending the earlier guess had never happened. Rosa wanted the relationship between the traveller and her companion to matter as much as the stones. I prepared to enjoy both, then caught myself writing **CERTIFIED TRANSLATION** at the top of an uncertain page. Shawna replaced it with **WORKING IDEA**. The new label was less magnificent, but it had the advantage of being true.

The actual attraction

Heaven's Vault follows archaeologist Aliya and her robot companion Six through a network of places and histories. Translating an ancient language is woven into an adaptive story, where discoveries and interpretations affect the journey. It offers grown-up curiosity, character exchanges and the possibility of forming a theory that later evidence complicates.

The catch worth knowing

This is more than a static translation screen: exploration includes navigation and sailing, and the source describes fast-flowing space rivers. Check camera movement, sustained travel input and the handling of those sequences. Tracking inscriptions, earlier interpretations and story choices can be demanding. Do not read its reflective subject matter as proof that every physical action waits comfortably.

An opening invitation

Try one conversation and one inscription before evaluating a travel sequence separately. Keep a translation provisional and notice whether uncertainty feels intriguing or merely burdensome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve archaeology for anyone who enjoys a theory with room to grow. My stamp cannot turn an attractive guess into a discovered fact.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/774201/>

P149 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Return of the Obra Dinn

The Insurance Form Has Become an Entire Ship

Edition considered: PC release

I volunteered to assess an abandoned merchant ship because, for once, somebody had admitted that paperwork was central to the adventure. Tank asked whether I had maritime experience. I said I had successfully carried soup across a room. Shawna explained that this did not constitute a qualification in identifying what happened to a missing crew.

The assignment suggested a more serious version of observation: people, places and small details might connect into an account of events. Mercedes wanted the mystery, but refused my proposal to issue conclusions before examining the evidence. Rosa said the crew should feel like people whose stories mattered, not spaces I was eager to fill in. That changed the mood around the imaginary desk. I put away the celebratory stamp. A strange ship could be fascinating without turning loss into a scoreboard. Tank kept the soup on land, where my demonstrated competence remained narrow but reasonably well documented.

The actual attraction

Return of the Obra Dinn casts the player as an insurance investigator examining a merchant ship that has returned without its crew. The developer emphasizes first-person exploration and logical deduction. Its appeal is reconstructing a complicated human mystery through observation, making it a strong story-and-evidence candidate for the right input setup.

The catch worth knowing

First-person navigation brings camera coordination and movement holds into the assessment. Connecting many identities and events can also impose a large memory burden, while the ship's fate involves death and disturbing material. The inspected primary description is brief; it does not establish every timing or interaction requirement. Choose it for substantial deduction, not as a low-effort introduction to mysteries.

An opening invitation

Inspect the opening environment and the investigation interface. Check visual comfort and navigation before deciding whether maintaining a larger network of people and clues sounds enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit the investigator only after checking the ship's controls. My soup certificate will not be accepted as evidence of maritime expertise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/653530/>

P150 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Opus Magnum

The Machine Works but the Management Has Opinions

Edition considered: PC release

I wanted a machine that would place the gold stamp on a page, admire the result, and then quietly perform all the work the stamp implied. Opus Magnum appeared more interested in making transformations actually happen. Tank said this was already an improvement on the department's current business model.

Programmable arms, tracks and repeating operations gave my imaginary workshop a clear question: could this arrangement produce the required result? Shawna built a small logical explanation while I considered a ceremonial name for the machine. Mercedes said a working solution could be enough, even if somebody else's was smaller or faster. That statement threatened the entire Bureau of Comparative Excellence, so I took a moment to process it. Rosa suggested watching the parts move once they were doing the right thing. There was pleasure in that, separate from winning an argument about efficiency. I approved the first working arrangement and resisted adding an arm whose sole job was to point at my name.

The actual attraction

Opus Magnum is an open-ended machine-building puzzle about arranging and programming alchemical equipment. Several solutions can work, with optional interest in making them cheaper, smaller or faster. A story of ambition and intrigue surrounds the workshop, while watching a successful mechanism repeat its work provides a distinctive reward.

The catch worth knowing

The editor, component placement and instruction sequencing create substantial interface and reasoning demands. Optimization comparisons can introduce self-imposed pressure even when a solution already works. Machine execution speed is not the same thing as required human reaction speed, but exact editing holds and all control requirements still need checking. The narrative is woven around construction rather than replacing it.

An opening invitation

Follow one introductory construction and make a single operation work. Ignore efficiency comparisons while deciding whether arranging and revising a machine is enjoyable in itself.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve a machine because it works and is satisfying to watch. An extra arm dedicated to congratulating its inventor is not a necessary component.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/558990/>

The Museum of Working Things

We opened the retro cabinet with appropriate ceremony. Tank held the door so it would not strike the table. I announced that every artifact within had survived an era of inferior management and therefore deserved respect. Shawna asked which one currently worked on the available equipment. The ceremony paused while the museum encountered the difference between historical interest and an actual evening's entertainment.

A mouse from an old console suggested a small creative studio. A city simulator suggested systems, budgets and a skyline. A contraption builder suggested a ball reaching an objective by the most entertaining possible route. These were distinct invitations. Mercedes refused to let the single word retro make them interchangeable. Rosa also refused to let nostalgia turn setup trouble into a social obligation. A lovely memory could stay lovely without everyone spending the evening chasing an unavailable driver.

We wrote down what was known from a manual or an exact-edition source and what still needed checking. A source gap stayed a source gap. A scan we could locate but not read did not become a control audit because I looked solemn beside it. I offered to issue a provisional seal. Shawna said the plain sentence about the gap was already doing more useful work than the seal would.

Tank found the red stapler in the cabinet and asked whether I intended to classify it as a historical pointing device. I said its original firmware was still intact. He stapled two loose sheets, demonstrating compatibility with paper. That was the strongest hands-on evidence produced during the ceremony. We left the cabinet open, placed the useful notes beside it, and agreed that an old favorite should earn its place through present enjoyment, with history allowed to make the invitation warmer.

P151 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Sokobond

The Molecule Has Rejected an Unnecessary Management Layer

Edition considered: PC release

I looked at a small arrangement of atoms and proposed adding a supervisor. Shawna explained that this was a chemistry puzzle, not a staffing dispute. 'Everything benefits from coordination,' I said. Tank pointed out that the atoms appeared to be doing substantially better without a meeting.

The appeal was a compact problem that could change meaning as the pieces connected. I did not need to turn the room into a laboratory or pretend I remembered every chemical symbol from school. Mercedes appreciated the promise that prior chemistry knowledge was unnecessary; she wanted to discover the rules through the puzzle itself. Rosa asked whether the quiet presentation hid a serious challenge. It could, which seemed like a fair arrangement if the challenge was enjoyable. I removed the supervisor from my diagram. A small system had enough relationships already. Then I tried to charge the department for the successful removal of an unnecessary position and discovered that everyone remembered who had proposed it.

The actual attraction

Sokobond turns molecular connections into compact logic puzzles with a minimalist presentation. The developer explicitly says chemistry knowledge is not required. Its current Steam declarations include keyboard-only play and play without timed input, making this a useful candidate when deliberate problem-solving is welcome but reaction pressure is not.

The catch worth knowing

A small control vocabulary can still support difficult spatial reasoning. Confirm comfortable key presses, any repeat behavior and how undo works on the actual device. The developer's no-timed-input declaration is useful evidence, not a hands-on comfort guarantee. This is mainly abstract puzzle pleasure; it will not supply the character-rich narrative that motivates some other choices in the catalog.

An opening invitation

Try one introductory molecular puzzle and learn the result of a single movement. Continue only if revising a spatial idea feels satisfying, without requiring prior chemistry expertise.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve bonds that make a good puzzle. Deny my proposal to place an executive atom above the others and call the arrangement leadership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam source supports chemistry-themed puzzles without required chemistry knowledge. Current developer declarations include Keyboard Only Option and Playable without Timed Input. Those declarations are not a hands-on test of sustained keys or individual comfort. Remote Play Together is not treated as native co-op.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/290260/>

P152 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Hexcells

The Hexagon Has Filed Six Equally Valid Complaints

Edition considered: PC original game

I chose a hexagonal form because it looked more advanced than the department's rectangles. Tank asked whether six sides made the instructions any clearer. I said the additional edges offered room for innovation. Shawna said they mostly offered room for me to write six versions of the same vague sentence.

A quiet field of cells was a more appealing use of the shape. There could be pleasure in finding one justified move, then letting it reveal another. Mercedes said that sounded like a good reason to sit down if the clues were readable. Rosa suggested removing the theatrical briefing so the actual instructions could be seen. I obliged, reluctantly folding my hexagonal agenda into a shape best described as damaged. The puzzle did not need an invented story about national importance. A visible pattern and a small piece of certainty might be enough. My form was reassigned as a coaster, where its unusually generous perimeter finally served a practical purpose.

The actual attraction

Hexcells is presented by its developer as an ambient logic puzzle. Its compact cell-based format offers a different kind of interest from walking through a world: inspect the board, understand its rules and look for a reasoned next step. It is a candidate for someone who likes deliberate abstract deduction.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected primary description is unusually brief, so it does not substantiate a full no-timer or hold-free claim. Check the game's instructions, cell readability and the distinction between its input actions before relying on it. A sparse screen does not guarantee an easy deduction. This original Hexcells entry should not inherit features or extra modes from the separate Plus and Infinite games.

An opening invitation

Read the opening board instructions and make one move whose reason is clear. Check whether selecting and distinguishing cells feels comfortable before increasing the puzzle size.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Grant six-sided logic a hearing if its clues invite another look. The department's hexagonal stationery remains a beverage accessory until its wording improves.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The exact-game Steam page describes an ambient logic puzzle; its short primary text does not establish full controls or timing. The separate sequels' features were not imported. Detailed input verification remains outstanding.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/265890/>

P153 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Tametsi

The Tiles Have Demanded Evidence Before Anyone Touches Them

Edition considered: PC release

I arrived with a strategy called Probably That One. Tametsi's promise of logic-based solutions made the strategy seem professionally weak. Shawna asked me to explain a move. I pointed confidently. She waited. Tank said confidence was not a number, although I had been submitting it as one for years.

The board invited a stricter pleasure: a conclusion that followed from what was visible. Mercedes liked that the game did not need guesses, but she wanted the word difficult printed somewhere I could not cover with my stamp. Rosa liked the possibility of leaving an unfinished puzzle without losing the work, since an interruption should not become an administrative incident. I considered the drawing tools as a place to keep a real argument instead of a speech about my intuition. There was something satisfying about admitting that a tile should remain untouched until the evidence supported it. The department briefly experienced the unfamiliar sensation of having fewer conclusions than claims.

The actual attraction

Tametsi offers demanding logic puzzles about finding hidden mines among tiles. The developer says solutions do not require guessing, provides on-screen drawing tools for notes, and saves progress even within a level. For someone who enjoys careful deduction, those features can support a substantial problem without requiring an immediate answer.

The catch worth knowing

The developer also explicitly describes the game as difficult. Large patterns, written notes and relationships between clues can become mentally busy even when the physical action is modest. Verify the click controls, tile visibility and stopping behavior on the device. The inspected text supports automatic progress saving, but it does not explicitly certify every input as hold-free or every activity as untimed.

An opening invitation

Try an early board and write down one deduction with the available note tools. Decide whether the reasoning itself is enjoyable before treating more difficult boards as an objective.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit a conclusion when the clues support it. My pointing finger has been demoted from Evidence Department to General Direction Services.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/709920/>

P154 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Mario Paint

The Stamp Department Has Finally Found Its Medium

Edition considered: 1992 SNES original; SNES Mouse input

I had spent several volumes defending stamps as a serious creative instrument. Mario Paint offered a room where that defense might actually stand up. Tank looked at a row of repeated pictures and said I had found a form of bureaucracy with better colors. I chose to accept this as professional recognition.

Rosa wanted to make a small picture without turning the process into an art examination. Mercedes wanted to see what happened when a ridiculous little image was repeated in a pleasing arrangement. Shawna directed us toward stamps and fills before I disappeared into every icon on the screen. The mouse made the old console feel like a tiny studio. I proposed composing the department's official anthem as well, but Tank said we should first establish whether the picture needed fourteen copies of my favorite symbol. It did not. We removed thirteen and suddenly it looked intentional. This remains one of the few documented occasions when reducing my contribution improved the composition.

The actual attraction

The original SNES Mario Paint is a creative toy for pictures, music and animation, built around the SNES Mouse. Stamping and filling areas offer a narrower first activity than exploring the entire toolbox. Its appeal is making something playful, with nostalgia as an optional bonus rather than a requirement.

The catch worth knowing

The original hardware needs the mouse peripheral. Manual instructions distinguish simple selections from held-button dragging used by other tools, so the whole program is not hold-free. Many icons and palette choices can create menu clutter. The separate Gnat Attack activity adds reaction demands and is outside this suggested stamp-and-fill trial. This is creation, not a character-story adventure.

An opening invitation

Choose one stamp and one fill color, then make a small picture. Leave freehand dragging, animation and the reaction minigame aside while checking mouse comfort.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorize the gold stamp to pursue an artistic career, provided it accepts criticism and does not fill every available inch with evidence of its own existence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo announcement confirms the 1992 original; original Nintendo manual transcription, hosted by a third party, distinguishes stamps/fills from held dragging and the separate Gnat Attack activity. Card scope is original SNES Mouse play, not an automatic claim about modern ports.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/whatsnew/mario-paint-scribbles-into-the-super-nes-collection/>

Source 2: <https://manualzz.com/doc/26101036/nintendo-mario-paint-family-user-manual>

P155 / DETOUR / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Color a Dinosaur

The Dinosaur Has Requested One Color and No Brand Strategy

Edition considered: 1993 NES original

I prepared a presentation about restoring the dinosaur's public image. Mercedes asked whether the animal had requested this service. I said it had left several areas uncolored, which I considered an invitation to develop a visual identity. Tank said it looked more like an invitation to choose a color.

The attraction here was deliberately narrow: an old console, a picture and a small set of choices. Rosa could see a place for that if someone actually wanted the nostalgia. Shawna could also see the danger of offering it to a person who had asked for a richer story and calling the mismatch kindness. I put the presentation away. The dinosaur did not become a more grown-up mystery because I gave it a committee. It remained a simple coloring toy, available to enjoy on exactly those terms. Mercedes chose a ridiculous color and laughed. That was a good enough reason for the choice; it did not require me to pretend the picture concealed an epic.

The actual attraction

Color a Dinosaur is an original NES coloring toy with a deliberately small activity loop. Its manual describes selecting pictures and filling regions with colors, including a point-to-point control arrangement. It belongs here as a specific retro curiosity for someone who wants that simple action, not as a substitute for adult narrative.

The catch worth knowing

The presentation is aimed at young children and the variety is limited. That may be a taste veto regardless of how few controls are needed. The original manual supports the coloring controls, while full-play timing and modern-device behavior have not been tested here. Mode changes can affect the drawing; check the intended setup rather than assuming an emulator reproduces every behavior conveniently.

An opening invitation

If the retro coloring idea itself appeals, fill a few regions in one picture. Stop the trial once its narrow appeal is clear; completing a picture is optional.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit the dinosaur only by personal invitation. No amount of executive branding can turn a coloring toy into the grown-up mystery somebody asked for.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original manual scan, hosted by a third party, was visually examined in the earlier project research (work/retro-games.json); current reopen yielded no searchable text. Manual-supported point-to-point coloring is a narrow option, not a tested whole-game or emulator guarantee. Wrong Steam coloring-game match excluded.

Source 1: <https://www.digitpress.com/library/manuals/nes/Color%20a%20Dinosaur.pdf>

P156 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Incredible Machine 3

The Ball Will Ring the Bell After Several Avoidable Expenses

Edition considered: 1995 Windows original

I could see the appeal immediately: a simple task achieved through an arrangement so elaborate that everyone else would wonder why I had not just done the task. Tank said the department had finally found its autobiography. I objected because our office did not contain a balloon-powered component. 'Give you another hour,' he said.

The imagined contraption had a ball, a useful object, and more connecting logic than the result strictly required. Shawna wanted to know whether changing one part would explain the failure. Mercedes liked the comedy of an absurd mechanism that genuinely worked. Rosa asked whether we could celebrate a small successful chain without rebuilding the entire table. I agreed, although the agreement was difficult because a pulley seemed like the kind of thing the table had been missing. We kept the experiment modest. A practical outcome reached by a wonderfully impractical route felt like honest entertainment, provided nobody confused it with my preferred method for organizing everybody else's evening.

The actual attraction

The Incredible Machine 3 is a historical contraption-building puzzle candidate: arrange parts into chains of cause and effect to achieve an objective. Its appeal is seeing an unlikely mechanism succeed after a useful adjustment. This 1995 Windows entry is included for a revisit if an existing copy and workable setup are available.

The catch worth knowing

Evidence is weaker here than for the modern store entries. A Sierra historical archive identifies the game, but its descriptive text credits a secondary database; the linked scanned manual was located without usable text verification. Exact mouse actions, timers, compatibility and present availability remain unresolved. Do not mistake this historical candidate for a certified easy-to-run or hold-free recommendation.

An opening invitation

On a working existing setup, inspect one introductory contraption and its controls before changing a single component. Avoid turning software setup into the evening's main activity.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve a ridiculous machine when its workings are the pleasure. Deny my attempt to use that principle as the department's purchasing policy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Explicit source gap: historical Sierra archive page inspected, but its descriptive prose credits MobyGames. Original scanned manual located, not successfully read for mechanics in this pass. Primary identity locator is available; detailed controls, timing, current availability and compatibility remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.sierragamers.com/tim-3/>

Source 2: https://www.sierragamers.com/wp-content/uploads/2019/12/TIM_3_Manual.pdf

P157 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

SimCity 2000 Special Edition

The Mayor Has Built a Monument Before Asking About Water

Edition considered: PC Special Edition

I laid out a magnificent avenue leading directly to the mayor's office. Tank asked where the residents lived. I said that was the next phase of civic excellence. Shawna asked about utilities. I pointed to the avenue again, which did not improve its ability to supply water.

A city-building game could make these decisions interesting because the city would have reasons to care about them. Mercedes liked the thought of shaping a place, then seeing how its parts related. Rosa preferred a neighborhood people might enjoy to a skyline designed entirely for my portrait. I began to understand why a city was more than a large arrangement of attractive blocks. It also meant that this was not the same kind of evening as placing a few decorative houses. The council could not honestly promise simplicity while handing over a budget. I reduced the proposed monument to a bench, and even that remained conditional on somebody actually having a place to live.

The actual attraction

SimCity 2000 Special Edition offers the classic city-building and management fantasy, with the ability to design a settlement and respond to its needs. The current exact-edition store description includes additional cities and scenarios. It may appeal through nostalgia, long-term planning and the satisfaction of a place taking shape.

The catch worth knowing

Management brings budgets, services, tools and simulation behavior into the same interface. This is a meaningful increase in menu and system complexity, not a default low-demand choice. Check speed controls, pausing, the ability to inspect while paused and the readability of the old interface on the intended setup. The reviewed sources do not establish a special no-pressure mode or hold-free operation.

An opening invitation

Inspect an existing city or an introductory situation and identify one service before building extensively. Decide whether managing relationships between systems sounds enjoyable, rather than merely liking the skyline.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorize the mayor only if planning is the attraction. The monument budget stays frozen until the ordinary neighborhood has something useful beneath its impressive view.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Special Edition GOG listing and official EA title page inspected. Supports city design/management and edition identity; pause behavior, no-pressure modes and present-device control comfort were not verified.

Source 1: https://www.gog.com/en/game/simcity_2000_special_edition

Source 2: <https://www.ea.com/games/simcity/simcity-2000>

P158 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe

The Queue Has Become Longer Than the Official Speech

Edition considered: PC Deluxe edition

I designed a grand entrance and prepared to welcome the first guests with a speech. Tank examined the imaginary queue and suggested that people had come for rides. I said the speech would establish the park's values. Mercedes asked whether one of those values was eventually letting people reach a roller coaster.

The park offered both a visual pleasure and an operational problem. Paths, rides and guests could become a place worth looking at, but the visitors also brought needs and expectations. Shawna wanted to start with something already built before allowing me to design an attraction with six official opening ceremonies. Rosa proposed one comfortable corner with a sensible route through it. I began to see why a prebuilt ride could be a useful beginning rather than an insult to creativity. The first successful improvement might be small. I cut the speech to one sentence, which made the queue shorter in spirit even before anybody touched the paths.

The actual attraction

RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe combines the original park-management game with its two expansion packs. It offers both custom coaster construction and prebuilt rides, alongside the business of keeping guests and finances in order. The pleasure can be a recognizable little park evolving through practical and creative decisions.

The catch worth knowing

Designing rides is only part of the game: management menus, guest needs, money and scenario demands can create pressure. Check simulation speed and pause behavior, exact mouse operations and interface size. The presence of prebuilt rides does not remove the rest of the management system, and this edition should not be credited with modes from later RollerCoaster Tycoon releases.

An opening invitation

Inspect an opening park or scenario and locate one prebuilt attraction in the interface. Evaluate whether the management surrounding construction feels interesting before committing to a large custom coaster.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve a park for someone who enjoys designing a place and managing its consequences. My welcoming speech must remain shorter than the path to the first ride.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/285310/>

P159 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Theme Hospital

The Administrator Has Bought a Fountain Instead of a Sensible Floor Plan

Edition considered: 1997 PC original

I proposed improving institutional confidence with a spectacular entrance. Shawna asked whether the building's actual rooms were ready. I said the fountain would communicate readiness. Tank said it would communicate water, and only if we had remembered the pipe. Theme Hospital's absurd institution seemed likely to understand the gap between official ambition and everyday operations. Mercedes was interested in the satire but declined any attempt to turn the evening into a real discussion of medical experiences. Rosa agreed: the joke could stay on ridiculous management, especially mine. We imagined the consequences of making a decorative decision while the useful work waited. It was an uncomfortable mirror, although a funny one. I moved the fountain down the plan. Shawna moved it off the plan. Tank suggested replacing it with a sign reading THE ADMINISTRATOR HAS BEEN ASKED TO CONSIDER OTHER PEOPLE. I objected to the length, then recognized that reducing the message would probably make it about me again.

The actual attraction

Bullfrog's original Theme Hospital is a comic management game about designing and running an institution with limited resources. The official EA page emphasizes building, maintaining and managing the hospital while balancing cash and its exaggerated fictional problems. Its appeal is institutional satire and operational tinkering, rather than a rich personal adventure.

The catch worth knowing

Staff, rooms, resources and developing demands can make this a busy management choice. Its comic visual style does not remove time pressure or menu work. Check pausing, speed behavior, readable text and the exact mouse controls before assuming a relaxed setup is possible. The humor includes exaggerated illnesses and death, which may simply be the wrong subject for an enjoyable evening.

An opening invitation

Inspect the early building and management interface without committing to an elaborate plan. Decide whether its subject and overlapping responsibilities are appealing before taking on the continuing simulation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit the satire only when its subject is welcome. Reject the fountain until the administrator can explain what useful problem it is supposed to solve.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official EA page identifies Bullfrog's original 1997 Theme Hospital and building/management with limited resources. The automatic Steam hit was unrelated DLC and is excluded. Exact pause/hold behavior remains to be checked.

Source 1: <https://www.ea.com/games/theme/theme-hospital>

P160 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Zoombinis

The Travellers Have Asked Me to Stop Improving Their Names

Edition considered: 2015 PC remake of Logical Journey of the Zoombinis

A group of small blue travellers needed a way forward. I offered a full naming convention, complete with reference numbers and an organizational chart. Rosa said they already had enough to deal with. Tank suggested that helping them through the actual puzzle would be a more convincing welcome.

The old logic-journey idea had an honest attraction: notice a pattern, make a choice, see whether the group could continue. Mercedes wanted the childhood-adventure presentation described plainly so nostalgia could do its own work. Shawna pointed out that an inviting cartoon could still contain a serious rule to figure out. I agreed to stop confusing appearance with difficulty in either direction. Some evenings might welcome these peculiar travellers; others might want a human mystery with complicated motives. Neither preference required a hearing. I retired the naming chart and concentrated on the route. The travellers retained their own identities, and the department was spared an unnecessary argument over whether a person could be filed under Blue.

The actual attraction

This is the 2015 remake of Logical Journey of the Zoombinis, a cartoon adventure built around pattern and logic puzzles. The developer describes twelve puzzle types with several difficulty levels as the travellers seek a new home. It may appeal through nostalgic character, rule discovery and a sequence of distinct reasoning tasks.

The catch worth knowing

The child-oriented presentation is a real taste consideration, especially when the desired experience is a grown-up character story. Logic difficulty can increase independently of that appearance. Check the specific puzzle's clicking, dragging, penalties and timing; the store description does not establish a universally untimed or hold-free route. This entry refers to the remake, not every older edition or platform version.

An opening invitation

Try one early puzzle and explain the pattern you think matters. Check whether helping these characters feels charming before investing in harder levels or the larger journey.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve the travellers if their particular charm is wanted. The department has no authority to replace personal taste with nostalgia or a compulsory naming system.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/397430/>

The Last Compartment

By the end of the department's review, the cabinet contained fewer things than I had intended and more things we could actually find. The gold stamp had a small space of its own. The red stapler sat where a hand could reach it. The binder had become several manageable volumes. Tank opened the door and closed it again without holding the entire structure steady, which I described as a major infrastructure milestone. He described it as a cabinet.

We did not finish every puzzle in order to justify their existence. Some pages made somebody curious immediately. Others revealed a catch that settled the choice just as usefully. A drag could be unwelcome. A dense logic board could be exactly the right invitation. A beautifully told mystery could still include timing that ruled it out for a particular evening. The point of the collection was to make those differences visible before my enthusiasm tried to run over them with a ceremonial trolley.

Mercedes chose a page because she liked the premise, then checked the burden before considering the first action. Rosa set the tea where nobody had to reach across the book. Shawna left a blank line beside an unresolved control question. Tank put the spare fittings in a small bag and wrote CABINET on it. I admired the economy of that label while privately considering whether Cabinet Affairs would sound more established.

There was one compartment left. I proposed reserving it for future expansion. Mercedes suggested leaving it empty until something worth keeping appeared. This felt dangerously unambitious until I noticed how calm the shelf looked without a speculative monument to my plans. An empty place was not a failure to choose. It was room for the next thing that actually appealed.

I put away the final form. Nobody had signed it, and nothing important had gone wrong. The guest could pick a puzzle, return to a story, try a creative toy, or close the book. The cabinet did not award points for finishing its contents. Neither, after a brief and unsuccessful attempt to add a scoring drawer, did I. Tank shut the door. For once the department's most convincing achievement was that everything useful remained easy to reach.

An index with no authority over you

The case number works in every format. The last column is this volume's printed page. Click a title in the PDF to jump to it.

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 5 OF SIX

The Office of People Who Have Something to Tell You

Character stories, dialogue and consequential choices

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 5. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P161	P162	P163	P164	P165	P166	P167	P168
2. Ready for conversation	P169	P170	P171	P172	P173	P174	P175	P176
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P177	P178	P179	P180	P181	P182	P183	P184
4. Here for the atmosphere	P185	P186	P187	P188	P189	P190	P191	P192
5. Open to a wildcard	P193	P194	P195	P196	P197	P198	P199	P200

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Listening Fee Nobody Agreed To

I opened the Office of People Who Have Something to Tell You with a gold microphone, six upholstered chairs, and a sign that said I UNDERSTAND. The sign cost more than the chairs. That was deliberate. A chair supports one person. My understanding was intended to support an entire market.

Shawna arrived carrying the enormous game binder against her hip. The spine had developed the soft, defeated curve of a man asked to attend another meeting. She set it on the table. One chair rose half an inch. Tank caught the coffee before my administration could baptize its own documents.

“Why is there a microphone?” Shawna asked.

“So nobody feels unheard.”

She touched the switch. My voice came out of a speaker in the bathroom.

“They hear you flushing,” Tank said.

I explained that this was a pilot arrangement. Mercedes explained that every arrangement I did not understand was apparently a pilot, and that I should stop allowing aircraft into the furniture budget. Rosa unplugged the speaker. Instantly the room became capable of conversation.

The proposal was simple. People in these games had jobs, friends, secrets, ambitions, terrible employers, and requests that did not fit into a yes-or-no box. We would listen. We would notice whose company felt interesting. We would find a story worth sitting inside. I had expanded that proposal into a department with a Director of Emotional Weather because a title that good should not have to wait for an actual vacancy.

Rosa read the first sheet. “You have charged a handling fee for feelings.”

“Fictional fee.”

“It has your bank details.”

“Fictional ambition.”

She drew one line through the amount and another through the account number. I admired her commitment to clarity even as she dismantled my retirement. Then she placed a bowl of oranges where the invoice tray had been. Everybody understood the new system immediately. You took an orange. You could talk. You could also remain completely quiet, an option my draft had neglected to monetize.

Mercedes sat in the chair facing the window. “Some of these stories are sad.”

“We have tissues.”

“That isn't a recommendation.”

She was right. A box of tissues did not make every story the right company for every evening. A game about grief might be welcome because it took grief seriously. On another evening the same game might feel like somebody delivering a piano through your chest. The reader got to decide. My stamp, though gold and offensively heavy, could not settle the matter.

Tank opened the binder at a page covered in resource bars. “This one wants me to manage food.”

“Narrative food.”

“I'm already managing real food. Rosa got the last orange.”

Here was the second distinction I had tried to bury beneath stationery: a game could wait for a decision and still make that decision feel pressured. A calendar, a dwindling supply, a political bargain, a friendship with consequences - none required quick fingers to produce a tight stomach. We needed to say what the demands actually were. We also needed to let a perfectly good game remain a perfectly good game that somebody did not want tonight.

Shawna moved my microphone to the end of the table. "And a lot of reading is still a lot of reading."

I put that on the board. Under it I wrote NO EXAM AFTERWARD. Tank added UNLESS AIDEN HAS LOST HIS KEYS AGAIN. The keys were in my pocket. I made a point of finding them silently.

The reader's chair was not at the end of the table beneath the seal. Rosa put it wherever the reader wanted. Mercedes turned the screen so other people could follow without leaning across whoever held the controls. We agreed that a shared story did not automatically become a multiplayer game. Sometimes one person clicked while the others offered theories. Sometimes everybody shut up so a line could land. Sometimes the best contribution was bringing water and not explaining the joke.

I tried the microphone again. Nothing happened. I checked the cord, the switch, the speaker, and the magnificent little green light. Shawna watched me conduct a full technical inquiry.

"It's unplugged," she said.

"I know."

"Then why keep talking into it?"

Because, privately, I had been hoping my position would supply electricity.

We opened the first page without amplification. The tiny red stapler rested beside the oranges. For once it was not holding together a policy. It was keeping the window from knocking shut.

P161 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Coffee Talk

The Espresso Machine Requests a Confidentiality Agreement

Edition considered: PC first game

I installed a velvet rope around the coffee machine because the first game concerned intimate conversations, and intimacy deserved a premium entrance. Tank walked around the rope to reach the sugar. That exposed a structural weakness in my business model.

“You're supposed to tell me your problem first,” I said. “Then I prepare the appropriate drink.”

“My problem is a rope in front of the sugar.”

Shawna watched me remove it. On the screen, Coffee Talk offered a counter in an alternate Seattle where fantasy people had recognizable troubles. I immediately proposed separate departments for elves, orcs, and people who ordered something complicated. Rosa replaced all three signs with CUSTOMERS.

I brewed a cup of real coffee and began explaining how its bitterness represented the customer's journey. Mercedes tasted it. “It represents you forgetting the water.” She made another pot while I listened to a fictional conversation that managed, without a velvet rope, to be interesting. The office's first successful intervention was letting somebody else use the kitchen.

The actual attraction

Coffee Talk makes a café counter into a place to get to know recurring people. The fantasy setting puts a fresh surface on work, romance, identity, and belonging. Serving drinks influences story branches; the appeal is noticing a person's request and watching relationships develop.

The catch worth knowing

Use the main story with manual text advance; avoid timed Challenge mode. Expect substantial reading and ingredient selection. Drink choices can change story branches. Check the brewing interface and text controls; any decorative latte work is a separate hold/drag question.

An opening invitation

Choose the main Story mode and manual text advance. Serve one early request, then stay for the conversation it supports. Notice whether ingredients add pleasure or interrupt listening; check the exact edition's controls before settling in.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because the guests have interesting lives and my coffee machine has finally been demoted from therapist to appliance.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports the first game's premise and drink-driven story. The identified secondary walkthrough separates the main story from timed Challenge objectives; this is a mode-specific recommendation. Manual advance, brewing and hold comfort still need checking in the chosen edition. The whole-game pace field remains unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/914800/>

Source 2: <https://www.trueachievements.com/game/Coffee-Talk/walkthrough>

P162 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

The Second Cup Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC sequel

When the café returned with hibiscus and butterfly pea, I announced a botanical expansion of the listening office. I put a fern behind reception. It had no duties, but its posture suggested excellent discretion.

“That’s plastic,” Rosa said.

“Then it won’t repeat anything.”

Tank arrived with two cups bearing identical elaborate swirls. I praised his mastery of latte art. He turned one over. It was a saucer. The artistic department had been operating at an angle.

The sequel’s customers already had lives before I entered the room. That offended my instinct to introduce everybody, but Mercedes insisted that catching up was a pleasure of returning. Shawna found me preparing an official welcome speech for a fictional barista who had done the job before.

She crossed out the speech and wrote LISTEN FIRST. I drew a heart in the margin. It looked like a dented radish. The plastic fern declined to comment, maintaining the strongest professional record of anybody I had hired that day.

The actual attraction

The second Coffee Talk offers more café conversations with returning and new fantasy customers, additional drink ingredients, and latte-art play. It suits an appetite for spending more time with this particular world rather than racing through a chain of dramatic reveals.

The catch worth knowing

Recipes and returning relationships can increase the things to remember. The official description includes fluid-simulation latte art, so drawing or held-pointer demands need checking separately. Nothing about the calm presentation establishes a complete absence of fiddly inputs.

An opening invitation

Make an early drink and follow one customer’s situation. Try the art interface only if it interests you; inspect how to proceed if it does not. Decide whether the return feels welcoming or depends too much on previous familiarity.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for an evening when catching up with fictional regulars sounds better than hearing my new employee-orientation speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1663220/>

P163 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

VA-11 Hall-A: Cyberpunk Bartender Action

The Bartender Refuses My Corporate Mission Statement

Edition considered: PC release

I put on a silver jacket to demonstrate cyberpunk readiness. The jacket reflected the lamp into Tank's eyes. He rotated my chair until I faced the wall, which apparently solved both the lighting problem and the presentation.

"I'm building atmosphere," I said.

"You're building a second sun."

In VA-11 Hall-A, the bar's customers carried news of a corporate dystopia into conversations about ordinary life. I designed a cocktail called The Synergy. It contained five ingredients and no clear purpose. Mercedes asked whether it came with a mandatory team-building exercise.

Shawna took over the measuring while I tried to remember whose drink required what. It was a useful correction: running a fictional bar involved an interface and requests, not just leaning against a counter looking expensive. Rosa gave my jacket to the back of a chair. The chair immediately looked more employable. I stopped inventing drinks long enough to discover that the people ordering them were the interesting part.

The actual attraction

The game uses bartending to frame a series of conversations about life in a high-tech, unequal city. Drinks influence which stories unfold. Its attraction is the contrast between large political systems and the specific people living, working, joking, and struggling inside them.

The catch worth knowing

Reading, recipe selection, and remembering customer preferences are real parts of the experience. Sexual conversation, alcohol, and adult subject matter belong to its tone. Check ingredient operations and any mixing or waiting controls rather than inferring simplicity from the visual-novel label.

An opening invitation

Complete one customer order with the recipe information available on screen. Then judge the conversation itself: are these people enjoyable company, and is the bar routine a satisfying rhythm rather than unwanted clerical work?

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Licensed to serve intrigue, provided nobody mistakes my metallic jacket for a required peripheral or a source of useful illumination.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/447530/>

P164 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Red Strings Club

The Pottery Wheel Knows Too Much

Edition considered: PC release

I welcomed the pottery wheel as evidence that corporate espionage had finally developed a respectable arts budget. Tank asked whether I knew how to use it. I assured him that my hands understood luxury.

The clay collapsed immediately.

“Your hands have issued a correction,” Shawna said.

The Red Strings Club combines conversations with bartending, shaping implants, and impersonating voices. I had assumed a game about talking would permit me to delegate all physical technique to my charisma. The little ruined bowl in front of me suggested otherwise.

Mercedes examined my attempt. “What is it?”

“A vessel for difficult questions.”

“It has no bottom.”

Rosa set a plate beneath it. We discussed whether happiness imposed by a corporation sounded like a service or a threat, while my vessel leaked onto a napkin. For once my failure had produced a relevant metaphor. I attempted to claim that this had been intentional. The entire room declined, politely but with excellent coordination.

The actual attraction

This cyberpunk conspiracy story asks what happiness and emotional freedom mean. Its unusual sequence of bartending, implant pottery, and phone impersonation gives those arguments different forms; you manipulate both objects and conversations while learning what a corporation intends.

The catch worth knowing

The store explicitly describes a lathe and cocktail manipulation, which makes pointer precision and held movement significant checks. This is not safely described as dialogue-only. Its emotional manipulation and corporate-control themes may also feel sharper than a relaxed conversation game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first hands-on task as soon as it appears. Determine whether its movement is enjoyable and whether the offered controls work for you. A compelling ethical question is not an obligation to tolerate an irritating interface.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Provisionally admitted because my bottomless bowl has demonstrated why every philosophy department needs a practical spill tray.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/589780/>

P165 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Neo Cab

Five Stars for Not Explaining the City

Edition considered: PC release

I appointed myself the office's mobility visionary and sat in a parked car wearing driving gloves. Shawna held the keys outside my window. Apparently the position did not include access to the fleet.

Neo Cab's Lina makes a living transporting people through an automated city while searching for a missing friend. I prepared a passenger questionnaire with a section called **OPINIONS ABOUT YOUR EXCEPTIONAL DRIVER**. Mercedes used it to shade her eyes.

"What does the passenger want?" she asked.

"Transportation."

"Try starting there."

Tank got in and requested the kitchen. I delivered an unnecessary speech about the future of cities. He got out, walked six steps, and arrived before my conclusion. Rosa awarded him five stars.

The game put conversations, income, and emotional state into the same working life. That was more interesting than my imaginary steering credentials. I took off the gloves and read the next exchange. Shawna left the keys where they were.

The actual attraction

Neo Cab is a visual novel about Lina, a human driver in an increasingly automated city. Passengers become sources of stories and possible leads in her search. Her emotional state affects available responses, giving conversations a connection to the strain of working and surviving.

The catch worth knowing

Do not confuse its driving premise with a promise about vehicle controls: the inspected listing calls it a visual novel and declares a mouse-only option. Money, ratings, and emotion restrictions can still create pressure. Check reading flow and map/menu operations.

An opening invitation

Follow an early passenger conversation through to its outcome. Look at how a mood change affects the next available response. Decide whether that constraint deepens the character or makes the conversation feel less enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a route permit because the passengers have more to say than my glove-based transportation strategy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/794540/>

P166 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Eliza

The Microphone Has Been Replaced by a Script

Edition considered: PC release

I hired myself as the human face of an automated listening service. The face was excellent. The service consisted of Shawna passing me cards from behind a screen.

“Please describe the issue,” I read.

Tank pointed at the screen. “You’re behind a curtain in the dining room.”

The next card said ACKNOWLEDGE CONCERN. I acknowledged it in a voice I believed sounded professionally upholstered. Mercedes pulled the curtain aside. There was Shawna, the cards, and my invoice printer. The entire technological revolution fit on a folding table.

Eliza asks what happens when a human worker delivers words supplied by a counseling system. Rosa made clear that our game discussion was about a fictional workplace and its questions, not a service anybody here was receiving. I nodded and put the cards down.

Without the script, I had to decide what I actually thought. It took longer. The answer was less polished. For the first time that afternoon, it also belonged to me.

The actual attraction

Eliza follows Evelyn as she works as a human proxy for an AI counseling program and reconnects with people from her past. Fully voiced characters and a contemporary setting carry questions about work, responsibility, technical power, and whether simulated care meets real needs.

The catch worth knowing

The subject includes personal distress and the limits of counseling technology. Consider whether that is welcome material tonight. Expect substantial dialogue and choices; verify text pacing and navigation. This is a fictional story, not an instruction manual for supporting another person.

An opening invitation

Read an early work scene and a conversation outside it. Compare the constrained professional role with Evelyn’s own voice. Continue if the contrast makes you curious, rather than because the subject seems worthy enough to require homework.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted a hearing after my automated empathy platform was revealed to be Shawna with index cards and better judgment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/716500/>

P167 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Citizen Sleeper

The Dice Have Unionized

Edition considered: PC first game

I rolled six dice across the table to allocate the afternoon's work. Every result assigned the unpleasant tasks to Tank. He inspected the sheet, then the dice, then me.

"Why does every number mean Tank?"

"Elegant interface."

Shawna rewrote the allocation table while Rosa moved the snacks out of the resource pool. In Citizen Sleeper, dice and cycles shape the life of someone escaping corporate ownership on a space station. I found its distinction between available actions and endless demands uncomfortably relevant to my staffing policy.

Mercedes gave me one die and the printer manual. "Use your opportunity."

The page I needed was underneath the binder. I spent my turn moving it. Tank spent his making tea. His choice immediately improved the station.

The game would wait for an input; that did not make its scarcity disappear. We could think carefully and still feel the pull between a useful job and a person worth helping. My dice system had finally encountered a consequence it could not assign elsewhere.

The actual attraction

Citizen Sleeper turns life on a crowded station into choices about work, friendships, resources, and survival. Assigning dice creates a clear connection between what you can do this cycle and what you care about. Its characters make those allocations feel personal rather than merely numerical.

The catch worth knowing

Steam declares playable without timed input, but the story uses resource pressure and advancing clocks. Several systems and ongoing relationships need attention. That declaration does not verify hold-free controls; inspect dice placement, text size, and the station interface.

An opening invitation

Spend one cycle slowly, explaining to yourself what each chosen action will cost or advance. Meet somebody whose situation interests you. Notice whether the limited opportunities feel engaging or like a second schedule to manage.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved when you want meaningful tradeoffs and can tolerate the dice refusing to fund my entire executive department.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC first game. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1578650/>

P168 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Citizen Sleeper 2: Starward Vector

The Escape Ship Has a Procurement Committee

Edition considered: PC sequel

I unveiled our escape ship using a cardboard box, a kitchen timer, and three chairs. Tank asked what we were escaping. I gestured toward the commission's paperwork.

"You made the paperwork."

"Then I understand the threat."

Citizen Sleeper 2 moves between habitats with a ship, crew, and risky contracts. I appointed Mercedes navigator without asking whether she wanted the role. She navigated directly out of my cardboard vessel. Rosa followed with the snacks. The crew's first joint decision was excellent.

Shawna stayed long enough to examine my maintenance budget. I had spent most of it on a gold captain's plate. She set it beneath a wobbling chair, turning decorative authority into a functioning repair.

Contracts in the game would require preparation and decisions about stress and resources. My fictional command had already illustrated why choosing companions involved more than collecting names. I asked the others whether they wanted to return. They did, on the condition that I stop referring to the living room as deep space.

The actual attraction

The sequel expands the dice-driven roleplaying into travel, crew-building, and contracts across an asteroid belt. A battered ship can become a home, while temporary jobs bring distinct characters and risks. The appeal is making a future through relationships as well as careful decisions.

The catch worth knowing

The current Steam record declares adjustable difficulty and play without timed input. It also describes stress, damaged dice, and multi-cycle contracts: waiting for you is not the same as removing consequences. Inspect the actual difficulty choices before relying on them.

An opening invitation

Learn one contract's objective, available dice, and stress consequences before committing actions. Try a manageable early job and ask whether preparing with a crew adds pleasure or too many interconnected things to track.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Commissioned after the captain's nameplate proved better at supporting a chair than supporting my claim to leadership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2442460/>

P169 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Disco Elysium - The Final Cut

My Necktie Has Requested a Separate Office

Edition considered: PC Final Cut

I arrived in a spectacular tie and announced that the office required a detective. Tank asked what I had lost. I said that true investigation began before the crime. He checked whether I still had the receipt for the tie.

Disco Elysium filled a detective's head with competing perspectives. This struck me as efficient staffing. I already possessed confidence, ambition, and an inner voice insisting that expensive stationery would solve things. Shawna pointed out that none of them could locate the printer's power button.

Mercedes offered to voice my common sense. I objected that the role was already occupied. She waited. The silence established a vacancy.

Rosa studied the tie. "That thing's going to give advice, isn't it?"

In the game, the comedy and damage sit close together; a magnificent declaration can conceal a person in real trouble. I loosened my own tie before reading further. It had begun to feel like an unusually ornate argument I did not need to win.

The actual attraction

The Final Cut presents a dense, voiced detective roleplaying story about a damaged investigator and a politically complicated city. Skills become argumentative inner voices, making character-building part of the writing. Conversations can be funny, cruel, revealing, and unexpectedly tender.

The catch worth knowing

Expect extensive dialogue, skill checks, inventory and character menus, and mature material including addiction and violence. A failed choice can have consequences. The manually checked source confirms the Final Cut edition, but does not certify all interactions as untimed or hold-free.

An opening invitation

Follow an early conversation and inspect one relevant skill explanation. Decide whether the competing voices delight you or interrupt the person you want to hear. Treat the opening as a test of tone as much as controls.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted only after my tie's application for municipal funding was rejected on the grounds that it already consumed enough resources.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app632470 on 2026-09-20, exact title Disco Elysium - The Final Cut. Source supports full English voice acting, skills, roleplaying choices, and mature content. Control and workload judgments remain editorial.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/632470/>

P170 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

NORCO

The Refinery Declines My Mood Board

Edition considered: PC release

I prepared a tasteful mood board for the industrial South. It contained a swamp photograph, a neon swatch, and a note reading ADD ATMOSPHERE. Mercedes looked at it for several seconds.

“Where are the people?”

I had left room in the lower corner, which did not improve my answer.

NORCO's world contains refineries, shops, family memories, strange technology, and people whose lives do not fit inside an aesthetic label. Shawna replaced my mood board with a map of who was missing and why the search mattered. Suddenly we had a reason to go somewhere.

Tank offered a stuffed monkey as our departmental mascot. I tried to give it a security clearance. Rosa took the badge away before I could pierce the fabric. The monkey's refusal to participate made it our most plausible investigator.

We followed the first thread of the story. My atmospheric swatches remained unused. Outside the window, a delivery truck backed up with an ugly practical beep. For once I let a place make its own sound.

The actual attraction

NORCO combines a missing-person search with family history, industrial landscapes, and increasingly strange science fiction in South Louisiana. Its dialogue-focused point-and-click structure invites attention to both particular characters and the forces shaping their world.

The catch worth knowing

The official description also mentions puzzles and fights; do not treat dialogue-focused as proof that every sequence is mechanically quiet. Expect dense imagery, unfamiliar connections, and bereavement. Check each new interaction type and the text/interface size.

An opening invitation

Explore an early location and follow one clue about the missing brother. Pause to decide whether the place feels intriguing in its own right. Inspect the first unfamiliar mechanical sequence before assuming later play matches the opening.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a travel warrant because an industrial landscape deserves more attention than my decorative label reading interesting decay.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1221250/>

The Committee for Leaving a Sentence Alone

By the middle of the afternoon, I had developed a method for responding to every fictional confession. I leaned forward, lowered my voice, and said, “That must be difficult.” It worked beautifully until Tank told me the printer was out of paper.

“That must be difficult,” I said.

“It must be loaded.”

Mercedes slid a sheet toward me. She had kept a record of my contributions. The same six words appeared seventeen times. At the bottom she had drawn my microphone inside a recycling bin. The drawing was very good. I considered commissioning a portrait before I understood the insult.

“Listening isn’t waiting to deploy your sentence,” she said.

I wanted to object on professional grounds. Unfortunately the profession was one I had invented that morning, and its entire training consisted of buying the sign. Shawna took the page and folded it into a small stand for the screen. My empty reassurance was finally providing practical support.

We had reached the games where choices mattered in different ways. Some changed a line. Some spent a resource. Some opened or closed a route. Some simply let you express how a character regarded a thing that would happen anyway. None of these automatically made the others dishonest. The pleasure could be in steering events, in inhabiting a voice, or in noticing a detail that another person missed.

I proposed a universal significance scale. Rosa asked whether I could accurately scale the amount of tea left in my cup. I lifted it to demonstrate. It was empty. She refilled it without comment, which was both kind and a devastating audit.

Tank had found a conversation he wanted to finish. The rest of us were halfway through a discussion of what he should say. He raised one hand.

“Can I hear what they say first?”

We could. We did. The room became quieter than my expensive acoustic panels had ever managed to make it. A fictional person finished a thought. Tank chose a response none of us had suggested. It belonged to his reading of the scene, and nobody needed to win an argument about it.

That gave Shawna the policy she had wanted all day: suggestions by invitation. A companion could read aloud if asked. A companion could keep a note if wanted. A companion could solve a menu problem without taking over the character’s life. If a difficult choice was part of the fun, we did not steal it in the name of being helpful.

I approved the policy with the gold stamp. The ink pad was dry.

“You can just say yes,” Rosa said.

I said yes. It left no embossed border, no seal, no glorious mark that future historians could place beneath glass. Everybody understood me anyway.

Outside the window, the wind changed. The red stapler held. My Director of Emotional Weather had produced less useful weather management than a stationery item with one visible screw.

P171 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Kentucky Route Zero

The Delivery Address Is Underneath the Road

Edition considered: PC complete five-act edition

I took charge of route planning with a map so large that Tank had to stand outside the room to unfold it. Our destination was a secret highway beneath Kentucky. I drew a confident arrow through the middle of the table.

“That’s not a road,” Shawna said.

“It’s a conceptual route.”

“It’s the sandwich grease.”

Kentucky Route Zero seemed less interested in rewarding my navigation credentials than in the people met along the way. A delivery, a debt, a conversation: ordinary things could open into rooms that felt like theater or a dream. Mercedes asked me to stop demanding that every strange image produce an immediate explanation.

I folded the map. It resisted. Tank folded me out of the way and dealt with it properly. Rosa left a small lamp on the table. We read the next scene without trying to turn it into a checklist. The grease mark remained where it was, giving our official route map its only reliable local landmark.

The actual attraction

This five-act magical-realist adventure follows a delivery into a world of strange roads, precarious work, debts, and fragile communities. Its pleasure lies in language, staging, music, and atmosphere. Choices can feel like shaping a performance rather than selecting the correct solution to a puzzle.

The catch worth knowing

Expect substantial reading, ambiguity, and a pace that may feel deliberately indirect. The PC Edition has been manually matched to the assigned complete game. Check movement and text advance; no inspected source establishes every scene as free of held or timed input.

An opening invitation

Stay with one early encounter rather than trying to solve the whole world’s meaning. Notice whether choosing a line makes you feel involved. If the theatrical distance leaves you cold, that is useful taste information, not a reading failure.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted an underground delivery permit because the address is interesting enough to survive my inability to fold its map.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app231200, Kentucky Route Zero: PC Edition; the five-act PC edition matches this assigned game despite title-review flag. Other control and mood judgments remain provisional.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/231200/>

P172 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Night in the Woods

The Reunion Committee Has Been Banned from the Roof

Edition considered: PC release

I planned a homecoming party for myself even though I had only gone to the shop. Tank was instructed to say that I had changed. He said I had forgotten the milk.

“Emotionally changed.”

“Still no milk.”

Night in the Woods returns Mae to a town and friendships that have continued without her. I understood the desire to pick up an old role. I was less enthusiastic about the possibility that other people had developed their own opinions while I was away.

Mercedes took the welcome banner down from the doorway. “It has been nine minutes.”

Shawna pointed out that a story about hanging out could still ask us to move and jump through its town. I had been ready to approve it on the strength of autumn leaves alone. Rosa asked whether my leaf-based assessment included the roof I was now suggesting Tank climb to hang the banner. It did not. We left the banner at chair height and paid attention to the actual controls.

The actual attraction

Night in the Woods offers the company of young adults negotiating friendship, disappointment, work, and changes in their hometown. Its animal characters carry recognizably human conversations, with a mystery growing around the edges of daily wandering.

The catch worth knowing

Movement and platforming are part of its adventure structure, and additional activity types require checking. Do not file it as a static visual novel. Its themes can be bleak, including economic decline and emotional distress, despite the bright designs and frequent jokes.

An opening invitation

Walk through an early stretch of town and talk to somebody who knows Mae. Test the movement before investing in the story. Decide whether the everyday conversations are reward enough for the amount of traversal between them.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally welcomed because a reunion should reveal how people changed, not just congratulate me for returning with the wrong groceries.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/481510/>

P173 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Beacon Pines

One Word Has Overturned the Entire Department

Edition considered: PC release

I wrote a ceremonial sentence for the office: AIDEN WAS WISE. Mercedes replaced the last word with AVAILABLE. Tank replaced it with LATE. Rosa said both amendments could stand.

Beacon Pines makes words into objects that can alter a story's turning points. This was a dangerous precedent for a man who had invested heavily in controlling the minutes. I tried locking the marker in a drawer. Shawna opened it with the handle.

"Security needs work," she said.

The book's inviting appearance did not mean every possible branch would be comforting. That interested Mercedes, who liked the friction between a charming surface and something wrong beneath it. I liked the possibility of revisiting a decision until somebody called me wise.

Tank collected the three word cards and arranged them into AIDEN WAS AVAILABLE LATE. It was both a correction and a workable office schedule. We let the fictional story keep its own surprises while my real sentence remained, at last, supported by evidence.

The actual attraction

Beacon Pines combines exploring a small town with collecting word charms and revisiting branches through a story tree. New words can transform a moment and open different events. Curiosity about how a sentence changes the world becomes part of solving its mystery.

The catch worth knowing

The Steam record declares play without timed input and keyboard-only operation. Branch tracking still adds a memory burden, and the cute art accompanies creepy events. Those declarations do not establish that every control avoids holds; test ordinary walking and menu selection.

An opening invitation

Collect an early charm and use it at a turning point. Then inspect how the story tree represents the route. Continue if comparing possibilities feels like discovery rather than keeping several unfinished stories in your head.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved because the Department of One Carefully Chosen Word has achieved more reform than my complete annual report.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1269640/>

P174 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Mutazione

The Garden Has Heard About My Promotion

Edition considered: PC release

I entered the community garden with a badge reading DIRECTOR OF GROWTH. Rosa asked which plant I had grown. I pointed at the plastic fern. She removed my badge without disturbing its leaves.

Mutazione's gardens and conversations offered a different kind of attention: visit, listen, learn how people were connected, and let a place become familiar. I began a gossip chart with myself in the center. Mercedes turned the paper over.

"You aren't in this town."

"I could be a visiting dignitary."

"You could be quiet for one conversation."

Shawna listened to the musical garden while Tank arranged our actual plants so they could reach the window. One plant leaned away from my badge. I declined to interpret that as a performance review.

The story's community had secrets and pain as well as warmth. It did not need me to certify it wholesome. I sat down, asked Rosa what the real plant needed, and received the remarkably actionable answer: water, occasionally, without a speech.

The actual attraction

Mutazione follows Kai visiting her grandfather in an unusual island community. Conversations, old tensions, and musical gardens sit alongside the supernatural plot. Its attraction is spending enough time with a place that the relationships begin to matter.

The catch worth knowing

Illness, family secrets, and community conflict are central; gentle presentation is not a promise of emotionally light material. Steam declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and save-anytime. Verify those options on the installed version and inspect ordinary navigation.

An opening invitation

Meet one resident and spend time with an early garden interaction. Judge the balance between conversation and moving through the community. If you like it, a note of the next person to visit may make returning easier.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because the garden's useful advice was shorter than my title and considerably more likely to keep something alive.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1080750/>

P175 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Wytchwood

The Witch Has Rejected My Ingredient Spreadsheet

Edition considered: PC release

I proposed a centralized inventory for the witch's cupboard. Everything received an impressive label. The first jar said PREMIUM BOTANICAL SOLUTION. Rosa opened it.

“Dried basil.”

“Branding.”

Wytchwood's old witch gathered peculiar materials and used them to intervene in other people's stories. I admired her confidence until Shawna pointed out that confidence did not collect the ingredients. Somebody still had to go find what the recipe required.

Tank handed me a shopping list. I returned with a notebook, two gold clips, and nothing on it. Mercedes suggested I might be the cautionary character whose moral the witch was preparing to teach.

I defended my procurement philosophy. Rosa defended dinner by sending Tank. On screen, a chain of ingredients led toward a particular spell. I finally understood the actual attraction: making a strange recipe come together. I also understood the possible burden, because my own cupboard still contained seven labelled jars whose contents I could not remember.

The actual attraction

Wytchwood turns gothic fairy-tale errands into gathering and crafting. The witch's judgments give the recipes personality: ingredients are steps toward changing a troublesome situation, not simply collecting for its own sake. The illustrated world helps make each place distinctive.

The catch worth knowing

Expect repeated travel, nested recipes, and remembering where resources come from. The official description includes monsters and overcoming them through tools and spells; do not assume that crafting removes all hazards or movement demands. Check inventory and held movement.

An opening invitation

Follow one early recipe from request to ingredients to use. Notice whether retracing a route is satisfying familiarity or unwanted repetition. The useful trial is the whole small crafting loop, not just admiring the art.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted cupboard access provided the inventory lists actual ingredients rather than my premium names for forgotten herbs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/729000/>

P176 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: real time / native co-op: unknown

Wandersong

The Bard Has Been Asked to Lower the Volume of Leadership

Edition considered: PC release

I declared myself a walking musical instrument. Mercedes said that explained several complaints. Tank asked whether I came with a volume knob. I said artistic expression could not be reduced to hardware.

Shawna closed the window.

Wandersong's bard uses singing to interact with a world full of people and puzzles. That sounded like a strong argument for my continued solos until Rosa noticed the word platforming in the description. I had skipped it because it was standing between musical and adventure.

We tested a simple musical idea at the table. I sang a grand note. Tank moved the orange bowl six inches. I sang another. He moved it back. The system was responsive, but I could not establish what I had achieved.

Mercedes showed me how a response could be a conversation rather than applause. The bard's journey might offer that pleasure, but our invitation still had to account for the movement. I wrote down the catch and, for a historic moment, did it without singing.

The actual attraction

Wandersong builds a characterful adventure around a bard who changes things through music. Its humor, unusual interactions, and emotional story can make singing feel like a way of meeting the world. The official pitch also explicitly calls it a platforming adventure.

The catch worth knowing

Directional movement, platforming, and selecting musical responses are meaningful demands. The developer's broad accessibility language about color and sound does not answer every motor-input question. This is a contrasting option for someone who wants those active elements, not a guaranteed quiet story.

An opening invitation

Try an early singing interaction and a small piece of traversal. Check whether choosing the notes and moving through the space are enjoyable. If either feels like an obstacle, keep the musical premise separate from the actual fit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Invited as a musical detour after the commission confirmed that enjoying a bard does not require enduring my full operatic briefing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/530320/>

P177 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Chicory: A Colorful Tale

The Brush Has More Authority Than the Director

Edition considered: PC release

I took responsibility for restoring color to the office. The first thing I painted was my nameplate. The second was the sleeve of Tank's shirt. He asked whether this counted as environmental storytelling.

Chicory put a powerful brush into the hands of someone following a celebrated artist. I announced that I understood the pressure of artistic greatness. Mercedes asked me to distinguish pressure from the lid I had not opened on the paint.

Shawna placed clean paper in front of me. "Make something."

I spent several minutes deciding what would be worthy of the office. Rosa drew a little orange with legs and laughed. Her orange had already achieved the evening's purpose.

The game could be enjoyed through painting, exploration, and its characters, but a brush meant actual input: pointing, moving, perhaps holding. Two people could paint together locally, which was a real feature and not merely me assigning Tank to clean up. We read that distinction aloud before my administrative imagination found a loophole.

The actual attraction

Chicory is a coloring-book adventure about taking up an artist's brush. Painting changes the environment and supports puzzles, while the story explores creativity and the people around it. The official listing explicitly includes local cooperative painting.

The catch worth knowing

Painting, directional movement, and more active sequences need separate checks. Local co-op does not necessarily give both people identical roles. Inspect brush behavior and the game's actual options before deciding whether the action is welcome; no assumed setting is required by this card.

An opening invitation

Color one small area and use paint for an early puzzle. If playing together, establish who controls movement and who paints. The point is to discover whether making marks feels playful without turning the result into an art assessment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorized because Rosa's walking orange accomplished more joy than my perfect, unfinished plan for the entire color spectrum.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1123450/>

P178 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Rakuen

The Storybook Has Refused My Fast-Track Stamp

Edition considered: PC release

I placed a ribbon across the storybook to celebrate our expedition. Rosa removed it before anybody had to untie something just to read. I called it an opening ceremony. She called it an obstacle.

Rakuen moves between a hospital and a fantasy world through a boy and his mother. Its people had unfinished business that would not become simpler because I had arrived with a gold stamp. I put the stamp away before Shawna had to ask.

Tank set a music box on the table. The tune stopped halfway through. I reached for it with an immediate repair proposal. Mercedes asked whether we could listen to the silence before deciding what it meant.

We did. Then Tank wound it again. It played on.

The game promised a non-combat adventure, which answered one useful question but not every question about puzzles or movement. Its emotional material deserved an equally clear introduction. I replaced the expedition ribbon with a bookmark. It would hold a place without insisting that anybody hurry beyond it.

The actual attraction

Rakuen follows a boy and his mother as helping people in a fantasy world reveals the lives of people around him. Music and character stories connect the two settings. The developer explicitly describes a non-combat adventure with puzzles and dialogue-based mysteries.

The catch worth knowing

Hospital life, illness, grief, and unfinished relationships are central themes. Non-combat does not mean no navigation or difficult puzzle. Check walking, object interaction, text advance, and any eerie sections; decide separately whether the emotional subject is welcome.

An opening invitation

Explore a small early area and speak with one person. Test the ordinary movement and the way information is presented. Continue for interest in the people, with permission to stop before an emotional scene feels like an obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a bookmark instead of a clearance stamp, because a story about other people's lives deserves room to set its own weight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/559210/>

P179 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

To the Moon

The Moon Has Not Approved My Itinerary

Edition considered: PC original release

I prepared a lunar travel package with a window seat and an unnecessarily formal boarding announcement. Tank asked how we would get there. I pointed at the illustration of a rocket. He said the illustration had no fuel.

To the Moon approaches its destination through a man's memories and a final wish. Shawna folded my itinerary in half. "Maybe listen to why he wants to go."

I had written the destination in enormous letters and left the reasons section blank. That was not an excellent document for this particular story.

Mercedes placed a small paper moon against the lamp. It cast a crooked shadow. Rosa left it crooked. We let the game reveal its connections in its own order rather than demanding a tidy account at the start.

I had intended to narrate the journey as an expedition. Instead I found myself paying attention to small objects and conversations. The moon stayed on the table. It was doing better work as a question than my whole travel department had done as an answer.

The actual attraction

To the Moon follows two doctors working backward through a dying man's memories to understand and fulfill his final wish. Its compact story links small details across a life. Music and changing context supply much of the emotional effect.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes a non-combat experience, but movement, searching for objects, and puzzle interfaces remain. Bereavement and questions about memory and relationships carry significant emotional weight. Verify text advance and the particular PC version rather than assuming all ports behave alike.

An opening invitation

Play through an early memory investigation, noticing whether gathering its clues supports your curiosity. There is no need to solve the eventual meaning in advance. Check whether the dialogue rhythm and movement let the story land comfortably.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Permitted to approach the moon only after my itinerary acquired the essential missing field: why this journey matters to this person.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC original release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/206440/>

P180 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Finding Paradise

The Contradictory Wish Has a Perfectly Valid Signature

Edition considered: PC release

I established a department for requests that could not both be true. Its first customer was me. I wanted the largest office and an intimate atmosphere; universal acclaim and complete privacy; help with the binder and sole credit for carrying it.

Shawna opened a fresh folder. “We may need more shelves.”

Finding Paradise follows a life and a wish that resist a simple summary. I proposed resolving the contradiction by choosing whichever half sounded more prestigious. Mercedes asked whether that would help the person whose life it was.

It would not.

Tank brought two chairs rather than the single enormous chair I had ordered. One faced the window. The other faced the room. Rosa said a person could want different things at different times without becoming an administrative error.

I placed my contradiction stamp face down. We listened to the story. The office had not solved human complexity, but it had finally stopped treating complexity as evidence that somebody had filled out the form incorrectly.

The actual attraction

Finding Paradise is a standalone follow-up in the memory-traversing series. The doctors investigate Colin's life and a wish whose apparent contradictions invite a closer look. It offers another character-centered story about how a life can mean more than its neatest explanation.

The catch worth knowing

Expect reading, walking, and attention to details that gain significance later. End-of-life material remains central. The publisher says previous games are not required, but that does not establish identical controls or a complete absence of unusual sequences.

An opening invitation

Follow the first substantial memory scene and identify one question you want answered. Check ordinary movement and dialogue handling. Let the uncertainty be part of the pleasure rather than trying to create a complete timeline immediately.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed under requests worth hearing twice, after my office admitted that a person is entitled to be more complicated than a checkbox.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/337340/>

P181 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Impostor Factory

The Bathroom Has Been Granted Temporal Jurisdiction

Edition considered: PC release

I refused to hold the next meeting anywhere without adequate facilities. Then Impostor Factory introduced a mansion party with a bathroom time machine, and I realized my facilities checklist had been embarrassingly provincial.

Tank inspected our bathroom. “We’ve got hot water.”

“For now. Think bigger.”

Shawna removed the label TEMPORAL OPERATIONS from the toilet before a guest could misunderstand it. Mercedes wanted to know why every impressive fictional building encouraged me to renovate a room that already worked.

The game's murder mystery and absurdity promised a story willing to change its own apparent shape. I prepared a timeline on the wall. Rosa asked me not to reveal anything merely to make the chart look complete. That was fair. A surprising story deserved to remain surprising.

Tank returned from the bathroom carrying the missing printer cable. “Recovered from the past,” he said. I accepted the joke as an official field report, which was the most useful temporal research our office conducted all evening.

The actual attraction

Impostor Factory begins with a strange party and a time-loop murder mystery, then develops into a broader narrative. Its mixture of absurd comedy and emotional storytelling makes it a candidate for someone who enjoys being led somewhere they did not initially expect.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher permits independent play but notes that series order affects the experience. Expect reading, walking, deaths, and disturbing imagery within the mystery. The time-loop premise does not itself verify the absence of timed tasks or unfamiliar input sequences.

An opening invitation

Follow the opening invitation and inspect an early area without looking up the eventual explanation. Check movement and dialogue handling. Decide whether the strange humor earns your trust before committing to the story's later changes of direction.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because a bathroom time machine is the first facilities upgrade capable of retrieving the meeting I wish I had cancelled.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182620/>

P182 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

A Bird Story

The Bird Declines to Complete the Questionnaire

Edition considered: PC release

I created a welcome form for an injured bird. It requested a name, a forwarding address, and an explanation of long-term goals. Rosa took the form away before I could invent a signature requirement.

A Bird Story tells its small tale without dialogue. This left my office's magnificent microphone with nothing to do. Tank suggested putting it in a cupboard. I suggested that silence could be amplified. Mercedes asked me to demonstrate without speaking.

I failed immediately.

Shawna placed a small empty box beside the window, and we watched an actual bird land outside. Nothing in that moment needed narration from the Director of Avian Relations. The bird looked in, considered the binder, and flew away with the understandable air of someone avoiding paperwork.

The game offered a boy, a bird, and a blur of ordinary life and imagination. I sat back. For once I could not improve the experience by selecting a more impressive sentence, which removed an entire category of trouble.

The actual attraction

A Bird Story is a short, wordless interactive animation about a boy and an injured bird. Its small scale and reliance on images make it distinct from the more dialogue-heavy games nearby. The developer explicitly presents it as an experiment, not To the Moon's sequel.

The catch worth knowing

Fewer words do not eliminate movement, interaction, or waiting through a deliberately authored sequence. The child-and-bird story still has emotional stakes. Check the ordinary controls and whether the amount of interaction matches what you want from a game tonight.

An opening invitation

Follow the first simple routine and observe how images communicate the relationship. Let the initial section show you its rhythm. If you want many decisions or extensive dialogue, use that preference to choose another page rather than forcing this one.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Welcomed after the bird established that a complete story can exist without answering any of my unnecessary questions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/327410/>

P183 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers

The Rocket Budget Contains a Line for Goodbye

Edition considered: PC release

I drafted a rocket budget with separate columns for propulsion, heroic photography, and ribbons. Tank asked where I had included the reason for launching it. I pointed at the word rocket. He waited until I understood the difference.

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers follows survivors gathering materials for a space burial. That purpose changed how the work felt. Shawna put the photograph budget aside. Some journeys did not need my face attached to their destination.

Rosa brought a battered tin from the cupboard. It held buttons collected from clothes she no longer owned. Each one had a small story. Mercedes listened while she named them, and I resisted the urge to classify the collection as inventory.

The game would ask us to explore and gather, not merely admire its snow. I wrote that down. Then I removed the ribbon line from the budget. Tank used the ribbon to tie the tin closed, a modest practical task that seemed, in the circumstances, exactly the right scale.

The actual attraction

Rocket of Whispers connects exploring a ruined snowy world with building a rocket to honor the dead. Objects found along the way reveal history as well as supplying materials. The gathering has an emotional purpose shared by the surviving characters.

The catch worth knowing

Expect travel, searching, equipment crafting, and keeping track of needed supplies. Plague aftermath, loss, and saying goodbye are central. The store's single-player description is explicit; two protagonists do not imply two-player control. Check navigation and repeated collection demands.

An opening invitation

Explore an early area and bring back one useful material or discovered story. Notice whether the search feels purposeful or repetitive. A strong emotional premise need not compensate for a gathering loop you do not enjoy.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Given launch consideration because this rocket has a reason to leave the ground that is better than my publicity photograph.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/742250/>

P184 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

The Asteroid Refuses to Sing My Anthem

Edition considered: PC Full Bloom Edition

I commissioned an office anthem so that important objects could announce my arrival. Tank said the printer already made a noise whenever I approached it. That was because I kept feeding the paper in crooked, but the timing was impressive.

Echo of Starsong imagined sounds from asteroids and a journey built around hearing, exploring, and interpreting them. I attempted to demonstrate with a glass and a spoon. Mercedes took the spoon away after the third note.

“The stars didn't request accompaniment.”

Shawna checked the edition. Full Bloom added voice acting, but our language still needed checking; the English interface did not magically turn every voice into English. I had been ready to promise that from the title alone.

Rosa dimmed the lamp so the screen's spaces felt larger. The game's journey also involved puzzles and resources, so we left room to inspect those. My anthem remained unfinished. Space had survived another threat to its silence.

The actual attraction

Full Bloom presents a voiced, visual-novel-style space adventure following Jun and Eda in search of mysterious starsongs. Their journey connects personal motives with conflict, ancient places, and other travelers. Music and the relationship between the leads are central attractions.

The catch worth knowing

The official page describes light puzzles and resource management alongside narrative scenes. English subtitles/interface are listed, while the checked full-audio languages are Japanese and Chinese. Check reading, exploration, and sound-puzzle presentation; the word accessible in marketing is not a complete control audit.

An opening invitation

Follow an early exchange, then inspect one exploration or travel decision. Confirm language settings and whether the sound-related information is presented in a usable way. Continue if the relationship interests you as much as the scenery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Cleared for departure once the asteroid's musical independence was protected from my extremely local concept of a universal anthem.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually opened Steam app1504500 and verified exact Full Bloom Edition title, voice-language table, narrative/exploration/light puzzle/resource description. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1504500/>

P185 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist

My Childhood Has Been Converted into a Deck

Edition considered: PC release

I made a card representing my greatest childhood achievement. It showed me looking magnificent beside a science project. Shawna asked who had built the project. I put the card back in the deck.

Exocolonist turns experiences into cards while a young person grows up in an alien colony. I immediately tried to combine NATURAL LEADERSHIP with UNLIMITED POTENTIAL. Tank laid down FORGOT LUNCH and won the exchange.

Rosa said growing up was allowed to include things that were not achievements. Mercedes added a card called LISTENED TO A FRIEND. Its artwork was simply an empty microphone stand. Everybody understood whom it concerned.

The game could connect relationships, study, exploration, and danger over years, which made the card system more than a decorative score. It also meant a lot of choices and consequences. I stopped promising a carefree childhood simulator. My own little deck had already exposed three unresolved stories and the fact that Tank had remembered everybody's sandwiches except mine, at my explicit instruction.

The actual attraction

This narrative roleplaying game follows ten formative years in an alien colony. Experiences become cards used in challenges, while activities and relationships influence the future. Its appeal is watching personal growth and a larger community's fate affect one another.

The catch worth knowing

Cards, skills, schedules, and branching relationships create substantial system and memory demands. The attractive watercolor setting includes danger, death, and difficult personal material. Inspect challenge rules and content information rather than treating a youthful cast as proof of lightness.

An opening invitation

Choose an early activity and learn one card challenge deliberately. Pay attention to a character whose company you enjoy. Decide whether the cards make your history feel meaningful or add a management layer you would prefer to avoid.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted when a remembered conversation sounds like a better collectible than the gold certificate I printed for my own childhood.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1148760/>

P186 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Growing Up

The Schedule Has Asked When I Plan to Grow Up

Edition considered: PC release

I produced a daily plan for my development. It contained eight hours of influence, two hours of mysterious availability, and a large space marked DESTINY. Tank wrote laundry in that space.

Growing Up offered a much more concrete schedule: activities, skills, friendships, school, and the gradual shape of a life. I asked whether the game would recognize innate greatness without making me attend anything. Shawna said that sounded like a request for a different genre.

Mercedes examined the illustrated nineties setting while Rosa remembered a terrible haircut with surprising affection. I tried to nominate my silver jacket as period evidence. Nobody accepted its historical credentials.

The game had many systems, which might be satisfying to someone who wanted to direct a life in detail. They were not automatically relaxing just because the illustrations were warm. I revised my plan to include one achievable task. Tank pointed at the laundry. Destiny, for that afternoon, had excellent stain-removal properties.

The actual attraction

Growing Up combines a coming-of-age story with choosing activities and developing skills. Friendships and family continuity give the schedules a narrative context, while its nineties setting offers a particular flavor of ordinary life and remembered ambitions.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description explicitly includes aptitude mini-games, exams, daily scheduling, many skills, and varied outcomes. This is a management-rich life game, not only dialogue. Check the mini-game inputs and whether balancing the systems feels enjoyable rather than like another planner.

An opening invitation

Set one early schedule, try its associated activity, and see how a friendship develops around it. Use the result to judge the management loop. There is no need to optimize a whole childhood before deciding whether you like playing one day.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted a developmental appointment after my personal growth plan finally contained a task that could be completed before dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1191120/>

P187 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Volcano Princess

The Royal Parent Has Lost the Activity Form

Edition considered: PC release

I offered to mentor the next monarch. Rosa asked whether I had watered the actual plant. I said leadership involved delegation. She handed me the watering can.

In Volcano Princess, raising a daughter connects activities and relationships to a fantasy kingdom's future. I tried to draft her entire life in advance. Mercedes read the document and asked where the person was supposed to go.

“She's at the center.”

“You've put your crest at the center.”

Shawna replaced the crest with a question: what seems interesting to her? That made our discussion immediately less ridiculous. It did not erase the game's schedules, stats, and outcomes, but it gave us a reason to look beyond winning an imaginary parenting tournament.

Tank found my activity form beneath the gold stamp. I had flattened it so thoroughly that the ink transferred onto the table. Rosa said the furniture was now better prepared for public office than I was. I completed my watering assignment before applying for any more responsibility.

The actual attraction

Volcano Princess mixes a fantasy coming-of-age story with arranging a daughter's activities, studies, and relationships. Different interests can lead toward different lives. The attraction is seeing a character develop through the choices and people around her.

The catch worth knowing

Menus, stats, planning, and multiple activity types are a substantial part of play. The story begins after a parent's death and includes conflict and combat-related training. Inspect each activity's controls and avoid treating the parenting premise as a simple conversation game.

An opening invitation

Choose one early activity and see how its result connects to a conversation or new opportunity. Check the calendar and character information together. Continue if guiding development is enjoyable without needing a supposedly perfect outcome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted for consideration after my mentorship proposal was reduced from hereditary glory to remembering what the person actually enjoyed.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1669980/>

P188 / DETOUR / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Long Live The Queen

The Princess Has Survived My Advice Thus Far

Edition considered: PC release

I placed a small crown on the printer to establish a royal training environment. It jammed immediately. Tank said that was the most convincing succession crisis he had seen all week.

Long Live The Queen asks a young heir to prepare for a dangerous coronation. I offered a simple curriculum: confidence, posture, and advanced waving. Shawna opened the list of actual threats and invited me to reconsider.

Mercedes suggested that a game capable of killing its protagonist should not be introduced with the phrase a lovely princess afternoon. Rosa removed that phrase from my notes so firmly the paper tore.

The attraction here could be planning, discovering consequences, and trying another approach. That was a legitimate taste, but it was very different from wanting an undemanding conversation. I admitted the difference. Tank removed the crown and freed the printer's paper. Our own monarch had survived because somebody learned a practical skill, a detail I added to my curriculum in extremely small handwriting.

The actual attraction

Long Live The Queen makes preparation and choices the center of a perilous royal coming-of-age story. Learning which skills and decisions help the young heir survive can become a puzzle across attempts. It is an option for someone who actively enjoys that kind of consequence.

The catch worth knowing

The official premise emphasizes threats and survival. Skill planning, hidden consequences, and character death make this a deliberate detour rather than a low-pressure suggestion. Cute presentation does not soften the underlying challenge into a guaranteed easy evening.

An opening invitation

Inspect the training choices and follow an early consequence. Ask whether discovering how the system works is enjoyable even when an outcome goes badly. If avoiding punishing decisions is a hard preference, choose another story immediately.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retained as a strategic detour because the printer's brief reign proved that a crown supplies neither competence nor immunity from a jam.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251990/>

P189 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Roadwarden

The Roadwarden Wants a Map Instead of a Title

Edition considered: PC release

I volunteered to connect isolated communities and issued myself a badge large enough to obstruct a doorway. Tank asked whether I knew the route. I said the badge would inspire local cooperation.

“Or get caught on a branch.”

Roadwarden's traveler needed information, supplies, and judgment in a dangerous peninsula. That was an admirable correction to my belief that entering a place confidently counted as preparation. Shawna asked me to name our next stop. I described a mood. She asked again.

Mercedes read a passage aloud and the room became a road, a settlement, a decision about whom to trust. Rosa put the badge down so it stopped scraping the table. The words were doing the traveling.

Choices still used time and resources inside the game. We could read slowly while the fictional journey remained demanding. I wrote the distinction on the back of my badge, making it useful for the first time. Tank approved it as an oversized note card with an unnecessary pin.

The actual attraction

Roadwarden offers a richly written fantasy journey through settlements, roads, and uncertain loyalties. Its text-based roleplaying combines conversation, inventory problems, survival, and discoveries about a particular place. The pleasure is becoming familiar with a world through attentive decisions.

The catch worth knowing

The source explicitly mentions hit points, survival mechanics, and quests restricted by in-game time. Reading at your own pace does not remove that strategic pressure. Expect substantial text and several tracked resources; inspect any typed-response or menu operations.

An opening invitation

Reach an early conversation or travel choice and identify what it costs in the game's systems. Make one decision because you are curious about its result. Judge whether the prose and the management work well together for you.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted road authority only after my badge contained directions instead of another decorative assertion that I was in charge.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1155970/>

P190 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante

The Family Chronicle Has Redacted My Best Qualities

Edition considered: PC release

I began my family chronicle with the sentence AIDEN WAS BORN READY. Shawna asked ready for what. Tank suggested a nap. Mercedes suggested a rewrite. Rosa suggested that I leave enough room for other people to exist.

Sir Brante's life unfolds inside an oppressive order where birth and status carry enormous consequences. My sentence suddenly looked even less informative. I had made a whole life into an advertisement before allowing it a second paragraph.

I tried replacing ready with destined. Shawna took the pen.

The game's journal structure could make choices feel like marks on an entire history. It could also make the weight of consequences exactly the wrong company for a quiet evening. We would say both things.

Rosa handed the pen back and asked for a true sentence. I wrote that I had wanted to sound impressive. Tank nodded. "Now something can happen." It was an alarming amount of narrative progress from a line with no title, crest, or embossed border.

The actual attraction

This narrative roleplaying game follows a life within a harsh fantasy empire. Decisions, learned traits, family ties, and social position shape possible paths. It offers the pleasure of tracing how personal ambitions interact with an unjust and powerful order.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher calls it a hardcore narrative RPG and emphasizes costly consequences, oppression, death, and rebirth. Dense reading and long-term planning are central burdens. Treat it as a deliberate heavy-story option, not a gentle alternative simply because much of the action is written.

An opening invitation

Read an early chapter and inspect how one decision changes a relationship or trait. Decide whether you want to inhabit this society's pressures. You can value the writing without accepting the emotional weight of a full life inside it.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Kept on the serious shelf after my autobiography learned that a life needs actual people and consequences, not just flattering headings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1272160/>

P191 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Suzerain

The Republic of My Extremely Good Intentions

Edition considered: PC base game; Kingdom of Rizia expansion separate

I assumed the presidency of the office with a mandate to improve everything, especially the view of my portrait from the doorway. My first cabinet meeting concerned whether the snack budget should fund snacks or a photograph of me funding snacks.

Rosa voted for food. Tank voted for a chair that stopped making the sound of a submarine dying. Shawna placed three mutually incompatible promises in front of me and asked which one I intended to break. I requested a fourth promise, preferably one about listening.

Suzerain arrived with an entire country attached to the question. My campaign smile suddenly looked like something a printer had produced on its economy setting. People had interests, memories, livelihoods. They were not blank spaces waiting for my inspirational handwriting.

Mercedes removed the portrait. This improved the view considerably. I announced a historic transparency initiative and spent the remainder of the meeting admitting that I had not read the second page.

The actual attraction

As President Anton Rayne, you navigate Sordland's political institutions, economy, international relationships and family life. The attraction is sustained argument: people want incompatible things, and a policy decision can become a personal problem later.

The catch worth knowing

This is a dense reading and decision game with a codex, reports and many relationships to remember. Political violence and harsh outcomes add pressure. The inspected description does not establish every input's timing or hold requirements. This card covers the base game, excluding the Rizia expansion.

An opening invitation

Read the opening political setup and one conversation. Judge whether identifying factions feels intriguing or like an unwanted meeting. A companion can discuss priorities without supplying the supposedly correct ideology.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for the evening you want to interrogate a minister; my portrait has already exercised its right to remain silent.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1207650/>

P192 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Yes, Your Grace

The Throne Has Run Out of Biscuits

Edition considered: PC first game

I built my throne from two office chairs, which gave it twice the authority and an alarming tendency to swivel in opposite directions. Petitioners were invited to approach with any problem that could be solved by a confident expression.

Tank needed a working kettle. Rosa needed the snack cupboard replenished. Mercedes requested that I stop calling the hallway my northern province. I granted all three requests verbally and then discovered that verbal grants do not heat water.

In Yes, Your Grace, a king must hear requests while his resources remain inconveniently finite. I regarded this as a terrible design flaw in monarchy. Shawna regarded it as the beginning of accounting.

She placed four coins beside six requests and watched me arrange them into a more optimistic shape. The coins remained four. Eventually I climbed down from the throne to help with the kettle. Both chairs immediately became more useful, which Tank said was my strongest policy result.

The actual attraction

King Eryk hears petitioners, manages scarce resources and tries to protect his family and kingdom. Small requests sit beside larger alliances and threats, giving decisions an immediate human face rather than reducing everything to an abstract national graph.

The catch worth knowing

Resources run out, requests conflict and family decisions can hurt. The presentation includes strategic preparation and dangerous events; a throne screen is not a promise of carefree play. Verify the controls and pause behavior in the chosen PC version before assuming all situations wait.

An opening invitation

Hear the first petition and look at the resources attached to an answer. Ask whether saying no feels satisfyingly consequential or simply unpleasant. Stop without treating a difficult decision as something you must finish tonight.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Suitable when four coins and six requests sound like a story; unsuitable when you already chaired that meeting at breakfast.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1115690/>

P193 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

Aiden's Search History Requests Legal Representation

Edition considered: PC first game

I demonstrated my new surveillance department by projecting my own browser history onto the office wall. It included searches for ceremonial cape storage, affordable marble that looks expensive, and whether a person can trademark the concept of arriving.

'Strong case,' Tank said.

I explained that these fragments had been cruelly separated from context. Shawna asked what context could possibly improve the marble query. I said architectural ambition. Mercedes said plastic.

Orwell made the exercise less comfortable. A digital trace can be true and still create the wrong picture when somebody chooses which piece to pass along. My department's excellent equipment consisted of a mouse, a projector and an alarming amount of confidence in itself.

Rosa switched off the projector before the cape measurements appeared. I thanked her for respecting due process. She said she was respecting everyone else's lunch. We agreed that access to a detail does not automatically make its use wise.

The actual attraction

You investigate digital records for a state surveillance program and decide what information to submit. The pleasure lies in connecting messages, profiles and apparent contradictions, then noticing how your selection shapes somebody else's fate.

The catch worth knowing

Expect substantial reading, interface switching and memory for names and relationships. Surveillance, terrorism and personal intrusion are central themes. Selecting or transferring evidence needs a direct input check; the premise alone cannot certify mouse-only ease, no dragging or an absence of timed sections.

An opening invitation

Examine one person's available records and identify two details that might mean different things together. Before forwarding evidence, decide whether the ethical discomfort interests you. A companion can compare interpretations while one person operates the interface.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for suspicious document readers, provided my search for a throne-sized lumbar cushion remains contextual evidence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/491950/>

P194 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength

The Department of Technically Accurate Nonsense

Edition considered: PC sequel

After my first surveillance scandal, I established a communications office. Its inaugural headline was AIDEN PROVIDES UNPRECEDENTED SEATING. Underneath sat a photograph of the chair I had finally returned to the kitchen.

'Every word is true,' I said.

'And somehow the sentence is still lying,' Shawna replied.

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength understands that territory: information gains power through its placement, selection and use. I tried writing a correction that celebrated my commitment to corrections. Mercedes crossed out everything except RETURNED A CHAIR.

Tank wanted to know why the public needed a statement about a chair at all. This was a devastating question for an institution with an entire stationery drawer devoted to statements.

Rosa moved the drawer out of the kitchen and asked us to set the table. For once, a useful event occurred without a headline. I privately described it as a successful pilot of our low-visibility domestic infrastructure initiative, but I had the decency to keep that inside my head.

The actual attraction

This second Orwell story places you in a darker investigation shaped by political narratives and information manipulation. It can reward a reader who enjoys noticing how an apparently factual detail becomes a persuasive weapon.

The catch worth knowing

The official description introduces a time-of-day system and decisions about whom to investigate and when. That establishes scheduling pressure inside the story, not a verified real-time countdown or a no-timer guarantee. Expect dense records, unsettling politics and morally compromised work.

An opening invitation

Read the first assignment and inspect how the interface represents time before making several moves. Decide whether tracking opportunities sounds engaging. Discuss one competing interpretation with a companion without assuming the game offers a neutral choice.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

For evenings when a misleading headline makes you want to inspect its footnotes; my chair announcement has been withdrawn.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/633060/>

P195 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Emily is Away

My Away Message Is Longer Than My Visit

Edition considered: PC first game

I prepared for Emily is Away by constructing a nostalgic online persona. My screen name contained three titles, two mysterious numbers and enough punctuation to make it look like a damaged shipping address.

Tank chose Tank. This struck me as an irresponsible refusal to develop a brand.

My away message announced that I was pursuing destiny beyond the limits of ordinary communication. Rosa looked through the doorway and found me searching for a clean spoon. Mercedes suggested a more accurate status: available, but being weird about it.

The game's instant-message window made small choices feel exposed. A short answer can carry all the things somebody is unwilling or unable to say. I began composing a magnificent explanation of why my fictional younger self deserved universal understanding.

Shawna tapped the screen. 'You're supposed to hear the other person too.' I deleted three paragraphs. Somewhere in the abandoned punctuation, a much more plausible conversation began to breathe.

The actual attraction

A simulated desktop and instant messenger frame a relationship across several years. Buddy profiles, changing circumstances and brief exchanges turn a familiar piece of technology into a story about growing apart, uncertainty and what people leave unsaid.

The catch worth knowing

Reading is central, and the messenger presentation includes keyboard interaction that should be tried directly. Do not assume every message is simply a pointer click or that arbitrary typing works identically across versions. Relationship regret may carry more weight than the small interface suggests.

An opening invitation

Choose a screen name and follow the first conversation far enough to feel its rhythm. Check the actual typing demand and text size. The useful question is whether the intimacy of messaging appeals, rather than whether you chose the best reply.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommended when an old away message can summon an entire era; my era apparently smelled of spoon polish and ambition.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417860/>

P196 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

We Know the Devil

The Campfire Refuses My Team-Building Exercise

Edition considered: PC release

I announced a summer retreat for the office. Attendance was optional, although I had already embroidered everyone's names onto a banner reading TOGETHER WE VALIDATE AIDEN.

Mercedes inspected it. 'I opt out of the verb.'

We Know the Devil offered a much sharper picture of a group: three teenagers, a religious camp, and the way choosing closeness with one person can leave another outside. My icebreaker asked everybody to name a leadership quality they admired in me. The room became so silent that the printer's cooling fan sounded like weather.

Rosa took down the banner. Shawna replaced the exercise with a question anyone could decline to answer. Tank made a small campfire out of a battery lamp and some orange tissue paper, because he correctly distrusted my relationship with ceremonial flames.

I sat down without facilitating anything. Nobody applauded. The room improved anyway. It was an uncomfortable discovery for a man who had purchased a whistle specifically for fostering togetherness.

The actual attraction

This visual novel uses a small cast and a threatening camp setting to explore belonging, exclusion and queer identity. Which characters spend time together matters, creating room for conversation about relationships rather than inventory puzzles or navigation.

The catch worth knowing

Psychological horror, religious pressure, isolation and an alarming soundscape are integral to the experience. Light movement demands would not make the subject gentle. The inspected page supports its visual-novel form but does not independently verify every advance input or the absence of all timing demands.

An opening invitation

Read the opening exchange and listen to a short portion of the atmosphere at a comfortable volume. Decide whether this kind of unease is welcome before pursuing a route. Nobody owes the camp a complete visit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted for people curious about an unsettling triangle of loyalties; my whistle is not permitted within camp boundaries.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435300/>

P197 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

A Normal Lost Phone

The Missing Phone Contains Fourteen Pictures of My Elbow

Edition considered: PC release

When somebody mentioned a found-phone mystery, I offered my own handset as a practice case. Its photographs consisted of my elbow, several meals I had forgotten to photograph until after eating them, and a blurry close-up of the gold stamp.

'We can establish one thing,' Shawna said. 'The suspect has never met a camera angle he understands.'

A Normal Lost Phone asks you to reconstruct a life from a fictional device. I started explaining that my contacts list revealed a complex network of influence. Tank showed us the entry for Kettle Guy, which was my own number from a failed repair appointment.

Rosa put the phone down. 'A real person's privacy isn't a party game.' The distinction held: this is a designed fictional investigation, with a story waiting behind its interface. My embarrassing photographs were merely an administrative failure. Mercedes deleted nothing, because evidence of my elbows deserved a fair hearing, however unflattering its composition.

The actual attraction

Messages, pictures and apps form a narrative investigation into Sam's life and disappearance. The appeal is close reading: an ordinary digital object gradually reveals relationships and circumstances that were invisible at first glance.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected Steam page says this game is no longer available on that store as of September 20, 2026. Existing access must be established before planning a session. Expect personal, potentially sensitive material, small interface details and searching across apps; the page does not certify input comfort.

An opening invitation

If you already have a legitimate playable copy, inspect one message thread and test the fictional phone's navigation. Ask whether piecing together a person's circumstances feels compelling, and stop before curiosity becomes an obligation to finish.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Provisionally welcome for digital archaeologists; the committee must first locate the game, unlike my elbow, which is exceptionally well documented.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 523210 identifies A Normal Lost Phone and explicitly states it is no longer available on Steam, observed September 20, 2026. Premise comes from the product description. Existing access, controls and availability elsewhere are not established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/523210/>

P198 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

Laura's Calendar Declines an Interview with My Ego

Edition considered: PC release

For the second phone investigation, I proposed an improved method: reconstruct somebody's life from their calendar. My own calendar contained Breakfast Strategy, Lunch Strategy and an unexplained three-hour appointment called Become Unignorable.

Mercedes said the last event appeared to be recurring.

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story invites attention to the gaps between a person's public routine and private circumstances. I spread coloured cards across the table, certain that enough organisation would make another life simple.

Shawna separated what the records actually said from what I had guessed. Half my impressive diagram moved into the second pile. Tank added a third pile labelled AIDEN LIKES ARROWS. It was distressingly large.

Rosa asked what Laura might need us to notice, rather than what would make us feel clever. That question rearranged the whole table without a single new arrow. I cancelled Become Unignorable and scheduled Listen. Then I removed the alarm, since apparently listening was allowed to continue beyond its appointment.

The actual attraction

A fictional found phone holds Laura's photographs, messages and apps. Following connections between professional life, relationships and social habits creates a story through investigation rather than through moving an avatar around a large landscape.

The catch worth knowing

Expect close reading, app navigation, inference and difficult personal circumstances. The official game site verifies the premise, while a retailer verifies this PC edition; neither settles every control demand or current availability elsewhere. Automated Steam matches were wrong, so those unrelated products are excluded from this card.

An opening invitation

Start by examining the fictional phone layout and a short exchange. Compare an observation with an interpretation, keeping them separate. Decide whether the interface is legible and the personal investigation welcome before following every available thread.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for readers who enjoy understanding a story through its ordinary details; the committee's decorative arrows have been placed on unpaid leave.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official game site anotherlostphone.com is credited to Accidental Queens and directly describes the narrative investigation, phone apps, friendships, professional life and disappearance. GameHouse separately verifies the PC title. Incorrect automated Steam matches were excluded. Neither source certifies full-path timing or holds; checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://anotherlostphone.com/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamehouse.com/games/another-lost-phone-lauras-story>

P199 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut

A Narrator with a Very Suspicious Job Description

Edition considered: PC Pristine Cut

I read the instruction aloud: go to the basement, deal with the princess, trust the narrator. This sounded wonderfully efficient to a man who routinely wrote his own glowing minutes.

Shawna asked why anyone should trust the narrator. I pointed at my official speaking jacket. Tank pointed at the fact that I had named it myself.

Slay the Princess made the dispute much less cosy. A voice can sound certain while the person listening has good reasons to question the assignment. I attempted to restore order with a sentence beginning Obviously. Mercedes stopped me before the second word.

Rosa said we could simply decline an evening of horror. This had not appeared anywhere in my dramatic briefing, because I had been busy choosing the basement font.

I rewrote the invitation. It now described the disturbing material and let people decide. The speaking jacket remained on its hanger, where its claims to moral authority could trouble only the spare umbrella and one exceptionally sceptical moth.

The actual attraction

The Pristine Cut expands a fully voiced psychological-horror visual novel whose branching story turns on what you do, believe and question. Narration, performance and shifting interpretations are major attractions for somebody who enjoys arguing with a story's apparent authority.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly warns of intense violence, gore, partial nudity, strong language and suicide themes. This is a substantial content catch, not a gentle princess tale. Full voice acting does not establish no timed or held inputs; check the exact interface before making that assumption.

An opening invitation

Read the content notice first. If the premise still appeals, hear the initial narration and inspect how dialogue advances. Choose whether to continue for its argument and atmosphere, without accepting the narrator's urgency as your own.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional invitation for people who enjoy a sinister voice being challenged; my jacket failed the narrator-trust examination on sight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified exact Steam title Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut, app 1989270. Publisher description supports branching fully voiced psychological horror and expanded Pristine Cut; developer mature-content notice supplies the explicit content catches. No full-playthrough timing or hold audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1989270/>

P200 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Scarlet Hollow

The Family Reunion Has an Unscheduled Creature

Edition considered: PC episodic release; current completion status must be checked

I arranged a perfectly normal family gathering on behalf of Scarlet Hollow. The seating chart accounted for old grievances, difficult conversations and one cousin who might bring an inexplicable object.

Tank asked why there was a place marked CRYPTID. I said good hospitality anticipated unusual guests. Rosa agreed about hospitality but asked why the cryptid had a better chair than everybody else.

The game combines a funeral visit, strained family ties and a town with deeply unwelcome mysteries. I selected personal traits for my fictional host, starting with Unmatched Charisma. Shawna asked whether a game actually offered that trait or whether I was filling in my own publicity again.

Mercedes chose a chair where she could see the door. I revised my seating chart to include a clear exit for anybody who disliked the horror. The cryptid never arrived, but my aunt's silence about the potato salad developed an atmosphere powerful enough to qualify for its own soundtrack.

The actual attraction

Character traits and choices shape a branching horror mystery around a family visit and a troubled town. Conversations can reveal different details, making personality and relationships part of the investigation rather than merely decoration around clues.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected description lists five available episodes and another major update before the conclusion as of September 20, 2026: this is unfinished. The developer declares no jumpscare and Steam lists play without timed input, but disturbing imagery and tension remain. Neither statement certifies every hold or device.

An opening invitation

Inspect the opening traits and read the first family exchange. Decide whether you want a tense serial whose ending is still pending. A companion can debate impressions while the person playing keeps authority over the actual choices.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted for readers who welcome an ominous family visit and can tolerate a story still arriving; the cryptid gets an ordinary chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description on September 20, 2026 says five episodes available and another major update before the conclusion. Developer states no jumpscare; the Steam category declares playable without timed input. Those are sourced declarations, not a complete no-hold or no-distress certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1609230/>

The Office Closes When the Guest Leaves

I had reserved the final hour for a grand address on the transformative power of narrative. The heading occupied half a page. Beneath it I had written REMEMBER TO BE HUMBLE in letters large enough to be read from the corridor.

Mercedes found it while looking for a clean sheet.

“You scheduled humility?”

“Otherwise it gets crowded out.”

“By what?”

I glanced at the microphone. She nodded as if that completed the paperwork.

Instead of the address, Rosa asked everybody what they actually wanted to return to. The answers were not a ranking. One person wanted another conversation at a counter. Another wanted a difficult political decision precisely because it was difficult. Somebody wanted a strange town. Somebody else had had enough reading and wanted dinner. Nobody had failed the afternoon by choosing dinner.

Tank named one character he liked and one menu he disliked. That was more useful than my twelve-column experience matrix. Shawna wrote the two observations on a small card. We could act on them. We could try a different game, make a short next-step note, or return another day. We did not need to invent a permanent identity for a person from one evening's taste.

I looked at the binder. Forty stories sat in this part of it, and each contained more lives, choices, and complications than any summary could comfortably hold. The book could point toward a door. It could tell you whether there appeared to be stairs behind it. It could admit when we had not inspected the stairs. It could not make you enjoy the room.

That was a smaller job than the one I had advertised. It was also an honest one.

Shawna began stacking the chairs. I stopped her after the second.

“Leave one.”

She waited.

“If somebody wants to keep going.”

We left the screen where it was, the water beside it, and the route note within reach. There was no ceremony of completion. A conversation could remain unfinished without becoming a debt. A game could be abandoned without insulting its creator. The office could still contain an open book after the person who opened it had decided to do something else.

Rosa handed me the sign. I UNDERSTAND still glittered across it in deeply unnecessary gold.

“What do you want to do with this?”

I turned it over. The back was plain white. With a marker, I wrote TELL ME MORE.

Mercedes studied it. “Better.”

Tank added OR DON'T beneath it.

That was the part that made it work.

We carried the oranges into the kitchen. I took the gold microphone with us because it turned out to be an excellent weight for holding down the corner of a curling recipe. My understanding finally had a practical assignment. It did not speak once.

The red stapler stayed at the window until the evening cooled. Then Shawna closed the window, picked it up, and put it beside the binder. Nothing was permanently fixed. Everything necessary remained within reach.

An index with no authority over you

The case number works in every format. The last column is this volume's printed page. Click a title in the PDF to jump to it.

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 6 OF SIX

The Joint Commission for Bringing a Friend

*Native cooperative games, shared puzzles and stories for an optional
companion*

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 6. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P201	P202	P203	P204	P205	P206	P207	P208
2. Ready for conversation	P209	P210	P211	P212	P213	P214	P215	P216
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P217	P218	P219	P220	P221	P222	P223	P224
4. Here for the atmosphere	P225	P226	P227	P228	P229	P230	P231	P232
5. Open to a wildcard	P233	P234	P235	P236	P237	P238	P239	P240

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

Two Controllers, One Astonishingly Bad Contract

I bought a second controller and announced that loneliness had been defeated. Tank asked where the batteries were. I told him he was focusing on implementation instead of vision. He put the controller down. My victory lasted eleven seconds.

The Joint Commission for Bringing a Friend met at the same table that had survived the other five volumes. Survived was the right word. Its legs had begun making small noises of legal significance. The game binder lay across the middle like a bridge that had been designed by a man who hated rivers. Beside it sat the gold stamp, the tiny red stapler, and a plate of sandwiches Rosa had expressly excluded from all jurisdiction.

I had prepared seats for Player One and Player Two. Player One's seat reclined. Player Two's was a folding chair with a sticker that said AUXILIARY.

Shawna peeled off the sticker.

"Everybody gets a comfortable chair."

"The design expresses roles."

"So does a throne. We aren't putting one in the living room."

Tank looked toward the hallway. I looked somewhere else. The delivery men would be informed.

The reader had asked, at various points, whether a game could be enjoyed together. I had heard an opportunity to establish a commission. Those were not the same request. Mercedes made me write the ordinary question on the first page: what would each person actually do?

That exposed a surprising number of differences. In some games, two people each controlled a character. In some, one character had more abilities than the other. In others, players needed separate devices and had to describe information neither could see in full. Some games offered distinct cooperative levels rather than a shared version of the main story. And some had no native cooperative mode at all; two people could still enjoy discussing a puzzle while one operated the controls.

I had labelled all of these TWO FRIENDS, EXCELLENT. Shawna returned the page with the kind of silence that means a document has disappointed a woman personally.

"We need the distinction," she said.

"We have a distinction. Excellent is in italics."

Rosa took the marker from me.

We made three plain signs. Two people controlling the game. Two people sharing ideas around one player's game. A game for somebody who specifically wanted its action demands. The last sign was necessary because friendly art could conceal a lot of running, jumping, aiming, holding, and falling off things. A knitted character could demand excellent timing while looking as if it had personally forgiven you.

Tank recovered the batteries from the drawer marked HISTORICAL RECORDS. The records were mostly spare cables and a receipt for the sign that said I UNDERSTAND. He installed them in the second controller. I watched him perform the practical miracle my announcement had skipped.

"Now," he said, "who's doing what?"

That became our opening question for every shared game. A helpful friend could handle a menu or read a clue, if invited. A helpful friend could also become a second weather system, shouting instructions while pushing the pace. We agreed to describe before commanding, ask before taking over, and leave space for the person holding the controls to make the interesting decision.

Mercedes tested the arrangement by handing me a sandwich.

“Eat this cooperatively.”

I held one side. Tank held the other. We looked at each other for a while.

“This is stupid,” he said.

“Some activities have a natural lead.”

Rosa cut the sandwich in half. It was the first redesign of the day to improve everybody's experience without a presentation.

The native-co-op label would describe a feature, not a social obligation. Nobody owed us a second player. Nobody needed permission to enjoy a game alone. Where cooperative support depended on an edition, a platform, an update, or a particular mode, we would say so. The original Secret of Mana and its later remake were not one interchangeable object merely because their names matched. My filing cabinet had tried that trick with three different insurance policies. It had not survived contact with Shawna.

We also needed to distinguish a first trial from a promise about the whole game. A pleasant opening could introduce later timers, fights, menus, or demanding movement. Our invitation was to test one useful thing: a conversation between players, a room, a small build, a puzzle, a handoff. We were not scheduling anybody's endurance.

I stamped the revised charter. This time the ink worked. Unfortunately I had placed the charter on the sandwich plate.

“You certified the bread,” Tank said.

I turned the slice over. JOINT COMMISSION shone blue across the crust.

Mercedes leaned back in her comfortable chair. “At least that one actually supports two people.”

We ate the unstamped halves and opened the binder. The second controller remained available. It did not acquire authority over anybody by being present.

P201 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Secret of Mana

The Sword Requires Fewer Speeches and More Attention

Edition considered: 1993 SNES original / Collection of Mana on Switch; not 2018 remake

I lifted a cardboard sword and announced that the three of us would restore balance to the world. Tank asked whether balance included moving the binder away from the edge of the table. I said the quest had many layers.

Secret of Mana gave us forests, companions and monsters that did not wait for my speeches. I attempted to negotiate with the first creature by explaining our cooperative values. It appeared unmoved by the committee's mission statement.

Shawna reached for the ring menu. For a moment, the action stopped and we could think. I immediately proposed a subcommittee on swords. She closed the menu before I found a chairperson.

Rosa clarified that playing together meant each person actually wanted to fight, explore and manage the party. It did not mean Tank performed every difficult action while I called it leadership. We set down the cardboard sword and agreed to try one familiar area, with both voices carrying more weight than my heroic introduction.

The actual attraction

The original 1993 adventure offers a colourful party journey with native cooperative fighting once companions join. Its overhead view removes free-camera steering, while towns, equipment, magic and connected areas give the journey continuity.

The catch worth knowing

Combat runs in real time. Original manual instructions include held dashing and charged attacks, plus Y opening the paused ring menu. Original SNES two-player play needs two controllers; a third needs a multiplayer adapter. Collection of Mana supports up to three. The 2018 remake is excluded.

An opening invitation

Enjoy the solo opening together or use an existing shared save after an ally joins. Try moving, opening the ring and one familiar encounter. The second player should choose their own role rather than automatically receiving every difficult job.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional retro expedition for two willing adventurers; my cardboard sword qualifies only as evidence that packaging can develop delusions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo Collection of Mana page confirms original Secret of Mana supports 1-3 players. Original manual text inspected through archival transcription establishes ring pause, held actions and SNES controller/adapter rules. Ally-gated joining follows party availability. No 2018 PC remake metadata is used.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-ca/store/products/collection-of-mana-switch/>

Source 2: https://www.world-of-nintendo.com/manuals/super_nes/secret_of_mana.shtml

P202 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Spiritfarer: Farewell Edition

The Ferry's Emotional Baggage Exceeds My Luggage Allowance

Edition considered: PC Farewell Edition

I designed a passenger ferry with a ballroom, a portrait gallery and an extremely small place for passengers. Rosa asked where anyone would sleep. I pointed to a future expansion marked COMFORT, PENDING PRESTIGE.

Spiritfarer had a better order of priorities. People arrived carrying needs, histories and the knowledge that a journey could end. My proposed Captain's Welcome was seven pages long. Tank used page four to level the model boat.

Daffodil the cat had my immediate respect: excellent presence, no committee membership required. I announced that I would take the cat role and supervise from an attractive ledge. Shawna suggested actually testing what the two roles could do before allocating our entire friendship.

We cooked one imaginary meal and removed the ballroom from the plan. Mercedes kept the window seat. The boat was smaller, more useful and considerably less impressed with me. I found that I could bear this, particularly when somebody passed me the bread.

The actual attraction

Build and travel on a ferry, care for spirits, gather materials and eventually say goodbye. The Farewell Edition includes the expanded character stories. Native local cooperation pairs Stella with Daffodil, giving two people a shared place to inhabit.

The catch worth knowing

Movement includes jumping and gliding; chores, recipes and resources accumulate. The cat's role differs from Stella's. A previously inspected secondary walkthrough identifies Elena's later timed Gold Dragon challenge, so the gentle presentation is not a no-rush guarantee. Bereavement is the central theme.

An opening invitation

Meet a passenger, walk around the boat and try one chore in each role. Check whether both people enjoy what their character can do. Leave the larger building plan alone until the small shared activity feels worthwhile.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

For company that wants to care for a floating household; the committee has denied my application to become Admiral of the Pantry.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam publisher description confirms Farewell Edition activities and local Daffodil cooperation. Prior inspected GuideStrats walkthrough supplies the secondary-source warning about Elena and the timed Gold Dragon; not represented as a developer access statement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/972660/>

Source 2: <https://guidestrats.com/spiritfarer-elena-guide/>

P203 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: yes

Pode

A Rock Has Been Appointed My Publicist

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

I volunteered to play the fallen star, for reasons I considered obvious. Tank volunteered to be the rock, for reasons he said were becoming increasingly obvious to everyone else.

Pode asks its unlikely pair to help each other through a mountain. I explained that a star should naturally receive the larger dressing room. Tank pointed out that we were in a cave and neither of us had a dressing room. Shawna gave my imaginary agent a pebble to sit on.

The interesting thing happened when we stopped discussing which character mattered more. One ability opened a possibility the other could use. My magnificent glow was useless in the wrong place; Tank's patient presence had practical consequences.

Rosa watched us rehearse a route with two salt shakers. 'Try asking where he needs you.' I did. For several beautiful seconds, I contributed without announcing a new era. Then I demanded a commemorative photograph, and the rock declined to comment.

The actual attraction

A rock and a fallen star explore Norwegian-inspired caverns, using different abilities to bring an ancient environment to life and solve spatial puzzles. The Switch edition supports one or two players on one system.

The catch worth knowing

You still move characters through three-dimensional spaces and coordinate their positions and abilities. The store's cooperative and gentle-looking presentation does not prove no held movement, no tricky jumps or no timed sections throughout. The assigned edition is Switch; PC controller requirements are not imported here.

An opening invitation

Try the first shared room and let each person explain what their character appears able to change. Check movement, positioning and the viewpoint before tackling a long puzzle. Switch roles only if both people would like to.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommended conditionally for a pair curious about complementary talents; the rock's refusal to attend my press conference counts as sound geological judgement.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/pode-switch/>

P204 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Stardew Valley

The Farm's First Crop Is an Unnecessary Spreadsheet

Edition considered: PC current release; platform and version must be recorded

I arrived in Stardew Valley with a five-year agricultural strategy and no clear understanding of where I had put the hoe. The first field was assigned to revenue optimisation. The second was reserved for a statue commemorating the first.

Rosa wanted a little garden. Tank wanted to see the town. Mercedes wanted to know why my spreadsheet had already made everyone late for something that had not happened.

The valley contains neighbours, seasons, crops and opportunities to become busy. I interpreted this as permission to run the farm like a minor empire. Shawna placed one seed packet over the spreadsheet and asked what we actually wanted to do together.

We settled on a small patch and a walk. I struggled with the modest scale of our success until a plant became more interesting than my projected margins. The statue remained unbuilt. Several residents benefited from never learning that it had been proposed, which I recorded as a community relations achievement.

The actual attraction

Farming, friendships, seasons, crafting and exploration create a place that can grow alongside a group. The current inspected PC listing advertises online cooperation and shared-screen support, allowing genuine joint work rather than only discussion beside one controller.

The catch worth knowing

An active day, energy, inventories, travel, fishing and combat create different demands. Multiplayer pause behavior must be checked; a partner does not automatically stop the clock. Many recipes and social schedules can turn leisure into planning. Record the actual installed version before comparing features.

An opening invitation

Plant a small patch or take one walk together. Inspect movement, item selection and what happens to time when a menu opens. Avoid choosing a mining or fishing challenge as the sole measure of whether village life appeals.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally welcome when a farm sounds like a place to visit, not another dashboard; my statue may remain theoretical indefinitely.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/413150/>

P205 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Minecraft

The Cathedral Has No Door Because I Began with the Spire

Edition considered: Java & Bedrock Edition for PC; editions need separate control profiles

I chose Minecraft's Creative mode and began a cathedral dedicated to my own surprisingly modest ambitions. Its spire could be seen from almost anywhere. Its entrance could be seen from nowhere, because I had forgotten to build one.

Tank made a doorway. Rosa made a little seating area. Mercedes added a window that improved the building so much I briefly considered calling it my original intention.

The blocks gave us something to discuss that was neither a score nor my architectural reputation. Shawna tried the camera, placed a few pieces and decided that the movement itself deserved attention before we expanded the project.

I proposed a grand opening. Nobody wanted another ceremony. We sat inside the unfinished structure and looked out of Mercedes's window. The view contained a hill, a tree and no explanation of my achievements. I admitted it was rather good. Tank offered to build a plaque saying AIDEN EVENTUALLY FOUND THE DOOR, but Rosa persuaded him that the doorway already made the point.

The actual attraction

Creative mode supplies unlimited resources, damage immunity and flight for shared building. Java and Bedrock both support multiplayer, but they have different compatibility and input profiles. A modest construction can give two people an enjoyable shared purpose.

The catch worth knowing

Moving while steering a three-dimensional view and precisely placing blocks can be substantial work. Creative mode changes survival pressure, not those demands. Official comparison lists controller support for Bedrock, not Java, and split-screen only on consoles; do not plan PC couch split-screen.

An opening invitation

Choose the exact edition and arrange compatible separate-device play if sharing online or locally. In Creative mode, try looking around and placing a few blocks before planning anything large. A wall with one window is an adequate architectural brief.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional building invitation when the camera feels comfortable; all cathedrals must demonstrate a functioning entrance before accepting my name.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.minecraft.net/en-us/about-minecraft>

P206 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Animal Crossing: New Horizons

The Island Has Elected Somebody Else to Relax

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

I stepped onto the island and announced a comprehensive beautification programme. First would come a triumphal avenue. Then a plaza. Then a tasteful plaque explaining why the avenue and plaza were named after the same unusually deserving person.

Rosa picked up a shell and said she liked the beach as it was. Tank found somewhere to sit. Mercedes asked whether my plan included a district where nobody had to listen to a plan.

Animal Crossing: New Horizons made room for collecting, decorating and visiting. I tried to convert those possibilities into a compulsory itinerary. Shawna gently returned the itinerary to the binder, where it could inconvenience only the other paper.

We spent a while looking at things. I discovered a particularly excellent spot for a bench and nearly ruined it by calling it an urban planning breakthrough. Instead, I asked who wanted to choose the bench. The island survived this astonishing decentralisation, and my imaginary mayoral sash was repurposed as a ribbon for the picnic basket.

The actual attraction

Collect materials, meet animal neighbours and gradually arrange an island home. The current Switch page supports up to four people sharing one system and larger visits with separate systems, though these are different ways of playing together.

The catch worth knowing

Crafting, tool selection, storage and repeated dialogue can create menu work. Same-system roles and restrictions deserve a practical check before assuming everyone has identical freedom. The page reflects current updates, so check the installed version; this card does not certify every activity as untimed.

An opening invitation

Walk around, talk to one neighbour and try placing or collecting an object. If playing together, test the specific visiting or shared-system mode and let both people describe what they can actually do. An unproductive beach stroll is a valid result.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising in spirit but conditional in operation: approved for people who want an island, with no requirement to elect me its visionary.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/animal-crossing-new-horizons-switch/>

P207 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Portal 2

The Test Chamber Has Rejected My Motivational Poster

Edition considered: PC release

I brought Portal 2 a motivational poster reading THINK OUTSIDE THE BOX. Tank looked at the test chamber and asked whether I had considered locating the box first.

I proposed that one robot provide inspiration while the other handled buttons, portals and the inconvenient business of survival. Shawna said that sounded suspiciously like our old office arrangement. Mercedes assigned me the next physical task before I could establish a leadership exception.

The pleasure of a cooperative chamber is that two perspectives can become one solution. The less pleasant discovery was that my perspective included repeatedly looking at the wrong ceiling. Tank described the actual panel. I followed his description and, for once, improved the situation.

The poster eventually became a useful diagram on its reverse side. Rosa drew the two portal colours clearly and asked what information each of us needed. We had a plan rather than a slogan. This offended my communications department but worked considerably better.

The actual attraction

The dedicated two-player campaign has its own robots, story and chambers designed around joint portal solutions. Humour and mechanical discoveries make it attractive to companions who like discussing how a space works.

The catch worth knowing

First-person movement, aiming, spatial transformations and coordinating actions remain substantial catches. Steam declares play without timed input, but that declaration is not a tested guarantee that every cooperative manoeuvre avoids urgency or awkward timing. Both camera comfort and joint execution need direct trials.

An opening invitation

Enter the cooperative introduction and test looking, walking and placing a portal before pursuing a complex solution. Describe a location without pointing at the other person's screen. Stop if the camera or required coordination outweighs the pleasure of solving.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional laboratory visit for two people who enjoy spatial reasoning; motivational posters must earn their wall space by becoming diagrams.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/620/>

P208 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Untitled Goose Game

My Public Relations Department Is Two Geese

Edition considered: PC release with two-player update

I hired two geese to improve the office's public image. The first stole my pen. The second honked during the phrase stakeholder confidence. Their invoice, had they issued one, would have been impeccable satire.

Untitled Goose Game gives two players a village in which to collaborate on mischief. I admired the efficiency of a plan that could be communicated through waddling and the removal of somebody else's hat.

Shawna asked whether I preferred operating the goose or telling everyone where it should go. This was a difficult distinction for a man who had recently called a traffic cone his deputy. Tank took the other role and waited while I examined the surroundings instead of rushing the next prank.

Rosa reminded us that only fictional gardeners were available for harassment. My attempt to honk at the actual kettle received no institutional support. Mercedes returned the stolen pen and gave the geese my job description. They appeared fully qualified.

The actual attraction

The updated PC game lets two people play the whole village prank campaign together. Watching people react, coordinating distractions and creating ridiculous little situations can be as entertaining as completing the written objectives.

The catch worth knowing

Stealth, pursuit, object handling and positioning operate in real time. Some tasks require observing routines and acting at a useful moment; held inputs and later time challenges need checking. A charming goose is still capable of making a control scheme demanding.

An opening invitation

Explore the first garden together and try moving, honking and handling one object before attempting an elaborate prank. Agree whether either person wants hints. Enjoy an accidental comic moment without turning every task into a performance target.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted when shared mischief sounds better than shared productivity; the geese have already exceeded my department's annual honesty forecast.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/837470/>

P209 / DETOUR / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Unravel Two

The Leadership Retreat Is Tangled Around a Table Leg

Edition considered: PC release

I connected two lengths of yarn to demonstrate the strength of partnership. Within a minute, one was around a chair, the other was under the printer, and my sleeve had become an unofficial third participant.

Unravel Two's little companions face a more beautiful version of the same practical question: how do connected bodies help each other move? I suggested that I could provide vision while Tank provided traction. Tank suggested that I untie the printer.

The game looked like a lovely invitation to cooperate. Shawna kept the movement demands visible: jumping, swinging, running and finding a route together were part of the invitation too. A soft-looking character did not soften every landing.

Rosa brought scissors for our physical demonstration and asked us to stop turning metaphor into a tripping hazard. Mercedes freed my sleeve. The partnership survived, although its first documented success was allowing everyone to reach the snacks without crawling. I considered commissioning a tapestry. The committee advised against more yarn.

The actual attraction

Two Yarnys work through natural and built environments, helping one another across obstacles. Native local cooperation makes the physical connection between characters a direct shared puzzle, with an emotional story running through the journey.

The catch worth knowing

This is an active platforming game: jumping, swinging, running and reaction demands are explicit. Coordination can amplify frustration when one person wants a slower pace. Its warmth does not establish an easy route through every chase or challenge; check any assistance options in the actual build.

An opening invitation

In an early safe area, each person should try movement and one simple shared traversal. Ask whether being physically linked feels funny and satisfying or restrictive. Do not make completing a chase the admission test for an enjoyable evening.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A deliberate action detour for companions who want movement as part of the fun; the office printer has declined to become a Yarny.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1225570/>

P210 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

80 Days

Eighty Days, Seventy-Nine Hatboxes

Edition considered: PC release

I packed for a journey around the world with one useful coat and seventy-nine containers of ceremonial importance. Tank asked what was in the largest box. I said the smaller boxes needed a dignified entrance.

In 80 Days, routes, money, luggage and a companion's needs make travel a sequence of interesting compromises. My first proposed itinerary involved visiting every city that might appreciate my hat. Shawna calculated that this would take substantially longer than the wager allowed.

Mercedes wanted to follow an intriguing conversation. Rosa wanted to know whether we could afford the next connection. Both concerns proved more engaging than my luggage manifesto.

We reduced the baggage and chose a direction together. Nobody pretended the decision had become certain merely because two people discussed it. I retained one excellent hat and discovered that an unexpected encounter could justify a detour. Tank carried the map, largely to prevent me replacing the continents with a diagram of my personal brand.

The actual attraction

As Passepartout, choose routes and encounters across an alternate-history world while managing Fogg's wellbeing, money and travel. This is single-player storytelling that can be discussed beside the screen; its shared appeal does not make it native cooperative play.

The catch worth knowing

The premise includes a travel deadline, schedules and an in-game clock. The inspected store language stresses continuous time, so do not assume a fully untimed experience or confuse the multiplayer journey feed with joint control. Reading, inventory and route planning are significant.

An opening invitation

Inspect the opening route choices and how time behaves in each screen before committing to a journey. Let the person operating choose whether advice is welcome. One interesting encounter is enough to assess the prose and decision rhythm.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally approved for armchair travellers who enjoy a consequential itinerary; my hatboxes may circle the globe separately at their own expense.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/381780/>

The Friend Who Became a Tutorial

I discovered an extraordinary gift for cooperative instruction. Whatever Tank was doing, I could describe how I would have done it three seconds earlier. This service required no controller and, apparently, no correct information.

“Go left,” I said.

He went left.

“Your other left.”

Tank paused the discussion by looking at me. It was not a pause button; it was a face. The distinction mattered because I had already become confident enough to promise features I had not checked.

Shawna put a small card beside the screen. It read ASK.

“Ask what?”

“Whether he wants help.”

“He clearly needs - ”

She tapped the card.

I asked. Tank said he wanted to try the thing. So I let him try the thing. A door opened. I immediately felt the urge to explain that his method had been broadly consistent with my strategy. Mercedes placed a sandwich directly in my hand. It was a merciful intervention.

Later, in a different puzzle, Tank asked what I could see. I described a shape, its position, and the marks beside it. He compared those with his own information. For once my mouth was connected to an actual function. We made progress by building a shared description, not by making one person into the other's remote-control accessory.

Rosa noticed the difference first. “You two sound like you're enjoying it.”

I wanted to issue a certificate. Shawna pointed at the ASK card. I did not ask whether they wanted a certificate because some impulses deserve to be carried privately until they pass.

We adjusted the room instead. The screen moved so both people could see. A lamp stopped reflecting across a clue. The water came closer. None of that changed the software, and none magically erased a game's real demands. It simply removed three problems I had accidentally supplied for free.

The binder contained some excellent candidates for shared thinking that were still single-player games. We kept that plain. Taking turns at a puzzle could be enjoyable, but it was not the same as two simultaneous characters. Watching a friend play could be a pleasure, but it was not automatically participation. A guest could prefer to watch, offer a theory, take a turn, or go make tea. The room could accommodate all four without assigning ranks.

The red stapler disappeared during this discussion. I suspected theft. Rosa found it beneath my elbow.

“You are the obstacle in more systems than you realize,” she said.

I returned it to its tray. Then I moved my elbow, my advice, and my magnificent self far enough back that the next person could reach the controls.

P211 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: yes

The Past Within

My Future Self Has Misfiled the Past

Edition considered: PC release; two devices required

I offered to be the future in *The Past Within* because I felt my achievements belonged there. Tank accepted the past on condition that he would not be held responsible for anything I eventually did with the stationery budget.

Our two screens did not contain the same information. I began describing a symbol as a triumphant shape of inevitable progress. Shawna asked whether it was a triangle. It was a triangle.

The puzzle improved when I stopped narrating my importance and started reporting useful details. Tank told me what he saw. I repeated it back. For a remarkable moment, neither of us accused the other of having the wrong screen.

Rosa supplied paper for notes; Mercedes vetoed a twenty-page communication protocol. The spooky Vanderboom mystery continued without our administrative assistance. I did, however, send a warning to my future self about leaving biscuit crumbs in the keyboard. The future offered no assurances, which seemed entirely consistent with its record so far.

The actual attraction

Two players occupy different times and exchange information to solve a Rusty Lake mystery. Separate perspectives make describing, listening and comparing observations the actual cooperative activity rather than a decorative addition to a solo puzzle.

The catch worth knowing

This is co-op only: each player needs their own copy, a device and a way to communicate. Eerie imagery and puzzling symbols may be unwelcome. Reading, remembering descriptions and manipulating the interface still need checking; the premise does not establish a complete absence of timed or held actions.

An opening invitation

Set up both perspectives and exchange one precise observation before pursuing a solution. Try any unfamiliar interaction separately. Decide whether the pleasure comes from explaining what you see, and whether either person wants brief written notes.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved conditionally for a pair who enjoy saying what is actually on their screens; triumphant shapes of inevitable progress should first be checked for three sides.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1515210/>

P212 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Kirby and the Forgotten Land

Kirby Inhales My Entire Presentation

Edition considered: 2022 Nintendo Switch original; not Switch 2 Star-Crossed World edition

I had just reached slide seventeen when Kirby inhaled the projector. This was not a feature I could promise from the actual game, but as a fantasy of office reform it held obvious merit.

Kirby and the Forgotten Land offered us an overgrown world and two different roles. I wanted to be the star. Tank wanted to know which role allowed him to get on with the game while I explained that desire.

Shawna put the controllers down long enough to settle it properly. One person could play Kirby, the other Bandana Waddle Dee; the characters were not interchangeable job titles. Mercedes suggested we try both before I established a constitutional monarchy.

Rosa liked the town and wanted time to look around. The adventure also contained fights and challenges. We agreed that the pinkness of the hero was not evidence about the difficulty of every action. My slides were quietly retired. Kirby received credit for a productivity improvement he had achieved only inside my extremely selective imagination.

The actual attraction

Explore three-dimensional stages, rescue Waddle Dees and develop a town between adventures. Original Switch local cooperation adds Bandana Waddle Dee beside Kirby. Nintendo's Spring-Breeze mode gives more health and easier enemies.

The catch worth knowing

This remains platforming and combat. Nintendo explicitly describes timed Treasure Road challenges and abilities involving held buttons, such as charging a hammer or aiming a bomb. The second role differs. The 2022 Switch original is assessed here, not the Switch 2 expansion or upgrade.

An opening invitation

Try the opening area in Spring-Breeze mode if desired, testing movement and each character's basic actions. Check whether both people like their role before pursuing a boss or time challenge. The official page lists a demo, whose current availability can be checked on the console.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional expedition when active movement sounds appealing; the committee cannot legally list projector consumption as an accessibility option.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/kirby-and-the-forgotten-land-switch/>

P213 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Kirby's Return to Dream Land Deluxe

Four Kirbys Apply for the Same Corner Office

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch Deluxe edition

Once I learned we could have several Kirbys, I declared the corner office insufficiently cornered. Four distinguished heroes would require four distinguished views. Tank rotated the table and said the problem was solved.

Return to Dream Land Deluxe gives a group more character choices than my original seating plan. I announced that everyone could choose freely, then delivered a speech about why my preferred choice naturally carried executive authority.

Shawna selected a character before the speech finished. Mercedes selected another. Rosa asked whether the little cosmic traveller needed his ship repaired or merely a committee to discuss the damage.

The actual adventure required moving, fighting and helping. It also offered Helper Magolor, which seemed a better practical resource than my motivational remarks. I tried to appoint myself Helper Aiden. Tank handed me the refreshments and told me I had finally identified a useful role. The ship remained fictional, but the tea arrived at a sensible temperature and without a ceremonial launch.

The actual attraction

The Deluxe Switch platform adventure supports up to four local players, including different Kirbys and familiar companions. Repairing Magolor's ship gives the group a shared journey, while character abilities and separate subgames provide variety.

The catch worth knowing

Floating, fighting, jumps and different move sets remain active demands. Nintendo confirms Helper Magolor for the main adventure, but that does not erase every challenge. The later Magolor Epilogue must be unlocked and has its own action; do not treat all modes as equivalent.

An opening invitation

Use an early main-adventure section to test movement and a character's basic ability. Examine Helper Magolor if helpful. Leave competitive subgames and coordinated team attacks for later, and keep the first shared session free from a completion target.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally suitable for a group that wants colourful action with some assistance; four Kirbys do not require four separate speeches about my chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/kirbys-return-to-dream-land-deluxe-switch/>

P214 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Super Mario Bros. Wonder

The Flower Has More Stage Presence Than I Do

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

I entered the Flower Kingdom prepared to be the most surprising object in the room. A talking flower immediately challenged that assumption. Then the landscape began doing things my planning documents had failed to anticipate.

Super Mario Bros. Wonder seemed determined to make curiosity physical. I attempted to preserve my dignity by explaining every new transformation as if I had personally authorised it. Mercedes asked me to let the surprise finish before taking credit.

Shawna considered the different characters. Nabbit and Yoshis avoided enemy damage, which sounded useful, but the courses still needed moving through. Tank asked whether I understood the difference between protection and the ground continuing beneath one's feet. My recent relationship with the office step stool suggested further research.

Rosa chose the character she liked. We agreed to travel at a pace the group could actually share. I put away the stopwatch I had brought for my triumphal entrance, and the talking flower continued its career without needing to chair a single meeting.

The actual attraction

Side-scrolling courses change in imaginative ways when Wonder effects appear. Up to four local players can tackle them together. Nabbit and Yoshis avoid damage from enemies, and Yoshis can carry other players.

The catch worth knowing

Running, jumping, gaps, moving hazards and coordination remain part of an action game. Enemy-damage protection does not certify an effortless or no-hold path through every course. Character restrictions also matter: Nintendo says Nabbit and Yoshis do not transform with power-ups.

An opening invitation

Pick characters for their actual appeal and try one early course without collecting every optional item. Check movement and jump controls before introducing extra badges. A companion should match the agreed pace rather than racing ahead to demonstrate expertise.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A cheerful conditional action choice when surprises and jumps are welcome; the flower's speaking engagement has priority over my ribbon-cutting ceremony.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/super-mario-bros-wonder-switch/>

P215 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: yes

Tick Tock: A Tale for Two

Two Clocks and One Man Who Cannot Describe a Drawer

Edition considered: PC release; two-device format

I opened the clockmaker's mystery with the confidence of somebody who owned a watch he did not know how to adjust. Tank was given the other screen and immediately encountered information I did not have.

I described a drawer as antique, purposeful and carrying the weight of untold history. Shawna asked whether it was open. It was not. She asked what was on it. I had somehow omitted that part.

Tick Tock: A Tale for Two rewarded the details my dramatic training usually treated as beneath notice. A mark, a position, a sequence: these could help another person. My atmospheric interpretation could wait until we had located the relevant object.

Mercedes established a temporary ban on the phrase time itself. Rosa said either of us could ask for a description again without making it a test. We began to work together. I still admired the watch on my wrist, although it remained impressively accurate about a completely different hour.

The actual attraction

Separate screens hold pieces of an eerie clockwork mystery, and two people combine what they see to escape. The developer describes cross-platform play, so communication rather than a shared physical controller is the central partnership.

The catch worth knowing

It requires two players and separate devices; check the exact copies and setup needed on the chosen platforms. Describing symbols and retaining another person's clues can be demanding. The clock imagery and promotional urgency do not establish the actual timer behavior; inspect it directly.

An opening invitation

Choose the two perspectives and compare one visible clue. Try describing shape, location and order before proposing a theory. Establish that asking for a repeat is ordinary cooperation, then see whether the eerie atmosphere adds pleasure or merely pressure.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally recommended for two people who enjoy exchanging useful observations; my drawer must supply identifying details before receiving another historical monologue.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/790740/>

P216 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker

Captain Toad Audits My Suitcase

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch version

I packed for a small treasure hunt with a ceremonial telescope, three waistcoats and a collapsible lectern. Captain Toad's heavy backpack suddenly seemed an entirely reasonable professional arrangement.

The little stages encouraged looking from another angle. I initially interpreted this as advice to photograph myself from the left. Tank rotated our cardboard model and revealed the passage I had been talking over for five minutes.

Shawna suggested checking the actual viewpoint controls before declaring the adventure serene. There were hazards in these small places; their compactness did not make them imaginary. Mercedes wanted to know what the second player would actually do in the installed version, a question my brochure had replaced with a picture of two smiling hats.

Rosa removed the lectern from my luggage. With fewer things to carry, I could inspect the model properly. The treasure had been behind a folded corner all along. I announced that this vindicated my patient investigative method. Everyone present had a more accurate, less printable description.

The actual attraction

Compact three-dimensional courses invite you to inspect routes, hidden items and mechanisms from different angles. The Switch release includes two-player support, making it a possible shared puzzle expedition once the actual roles and update level are clear.

The catch worth knowing

Camera rotation, hazards, aiming and some moving challenges remain relevant. Nintendo's current product text describes second-player turnip assistance and newer features separately; verify the installed version's cooperative roles rather than assuming identical control. This card excludes VR and separately sold extra stages.

An opening invitation

Explore an early course and rotate the view deliberately before moving near a hazard. Try the second-player role on the actual console. Ask whether discovering a route together feels satisfying and whether the camera is comfortable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional choice for people who enjoy examining a miniature world; my lectern must remain at base camp with the rest of the unnecessary equipment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/captain-toad-treasure-tracker-switch/>

P217 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Yoshi's Crafted World

The Cardboard Scenery Has Filed a Complaint About My Budget

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

I proposed a scenery budget involving imported stone and professional lighting. Yoshi's Crafted World answered with paper cups, boxes and an imagination that made my proposal look both expensive and rather embarrassed.

Rosa constructed a little house from a biscuit carton. Tank made a bridge. Mercedes turned an ordinary lid into a view I would have described as internationally significant if I had thought of it first.

The game let a pair of Yoshis explore a handmade world, including different perspectives on its stages. I became fascinated by what a familiar object could suggest when treated playfully. Shawna became fascinated by whether the aiming and jumping felt comfortable, an equally valid form of curiosity.

We looked at Mellow mode rather than making assumptions from the soft scenery. I then tried to improve Rosa's carton house by adding my initials to the roof. She removed the initials and left the house. This was the strongest architectural review my office had received all week.

The actual attraction

Everyday craft materials become a playful landscape for two local Yoshis. Collecting objects and seeing stages from the reverse side can turn a familiar route into a fresh observation game. Mellow mode gives Yoshi wings.

The catch worth knowing

Jumping, aiming, enemies and movement still exist, and searching for every collectible can add repeated travel. Wings change part of the challenge; they do not prove every input is comfortable or every sequence untimed. Both players should test their controls rather than relying on the handmade appearance.

An opening invitation

Try an opening section, with Mellow mode if desired, and practise one jump and one aimed action. Enjoy the scenery without making complete collection a requirement. Let either player decide that looking together is more pleasant than controlling a character.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally admitted for people charmed by ingenious craft scenery; the imported stone has been cancelled and the biscuit carton promoted on merit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/yoshis-crafted-world-switch/>

P218 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Snipperclips - Cut it out, together!

My Partner Has Trimmed the Leadership Out of Me

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game; Plus expansion separate

I thought Snipperclips sounded like a useful workshop on refining a shared vision. Then I learned the partners could literally cut one another into more useful shapes, and the room became alarmingly interested.

Tank suggested removing my ceremonial shoulder pads first. Shawna suggested removing the paragraph in which I explained why I needed them. Mercedes asked whether we could trim an entire job title.

The actual paper characters needed to overlap, rotate and cooperate. My first imaginary cut produced a shape excellent at announcing an intention and completely unable to perform it. Rosa turned the scrap sideways and found a use for it anyway.

We began asking before making a change. That improved both our puzzle and our paper casualties. I discovered that helping somebody become the shape they wanted was more enjoyable than cutting them into the assistant I had planned. My shoulder pads remained intact in real life, but their annual funding faced an unusually serious review.

The actual attraction

Partners reshape paper characters to interact with objects and solve physical puzzles. The Switch base game includes cooperative play; its competitive Blitz activities and larger Party challenges are distinct choices, not one uniform experience.

The catch worth knowing

Precise overlap, rotation, movement and manipulating unstable objects can take repeated attempts. Some modes are action-focused. The cheerful visual style does not establish no holds or no urgency, and the Plus expansion should not be assumed to be part of the base release.

An opening invitation

Begin with an ordinary cooperative puzzle, test how cutting and restoring a shape work, and agree before cutting the other character. See whether the shared experimentation is funny even when it fails. Leave competitive activities out of the initial trial.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved conditionally for friends who enjoy negotiating a practical shape; my shoulder pads may be discussed, but no physical scissors are authorised.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/snipperclips-cut-it-out-together-switch/>

P219 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Blanc

The Snow Has Covered My Footprint Branding

Edition considered: PC release

I planned to leave a distinctive trail through the snow: confident steps, recognisable silhouette, perhaps a monogram at regular intervals. Tank pointed out that a sensible trail should first help someone find where they were going.

Blanc follows a wolf cub and a fawn through a snowstorm. Their different strengths mattered more than either animal's public profile. I tried to assign one as Chief Journey Officer. Mercedes asked whether the wolf had requested a promotion.

The wordless scenes gave us room to notice weather, movement and the other creature's needs. Shawna tested the actual actions, because two buttons plus movement still meant positioning a body in a space. Rosa wanted both animals to reach their families, not to win an argument about who was carrying the story.

I abandoned the monogrammed trail. We followed the footprints together and let the picture speak. For once, the absence of my commentary seemed like an additional environmental feature rather than a technical failure.

The actual attraction

A wolf cub and a fawn travel through a hand-drawn black-and-white landscape, following their families' traces and using complementary abilities. The PC release supports local and online cooperation, with text-free storytelling.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes two buttons plus movement, but a small button count does not settle coordination, precision, repetition or held movement. Navigation and obstacles still need both players. Separation and harsh weather give the gentle artwork an emotional edge.

An opening invitation

Move each animal through the opening space and try its first useful action. Check whether the viewpoint and character positions are easy to read together. Agree that either person can request a pause or a repeated explanation without apologising.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional snowy journey for companions who enjoy communicating through action and observation; all footprint monograms have been denied on grounds of navigational vanity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1982340/>

P220 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Hidden Through Time

History Has Hidden My Keys in Plain Sight

Edition considered: PC first game

I claimed exceptional powers of observation while standing directly in front of the keys I was looking for. Tank let the claim develop for another sentence before pointing at my coat pocket.

Hidden Through Time offered a less humiliating form of searching: busy illustrated scenes, clues and little objects waiting to be noticed. I announced that I would divide the picture into administrative zones. Rosa noticed something while I was still naming Zone One.

Mercedes preferred wandering with her eyes. Shawna wanted to read the hint carefully. Both methods produced more progress than my proposed Department of Sequential Looking.

We made a rule that anybody could point out a discovery, but nobody had to race. It turned out that sharing a picture did not require inventing native cooperative controls. One person could operate while the others enjoyed the search. I found an object and accepted the achievement with reasonable restraint, which in my case meant a speech shorter than the clue.

The actual attraction

Search colourful scenes for hidden objects across historical settings, using hints and visual detail. The PC game also offers a map editor and community creations, though the initial appeal can simply be one busy picture enjoyed together.

The catch worth knowing

Dense scenes, small objects and repeated scanning may be the main burden. Zooming, panning and clicking deserve direct checks; a hidden-object premise does not establish a complete no-timer or no-hold path. The inspected product lists single-player: shared looking is not verified native co-op.

An opening invitation

Open one ordinary scene and inspect a clue, a small object and the available view controls. Search without a race or a requirement to clear the whole picture. Ask whether the artwork makes looking pleasant before adding community maps.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A plausible shared-screen choice when noticing tiny details sounds enjoyable; Zone One remains under investigation, mostly because I have misplaced its sign.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/524910/>

P221 / PROMISING / camera input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Tiny Lands

The Two Desks Differ Mainly in My Story About Them

Edition considered: PC first game

I presented two pictures of the office and challenged everyone to find the difference. In one, I was pretending to work. In the other, I had moved the pretence three inches to the left.

Tiny Lands offered more charming dioramas and less obvious evidence. We could turn the scenes and inspect what changed. Rosa noticed a small detail while I was constructing an elaborate theory about the political meaning of a fence.

The game explicitly removes a time limit and punishment for mistakes. This left me with no excuse for declaring an observation emergency. Tank settled into his chair and examined the scene from another angle. Mercedes said the little world looked like somewhere a person might actually enjoy visiting.

Shawna checked the rotation and zoom. Those operations mattered more than my assertion that calm scenery guaranteed calm controls. We found another difference. I celebrated by leaving the room exactly as it was, a rare administrative decision that improved its prospects of remaining tidy.

The actual attraction

Rotate and compare miniature three-dimensional scenes to find their differences. The publisher explicitly states that there is no time limit and no penalty for mistakes, making patient shared observation a plausible way to enjoy it.

The catch worth knowing

The scenes still require visual discrimination, zooming and rotation. Check whether the actual camera manipulation uses uncomfortable holds or drags. The inspected description presents a single-player comparison game; shared looking is an informal arrangement, even though Remote Play Together appears among store features.

An opening invitation

Compare one pair of scenes at whatever pace feels pleasant. Rotate once, zoom once and make an uncertain selection to understand the feedback. Nobody needs to find every difference before deciding whether the artwork and observation suit the mood.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising for an evening of small discoveries without a race; the committee accepts that both photographs of my desk may contain the same unfinished work.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Tiny Lands Steam publisher description explicitly states no time limit and no punishment for mistakes, and describes adjustable angle and zoom. Single-player comparison is explicit; Remote Play Together is not treated as proof of native cooperative roles. Held/dragged camera input remains to check.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1354910/>

P222 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

PHOGS!

Two Heads, One Belly, No Agreement About Lunch

Edition considered: PC release

I regarded a double-ended dog as an elegant solution to the problem of attending two meetings at once. Tank regarded it as an elegant reason never to schedule two meetings.

PHOGS! connected our characters through a stretchy middle. I wanted to investigate a distinguished-looking object. Tank wanted to investigate food. The body between us offered a firm critique of unilateral leadership.

Shawna suggested that before pulling, we explain where we hoped to go. This caused a brief silence while I adjusted to the possibility that direction could be negotiated. Mercedes put a little hat on our imaginary dog and said dignity was already a lost cause, so we might as well enjoy ourselves.

The game had worlds of food, sleep and play. Rosa approved of the agenda more than she had approved of any agenda I had ever printed. We practised cooperating without treating each tug as an argument. I still attempted to appoint my end the official spokesperson. The other end barked, and the minutes recorded a tie.

The actual attraction

Red and Blue stretch, grab and bounce through physics puzzles in food, sleep and play worlds. The PC release explicitly supports local and online co-op as well as single-player and shared-controller arrangements.

The catch worth knowing

Two connected heads create funny movement but also coordination demands. Grabbing, stretching, positioning and repeated physical attempts can matter more than the cheerful setting suggests. Check the chosen controller arrangement and any holds directly; shared-controller play is a separate configuration, not automatically the easiest one.

An opening invitation

Try moving toward one object together and agree which head will act first. Test grabbing and releasing before pursuing a larger challenge. Judge whether accidental entanglement feels playful or irritating, and adjust the partnership rather than blaming either person.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional invitation for companions who can laugh at a body with competing lunch plans; neither head receives permanent executive authority.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/850320/>

P223 / CONDITIONAL / directional input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Pikuniku

The Revolution Has Extremely Unreliable Knees

Edition considered: PC release; co-op levels separate from solo story

I arrived in Pikuniku's world prepared to issue a stirring proclamation. My long-legged representative moved in a way that made solemnity practically impossible. Tank laughed before I reached the part about our shared destiny.

The bright setting concealed a more suspicious arrangement than its simple shapes first suggested. I admired a story that could be silly and still have something to say about power. Shawna admired a game that clearly separated its solo campaign from custom cooperative levels, a distinction my brochure had tried to squeeze into a decorative footnote.

Mercedes asked whether we wanted the story or the two-player physical puzzles tonight. Rosa said we could decide without consulting a national strategy.

I attempted a dignified kick during our imaginary rehearsal and knocked my own ceremonial sign over. The revolution benefited immediately from having one less proclamation to read. Tank offered to print a new sign, but only if it said LOOK WHERE YOUR LEGS ARE GOING. I reluctantly admitted this was a useful policy platform.

The actual attraction

A deliberately silly puzzle-exploration adventure pairs peculiar characters with a story about a deceptively cheerful dystopia. The separate local cooperative levels offer a different way to enjoy its physical comedy with another player.

The catch worth knowing

The story campaign is not the same as the dedicated co-op challenges. Movement, jumping, kicking and physical timing can require active coordination. Do not infer an untimed or hold-free experience from the simple drawings or the description's invitation to explore at your own pace.

An opening invitation

First decide whether the goal is shared story viewing or actual two-player puzzles. Try one short movement section in that mode and see whether the comic physics are enjoyable. Leave progress targets aside while testing the basic legwork.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally approved when absurd movement is part of the appeal; the committee recognises LOOK WHERE YOUR LEGS ARE GOING as my first fully implementable revolutionary demand.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/572890/>

P224 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Overboard!

The Murderer Has Requested a More Flattering Alibi

Edition considered: PC release

I boarded the fictional liner with a plan to conduct a dignified investigation. Overboard! immediately complicated matters by making the player responsible for the murder. I asked whether the minutes could describe it as an unfortunate passenger reduction.

'No,' said everyone, with unusual procedural efficiency.

The interesting work became arranging what other people knew, saw and believed. I practised an alibi involving a tea tray, a minor celebrity and a speech nobody remembered hearing. Tank said the absence of witnesses to one of my speeches was the least believable part.

Shawna tracked where the characters were going while Mercedes questioned the story I wanted them to accept. Rosa reminded us that enjoying a fictional schemer did not require becoming one over dinner.

We treated the narrative as a shared puzzle with one person choosing. My final alibi was shorter, better and still deeply suspicious. The gold stamp marked it RECEIVED, which I was disappointed to learn was not the same as ACQUITTED.

The actual attraction

You play the culprit on a 1930s liner and try to escape justice through conversations, lies and manipulation. Characters remember events and move independently, making a replayed situation reveal new possibilities. A companion can discuss schemes beside the single-player screen.

The catch worth knowing

The story gives you eight in-game hours, with schedules and missed opportunities creating pressure. The inspected description does not resolve every real-time or pause detail, so test how the clock advances. Reading, remembering movements and replaying failed plans are central burdens.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first choices and clock behavior before pursuing an elaborate cover story. Discuss one possible explanation only if the player wants advice. Decide whether mischievous replay and moral inversion feel entertaining rather than exhausting.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally suitable for people who enjoy a fictional alibi unravelling; the committee's stamp cannot issue acquittals, refunds or immunity from Tank's questions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1546920/>

P225 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Expelled!

The Headmistress Has Read My Reference Letter

Edition considered: PC release

I applied to a distinguished school using a reference letter I had written myself. It praised my honesty in a font large enough to conceal the missing signature. Mercedes said the application had already developed a motive.

Expelled! places its heroine in a much more urgent predicament: accused of attempted murder, she has a school day to change the outcome. I proposed solving everything by making an excellent impression on the authorities. Shawna asked how that had worked for my unsigned letter.

The game's web of gossip, secrets and remembered actions invited a different approach. Tank wanted to compare what people claimed with what they had actually seen. Rosa wanted us to keep the difference between fictional scheming and real hospitality firmly intact.

I drafted a plan with seven contingencies and no realistic understanding of the timetable. We reduced it to one useful question. For once, the investigation advanced faster after my management document became smaller. The headmistress, had she existed, would probably still have wanted a word with me.

The actual attraction

Verity Amersham navigates a 1922 boarding school after being accused of attempted murder. Conversations, secrets and manipulation reshape the day, offering a replayable narrative puzzle that can invite lively discussion from an optional companion.

The catch worth knowing

One school day limits the investigation, and characters act on what they witness. The official description's ticking-clock language establishes schedule pressure, not a verified rule for every paused screen. Expect reading, route memory and potentially unpleasant choices; it remains a single-player game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the opening accusation and the timetable or clock as presented. Try one conversation and observe the consequence of an action before designing a perfect route. Let curiosity about the characters decide whether another run sounds worthwhile.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally admitted for readers who enjoy a devious school mystery; my reference letter has been returned for an independent author and a smaller font.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2963890/>

P226 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Machinarium

The Robot Has Repaired Everything Except My Reputation

Edition considered: PC release

I offered Josef a management position in our office on the basis that he appeared able to survive being thrown away and still solve practical problems. Tank said this qualified him to replace most of the furniture as well as me.

Machinarium's rusty city communicated through gestures, pictures and mechanical predicaments. I tried to introduce a spoken keynote. Mercedes pointed out that the robots had been doing perfectly well before I arrived with paragraphs.

Shawna examined the puzzle. Rosa noticed what the little character seemed to need. I opened a diagram so complicated that it could have powered a separate industrial district if connected to steam.

The answer required paying attention to the actual scene, a skill I am delighted to endorse whenever somebody else has already demonstrated it. We let one person operate and shared ideas by invitation. Josef continued his adventure. I offered him a ceremonial promotion to Director of Getting On With It, but Tank said the title would only slow him down.

The actual attraction

Guide a small robot through a hand-drawn mechanical city, solving logical puzzles and helping people he cares about. Animated thought bubbles replace long spoken conversations, giving a companion plenty to observe without requiring two playable characters.

The catch worth knowing

Inventory logic, small targets, brain teasers and minigames can become demanding. Wordless presentation does not mean obvious solutions or zero timing. Check the chosen PC interface and any puzzle assistance directly; the inspected source does not certify a fully untimed completion path.

An opening invitation

Explore the opening scene and try one object interaction. Ask whether the drawings and character gestures are appealing even before solving anything. Share a single suggestion only when requested, allowing the player to keep the satisfying discovery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional shared-observation choice when a rusty robot seems like excellent company; my honorary promotion remains unsigned to protect his productivity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/40700/>

P227 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Botanicula

The Seed Has Declined to Become a Strategic Asset

Edition considered: PC release

I gathered five tiny office objects to represent Botanicula's unlikely friends. There was a button, a leaf, a cork, a bent paperclip and the miniature red stapler, which immediately demanded a better view.

Their mission was to save a seed. I suggested a preservation strategy involving branding rights and a five-year growth forecast. Rosa put the seed in a safe dish while I was still calculating the forecast. The practical work had once again been completed behind my presentation.

The little creatures' strange abilities and comic reactions made the world feel alive. Mercedes wanted to click on something simply to see what it would do. Shawna said that was a perfectly good reason, provided we did not confuse delightful reactions with a promise that every puzzle would be effortless.

Tank named the cork Acting Director of Silence. Its performance was exemplary. I accepted a smaller role as observer and found an entire forest of peculiar business that had no interest in my organisational chart.

The actual attraction

Five tree creatures travel to protect the last seed of their home from parasites. The attraction is discovery: peculiar inhabitants, playful animations and inventive sound turn looking and clicking into a sequence of small surprises.

The catch worth knowing

Minimal text shifts the work toward interpreting visual behaviour, finding hotspots and inferring unusual puzzle rules. Some tasks may need precision or repeated attempts; the publisher's broad relaxed-play language is not a whole-game input audit. Shared observation remains distinct from native cooperative control.

An opening invitation

Explore a small area and interact with several visible creatures without trying to clear everything. Check the pointing demands and whether the nonverbal clues feel inviting. A companion can enjoy the reactions without supplying a running solution commentary.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising for someone drawn to curious little creatures and experimental clicking; the seed has no growth targets, and the cork retains its leadership position.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/207690/>

P228 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Samorost 3

My Cosmic Flute Has Become a Parking Violation

Edition considered: PC release

I announced an interplanetary expedition with a flute, a helmet and a certificate proving I was allowed to announce interplanetary expeditions. Tank asked which item would get us out of the kitchen.

Samorost 3 sent a curious gnome into stranger and lovelier places than my equipment inspection had prepared for. Sound, creatures and unusual objects suggested a world to discover rather than a list of achievements to recite.

I blew across the top of a bottle to demonstrate musical insight. Mercedes moved the bottle away from the microphone. Shawna watched the actual game for a pattern instead of treating my improvised noise as a clue.

Rosa said we could linger over one scene if that was where the pleasure was. This offended the timetable I had printed but suited everyone present. We followed a small discovery to another. My certificate was eventually folded beneath a wobbly table leg, giving the expedition its first demonstrably stable piece of equipment.

The actual attraction

A space gnome follows the mystery of a magical flute through alien worlds full of creatures, images and music. The pleasure can lie in interpreting an unfamiliar place together, with one person operating the adventure and another noticing details.

The catch worth knowing

Sound and visual patterns matter to the experience, and some puzzle logic is deliberately strange. Check any audio-dependent clue, hotspot size and object manipulation directly. The inspected description supports exploration and puzzles, not a guarantee of no timers, no dragging or easy completion.

An opening invitation

Visit the opening area, listen at a comfortable volume and try a few visible interactions. Decide whether uncertainty feels intriguing or obstructive. Invite a companion to describe one noticed detail without immediately searching for an external solution.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally recommended for a visitor who wants the cosmos to remain peculiar; my expedition certificate has been downgraded to structural support.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/421120/>

P229 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

LEGO City Undercover

My Undercover Identity Is Clearly Printed on My Badge

Edition considered: 2017 PC release; not original Wii U edition

I went undercover as a perfectly ordinary citizen wearing a badge that read AIDEN, SECRETLY IMPORTANT. Tank advised that the first word undermined anonymity and the other two undermined everything else.

LEGO City Undercover offered disguises, vehicles and a city full of comic business. I was immediately attracted to the possibility of changing jobs whenever the current one exposed a weakness in my qualifications.

Shawna kept our edition straight: the 2017 PC release includes two-player cooperation, unlike an assumption imported casually from another version. Mercedes examined the city rather than my costume and asked whether both people actually enjoyed steering through it.

Rosa wanted a manageable little outing, not a compulsory campaign against every collectible. We agreed on one short objective. I retired the badge and chose a less conspicuous jacket. Tank said this was progress until I asked whether the jacket could carry an embroidered explanation of how inconspicuous I had become.

The actual attraction

Chase McCain pursues a criminal through a large LEGO city, using disguises, vehicles and comic situations. The 2017 PC release explicitly supports two-player cooperation, so companions can participate in the city rather than only watch its story.

The catch worth knowing

Open-world navigation, camera control, driving, fights, jumping and collecting create a broad action workload. A familiar toy aesthetic does not simplify every task. Check split-screen legibility and each controller setup before assuming the shared view works comfortably.

An opening invitation

Try walking, looking around and one simple objective together before driving fast or chasing collectibles. Agree on a meeting place and whether exploration or story is the purpose. Stop when the city's activity becomes more busy than amusing.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional urban action choice for two people who enjoy roaming and slapstick; undercover badges must stop announcing that their owner is secretly important.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/578330/>

P230 / CONDITIONAL / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

LEGO Star Wars: The Skywalker Saga

The Galaxy Has Too Many Menus for My Cape

Edition considered: PC base game

I selected a cape for our galactic expedition and immediately caught it in a chair. Tank said this was a practical argument for droids. I said the incident would not appear in the official saga.

The Skywalker Saga offered an enormous collection of familiar places, characters and conflicts. I proposed seeing everything tonight. Shawna looked at the scale of that promise and asked whether I had confused an evening with a geological period.

Mercedes picked one character she actually liked. Rosa picked a comfortable seat. These modest decisions got us closer to playing than my proposed Comprehensive Galactic Appreciation Programme.

We tried a little movement and a little cooperation. The galaxy still included fighting, aiming, vehicles and more than one thing to remember. I kept the cape off the controller and resisted explaining every reference. Tank remarked that this was the first time he had seen me bring balance to anything without borrowing a spirit level. I accepted the compliment before he could clarify its limits.

The actual attraction

The nine Skywalker films become a large comic action adventure with local cooperative play. Familiar scenes, many characters and places to explore can make a lively shared journey for people who already enjoy the setting.

The catch worth knowing

Combat includes aiming and attack combinations, and the game adds vehicles, camera movement, character abilities and extensive menus. The large scope can overwhelm a simple evening plan. Split-screen comfort and both players' controls need checking; brand familiarity does not remove those demands.

An opening invitation

Choose one starting trilogy and test a small opening section together. Try looking, moving, attacking and selecting a character without pursuing every collectible. Decide whether the shared jokes justify the action load before treating the whole saga as a commitment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional galaxy-sized outing for willing action partners; the Comprehensive Galactic Appreciation Programme has been reduced to one scene and a cape safely on its hanger.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/920210/>

P231 / PROMISING / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

LEGO Builder's Journey

The Monument Is Six Bricks High and Already Over Budget

Edition considered: PC release; Creative mode separate

I began LEGO Builder's Journey by proposing a structure visible from space. Mercedes placed six little bricks on the table and asked whether I could first make something visible from my chair.

The game's miniature arrangements gave each piece a consequence. A small bridge could matter more than my entire monument proposal. Tank rearranged two bricks and solved the physical problem I had been trying to address with a commemorative plaque.

Shawna noticed that the PC release also had a separate Creative Mode. Rosa liked the idea of making a little scene without treating it as an exam. I suggested a tasteful statue of the committee's founder. Nobody asked whom I meant, which was at once gratifying and unhelpful.

We built something smaller: a place to cross and a place to stand. The result did not celebrate me, but it did have an entrance, unlike several of my earlier designs. I granted it provisional architectural approval. Mercedes turned the approval sheet into a backdrop and improved the scene again.

The actual attraction

Small geometric LEGO puzzles tell an atmospheric story through placed pieces and changing situations. The PC release separately includes Creative Mode for free construction and photographs, offering another route when arranging objects is more appealing than solving the narrative.

The catch worth knowing

Selecting, rotating, positioning and viewing small pieces may require precision. A quiet presentation does not prove every placement avoids holds or dragging. This is single-player; discussing designs beside someone is optional shared activity, not verified native cooperative control.

An opening invitation

Try one simple placement and rotate the view before choosing a longer puzzle. Alternatively, inspect Creative Mode and make a tiny scene. Let the person's interest in solving or building determine the mode instead of insisting on story progress.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising for somebody who enjoys a small meaningful arrangement; my monument is postponed until six bricks can survive an independent review.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1544360/>

P232 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Gardens Between

I Have Rewound the Meeting but the Minutes Still Embarrass Me

Edition considered: PC release

I wanted a way to revisit a meeting and improve the moment when I called the printer a sentient strategic partner. The Gardens Between offered time manipulation, although unfortunately only inside its own carefully designed world.

Arina and Frendt moved among oversized objects from their shared past. I proposed assigning every office object a dramatic memory. Tank picked the broken stapler and recalled the day I bought a replacement that was too small to staple anything.

The puzzles invited us to think about sequence: what changes when time moves one way, and what becomes possible when it moves back? Shawna watched the relationships between objects while Mercedes noticed the feeling of the scene.

Rosa said the friendship mattered more than whether we solved everything quickly. The developer's explicit absence of time pressure supported that approach. I rewound my imaginary meeting again and tried saying less. Everyone agreed this was a promising revision, although the printer's alleged strategic status would remain in the archive forever.

The actual attraction

Manipulate time through dreamlike island scenes built from two friends' memories. The publisher explicitly describes a single-player game with no text, speech or time pressure, giving shared observation room to focus on images and sequences.

The catch worth knowing

You control the flow of time rather than simply steering each friend independently.

Understanding cause and sequence can still be demanding, and sustained input to move time needs a direct check. Simple controls do not automatically mean no holds. This is shared thinking beside one player, not native co-op.

An opening invitation

Move time forward and back in the opening scene, noticing one object that changes or interacts differently. Check how the input feels before pursuing a long sequence. Decide whether the visual friendship story gives the puzzle enough emotional interest.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising when watching a small memory become a mechanism sounds appealing; my printer's executive title cannot be removed through ordinary calendar adjustment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description explicitly calls The Gardens Between single-player and states no text, speech, time pressure or complex UI. Time manipulation, friendship and island puzzles are supported. The card retains uncertainty about sustained input and does not equate simple controls with no holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/600990/>

P233 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Day of the Tentacle Remastered

The Tentacle Has a Better Succession Plan Than I Do

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

A purple tentacle announced an ambition to take over the world, and I was forced to admit that the competition for ridiculous authority had become serious. Mine had so far reached only the cupboard above the kettle.

Day of the Tentacle put three friends in different times. I immediately saw a chance to send my unfinished paperwork into the past. Shawna asked whether I understood that this might simply make it overdue for longer.

Tank wanted to know what an object could do in another era. Mercedes noticed a visual joke. Rosa asked whether we could follow one thread without opening every inventory at once. These were all better questions than my proposal to appoint a Deputy Director of Yesterday.

We tried to understand one cause and its distant effect. A funny solution became visible when we stopped insisting that objects obey ordinary office logic. I sent no paperwork through time. The tentacle's world-conquest application remained under review, primarily because it had arrived without the correct stationery.

The actual attraction

A cartoon adventure links three protagonists across time, turning changes in one era into possibilities in another. The Remastered edition offers revised art and audio alongside classic presentation options, with comedy built into the puzzle logic.

The catch worth knowing

Inventories, character switching and consequences across different periods create a real memory burden. Cartoon logic may feel inventive or arbitrary. The source does not establish every timing or hold demand; preview the interface and selected presentation rather than assuming a classic adventure is automatically easy.

An opening invitation

Explore an early room and identify one useful object or conversation. Try switching the presentation if you prefer, then decide whether the humour and inventory handling appeal. A companion can keep one current question visible without delivering the whole solution.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally approved for people amused by consequences arriving centuries late; my overdue paperwork is forbidden from using the time machine.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/388210/>

P234 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Trine Enchanted Edition

The Wizard Has Built a Box Around My Management Style

Edition considered: PC Enchanted Edition

I chose the wizard because creating objects from thin air seemed close to my usual budgeting method. Tank chose the knight. Mercedes asked whether anybody had remembered the actual puzzle before selecting a profession.

Trine bound different abilities into one adventure. I summoned an imaginary box and announced that leadership had provided the necessary infrastructure. Shawna pointed out that I had placed it directly in everyone's way.

The thief could approach a space differently; the knight could handle dangers my splendid box did nothing to discourage. Rosa suggested that roles should follow what people enjoyed doing, rather than whichever title best matched my jacket.

We moved the box. This produced a route, a useful metaphor and the first genuine improvement my magic department had delivered all morning. I offered a speech about complementary strengths. Tank lifted the box again and looked meaningfully at me. I understood that cooperation sometimes meant leaving enough room for the other characters, both on the path and in the conversation.

The actual attraction

Wizard, knight and thief combine different abilities in a fantasy world of physical puzzles and combat. Enchanted Edition supports up to three players locally or online, and the original 2009 release is also included as a separate launcher choice.

The catch worth knowing

Platforming, fighting, aiming and grappling remain active demands, with different burdens by character. The inspected description declares saving options and the store lists adjustable difficulty, but neither establishes a no-reflex or no-hold path. Choose Enchanted Edition deliberately rather than mixing its features with the original.

An opening invitation

In an early section, try each preferred character's movement and one ability. Discuss whether roles feel satisfying before combining them under pressure. A companion should not become the compulsory combat department unless that is genuinely the role they want.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A deliberate fantasy-action detour for a group that enjoys physical puzzles; boxes bearing my departmental logo must demonstrate that they are not blocking the exit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/35700/>

P235 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Pilgrims

The Traveller Has Declined My One Correct Solution

Edition considered: PC digital game; not the board game

I approached Pilgrims with an official sequence of events. First, meet a traveller. Second, assign the traveller a purpose. Third, demand a progress report before the traveller had finished sitting down.

The game preferred play. An object or character might produce an unexpected response, and different solutions could be part of the pleasure. Mercedes tried something simply because it looked funny. My schedule shuddered but remained technically printable.

Tank offered a new rule: if an experiment made us laugh, we were allowed to count it as something that happened. Shawna pointed out that this was not even a rule, merely an accurate description of enjoying a game.

Rosa gave the imaginary traveller a place at the table without requiring a completed objective. I revised my sequence to begin with See What Happens. This was so alarmingly short that I nearly added an appendix. The tiny red stapler, placed on the blank paper, restrained me more effectively than several previous policy committees.

The actual attraction

A playful illustrated adventure encourages trying items and characters in different situations, with multiple solutions rather than one fixed route through every task. Its brief, expressive reactions can be enjoyable to discover with someone watching beside you.

The catch worth knowing

Interpreting unusual responses and managing available objects still requires attention. Test how cards or items are selected and moved; do not assume that a playful interface avoids dragging or held actions. The inspected publisher description presents single-player experimentation, not verified native cooperative control.

An opening invitation

Try a couple of early combinations and watch what happens without demanding immediate progress. Check whether manipulating the items feels comfortable. A companion can suggest an experiment, but the person playing gets to choose which curiosity to follow.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Promising for people who like a story that tolerates a little messing about; the committee has authorised See What Happens and denied its appendix.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1049280/>

P236 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Longest Journey

Two Universes Have Both Misplaced My Reservation

Edition considered: Original PC release

I booked an imaginary journey between parallel worlds and requested a suite in each. The first world had no record of me. The second had apparently heard about the first and decided to maintain the policy.

April Ryan's adventure offered a much better reason to travel: people, puzzles and the uneasy relationship between different realities. I began drawing a map that reserved the centre for my portrait. Shawna moved the portrait to the margin so the worlds could actually fit.

Tank asked which conversation we wanted to follow next. Mercedes wanted time with the atmosphere. Rosa said a long story could be visited in pieces rather than swallowed as a demonstration of commitment.

I put the map down and listened. The older presentation asked for a little patience, but patience was not the same as an obligation to tolerate an uncomfortable interface. We agreed to check that first. My suite remained unavailable in both universes, which I described as remarkably consistent cross-dimensional customer service.

The actual attraction

April Ryan moves between parallel universes in a substantial original PC adventure filled with conversations, places and puzzles. Its appeal is spending time with a large imaginative world; another person can share the story and discuss clues beside the player.

The catch worth knowing

This older PC release needs a compatibility and readability check on the actual machine. Long dialogue, inventory puzzles, repeated travel and remembering multiple locations add work. Do not infer no timers, no holds or modern interface options from its age or genre.

An opening invitation

Launch the exact original release, inspect text and save behavior, then hear an opening conversation and try an object interaction. Decide whether the people and world justify the interface effort before treating the title as a promise to finish a very long journey.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally approved for readers who want to inhabit an expansive older adventure; neither universe is required to provide my requested executive suite.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/6310/>

P237 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Broken Age

The Talking Spoon Has Requested a Different Destiny

Edition considered: PC complete two-act release

A talking spoon seemed a natural addition to my office, where several silent objects already carried more responsibility than their job descriptions allowed. I appointed it Deputy Minister of Breakfast before asking whether it wanted the position.

Broken Age's two young protagonists had their own reasons to question the lives arranged for them. Mercedes looked at the spoon's appointment letter and asked whether I had understood that part of the premise.

Shawna suggested we follow one character's situation first. Tank wanted to test an object interaction rather than sit through my address on destiny. Rosa asked the spoon what it would like for breakfast, which was an odd question but at least granted it some agency.

We switched perspectives and found a world stranger than my office, although considerably better painted. I withdrew the appointment letter. The spoon remained on the table by choice, or at least without written evidence to the contrary. My own destiny involved washing it after lunch, a role with unusually clear responsibilities.

The actual attraction

Vella and Shay navigate very different worlds while trying to take control of their lives. The complete two-act point-and-click adventure combines hand-drawn scenes, voice performances, odd characters and puzzles, with switching between the protagonists part of the structure.

The catch worth knowing

Two story threads and inventory reasoning can require remembering details across scenes. Later puzzle complexity should not be inferred from an approachable opening. The developer page supports the premise and point-and-click form, not a full no-timer or no-hold certification. This is shared viewing of a single-player adventure.

An opening invitation

Hear an opening conversation, try one interaction and look at the character-switching interface. Choose which story to follow by interest. A companion can remember an earlier clue without taking over every decision or explaining a solution before it is wanted.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally welcome for someone who likes imaginative characters questioning their assigned roles; the spoon's ministerial appointment has been rescinded with full washing privileges.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/broken-age>

P238 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: real time / native co-op: yes

Dinkum

The Crocodile Has Rejected My Welcome Pack

Edition considered: PC release; current version status must be checked

I arrived in Dinkum with a town charter, a decorative shovel and a welcome pack for the local wildlife. Tank asked whether the wildlife had agreed to a town. I said consultation would follow the ribbon cutting.

The game combined building a settlement with a landscape that could be beautiful and dangerous. I attempted to admire a creature on behalf of the tourism department. Shawna suggested admiring it from somewhere less likely to become lunch.

Mercedes wanted to design a pleasant place to live. Rosa wanted the daily tasks to stay manageable. Both intentions seemed more useful than my plan to name every building before we had gathered its materials.

We started small and kept an eye on what survival actually required. I put the wildlife welcome packs back in the binder. The crocodile, as far as our imaginary correspondence established, preferred a more direct approach to visitors. Tank proposed making this fact the town's first piece of useful public information.

The actual attraction

Explore, gather, farm and build a settlement in an Australian-inspired landscape, meeting residents and inviting friends online. The full PC release combines town creation with survival and also includes a separate Creative Mode, offering a different focus for building.

The catch worth knowing

Default play includes wild animals, tools, combat, gathering, crafting and a three-dimensional view. Creative Mode changes building options, not the need to check camera comfort. Official launch notes leave some town quests to the host. Record the installed version rather than relying on old Early Access advice.

An opening invitation

Try walking, looking around and one modest town task before entering dangerous terrain. Inspect Creative Mode if building is the attraction, then check the chosen multiplayer permissions. Ask whether both players enjoy their available tasks rather than assigning one all the work.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional settlement project when both building and some danger appeal; wildlife welcome packs must be delivered by neither me nor anybody else.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched PC Steam description supports Australian-inspired survival, farming and online cooperation. Official launch announcements explicitly confirm the April 23, 2025 UTC exit from Early Access, Creative Mode and revised multiplayer permissions. Some town/building quests remain host-only in those launch notes. Current build behavior still needs checking; observed September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1062520/>

Source 2: https://store.steampowered.com/news/posts/?appid=1062520&enddate=1745490680&feed=steam_community_announcements

P239 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Farm Together

The Carrots Have Continued Growing Without My Supervision

Edition considered: PC first game

I left Farm Together for a moment and returned to the shocking possibility that the farm had continued existing without my strategic attention. I had not approved this independence. The carrots appeared entirely unmoved.

Time advancing while we were away could mean a pleasant return to something ready for attention. I tried to convert it into a compulsory check-in schedule. Rosa removed the schedule and said crops in a game were not entitled to summon us from dinner.

Tank liked the possibility of doing a little work side by side. Mercedes wanted a farm with paths that led somewhere attractive, rather than directly to my proposed founder's pavilion. Shawna checked the visiting permissions before imagining a shared project.

We planned a modest patch and an equally modest return. The tractor was allowed to remain a tool rather than a symbol of my agricultural authority. I still asked the carrots for a report. Their continued silence was both insubordinate and, according to everyone else, an excellent influence on the office.

The actual attraction

Grow crops, keep animals, decorate a farm and invite other players to cultivate it together. The first Farm Together explicitly lets time progress while you are offline, creating a place that can be revisited rather than requiring continuous attendance.

The catch worth knowing

Repeated tending, expansion, currencies, waiting and item menus can become a workload. Movement and camera handling need a direct check. Online farm permissions matter when sharing; the source does not establish every activity as untimed or hold-free. This card covers the first game, not its sequel.

An opening invitation

Plant or tend one small area and inspect how a friend joins and what they may change. Try camera movement and a basic interaction. Decide whether returning to growing things feels pleasant without agreeing to an attendance schedule.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally welcome for companions who like a persistent shared garden; the carrots' refusal to attend my progress meeting is fully protected.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 673950 is the first Farm Together, published by Milkstone Studios. Product description explicitly supports shared farming, permissions and time advancing offline. These claims are not imported from Farm Together 2; exact control comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/673950/>

P240 / **CONDITIONAL** / camera input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Staxel

The Village Has Built a House Where My Master Plan Used to Be

Edition considered: PC release

For the final farm proposal, I promised to listen before producing a master plan. This was easy for almost twelve seconds. Then I saw a flat patch of ground and began mentally arranging a ceremonial avenue.

Staxel let us shape a blocky village, restore a farm and work alongside friends. Tank wanted a useful workshop. Rosa wanted somewhere welcoming. Mercedes wanted to choose the colours herself, a terrifying but constitutionally sound development.

Shawna tested the movement and building controls before granting my imaginary planning permission. A first-person world required looking and moving, even if the activity was domestic. We agreed that a pleasant project could still be the wrong fit for a particular evening.

I set down the plan. Somebody put up a wall; somebody else noticed where a window should go. The little house became a record of choices made together rather than evidence that I had arrived first. I offered to carry the furniture. For once, nobody needed to revise my job description.

The actual attraction

Restore a farm, meet villagers and alter a voxel world through building and cultivation. The PC game explicitly supports online cooperation, allowing friends to share a farm or become neighbours while making their own projects.

The catch worth knowing

First-person movement, camera steering, selecting materials, crafting and placing blocks can create substantial coordination and menu demands. Farming tasks add routine work. The publisher's creative premise does not certify no holds, no timed activities or a frictionless multiplayer setup.

An opening invitation

Try looking around, moving through a doorway and placing or interacting with a simple object. If sharing online, establish who owns the session and how both people join. Choose one small project only after the controls feel worth using.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional final invitation for people who enjoy making a place together; my master plan has become spare paper, and the house is better for it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 405710 is Staxel, with explicit online co-op and shared-farm or neighbour play in the publisher description. Voxel building, village life and crops are supported. Camera workload and first trial are editorial checks, not access certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/405710/>

The Commission Votes to Leave the Door Open

The final vote concerned what the commission should do next. I had prepared three options: expand, establish a regional office, or expand while establishing a regional office. Mercedes wrote **PLAY SOMETHING** in the margin. It won unanimously.

“I haven't voted,” I said.

“You announced the vote was unanimous before you printed the ballot,” Shawna said.

The evidence was in my handwriting. We accepted the result.

Forty entries had given us several different kinds of company. Two characters sharing a world. Two people describing separate clues. A friend watching an absurd scene. A quiet debate over a railway route. A building project that could become a pleasant afternoon or a second job. The useful question remained the one we had started with: what would each person actually do, and would they enjoy doing it?

That question also permitted no. A game could be beautiful and still ask for movement somebody did not want. A cooperative mode could be generous and still give one person a role they found dull. A friend could be dear and still offer far too many instructions. In the last case, I recommended sandwiches as an interim measure and listening as the longer-term repair.

Tank put the second controller beside the first. He did not hand it to anybody. That small decision made the invitation feel different. There it was if wanted. Nothing in the room demanded an answer.

Rosa cleared the plate. She found the stamped slice of bread under my notes.

“Are we preserving this?”

“Founding document.”

“Compost.”

We had a brief constitutional discussion, which the bread lost.

I lifted the enormous binder from the table. Everybody watched, perhaps expecting the building to sigh with relief. It was heavier than any ordinary answer to what to play should have been. That was part of the joke. The real route through it could still be tiny: choose one interesting game, read the catch, try one meaningful thing, and decide whether to continue. The rest was optional company.

Shawna took half the weight. Tank opened the cabinet. Mercedes moved the shelf that I had installed upside down several volumes earlier. Rosa insisted that the snacks remain outside the filing system. Together we found a place for the book that did not require anyone to hold it indefinitely.

The gold stamp went in a drawer. The tiny red stapler stayed on the table. I left the ASK card beside it, where I would see it before developing another policy.

“So what are you now?” Mercedes asked.

I considered Director Emeritus of Recreational Companionship. It had a nice shape. It could fit on a brass plate. It could also turn a quiet evening into another delivery appointment.

“Available,” I said.

Tank nodded. “Good. Bring the water.”

I brought the water. No one applauded. Nobody needed to. The game was already interesting, the chairs were comfortable, and for once the administration had improved the evening by getting out of its way.

An index with no authority over you

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.